

The Conservatory of Broken Seasons

****T. K. Arven****

No community may be used as another community's weather.

Act I — The Unnamed Debit

Prologue — A Dawn Without Light

Ressa put her heel against the chalk mark so no one could sweep it away by mistake.

The mark crossed the plaster at the height of her ankle, one short white bar beneath the address hall window. Hesh had drawn it after supper and written the promised time beside it in smaller figures. When the light came, Ressa could erase both with the damp end of the chalk. That part belonged to her because she had asked first.

"It will not fall off the wall," Hesh said from the ledger table.

"Jori kicks things."

"Jori cannot kick plaster off a heat wall."

"He could try."

Hesh considered this, then nodded. Jori could try most things. Ressa kept her heel where it was.

Everyone in Lorn Dusk had gathered early for the reflected window. The public schedule promised twelve minutes of dawn through the high glass, long enough to warm the seed trays and let children see their own shadows. Adults brought work that wanted pale light: thread sorting, seal inspection, the search for splinters in a glove. Two mechanics had opened the outer shutters and braced them with iron hooks. Beyond the glass waited a sky without morning, black except for a thin green smear above the radiator towers.

The hall lamps had been turned low. Under them, faces looked unfinished.

Ressa knew dawn from windows rather than horizons. It arrived as a bright square that moved across the floor, climbed the communal stove, and reached the wall of names before the mirror turned away. Once, when she was five, light had touched the copper button on her coat and made it too bright to look at. She had kept the button afterward, though the coat no longer fit.

Tonight's window had been printed on the clinic board, the school door, and the flour station. Her teacher called it a promised dawn. They had moved the first lesson into the address hall so the class could sketch shadows while adults checked the youngest greenhouse leaves for gray mold.

A minute remained.

Hesh crossed one entry in the bound ledger and sanded the wet ink. The pages recorded households, births, burials, heater failures, and light windows. Ressa could read the large headings. She could not yet read Hesh's close script, which leaned forward as if every word had somewhere colder to go.

"Ready," called one of the mechanics.

Conversation stopped. People shifted away from the center of the floor. Ressa took her heel from the mark and held the chalk inside her fist.

The minute passed.

No white edge found the window. The greenhouse lamps remained yellow. Above the roofline, the aurora loosened into threads and gathered again.

"Mirror delay," someone said.

The mechanics checked the shutter hooks, though everyone could see the opening stood clear. A woman near the stove lifted her smallest child onto one hip. The child had been woken for dawn and now tried to sleep against her shoulder.

Ressa watched the floorboards. She had chosen the seam where the bright square usually began. If the light arrived weakly, perhaps the wood would show it before the glass did.

Two minutes passed. Then four.

At six minutes beyond the printed time, the address terminal gave a soft administrative tone. Its screen brightened blue beside Hesh's elbow. Ressa expected the chime used for a delayed window, followed by a new time. Instead, a line of narrow letters appeared and remained there.

Hesh read them without speaking.

"What does it say?" asked the greenhouse keeper.

"Window withdrawn from active schedule."

"For how long?"

"No duration."

The keeper set down the tray she had brought. "Reason?"

Hesh touched the lower corner of the message. More text should have opened. Nothing did.

"Ask district weather," one mechanic said.

"I did." Hesh entered the request again. The terminal waited, then displayed a list of civic districts. Orison appeared near the top in green. Cald drift, Nacre Coast, and cities Ressa knew only from school maps followed it. Hesh moved through two pages. Their finger stopped, went back, and searched by name.

NO FORECAST DISTRICT FOUND: LORN DUSK.

Ressa read that line because the letters stood wide apart.

"We are here," she said.

No one laughed. Hesh looked from the screen to her as if she had asked a serious question.

"Yes," they said.

"Then why can't it find us?"

"The forecast uses a different list."

The explanation did not help. Lists should contain what they listed. Ressa knew that from addresses. If someone moved from Heat Wall Three to the tower rooms, Hesh crossed out one room and wrote the next. Nobody vanished between pages.

Behind her, people began turning the hall lamps up. Yellow light strengthened over the tables. The mechanics released the shutters and drew the insulated panels together. Their iron edges met with a dull strike. A teacher told the children to take out their writing boards. The promised dawn had become an ordinary lesson before the scheduled twelve minutes ended.

Ressa opened her fist. Chalk dust filled the lines of her palm.

"Do I erase it?" she asked.

Hesh pulled the ledger closer. "Did the window arrive?"

"No."

"Then the mark stays."

"But it says the time."

"The time belongs to what was promised."

Across the room, Jori dragged his stool over the boards and came too close to the wall. Ressa pushed him away with one hand. He objected loudly until the teacher moved him to another table.

Hesh wrote the date, the scheduled duration, and the message from the terminal. Their pen scratched through the hush. A few adults came to read over their shoulder. The clinic porter dictated the heater reserve that had been used to prepare the treatment room. The greenhouse keeper reported six trays uncovered for expected light. One mechanic named the hours spent clearing frost from the

outer shutter track.

None of those things changed the sky. They changed the page.

The teacher set a lamp on the floor for the shadow lesson. Every child received a black stick of charcoal and a sheet of rough paper. Ressa's shadow spread too softly beneath the lamp, with three edges instead of one. She drew the shutter hooks while the others drew hands, cups, or each other's profiles.

"What happened to the mirror?" Jori whispered.

"It went somewhere else."

"How do you know?"

Ressa looked at the closed panels. She did not know. Perhaps a mirror could break. Perhaps it could forget an angle. Adults had said the Choir contained more mirrors than anyone in the hall could count without losing their place. One might have turned toward another greenhouse, another clinic, another room where children waited beside a wall.

She only knew the public schedule had named this window, then the forecast had failed to name Lorn Dusk.

When the lesson ended, the adults carried their unfinished light-work home. Seed trays went back under narrow lamps. The woman with the sleepy child tucked a warm brick beneath her coat. People touched the new ledger entry as they passed, not for luck but to show they had seen it.

Ressa stayed by the plaster.

Her chalk line no longer looked like the start of anything. In the stronger hall lamps it appeared blunt and dusty, no brighter than old marks above it. She counted those for the first time. Some had dates. Some carried small hooks at one end, Hesh's sign for a window that arrived late. Others stood plain.

"How many didn't come?" she asked.

Hesh capped the ink. "Enough that we write them down."

"Will writing make the next one come?"

"No."

Adults often softened a no by adding a later or a perhaps. Hesh left this one clean.

Ressa rubbed chalk from her palm onto her trousers. "Then why keep it?"

"So nobody can say we received what we did not receive." Hesh closed the ledger around its new page. "And so nobody can say nobody waited."

The answer fit inside her, though not comfortably.

At the door, the teacher called her to breakfast. Ressa bent and refreshed the white bar where her heel had blurred its lower edge. She copied the scheduled time more carefully beneath it. The figures leaned in different directions, but Hesh said they could still be read.

Outside, Lorn Dusk continued without dawn. Radiator hum passed through the floor. Green lamps shone over the high glass, and frost sealed the shutter seams the mechanics had cleared. The sky had kept nothing for her.

On the wall, the promise remained.

Chapter 1 — The Heat Ledger

Senn Vale held the hive door shut with her shoulder while six thousand municipal bees argued against her through the wood.

The box had warmed nine minutes ahead of schedule. A thin vibration traveled from the frames into her coat, purposeful as a pump beginning its cycle, and the temperature strip beside the latch showed a green line climbing toward release. Across the canal, Orison's eastern mirrors had not yet cleared the haze. Their light hung above the roofs in four pale columns, bright enough to silver the greenhouse glass but too weak to wake an apricot flower.

"Keep them closed," called the bloom steward from the lower terrace.

"I had reached that conclusion."

Senn leaned harder. The keeper beside her, a boy with a copper veil folded on his head, tried not to smile. He had been told that a senior seasonal auditor would inspect the first hive release. He had probably imagined a woman carrying a slate and asking ceremonial questions, not someone braced against a wooden box while the colony attempted an unauthorized spring.

Below them, canal gates opened in sequence. Water that had spent the night under insulated shutters slid into the terrace channels. Frost loosened from the stone in transparent scales. The public chimes sounded one low note, then another, calling gardeners to uncover the early beds.

None of it should have begun yet.

Senn took the probe from her pocket and pushed its blunt end through the hive's service port. Air temperature inside read 18.2 degrees. The bloom order authorized release at 18.5 after three continuous minutes of east-array light. No array light had reached the terrace.

"Did you preheat the box?" she asked.

The keeper's smile vanished. "No, Auditor."

"Did your steward?"

The woman below heard him hesitate. "I did not," she called. "The hive wall takes canal heat. If the canal woke early, so did they."

Senn looked across the terraces. Along five tiers, workers stood beside closed hive boxes, their shoulders in the same awkward posture as hers. Orison had

designed bloom to look effortless from the tram bridges. From inside the schedule, spring consisted of people holding doors against insects until a ledger and a sky agreed.

The third chime sounded. A bright edge appeared on the upper greenhouse roofs.

"Now," the steward said.

Senn lifted the latch. Bees pressed into the narrow opening, paused in a dark knot, then spilled across the warming air. They did not rise toward the official light columns. They turned down toward the canal, following heat already present in the stone.

She recorded the direction of flight.

The keeper reached for the box record clipped under the eave. Senn stopped him before he could write *release normal* in the morning column.

"Record the internal temperature at first latch pressure," she said. "Record canal surface temperature. Put my instrument number beside both."

He looked down at the steward. The woman climbed the terrace steps with the care of someone approaching a dispute she expected to outlast. Soil darkened her knees. A ribbon of white petals clung to one sleeve.

"A warm box does not make a failed bloom," the steward said.

"No." Senn showed her the probe reading. "It makes a question about where the warmth came from."

"It came from the canal."

"Then the canal has the question."

The steward read the strip and rubbed a thumb over the crease beside her mouth. Early warmth pleased growers until an auditor named it. An advance of fifteen minutes could bring one set of buds forward while another remained tight. Pollinators spent themselves against unopened flowers. Nursery managers compensated with extra lamps, then the next ledger treated those lamps as ordinary demand. A small shift could vanish into a turn's abundance while still charging someone for the correction.

Senn walked to the next box. Its keeper had already released the colony, but the empty hive held 18.1 degrees. The third measured 18.3. At the fourth terrace she crouched beside the canal and submerged the probe until cold water covered the metal stem. Heat moved strongest along the inner retaining stones, not the surface facing the new mirror light. Whatever warmed the channel had entered before dawn through the district return line.

"Do you want us to close the boxes?" the boy asked when she came back.

"No. Closing them now would punish the bees for our schedule."

The steward gave a short laugh. "That may be the first sensible sentence an

auditor has spoken on this terrace.”

“Put that in the remarks field.”

Senn copied five box temperatures, the gate sequence, and the direction of the bees' first flight. She also recorded what she did not do: no halted release, no crop alarm, no accusation against the keepers. A useful discrepancy needed clean edges. If every office could later claim she had mistaken ordinary bloom for an emergency, they would spend more attention defending spring than explaining its advance.

On the tram uphill, she watched the terraces pass under the growing light. Municipal hives opened one after another. Children on a school bridge counted the boxes and cheered each dark cloud of bees. Their teacher pointed toward the east array as if the mirrors alone had summoned them.

Senn kept looking at the canal stones.

By the time she reached the Conservatory, the first discrepancy had acquired three innocent explanations. Canal pumps might have retained heat from the prior rain turn. A greenhouse cooperative might have requested an unlogged nursery allowance. Mirror 117, whose edge corrections often painted more ground than intended, might have warmed the water before its measured light reached the roofs.

Senn preferred innocent explanations. They were cheaper to prove and usually came with someone embarrassed enough to fix them.

The heat ledger occupied a recessed desk on the Conservatory's second floor, where the old pressureworks windows faced starward through red glass. Even filtered, Varda's permanent glare left a copper bar across the slate. Senn set her coat over it before she opened Orison's account.

Four columns arranged the city's coming turn: light delivered, shade accepted, cloud water seeded, heat exported. Bloom allowances appeared in green. Winter obligations appeared in blue. Each quantity had a district, a source instrument, an authorizing schedule, and a balancing entry. Weather on Meral did not arrive. Someone angled it, seeded it, blocked it, or paid for its consequences elsewhere.

The canal reading sat within the light-delivery column as a correction of 0.08 percent. Small enough to disappear into routine tolerance. Senn traced it to mirror 117 and found a maintenance note signed D. Orro: EAST EDGE OFFSET TO HOLD CLINIC WINDOW. The note carried no district name.

She marked it for origin review and kept reading.

Orison's account did not merely close. It closed elegantly. The delivered bloom matched hospital heating, greenhouse demand, school-day extensions, and canal release within a fraction that would have pleased an examiner. The corresponding heat export flowed into darkward radiator capacity, where the planet could shed it into permanent night. No tower exceeded its listed tolerance. No district surrendered more than its traded share.

Yet the hive had warmed early.

Senn removed her coat from the copper bar and laid a transparent work sheet over the account. She copied the measured canal temperature, then reconstructed the preceding twelve hours from primary instruments rather than Conservatory summaries. Pumps 4 through 9 had started at the authorized time. The insulated shutters had opened correctly. Greenhouse discharge contributed less than a fifth of the excess. Mirror 117 explained part of what remained, but its offset could not have warmed five terraces.

She widened the query to the whole city.

The slate slowed. Orison carried too many bloom instruments for quick reconstruction: tram glass that turned reflective during high light, school roofs that banked warmth for evening lessons, hundreds of greenhouse skins, hospital reservoirs, canal stones, hive walls. The Conservatory condensed them into district totals because no one could govern a season by watching every surface.

Senn had once believed condensation meant clarity. Eight years earlier, she had reconciled storm losses for tenant growers in Caldrift. Her total had been exact. The compensation schedule had been exact. By the time the money reached the growers, twelve leases had already passed to landholders who could afford the delay. Every line had balanced. The people under the lines had moved.

She never again accepted a clean total before asking what it had made invisible.

The reconstruction completed. Eleven blocks of residual warmth appeared across Orison, each trivial alone. Together they formed a smooth advance in the bloom curve. The city had begun taking spring before its mirrors announced spring.

Senn checked the authorized schedule. It matched the public chimes. She checked the physical schedule. It matched the bees.

Then she found the second ledger.

Not a hidden file. Conservatory practice discouraged hidden files, which created legal risk. This one sat under Auxiliary Balancing, a category broad enough to contain harmless shade exchanges, emergency cloud seeding, and the slow redistribution of heat around a world with one day and one night. The category showed Orison receiving an eleven-day bloom extension over the coming turn.

The extension appeared nowhere in the public forecast.

Senn leaned back. Around her, the second-floor desks carried the quiet noises of ordinary climate work: styluses against slate, paper orders lifted from drawers, a technician dictating wind-shear numbers into a throat microphone. The Conservatory did not feel like a place concealing eleven days of spring. It felt like a place where concealment could wear the same gray cover as maintenance.

She opened the balancing side.

The account expanded into a diagram of transfers. On its left, Orison's added

light entered as a broad green band. On its right, the Conservatory had divided the cost until no single line looked like payment. Industrial shade carried a quarter. Radiator duty carried nearly half. Wind-risk tolerance absorbed a narrow fraction whose legal meaning depended on the season. The remaining demand descended through three nested categories and ended at the unnamed debit.

Senn rebuilt the balance without the summaries. She converted lumen-hours into expected surface heat, subtracted crop uptake, canal storage, and outgoing air exchange, then compared the result with darkward radiator capacity. The arithmetic required the debit. Remove it and the account held a physical deficit large enough to alter the next shear forecast. Keep it and the city received warmth whose receiving cost had no civic address.

A yellow flag appeared beside one radiator figure. The tower reported continuous operation above preferred load but below emergency tolerance. A second tower carried the same flag. Senn opened their maintenance histories and found repeated bearing inspections, coolant replacements, and one request for residential heater priority during a clinic window. Policy accounting had rolled every item into infrastructure demand.

She called the archive index and requested the legal definition of occupancy exempt.

The index offered six current manuals and an emergency glossary older than Senn. Current manuals defined unoccupied zones by absence of domestic heat, medical reserves, schools, births, and local burials. The old glossary defined service occupancy as personnel temporarily present to maintain equipment. Neither definition fit instruments showing continuous homes.

Senn sent a narrow question to policy accounting: *Which survey certifies continued occupancy exemption for allocation 9.7?*

The response arrived before she could close the query. *Certification inherited from originating order.*

She asked for the originating order.

Access limited: policy classification.

She requested only its date.

This answer took longer. The slate displayed a turning circle while someone, or a permission system designed by someone, considered whether a date could reveal too much. At last it returned a year thirty-one years earlier.

No temporary service crew remained temporary for thirty-one years. Either the instruments had been assigned to the wrong allocation, or the classification had survived the facts it once described.

Every benefit required a cost. The eleven days drew on hospital need, staple-crop stabilization, and "urban continuity," a phrase with no unit attached. The cost side listed shade acceptance at three unused industrial tracts, increased

radiator duty, and a winter debit.

The debit had an authorization number. It had a duration, a thermal value, and a risk ceiling. It did not have a district.

Senn read the line again, more slowly.

WINTER DEBIT: SERVICE ALLOCATION 9.7 / LOAD-BALANCED / OCCUPANCY EXEMPT.

Most weather transfers named both places. Caldrift surrendered two rain hours to the western reservoirs. Orison accepted a cold morning so Nacre orchards could finish fruit set. Even uninhabited tracts had survey coordinates, because wind did not respect administrative vagueness. This entry named only an exemption.

She requested the source map.

ACCESS LIMITED: POLICY CLASSIFICATION.

She requested the instrument bundle.

The slate returned eighteen radiator feeds, atmospheric shear monitors, heat-wall consumption, medical reserve draw, school-cycle load, and domestic warming demand. Senn stopped at the last three.

An uninhabited service allocation did not have medical reserves. Equipment did not attend school. Domestic warming demand required homes.

Someone had not erased the people from the instruments. They had erased them from the category that decided whether winter could be imposed.

Senn copied the authorization number to paper. Digital annotations could be revised with an audit trail; paper made the act of carrying a number visible. She went down one floor to maintenance coordination.

Dael Orro stood inside a shade-kite frame with both arms raised, holding a strip of black fabric against a test lamp. He was broad through the shoulders and wore the short gray coat of a lattice engineer. Two fingers on his left hand did not straighten fully. The lamp cast a hard rectangle across his face.

"You signed an offset on mirror 117," Senn said.

"Then it must have needed one."

"Your note says a clinic window."

Dael lowered the fabric. "Clinics generally prefer their windows to arrive."

"Which clinic?"

The junior technicians at the edge of the frame found urgent reasons to examine their tension gauges.

Dael stepped out and switched off the lamp. In the softer red light from the windows, he looked tired rather than obstructive. "Did the offset breach tolerance?"

"No."

"Did it compromise Orison's bloom?"

"It advanced canal heat by less than a tenth of a percent."

"Then your bees survived the outrage."

Senn placed the paper authorization number on the workbench. His amusement left without visible motion.

"Where does this debit go?" she asked.

Dael read the number. "That belongs to policy accounting."

"The instruments include school-cycle load."

"They include many things."

"Medical reserve draw."

His damaged fingers closed over the fabric strip. "You should ask the First Curator."

"I asked the ledger."

"And it refused you."

"A ledger cannot refuse. A person selects the access rule."

Dael looked toward the technicians, then motioned Senn to the narrow service balcony. Outside, Orison's central canal shone under the now-complete bloom array. Bees moved above the terraces as shifting brown dust. From this height, no one could see the workers who had held the boxes shut.

"The offset and the debit are not the same thing," he said.

"I know. Your offset is too small."

"Then leave it small."

"Who receives the clinic window?"

Dael watched mirror light travel down the canal. "A clinic that loses more windows than it receives."

The answer carried location without naming it: darkward, beyond the public district map, somewhere the Choir's reflected dawn could be withheld.

"Is the winter debit imposed on people?" Senn asked.

Dael's jaw tightened. "If I tell you yes, what do you do before the next schedule closes?"

"Open an origin trace."

"If the trace freezes the balancing order, Orison loses light before anyone has modeled the shear response."

"That sounds like yes."

"It sounds like weather has momentum. Auditors forget that because numbers stop when you close a file."

"I have not forgotten."

“Then do not make innocence out of speed.”

Senn picked up the authorization slip. “Do not make safety out of silence.”

Neither of them moved. Below, the canal released another skin of frost. The public chimes announced that bloom had begun exactly on time.

Back at her desk, three messages waited. The bloom steward had filed the early hive heat as a harmless calibration drift. Maintenance had attached Dael's mirror note to routine tolerance. Policy accounting had answered Senn's source-map request with a meeting invitation for the following afternoon, no documents attached.

Every response tried to reduce the discrepancy to the size of the office answering it.

Senn reopened Orison's account. Freezing a weather ledger did not stop the machinery. It prevented new authorizations from inheriting an unexamined entry. Existing schedules would continue for thirty-six hours under maintenance authority. After that, the Season Table would require a named curator to renew the debit or remove it.

She checked the storm field. Stable for four days under the current schedule, uncertain after that. She checked hospital reserves. Adequate. She checked greenhouse floor temperatures. Vulnerable, but not immediately. The decision contained risk. So did leaving the line unnamed.

In the freeze form, a blank field asked for grounds.

Senn wrote: BALANCING ENTRY APPEARS TO CARRY HUMAN OCCUPANCY UNDER INFRASTRUCTURE EXEMPTION. ORIGIN AND STANDING UNVERIFIED.

The form asked whether she alleged fraud.

She selected NO.

It asked whether she alleged measurement error.

NO.

It asked whether the entry could affect a protected climate floor.

She selected YES.

A final notice warned that an origin trace would alert the First Curator, the affected district, and all engineers whose maintenance entries touched the allocation. No affected district appeared in the account, so the notice listed only Orison.

Senn added the authorization number, Dael's maintenance initials, and the hive temperature. Then she pressed her thumb to the seal.

The ledger dimmed around the winter debit. Its blue line remained visible, but a thin white boundary appeared on either side, preventing it from flowing forward unnoticed.

Outside the red windows, Orison brightened into the spring it had expected. On

Senn's slate, the city kept eleven days no public forecast admitted it owned. Somewhere beyond the named districts, medical heaters and school lamps waited inside a category that claimed no one lived there.

The origin trace opened.

Chapter 2 — The Mirror's Small Lie

Senn lowered the light sensor into the canal until cold water covered the second calibration ring.

"Not the cable," Dael said.

"I can see the cable."

"Most people can. They still drown it."

Dael Orro crouched on the retaining wall with one boot braced against a greenhouse buttress. The fingers of his left hand held the sensor line below the connector, keeping its weight off the repaired joint. His right hand worked a portable shade over the instrument head. Above them, mirror 117 waited ten degrees west of its first bloom angle, a silver scratch moving through the red haze.

The canal-side beds had been uncovered before they arrived. Apricot branches stood in ordered rows behind the glass, their buds swollen but closed. Garden crews tested irrigation valves along the upper terrace. Every few minutes a hive keeper leaned close to one of the municipal boxes, listening for the pressure of bees against wood.

Orison prepared bloom by pretending not to hurry.

Senn read the instrument. "Dark baseline holding at point zero four."

"Within spec."

"You repaired this joint with seal thread."

"I repaired it with the correct seal thread."

"It has three colors."

"Three correct colors."

She recorded the baseline. Dael lifted the portable shade, allowing the city lamps to reach the sensor. The reading climbed by a measurable fraction. He lowered the shade again. Light vanished from the instrument without changing the canal temperature.

They repeated the sequence at two depths, then raised the sensor and set it in a cradle on the stone. Water streamed from its black fins. Dael wiped each optical face with a square of lint paper and held it toward the dim sky.

"No film," he said. "No thermal lag beyond seven seconds. If you hoped for a

dishonest sensor, this one will disappoint you.”

“I hoped for a complete account.”

“That costs more.”

The origin trace Senn had opened the previous afternoon had produced a procedural compromise. Policy accounting would not release the debit's source map. Maintenance would permit her to test the instrument path used to credit Orison's early warmth. First Curator Ceryn Ahl had scheduled a technical review in two days, which gave every office time to decide how little to bring.

Senn had chosen the canal test because mirror 117 offered the only named physical adjustment connected to the discrepancy. Dael had agreed because refusing would have turned a tolerance note into evidence of concealment.

Neither had called the arrangement cooperative.

A public chime sounded from the tram bridge. Workers opened the first greenhouse vents. Damp air rolled across the canal, carrying soil heat and the bitter scent of dormant leaves.

Dael checked his wrist slate. “First target in three minutes. Put the sensor on the inner edge.”

“That edge produced yesterday's advance.”

“Yes.”

“You say that without concern.”

“I say it because the canal has not moved since yesterday.”

Senn placed the cradle where the retaining wall turned toward the nearest hive terrace. Dael ran a sighting thread from its center to a brass notch in the stone. The notch bore years of small scratches from prior calibrations. One scratch had been filled with fresh white paste.

“Your offset?” she asked.

“My reference.”

“Which differs from the scheduled reference.”

“By eleven millimeters at this wall.”

“That becomes how much at the edge of the reflection?”

“Wait for the light.”

He did not speak evasively when metal or angle could answer instead. Senn respected the instinct despite the work it required from her.

Mirror 117 crossed its first control point. A narrow bar of reflected Varda light appeared on the upper canal, copper at its margins and white in the center. The bar moved down the water with mechanical smoothness. Greenhouse glass threw fragments across the terrace ceilings. Bees struck the hive doors in sudden waves.

Dael watched the sensor rather than the spectacle. “Now.”

Senn began a continuous record. The light bar touched the far edge of the canal. Temperature held. It advanced across the water, reached the sighting thread, and turned the sensor display from gray to green.

Delivered light matched the mirror telemetry within two tenths of a percent.

She checked the backup photometer. Its value agreed.

Dael moved the portable shade over both instruments. Their optical readings dropped at once while the thermal fins retained a slower trace. He counted seven seconds, lifted the shade, and nodded toward Senn's slate.

"No phantom delivery," he said.

"Not here."

"Test every stone in Orison if you like. Light remains irritatingly real."

Senn followed the reflection as it passed below the hive terraces. Yesterday's warmth had not come from false sensor credit. Orison had received the measured energy. The discrepancy survived contact with water, glass, and an independent device.

She had wanted the result clean. Clean results narrowed questions. This one also removed the cheapest answer.

At the end of the control pass, mirror 117 should have continued east along the canal. Instead, its bright edge paused. The central band narrowed, shifted half a degree darkward, then resumed its scheduled path.

Senn marked the time.

Dael began coiling the cable.

"That was your clinic window."

"That was an edge correction."

"You can give it both names."

"Only one fits the maintenance field."

The shift had lasted seventeen seconds. On the canal wall, its effect amounted to a patch of light narrower than Senn's hand. At orbital scale, however, the altered edge would travel beyond Orison's terraces. She opened the public angle trace and overlaid Dael's maintenance command. The official path displayed a smooth curve. His command inserted a shallow hook too small for the city summary.

"Show me the receiving geometry," she said.

"No."

"You entered the command under Conservatory authority."

"I entered a correction within my tolerance authority."

"Then the receiving geometry should survive an audit."

"The mirror survived it."

A hive latch rattled above them. The keeper held it with both hands and looked downhill for release permission. Dael raised one finger without taking his eyes from Senn. The scheduled light reached the terrace, and he lowered it. Six doors opened along the row. Bees poured into white brightness.

The correction had not taken enough from Orison to delay a single release.

Senn disconnected the backup photometer and wrapped its leads. "You told me the offset protected a clinic."

"I told the maintenance ledger."

"Without a place."

"Places complicate routine tolerance."

"People generally do."

Dael's mouth moved at one corner. "That sounds almost like something I would say."

They carried the instruments along the canal to the western gauge house. The path narrowed between water and greenhouse wall. Condensation rolled down the glass in clear beads, each briefly lit as the mirror band passed. Inside, apricot buds opened with minute snaps that Senn could hear only when the pumps paused.

At the gauge house, Dael bolted the sensor to a fixed mount and connected it directly to the canal archive. Senn watched his hands. The burned fingers lacked full extension, but he made no allowance visible in the work. He tightened each contact by touch, then asked her to inspect the seals before power entered the unit.

"You want my initials?" she asked.

"I want you unable to claim I changed it after the test."

"That is almost trust."

"That is good maintenance practice."

She initialed the seals.

The second pass tested spectral content. A mirror could deliver the recorded quantity while placing too much energy outside the crop-useful band, forcing greenhouse stones to absorb heat without waking flowers. Dael fitted three filters over the sensor. Senn called readings while he adjusted a shutter wheel.

Blue fraction within tolerance. Red fraction high by a third of a percent. Infrared fraction matched the canal's early thermal gain but remained insufficient to explain five warmed terraces before scheduled bloom.

"Your sensor tells the truth," Senn said.

"It has poor prospects in administration."

"Your mirror does too, mostly."

Dael removed the filters. "There is no mostly in a photon count."

"There is in an angle trace."

Before Senn accepted the result, she carried the backup photometer three terraces downstream. Dael followed with the fixed sensor's portable reference plate tucked beneath his arm. They chose a place where the canal bent under an old tram abutment, beyond the greenhouse reflections that might have contaminated the first test.

A maintenance hatch beneath the bridge gave them access to the district fiber. The lock resisted Dael's key until he warmed its face with his palm. Condensation had frozen inside the cylinder.

"You could list this as infrastructure obstruction," Senn said.

"I could also fix it."

He removed the lock barrel, dried each pin on his sleeve, and worked graphite into the channel. Senn held the lamp. Two tramloads passed overhead while he reseated the barrel. The bridge translated their wheels into a slow iron thunder.

Inside the hatch, the raw mirror feed arrived before municipal smoothing. Senn connected the photometer, covered it, then opened the shutter on Dael's count. The downstream reading agreed with the first site closely enough that instrument drift could not explain the early canal heat.

"Reverse the test," she said.

Dael directed the photometer toward greenhouse scatter while she placed the reference plate in the mirror path. If reflected glass had inflated canal delivery, the side reading would climb out of proportion. Instead, both values followed the geometry he had predicted.

A canal worker stopped above them and asked whether the bridge would lose light. Dael answered that the mirror could not tell the bridge from the water. The worker considered this bad design but accepted that it would continue.

Senn ran the calculation twice. "No hidden reflection credit."

"Would you like the water to sign a witness field?"

"It has better records than some offices."

They closed the hatch. Dael tested the lock three times, not because the audit required it but because another technician would need it in winter. Senn added the downstream result to the calibration bundle. The extra site cost them forty minutes and removed two more innocent explanations.

The edge correction sat between their slates. Seventeen seconds of documented light had gone somewhere the official district map did not show. Its energy could keep a treatment room above minimum, warm medicine storage, or do nothing useful after atmospheric loss. Without a receiving instrument bundle, Senn could not claim which.

"Give me a tower number," she said.

"No."

"A bearing."

"No."

"Expected transmission loss."

"That would give you a bearing."

"Then you admit there is a receiver."

"I admit mirrors point at surfaces."

Senn closed the spectral record before irritation entered her notes. "A clinic that lacks lawful weather standing cannot request a share. You protect it with offsets, the offsets vanish into tolerance, and the schedule continues to show no demand."

"You have built a sturdy argument from a name I did not give you."

"You gave me the function."

"Function does not grant you custody of the place."

"You think concealment does?"

Dael set the shutter wheel down with care. The gauge-house pumps cycled beneath them, shaking a film of dust from the rafters.

"I think a technical auditor arrives with powers she considers narrow," he said. "A location enters her origin trace. Policy freezes access. Licensing asks who has been adjusting unauthorized service. Security asks whether residents interfered with Choir property. By the time the audit discovers a person, three offices have discovered an offender."

"And your alternative lasts how long?"

"Seventeen seconds today."

"That is not an answer."

"It warms the medicine cabinet."

The specificity changed the room. Dael looked toward the canal immediately afterward, as though the water had spoken for him.

Senn let the pump vibration pass through the floor. A medicine cabinet implied storage temperature rather than patient heating. Seventeen seconds of edge light, captured through a receiving pane and banked in dense stone, might cover the cabinet's narrow range. The adjustment remained small enough to hide because the need had been reduced to the minimum an engineer could protect.

"How often?" she asked.

Dael did not answer.

She opened his maintenance history. Similar edge notes appeared irregularly across three mirrors, never enough to breach tolerance. Some protected diagnostic heat. Others cited coolant viscosity or shutter release. Each phrase could belong to machinery. Together they described a pattern of maintenance attention darkward

of the public schedule.

The pattern reached back twelve years, but Senn did not say the duration aloud. Naming everything she could infer might make him defend every detail at once.

"Does policy know?" she asked instead.

"Policy knows its instrument totals."

"That was not my question."

"It is the answer available here."

A greenhouse steward knocked on the gauge-house door. One western hive remained below release temperature although its neighbors had opened. She wanted to know whether the test had shaded it.

Dael took his probe and followed her without argument. Senn brought the archive cable.

At the hive, he pressed two fingers to the wall, then checked the lower vent. Cold air leaked around a warped wooden slide. He removed the slide, shaved its swollen edge with a service blade, and seated it again. The internal temperature began to rise.

"Not the mirror," he told the steward. "Keep this colony closed for six more minutes."

"That puts them behind the apricot row."

"Better six minutes behind than a cold release."

The steward looked to Senn, perhaps expecting audit authority to overrule maintenance. Senn entered the delayed hive into her notes and confirmed the decision. Bloom schedules tolerated local resistance even when public images did not.

While they waited, she walked the terrace boundary with the photometer. The delivered-light field stayed true within the advertised tolerance. Mirror 117's small hook had left no measurable deficit in the crop beds. Whatever Dael had given away, Orison had not been forced to notice.

That fact did not legalize the adjustment. It made its ethics more inconvenient.

Dael asked the keeper for the prior ten release records. The boy produced a grease-stained packet from beneath the hive shelf. Three entries showed delayed internal warmth on canal-cold mornings, but none recorded the warped vent.

"You have been correcting this with release time," Dael said.

"The colony catches up by second flight."

"Until it does not." He showed the keeper where the slide rubbed its guide. "Sand this edge after the bees settle tonight. Seal the lower corner before rain shift. If moisture enters here, the wood swells toward the latch."

Senn compared the packet with the municipal summary. Every delay had been rounded into normal bloom because no hive missed its daily pollination target.

"Another small discrepancy," she said.

"One caused by wood."

"One hidden by successful compensation."

Dael returned the packet. "You are developing a dangerous interest in maintenance."

The keeper looked between them. "Should I amend the old records?"

"No," Senn said. "Add today's finding. Leave the earlier entries as they were observed." Altering them after the cause became known would make the archive look wiser than the people had been.

At the sixth minute, the keeper opened the hive. Bees emerged slowly, tested the air, and rose toward the nearest flowering wall. Dael watched until their flight stabilized.

"You could file the medicine window as a protected service variance," Senn said.

"Protected for whom?"

"A medical facility."

"Facilities require district identifiers."

"Then give the place an identifier."

His gaze stayed on the bees. "You are circling the same closed gate."

"So are you. You simply service its hinges."

He accepted that without a joke.

They returned to the canal after midday. Orison had entered full bloom shift. White flowers covered the terrace walls, and the first pollen film softened the water's black surface. School groups crossed the high bridges carrying observation boards. Public screens showed the day's light delivery as an unbroken green band.

Senn compared that band with her raw record. The city had received every scheduled lumen-hour within tolerance. It had also received the early heat documented in the hidden balancing account. The instrument path contained no false light, no faulty sensor, and no calculation error broad enough to create the winter debit.

Dael's seventeen-second hook appeared only in the maintenance trace.

At the Conservatory annex desk, she prepared two findings. The first stated that mirror 117 and the canal sensor accurately measured delivered energy; Orison's bloom benefit therefore reflected physical delivery rather than instrument inflation. The second stated that an engineer had used an edge correction for an unlisted medical receiver while keeping the adjustment inside maintenance tolerance.

She turned the slate so Dael could read both.

"You called it medical," he said.

"You called it a medicine cabinet."

"I did not authorize a location trace."

"I have not named a location."

"You will."

"When the evidence permits it."

He read the second finding again. "If you attach my command path, they can reverse the bearing."

"I am sealing the raw geometry under auditor custody until the technical review."

"That protects it for two days."

"It protects it from a routine licensing query. If policy compels release, the request enters the record."

Dael studied her face with the same attention he had given the sensor seals. "Why?"

"Because the small discrepancy has a patient at the end of it."

"You do not know that."

"I know there is medicine."

After a pause, he touched his thumb to the witness field. His mark did not approve her finding. It confirmed he had read it.

Senn sealed the calibration bundle. On one side of her slate, the unnamed winter debit carried enough energy to alter a city's season. On the other, a mirror's small lie redirected seventeen seconds toward a clinic Dael refused to place on any map she could open.

The first discrepancy had institutional authority and no human name. The second had a human purpose and no lawful authority.

She sent both into the review record without allowing either to cancel the other.

Chapter 3 — Eleven Days of Spring

The first apricot petal struck Senn's sleeve while she was counting hospital windows.

She left it there. Across Orison's middle terrace, bloom light climbed the greenhouse walls in measured bands. Each band woke a different crop height: low strawberries first, then bean frames, then the apricot crowns trained against pale stone. Municipal bees crossed between them as dense brown threads. From the tram bridges, the terraces looked spontaneous. At ground level, every opening flower stood inside a schedule.

Senn marked the hospital's eastern reservoir inlet, checked its instrument

number, and moved to the next glass bay. The hidden debit's balancing path entered Orison through eleven allocation blocks. She had printed each block on paper and folded the sheets into her coat by function rather than account number.

Three belonged to hospitals. Four served food production. Two extended school light. One warmed municipal canals. The last carried the phrase urban continuity, which still had no unit attached.

A nurse opened a service door before Senn could knock. Warm damp air escaped around her, followed by the smell of boiled cloth and green leaves.

"You are blocking sterilization exhaust," the nurse said.

"I need the reservoir timing for this wing."

"Then stand inside or farther away."

Senn stepped through.

The hospital grew medicinal plants in narrow beds between its treatment blocks. Blue-veined feverleaf occupied the lower shelves. Above it, climbing filters drew metallic dust from intake air. The eastern reservoir banked light heat during bloom and released it through the dark hours, reducing demand on the municipal heat line.

"Which schedule do you use?" Senn asked.

The nurse pointed to a board above the beds. "Clinical bloom, green column."

The board listed thirty-three days.

Senn's public forecast listed twenty-two.

She compared start dates. Both schedules began that morning. The hospital version continued eleven days beyond the public bloom turn before shifting to rain.

"Who authorizes the extension?"

"Municipal continuity. We receive the schedule each turn."

"Is it optional?"

The nurse gave her the look reserved for questions formed in offices. "The feverleaf reaches usable vein density on day twenty-eight. We can buy dried stock from Caldriest if the roads stay open. The respiratory filters need thirty-one days unless you want to change them twice as often."

"Could you shift those beds under lamps?"

"With whose electricity?"

Senn copied the crop durations and asked for prior-turn usage. The nurse unlocked a cabinet of paper slips, each recording heat released from the reservoir during treatment hours. No single slip named extra spring. Together they assumed it.

A reservoir attendant took Senn below the growing beds to verify the release path. Copper pipes crossed the ceiling in paired runs, one from the bloom-facing

wall and one toward treatment rooms. Salt bricks packed between them stored heat without raising air temperature around the medicines. The attendant pulled a sample brick from its cradle and pressed a probe into the center.

"Day twenty-two leaves these at sixty-eight percent charge," she said. "The longer clinical schedule brings them above ninety before rain shift."

"What happens at sixty-eight?"

"We preserve surgery and neonatal rooms. Sterilization moves to the municipal line. Plant drying stops. If another ward calls for emergency heat, someone chooses which clean work waits."

"Has that occurred?"

"Before the extension became dependable, twice in one turn." She opened a valve no wider than her smallest fingernail. Warm fluid entered the treatment loop with a faint mineral click. "Now our staffing calendar assumes we can sterilize after the public bloom ends. Cut the input without moving staff and the reservoir empties during occupied hours."

Senn inspected the charge log. Hospital planners had turned an unlisted benefit into shift assignments, linen cycles, and medicine preparation. Replacing its energy would not only require heat. It would require people at different hours.

Before leaving, Senn removed the petal from her sleeve. It had gone translucent in the humid room.

The school terraces began two levels uphill. Children in copper visors carried trays of germinating beans from one glass classroom to another, following the moving light. Their teacher recognized Senn's auditor seal and became careful at once.

"We have not exceeded the education allotment," he said.

"I am tracing its duration, not alleging excess."

"That distinction rarely reaches the budget office."

He showed her the school calendar. During public bloom, morning lessons began early and ended when mirror glare sharpened. The undocumented extension supported eleven longer school days after the public turn changed, allowing children from colder outer wards to attend while their household heat walls drew less power.

"Why not print the longer days on the public forecast?" Senn asked.

"They have always been on our calendar."

"That does not answer why."

"It answers everyone who needs to bring a child here."

The teacher tapped a line labeled seasonal stabilization. No source district appeared. The school received the hours through Orison's municipal total, already condensed before the calendar system touched it.

A girl at the nearest table raised her hand. "Are you taking spring away?"

The teacher began to intervene.

Senn answered first. "I am finding out where it comes from."

The girl considered the bean sprout in her palm. "From the mirrors."

"Before the mirrors."

"From Varda."

"After Varda."

The child's patience ran out. "Then from your papers."

Senn wrote down the school schedule and left the answer standing.

On her way out, a transport clerk stopped her beside the boot warmers. Three darkward-facing school routes used the longer days to combine return trams. Without afternoon light, each route required heated cars two hours earlier, when hospital freight occupied the same track.

"We can move the children," the clerk said, laying route tiles across a bench. "We cannot move them at the hour the calendar assumes and also save the heat. Choose one."

"Could lessons begin earlier?"

"Some families share morning heat walls with night crews. Children leave after the wall recovers."

Senn shifted one tile and blocked a seed delivery. Another route crowded the canal interchange beyond its cold-platform limit. Even the school extension reached into freight, household heating, and safe waiting time.

At midday, she crossed the crop terraces with a municipal agronomist named Pel. He carried a hooked knife for opening irrigation clogs and used it more often than his slate. Every third channel held roots or fallen petals. While Senn asked about light-days, Pel knelt, cleared fibers from a grate, and sent water down another row.

"Twenty-two days gives you first set," he said. "Thirty-three gives stable set on the upper apricots and brings the bean flowers into the same pollinator window."

"How much yield depends on the last eleven?"

"Depends on cloud water, hive strength, and night heat."

"Hold those at expected values."

"I do not hold weather at expected values. The Almanac does that, badly enough for conversation."

Senn waited while he cleared another grate.

Pel wiped the knife on his trousers. "Seven percent for apricots in an ordinary turn. Four for climbing beans. The seed nurseries vary from nothing to twelve."

"Staple effect?"

"Beans, yes. Apricots keep people willing to eat another year."

"Could Orison surrender the extension next turn?"

"Could your office tell forty thousand households to reduce meals by four percent next turn?"

"The city stores reserves."

"For failed rain, mold, bridge closure, and every other risk you prefer to count separately. Remove bloom days without changing those risks and you spend the same reserve twice."

He led her into a seed-start house where trays climbed three stories on rotating racks. Warmth rose through perforated floors. Tiny leaves made the air smell sharp and wet.

"These starts go to six districts," Pel said. "Not only Orison. Caldrift's late beans begin here because their nurseries cannot hold temperature through dark rain. The coast buys our root stock. Two smaller towns abandoned local seed houses after our schedules became reliable."

"Reliable through an allocation not shown publicly."

"You asked what depends on it. Dependence does not wait for honest labels."

Senn inspected the shipping cards. The final seed-start rotation ended on the thirty-second day. One day of margin followed before rain shift. If the city's bloom stopped at the printed turn, several racks would move under electric lamps. Others would ship immature or be discarded.

A stolen benefit would have been easier to despise if it served only ornamental walls. The apricots were beautiful, but hospital reservoirs, bean yields, school hours, and regional seed stock had grown into the same eleven-day extension.

By late afternoon, pollen coated Senn's cuffs. She sat beside a canal gate and arranged her paper sheets on the warm stone. Public bloom ended after twenty-two days. Internal hospital, crop, and school schedules all continued to day thirty-three. Their instrument demands matched the allocation blocks in the winter debit, including the advance warmth that had woken the hives.

She drew a line through each block as it closed.

The final line, urban continuity, resolved into canal storage, tram-glass heating, and night market lamps. None required eleven full days alone. Together they kept municipal demand smooth after the public turn changed. Orison did not merely receive extra light. Its institutions had been designed around the absence of a visible transition.

Senn called Tovin from the canal wall.

His voice arrived under a crack of fabric. "If this is family, I am holding a kite spar over my head."

"It is work."

"Then I am holding two."

"I need reserve absorption capacity for eleven bloom days removed from Orison."

The fabric noise stopped.

"What timescale?" he asked.

"Immediate, then staged options."

"Come to the south hangar."

"Send the figures."

"No. You will read the policy capacity, assume it means physical capacity, and accuse me of hiding a decimal."

"Would I be wrong?"

"South hangar."

Tovin ended the call.

The shade-kite hangars stood beyond Orison's last greenhouse tier, where the city's pale stone gave way to low service buildings anchored against wind. Senn took a maintenance tram. It passed beneath three collapsed kite frames, each longer than a market street. Their black fabric lay folded in ribbed crates. High-atmosphere shade kites did not block Varda directly. They altered where heat entered the ribbon and softened pressure differences before those differences became storms.

Inside the south hangar, Tovin hung from a safety line halfway up a test frame. He had their mother's narrow face and none of Senn's caution about heights. A crew below him tensioned a triangular panel while load meters blinked along its seams.

"You are late," he called.

"You provided no appointment time."

"You inherited that defense from childhood."

Senn put on an impact hood and waited outside the marked fall zone. Tovin drove a locking pin into the spar, tested it twice, then descended. He smelled of resin and cold metal.

"Show me your eleven," he said.

She handed him the folded allocation sheets. He read them standing beside the frame. Unlike Dael, Tovin moved quickly through numbers and returned to the physical object whenever a quantity displeased him. At the hospital reservoir block, he looked up toward the kite fabric. At the seed-start demand, he whistled once.

"You proved the link?"

"Every block. The hidden debit funds eleven extra bloom days embedded in

these schedules.”

“Not decorative light.”

“Some decorative and commercial bloom appears inside municipal continuity. Most of the fixed dependency sits here.” She tapped the hospital, crop, and school sheets.

Tovin rubbed resin from his thumb. “Policy says reserve can absorb twelve Orison-equivalent bloom days.”

“I read the same capacity.”

“Policy imagines the whole fleet deployed at rated tension, with six hours' warning and no active rain shaping.”

“What does the fleet imagine?”

“Kites do not flatter us.”

He led her beneath the suspended frame. Gray patches marked repairs along three seams. Fine sensing threads crossed the fabric like veins. Each thread measured load and sent a release command if tension approached tearing strength.

“Removing light from Orison does not erase it,” Tovin said. “The Choir can turn mirrors away, but central heat already banked in canals and stone keeps moving. If we reduce the next passes too sharply, starward air cools faster than the darkward return. The pressure edge steepens over the greenhouse belt.”

“You shade the starward intake.”

“With active kites. Six are in overhaul. Four shape next week's rain front. Three carry fabric beyond preferred age because procurement counts folded cloth as if it does not fatigue.”

“And reserve?”

Tovin pointed toward a sealed cradle at the far end of the hangar. A black numeral 6 had been painted on its cover.

“Reserve 6 has not flown under full shear load this cycle. Policy counts it at one hundred percent. I count eighty-two until the test proves otherwise.”

“Eighteen percent uncertainty does not consume the whole capacity.”

“No. The hospital reservoir and crop soil do.”

He set the allocation sheets on a workbench and drew three curves across a dusted glass plate. The first showed reflected energy withdrawn. The second tracked stored heat leaving Orison's stone over several days. The third represented kite capacity needed to keep wind exchange below the shear threshold.

“If you cut all eleven at once,” he said, “the fleet absorbs the transition while Orison releases stored warmth unevenly. Greenhouse districts cool slowly. Open canal wards cool fast. You get cross-city pressure cells before the planetary model

sees one clean front.”

“The Almanac can schedule district phases.”

“The Almanac receives roof-temperature summaries every twelve minutes. A torn panel changes the answer in less than one.”

“What staged removal can the reserve carry?”

“Not until I know fabric condition, rain commitments, and which mirrors can spread the angle changes.”

“I need a range.”

“You need permission to write a number. I need the kite not to split.”

Senn heard their old arguments inside the exchange. She had asked for quantities as a child; Tovin had brought her the broken latch or leaking pipe. Each thought the other mistook evidence for temperament.

A crew chief called him to the test rig. The frame would take simulated gust load in five steps. Tovin invited Senn behind the safety screen, perhaps because no explanation of capacity could compete with the sound of fabric under strain.

Pumps drew the panel outward. At twenty percent load, seams straightened. At forty, the entire hangar filled with a low drum note. Sensors painted green lines across the screen. Tovin watched one repaired corner rather than the average.

“Why that seam?” Senn asked.

“Thread response lags.”

“It remains inside tolerance.”

“For now.”

At sixty percent, the corner line turned yellow. Tovin stopped the test. The crew vented pressure, and the fabric settled with a long descending groan.

“Policy would continue to rated load,” he said.

“Would it fail?”

“Unknown. That is why we stop and inspect.”

“Your reserve capacity depends on a fleet full of unknowns.”

“Everything flying contains unknowns. Maintenance decides which ones may enter the sky together.”

They crossed to the panel. A sensing thread had loosened under its clear resin channel. No tear showed in the cloth. The defect only made the crew less certain about where one might begin.

Tovin knelt and marked the channel. “You can write that sudden withdrawal exceeds verified reserve until testing closes. You cannot write that Orison must keep the days.”

“I did not ask for that conclusion.”

"You came here wanting to switch off a theft."

Senn looked at the black fabric, then at her papers on the bench. "I came wanting to know whether it could be switched off."

"And?"

"The question had hidden dependencies."

"Most useful questions do."

He said it without triumph. That made accepting it easier.

The next morning, Senn returned to the greenhouse terraces before the first school shift. She followed the extra allocation forward rather than backward. The hospital had already placed future feverleaf use into treatment plans. Seed houses had promised trays to other districts. Schools had aligned transport heat with longer light. Hive rotations, canal storage, market cooling, and shade-kite maintenance assumed the same duration.

None of this made the winter debit lawful. Reliance could not turn an imposed burden into a weather share. A trade required a district able to refuse, and the debit named no district at all.

Yet closing the account at once would not restore what had been taken. It would transfer risk through systems built during twenty-two years of dependable spring. Hospitals and staple crops had the strongest claim. Schools and transport carried human costs less easily reduced to temperature floors. Decorative blossom could surrender first, but even that loss would alter pollinator timing and municipal work.

At the upper terrace, Senn found the girl from the school carrying another tray of beans. The child held it toward the light while her teacher adjusted a shade screen. One stem had bent during the climb. Senn steadied the tray while the girl tied the stem to a reed with green thread, then tested the knot by turning the leaves toward the mirror.

"Did you find out?" she asked.

"Some of it."

"Where spring comes from?"

Senn looked across Orison. Apricot walls shone white. Canal frost had vanished. Bees moved through air warmed by a debit hidden behind infrastructure language. Farther south, the kite hangars kept their black reserve folded under a capacity figure no prudent pilot trusted.

"It comes through mirrors," Senn said. "It also comes through choices about who receives cold."

The girl frowned at the bean tray. "That sounds worse."

"It is more complete."

Senn walked to the Conservatory with pollen on her coat and the eleven allocation sheets under her arm. By the time she reached her desk, the city's

beauty had stopped serving as an argument against the evidence.

It had become part of the evidence: living systems with roots in the hidden transfer, too dependent to cut blindly and too costly to leave unnamed.

Chapter 4 — The Season Table

Ceryn Ahl turned Lorn Dusk gray before Senn had permission to ask what it contained.

The name appeared only on Senn's private slate. On the circular instrument below, the corresponding sector carried no civic label, no population, and no climate floor. A narrow gray band extended darkward from the inhabited ribbon toward two radiator towers. When Ceryn touched the table's rim, the band faded into the infrastructure layer.

"Keep that layer open," Senn said.

The First Curator looked across the circle. "We have not begun the review."

"You have begun changing the display."

"I am removing maintenance noise from a seasonal allocation question."

Six people stood around the Season Table in the closed central chamber: Ceryn, Senn, Dael, a policy accountant, a crop-risk analyst, and the chamber operator. The doors had sealed behind them. Red light from the pressureworks windows crossed the floor but stopped short of the table, whose projected bands supplied their own color.

Orison glowed green through a broad section of the temperate ribbon. Its eleven added days lay over the city as a second, thinner band. Senn had never seen the benefit rendered so plainly. She had also never seen the gray that balanced it. Public displays clipped the map at the last inhabited districts.

Ceryn addressed the operator. "Restore infrastructure sectors at ten percent intensity."

Gray returned, pale enough to overlook.

"Full intensity," Senn said.

The operator waited for Ceryn.

"Twenty," Ceryn replied.

Senn entered the instruction into her review notes. Ceryn noticed and made no objection.

"Senior Auditor Vale has established that Orison receives physically delivered bloom beyond its published turn," Ceryn said. "The immediate purpose of this session concerns continuity risk during the open origin trace. We will not adjudicate historical policy."

"Historical policy authorizes the current debit."

"That remains your claim to establish."

"The authorization field says inherited from originating order. Your office restricts that order."

"Which makes access a separate matter."

Dael leaned both palms against the table rim. "Light, heat, and restriction still occupy one system."

Ceryn gave him a measured glance. "Your participation concerns mirror geometry, Engineer Orro."

"Geometry also refuses separate matters."

The crop-risk analyst coughed into her hand to hide a response. Ceryn let the interruption pass.

She began with the physical account. At her command, the table lifted Orison's bloom band above the map and divided it by use. Hospital heating showed blue-green. Food production carried a deeper green. Schools and municipal continuity appeared in amber. Decorative and commercial bloom occupied a white outer edge, smaller than Senn had expected but large enough to make the city famous.

On the balancing side, shade tracts darkened. Radiator duty brightened across the gray sectors. Wind-risk tolerance spread as a translucent field over the eastern terraces.

"Remove the winter debit," Ceryn told the operator.

The gray sectors dimmed. Heat remained in the central ribbon. After nine modeled days, a red shear line formed over Orison and thickened toward the canal districts.

No one at the table treated it as a prediction. It represented a known risk under stated assumptions, useful only if the assumptions remained visible.

Senn opened the model key. "You preserved all eleven bloom days while removing only the balancing debit."

"Yes."

"That tests cancellation without correction."

"It tests the current risk created by your freeze."

"My freeze allows existing schedules for thirty-six hours and requires named renewal after that. It does not command eleven days of unchanged delivery."

Ceryn folded her hands. "What replacement schedule did you submit?"

"None. I lack the source categories."

"Then the operator used the schedule we have."

The exchange had the polished quality of a corridor floor: no single step looked

dangerous, but every direction favored the institution that owned it.

Senn touched the table and restored the gray infrastructure bands. "Show the protected floor for this sector."

NO HABITATION FLOOR appeared above it.

"Show equipment tolerance."

A web of blue limits covered the radiator towers, heat walls, coolant lines, and service roads. Domestic warming demand entered the web as a load. Medical reserve appeared as another equipment requirement. School-cycle consumption had been condensed into a periodic service peak.

"Why does a radiator sector have a school-cycle load?" Senn asked.

The policy accountant read from his slate. "Service instruction and dependent shift care."

"Continuous through every turn?"

"Operations are continuous."

"Birth records?"

"Not in the instrument bundle."

"Burial heat?"

"Could reflect furnace maintenance."

Dael's damaged fingers tightened on the table rim.

Senn shifted her attention to a second gray band. Its load curve displayed domestic heating at night-equivalent intervals. A third carried clinic storage and greenhouse illumination. None had an address ledger attached because the Almanac category did not request one.

"How many people live inside these sectors?" she asked.

Ceryn answered without consulting anyone. "The Conservatory does not maintain resident totals for thermal service precincts."

"That is not zero."

"No."

The single word altered the chamber more than a denial would have. Ceryn never lied about a number once directly asked. Here she protected herself by refusing to pretend the absent total meant an empty place.

"Do people live there?" Senn asked.

"Personnel and dependents remain near darkward infrastructure."

"Continuously?"

"Yes."

"For how many years?"

"That question enters the historical policy matter I excluded from this review."

Senn marked the answer.

The crop-risk analyst, Rema Tal, moved Orison's food band into the center. "If the auditor's freeze causes a lapse, seed starts fail before policy access changes anything. Can we separate hospital and staple use from the outer bloom?"

"We can separate the account," Dael said. "The atmosphere will be less courteous."

"Give me the uncourteous version."

He spread the withdrawal over six mirror passes. The white decorative edge vanished first. Hospital reservoirs retained their input. Crop walls lost upper-tier light while seed houses stayed protected. Pressure differences formed along the city but remained below the red shear line for three days.

"After that?" Rema asked.

"Stored canal heat exits unevenly. Shade support becomes necessary."

"Available?"

"Not at published reserve."

Ceryn looked at him. "Maintenance reports thirty-six kites operational."

"Operational does not mean available for this transition."

"Your report lists reserve capacity above the modeled requirement."

"My report lists rated capacity and maintenance state. Someone else condensed them."

Senn thought of Tovin under the test frame, watching one lagging seam while policy counted the whole panel. The table rendered capacity as a smooth black arc. It did not show a loose sensing thread.

Ceryn asked the operator to save Dael's staged model. "This supports managed exposure during review."

Senn looked up from her notes. "Define that phrase."

"Maintain present balancing within verified equipment tolerance while we establish a safe transition."

"For the gray sectors, present balancing includes imposed winter beyond an inhabited district's protected floor."

"You have not established district status."

"You have established continuous personnel, dependents, medical demand, school-cycle load, and domestic heat."

"Those facts may support a status review. Until one occurs, the allocation remains governed by its existing category."

"Then managed exposure means continuing the burden while the institution restricts evidence required to challenge it."

Ceryn's face did not harden. Her attention grew more exact. "It means

preventing an unmodeled correction from crossing survival limits elsewhere.”

“Whose survival limit appears for these sectors?”

“Equipment tolerance remains visible.”

“I asked about people.”

“The table cannot render a climate floor without recognized habitation.”

“Recognition requires the archive you will not open.”

The operator kept his hands flat beside the controls. Rema studied the crop band. The policy accountant stopped pretending to annotate.

Ceryn touched the table's outer ring and rotated the entire map. Gray sectors passed beneath her fingers. “You believe category follows fact directly. It does not. Category follows a legal finding based on fact. Without that sequence, every maintenance camp, seasonal crew barracks, and temporary shelter could alter the planetary floor during an active schedule.”

“Does every temporary shelter remain for decades?”

“You do not yet know the duration.”

“Because you restrict it.”

Ceryn let out a breath through her nose. “When I was nineteen, the pre-Choir allocations failed during a fungal famine. Local officials opened stores without coordination. Three districts protected their own seed. Two hospitals lost heat because no one preserved the central balance. My family did not survive the second shortage.”

No appeal entered her voice. She offered the history as context, not absolution.

“I have watched correct local claims destroy a planetary schedule,” she continued. “The Conservatory exists so necessity does not become a contest won by whoever can reach a valve first.”

Senn understood the argument. That made its omission clearer.

“A floor protects necessity from trade,” she said. “You cannot defend planetary coordination by hiding which people have one.”

“I am defending the sequence by which we establish it.”

“Your sequence begins after the burden.”

“Every inherited system begins after something.”

Dael looked from one woman to the other. “Metal does not pause for jurisdiction. Nor do lungs.”

Ceryn turned to him. “Which is why your unauthorized offsets present a separate stability risk.”

“You have not shown instability from them.”

“You concealed receiving geometry from an auditor.”

"I kept a clinic window inside tolerance."

Rema shifted back from the table. The unnamed place now had a function in the official room, though not a location.

Ceryn said, "Submit the geometry under sealed maintenance review by tomorrow."

Dael glanced at Senn. She had promised only that a compelled request would enter the record. Ceryn's instruction now stood in the chamber log.

"I will submit a risk statement," he said.

"That did not answer the instruction."

"It answered what I can submit without exposing an unrecognized facility to enforcement."

Ceryn did not threaten him. "Your license terms make that decision reviewable."

"Then review it."

The table continued to glow between them, beautifully indifferent to professional ruin.

Senn returned to the gray sectors. "Display district totals."

The operator brought up forty-one inhabited bands with population, climate floor, traded surplus, and current risk. Gray infrastructure remained outside the total.

"Add these sectors to the denominator as unclassified occupancy," she said.

"I cannot assign population," he replied.

"Add their measured thermal demand."

"That mixes civic totals with equipment units."

"The existing category already mixes them. Show the result."

He looked to Ceryn again.

"Permit the comparison," Ceryn said.

The operator converted domestic heat, clinic reserve, school cycles, and greenhouse illumination into a demand-equivalent band. Gray widened along the darkward edge. Orison's share of discretionary benefit decreased. The planetary total no longer closed under the district view because substantial lived demand existed beyond its civic boundary.

Senn asked him to isolate the largest sector and run a standard winter interruption. The operator hesitated over the controls.

"Standard for equipment or habitation?" he asked.

"That distinction concerns the review. Run both."

Under equipment rules, the model allowed domestic heat to fall until radiator bearings approached their preferred range. Clinic storage retained a narrow

protected line because medicine counted as maintenance supply. School-cycle load disappeared during the interruption. The sector remained blue, indicating acceptable machinery conditions.

The habitation model required assumptions the current file did not contain. Senn entered the measured continuous heat as a floor proxy and marked it provisional. Amber spread through the heat-wall network within six hours. By the second modeled day, the clinic reserve could protect treatment storage or household warming, not both.

"Clear the proxy," Ceryn said.

"After the output saves."

"It has no certified population basis."

"It uses the demand your schedule already supplies."

"Demand does not establish minimum entitlement."

"It establishes what goes cold."

Dael pointed to the radiator load. "Equipment safety improves in the first model because living spaces surrender heat. The table calls that spare tolerance."

Ceryn examined the two outputs side by side. "Which proves why we need verified status before converting operational loads into Charter floors."

"Or why excluding status produces a false margin," Senn said.

Rema asked for the same interruption across the other gray sectors. One showed a greenhouse load large enough to preserve staple starts under equipment rules, though domestic walls could lose heat. Another protected coolant pumps while a periodic medical draw fell below its current pattern. The third lacked enough raw detail to model anything beyond aggregate power.

"Who owns these instrument bundles?" Rema asked.

"Darkward maintenance coordination," the accountant said.

"Can they certify the uses?"

Ceryn answered, "Maintenance can certify measurement. Civic use requires policy verification."

"So the people who see the loads cannot name them, while the people allowed to name them do not collect the loads."

"That separation prevents local operators from assigning legal status through instrumentation."

"It also prevents this room from seeing what its tolerances permit," Rema said.

The crop analyst had entered the review to protect Orison's yield. Now she watched a modeled clinic line disappear beneath acceptable blue. Senn did not mistake discomfort for alliance. Rema could recognize the category's harm and still oppose any correction that endangered seed starts.

The operator saved the interruption outputs inside the restricted session bundle. Export symbols remained red, but each model now had a timestamp and six witnesses.

Rema leaned closer. "How long has the denominator excluded that load?"

The accountant answered, "The current series inherits its precinct definitions."

"From when?"

"Originating policy."

The same phrase had become a locked door every office could point toward.

Senn asked the operator to save the comparison. A red restriction symbol appeared.

"Why can I not attach it to the origin trace?"

"Policy-derived category conflict," he said. "The instrument data can leave this room. The combined civic rendering cannot without First Curator release."

Ceryn said, "I will release the physical model and the staged-risk comparison. The gray-sector reconstruction remains internal pending legal review."

"It uses measurements already in my audit bundle."

"It also assigns civic meaning the current measurements do not possess."

"Meaning or consequence?"

"Both require authority."

Senn saved the raw demand conversion on paper, writing each value by hand because the table would not export its combined image. The operator watched, uncertain whether copying visible numbers violated the restriction. Ceryn allowed her to finish.

When Senn reached the last sector, she noticed a narrow gap between its current winter burden and equipment tolerance. The table showed that gap as available capacity. If people occupied the sector, their own heat demand filled much of it. Under the infrastructure category, human use counted against machinery but did not establish a floor. The system recognized bodies as load and rejected them as claimants.

"Does managed exposure have a maximum duration?" she asked.

Ceryn consulted the meeting clock. "Until safe transition parameters are approved or the category changes."

"That is not a duration."

"It depends on work not yet complete."

"Who reviews continuation?"

"My office."

"Under what legal authority?"

"The originating emergency classification and inherited seasonal powers."

"Name the classification."

Ceryn looked toward the policy accountant. He lowered his slate.

"Thermal service precinct," she said.

The term entered the official transcript.

The accountant requested a recess to consult policy counsel. Ceryn denied it.

"If the category governs current allocation, this room can name its basis without counsel," she said.

Senn noted the decision. "Does the originating classification authorize exclusion from public forecast notice?"

"I will not interpret unseen language from memory."

"Then release it."

"Archive access and interpretation follow separate controls."

"Which control allows the table to use the result while denying the rule?"

Ceryn looked at the gray bands. "Operational continuity. The Conservatory cannot stop every inherited instruction while its legal file travels upstairs."

"How long does a legal file travel?" Dael asked.

"That depends on the challenge."

"Longer than light."

Ceryn ignored the line. She directed the operator to attach the session transcript to any archive petition Senn filed, but not the restricted models themselves. The concession gave Senn proof that the chamber had discussed the category. It withheld the clearest display of its consequences.

Senn searched current policy from her wrist slate. No public Charter manual returned the category. An index reference pointed to sealed emergency orders below the Conservatory. Access required archival authorization or a written legal basis from the First Curator.

She opened a formal request field.

Ceryn watched her. "You may submit an archive petition after the session."

"I am submitting a narrower question now."

"State it."

Senn wrote while the Season Table held the darkward sectors at twenty percent gray.

Identify the current legal category and active authority under which continuously occupied thermal service precincts are excluded from district totals, climate-floor rendering, and civic forecast notice.

She selected WRITTEN RESPONSE REQUIRED. The field asked for grounds. She

attached the First Curator's acknowledgment of continuous personnel and dependents, the measured domestic and clinic loads, and the table's exclusion from district totals.

Ceryn read the request across the shared review display.

"You have combined technical findings with a legal conclusion," she said.

"I requested the category behind the findings. You may correct my conclusion in writing."

The policy accountant shifted his weight. A spoken refusal could later become context. A written answer had to name the door and who held its key.

Ceryn touched her seal to the receipt field. "Response due by the end of tomorrow."

The operator printed a narrow transaction strip and passed it across the table. Senn checked the request number, due time, and attached transcript range before she signed receipt. Ceryn added her own witness mark. No later summary could reduce the exchange to an informal question raised during technical discussion.

The request left Senn's slate and entered the Conservatory record. She folded the paper strip around her handwritten sector values and placed both inside the origin-trace envelope, where removal would require a second seal.

Only then did the chamber operator close the infrastructure layer. Gray sectors vanished from the Season Table, but their measured loads remained on Senn's paper in blue ink, widening the planetary total beyond the map permitted on the screen.

Chapter 5 — Order Nine

Pera Iven put both hands beneath the archive box and refused to let Senn lift it by the cord.

"The cord closes the lid," she said. "It does not forgive gravity."

"I was not going to carry it by the cord."

"You had the look."

"What look?"

"The efficient one."

Pera set the box on a felt pad and loosened its brass clasp. Blue dust marked her fingertips. Around them, the emergency archive descended in narrow iron aisles below the Conservatory. Paper occupied the coldest rooms. The ventilation kept mold low, ink stable, and every clerk unhappy after twenty minutes.

Senn had been below for an hour.

The written response from Ceryn's office had arrived that morning. It named the category as THERMAL SERVICE PRECINCT under inherited emergency authority, then cited Order 9 and six renewal instruments. It did not provide the documents. Access remained subject to archive handling rules, which required a clerk to retrieve paper originals because the policy scans were sealed against general export.

Pera had read the response twice and said, "That category sounds like an administrative ghost."

Now she opened the first box.

Inside lay construction permits, radiator schematics, food allotments, temporary shelter rolls, and weather exceptions from thirty-one years earlier. Every bundle carried a blue thermal-ink label fading toward brown at its handled edges. The paper smelled of mineral sizing, old cold, and the faint oil used on order seals in the lower archive.

The present Choir comprised 240 mirrors, 36 shade kites, and 18 radiator towers. These papers came from the smaller system that had not yet commissioned its final darkward towers, when a temporary camp could still sound temporary to someone reading in Orison.

"Order series runs by emergency domain," Pera said. "Crop, transit, medical, thermal, civil. The number alone does not give us a shelf because previous archivists believed future people would enjoy puzzles."

"Ceryn's response cites thermal."

"Thermal contains nine boxes for that year. Some numbering resets by quarter."

"Efficient."

"You have the look again."

They began with the index cards. Senn read headings while Pera checked embossed seals under a low side lamp. The emergency had covered radiator construction delays, worker housing, coolant rationing, and a pressure-front deviation that threatened two unfinished towers. Temporary camps appeared across four darkward work zones.

The first reference to precincts occurred in a food allocation note. *Service precinct population to be provisioned under equipment-support headcount pending Order 9 classification.*

"Population," Senn said.

Pera leaned over her shoulder. "Not equipment load."

"Before the order."

"Someone knew workers ate even before policy improved them."

Senn copied the reference. Pera found a corresponding shelter roll with one hundred eighty-six names. Each had an expected departure date within two years.

Family status showed only for medical rationing.

"Construction camps can contain families," Senn said.

"They can. The question concerns when temporary stopped describing them."

The next box held the originating meeting papers. A gray ribbon separated drafts from adopted orders. Pera checked every page number before allowing Senn to unfold the packet.

Order 9 began with three pages of engineering necessity. Towers 12 through 18 had to remain staffed through extended winter operation. Construction weather had exceeded its allocation. The Charter's inhabited-district process would take longer than the emergency allowed. Therefore four named zones would receive a temporary thermal service precinct classification.

The fourth page defined the legal effect.

Residents would draw heating, medical support, and food through infrastructure accounts. Precinct occupancy would not enter district climate-floor calculations. Local settlement rights remained deferred because the camps existed solely for completion and maintenance of planetary equipment.

Senn read the phrase twice. "It calls them residents here."

"And occupancy in the next line," Pera said. "Then removes both from habitation."

"The category does not claim no people exist."

"It claims their presence belongs to the equipment."

They reached the duration clause.

Authority shall expire upon commissioning of the designated towers or five years from adoption, whichever occurs first. Continuation requires civic-status review under the Charter of Habitation.

Pera placed a paper marker beside it. "There is your legal answer."

"It expired."

"Unless a renewal altered the duration."

"Ceryn cited six."

"Then someone kept teaching the ghost new dates."

Senn recorded the exact language, including the review requirement. The original signatures belonged to emergency governors now dead or retired. Ceryn's name did not appear. At the time of adoption, she had not led the Conservatory.

Pera turned the final page over. The reverse carried a routing stamp to the Almanac policy office: OCCUPANCY LOAD TO REMAIN EQUIPMENT-ONLY FOR ALLOCATION PURPOSES.

That instruction explained the Season Table's gray bands. It also predated permanent households, local births, and any evidence Senn could yet prove

existed.

"Find the commissioning dates," Senn said.

Pera consulted the infrastructure register. "Towers 12 through 15 entered service within three years. Sixteen and seventeen in year four. Eighteen missed the five-year limit by seven months."

"So most precinct authority should have ended before the maximum."

"If the whichever-comes-first clause survived renewal."

They requested the first continuation box. The retrieval system responded with a shelf code two levels deeper.

A hand lift carried them below the public archive floors. Frost edged the iron rails. Pera distributed fingerless archive gloves and warned Senn not to breathe directly over thermal ink.

"Does anyone?"

"Senior officials lean closer when a document contradicts them."

The first renewal had been filed one month before the five-year limit. Its opening report acknowledged permanent repair crews, expanded greenhouses, two births, and a burial ground. A settlement survey had been ordered but not completed. The continuation extended the classification for three years pending civic review.

"Already outside the original purpose," Senn said.

"Already carrying the facts needed for habitation."

"Continuous civic heat, address ledger, births or burials."

Pera counted on blue-stained fingers. "Heat through the infrastructure account. Births and burial here. No ledger yet."

A reference in the survey annex read: *Local address book maintained by precinct keeper; format not certified.*

"Ledger," Senn said.

"Apparently a book becomes an address ledger only after the right office admires its binding."

They copied the line.

The second renewal followed three years later. It shortened the stated purpose to operational continuity and removed construction language from the header. Its attached survey listed households by heat-wall section but withheld district status until radiator staffing stabilized.

The third cited crop instability and extended the category another three years. The fourth cited darkward maintenance shortages. Each included a recommendation for review. Each postponed that review until after the present weather risk.

A pattern emerged in the margins. Early pages used temporary residents. Later

clerks wrote precinct households. Medical allotments changed from shift casualty provision to clinic reserve. School transport appeared under dependent instruction. The category remained unchanged while its contents learned to walk, vote locally, grow food, bury relatives, and repair the walls that heated them.

Senn's feet had gone numb by the time they opened the fifth renewal box.

Pera made her stand on the warming grate while they logged the first four packets back into temporary custody. A temperature tag had shifted from blue to white on one folder, so Pera replaced its felt pad and waited until the paper cooled inside range. No discovery excused damaging the record that carried it. Senn flexed feeling into her toes and copied the custody times while the archive pipes ticked overhead. When the tag darkened again, Pera sealed the earlier box before touching the next clasp.

The file was thicker than the others. Its seal named the severe crop emergency seventeen years earlier. Fungal loss had struck central seed stores. Hospital nutrition demand exceeded reserve. The Conservatory redirected maximum bloom toward seven ribbon cities and increased darkward radiator duty.

Pera read the first page in silence. "This one had a real emergency."

"They all cite one."

"This one has mortality forecasts attached."

Senn examined them. Without expanded bloom, food deficit models crossed hospital thresholds in four districts. The risk did not excuse an unlawful category, but it explained why an administrator might avoid reopening every dependency while crops failed.

The renewal language extended precinct status for the emergency duration plus one turn, subject to full review afterward. An annex acknowledged permanent households and requested a plan for climate-floor recognition once central reserves recovered.

The signature page was missing.

Page numbering moved from eleven to thirteen. Binding holes showed that a sheet had once sat between them. Blue fibers clung to the cord where someone had removed paper without unbinding the packet cleanly.

Pera brought the side lamp close. "Not a scanning omission."

"Could it be misfiled?"

"Could be. It could also be sleeping inside someone's harmless crop annex."

"Who had authority to sign?"

"The First Curator, two emergency governors, or a delegated panel if the instrument changed Charter status."

"Does the routing record name the signatory?"

Pera checked the back sheet. "Received under valid seal. No name."

Senn looked at the empty interval between pages. She did not yet know who had approved the fifth continuation. Guessing would turn evidence into theater.

Pera did not accept the vacancy until she had tested the packet's assembly marks. Every renewal sheet carried a pinprick code near its lower edge, almost invisible unless light passed through the paper. She arranged pages nine through thirteen over a glass plate and dimmed the room lamp.

Codes formed a sequence of tiny bars. Page eleven ended with a left-facing notch. Page thirteen began with the matching right-facing half. A sheet from the same print run had occupied the gap.

"Could page twelve have contained only a routing cover?" Senn asked.

"Routing covers use coarse paper and no sequence marks. This belonged to the instrument."

Pera measured the torn blue fibers under a lens. "Removed after binding. Not recent. The exposed ends have browned with the rest of the packet."

They searched the box lining, then the paired crop-emergency folders. Senn lifted every annex while Pera checked folio numbers. A fungal-loss report held three detached authorization sheets, all for seed transport. A hospital allocation contained a signature page filed backward, but its order code differed.

The shelf register showed that the renewal packet had left the archive four times. Two withdrawals supported later policy migrations. One went to crop accounting. The oldest had no borrower name because the former ledger recorded offices only.

"Can we infer where the page went?" Senn asked.

"We can list where it might have traveled. We cannot select the most satisfying destination."

"Policy archive?"

"Possible. Crop annex, possible. Misfile, possible. Deliberate removal, also possible." Pera wrote each in the condition report with equal spacing. "Suspicion needs good shelving."

"Record missing page twelve," Senn said. "Include fiber condition and intact sequence marks."

Pera wrote the note on a separate sheet, signed it, and asked Senn to witness. "Now nobody can put a page back and claim it never traveled."

"Do you expect that?"

"I expect archives to contain everyone's past confidence. People become imaginative when confidence ages badly."

The sixth renewal had no ordinary signature packet. It consisted of an inheritance notice generated after the crop emergency ended. Existing classifications would continue while policy review queues cleared. A clerk had

marked the precinct file for review, but an automated continuation field had carried the category into the next seasonal cycle.

After that came annual administrative notices rather than formal renewals.

"How many?" Senn asked.

Pera checked the box depth. "Enough to ruin dinner."

They sampled the first, middle, and current years, then returned for every notice when the wording began to shift. Early forms read REVIEW REQUIRED. Later versions added continuity pending review. Seven years before the present, a policy migration converted the inherited status into active until superseded.

No official had to choose the burden again. The system treated the absence of a superseding order as permission to continue.

Senn laid the notices in chronological order along the felt table. "The current authority cites the originating emergency."

"Which gave five years."

"Then formal renewals extended it."

"Without the fifth signature page."

"And administrative inheritance carried it after the last stated review."

Pera tapped the current notice. "This does not renew the legal authority. It only says the database found no replacement."

"Policy may argue inherited seasonal powers."

"Policy may argue a cupboard remains locked because no one located the key. That does not turn the cupboard into a law."

Senn almost smiled. "Put that in the remarks field."

"I prefer continued employment."

They moved to the current cross-reference bundle. Ceryn's written response had cited only the order and renewal chain, but Senn wanted every live system attached to the category. Pera requested policy indexes, measurement ledgers, and address-related fields.

The policy index arrived first. Thermal service precinct mapped to equipment occupancy, maintenance staffing, medical reserve, dependent instruction, and local provision. The measurement index attached radiator loads, domestic heat, greenhouse lamps, burial furnace use, and clinic storage.

The address index returned ACCESS RESTRICTED, then offered a set of reference codes.

Pera stared at the screen. "It says addresses exist."

"It says references exist."

"Current references. Look at the update dates."

Each precinct code linked to a live external ledger source. The Conservatory did

not ingest names, but it queried household counts whenever it calculated heater demand. One source updated every seven days. Another recorded additions after births. A third adjusted heat-wall occupancy when someone moved.

Pera opened the query history rather than the protected ledgers. The first visible transaction asked how many heated rooms had changed occupancy since the prior schedule. A second requested age bands for clinic-reserve forecasting, stripped of names before it entered the Almanac. The latest transaction sought school-cycle participation by heat-wall section.

"Those are civic questions," Senn said.

"Asked through an equipment interface."

"Can we see who designed the interface?"

Pera traced its revision history. The earliest form asked for worker bunks and active shifts. Later revisions replaced bunks with heated rooms, then households. A policy migration had preserved the output label as occupancy units even after the input became local addresses.

Senn compared two consecutive weekly returns. The household total changed by one. A note attributed the change to a new address assignment after a birth record. No name crossed into Conservatory custody, but the added heater demand entered the next winter calculation.

"Can we attach this history?"

"The query language, yes. Local values remain restricted." Pera printed the field definitions and stamped them as derivative records. "This proves what the system asks, not who answered."

"It proves the category needs household facts to function."

"It also proves someone took care to strip the words that would make those facts civic."

"Equipment-only occupancy with address-ledger references," Senn said.

"The ghost receives mail."

They printed the index results because export restrictions blocked the linked data. Each page carried reference codes, update times, and query purposes. The system used address changes to forecast domestic heat while denying that those addresses established habitation.

One code recurred across clinic reserve, school-cycle demand, and burial heat. It belonged to the largest gray sector on the Season Table. Senn entered it into the archive catalog. A bound local ledger appeared as the source, held outside Conservatory custody. The place name remained masked under policy classification.

"Can we unmask it from paper?" she asked.

"Not in this series. External registers sit in correspondence or field survey."

"Find the most recent survey request."

Pera searched. The terminal produced a travel authorization draft from eight years earlier, canceled before issue. Another appeared four years later. Both cited the need to verify continuous occupancy at radiator settlements. Neither named the places in the visible header.

A current maintenance route attached to the same codes, scheduled three days from now. Its destination field remained sealed, but the travel office had assigned darkward transit provisions to two Conservatory staff.

Senn recognized Dael's engineer code among them.

The second traveler field stood blank.

"He has a route," she said.

Pera read the schedule. "You have an origin trace and a written restriction. Does that authorize field verification?"

"It authorizes me to establish whether the debit affects a climate floor."

"Policy will disagree."

"They can do it in writing."

Pera rubbed warmth back into her hands. "I would like to be present when you say that."

"You have spent seven hours in a basement with me. Do not become reckless."

They reboxed every document in reverse order. Pera aligned page edges, replaced gray ribbons, and tied each cord without pulling against the lid. The missing signature sheet received a vacancy marker cut to the exact page size. When the packet closed, the blank paper remained visible between pages eleven and thirteen.

Before shelving Order 9, Senn read the duration clause once more. Five years or tower commissioning, whichever came first. Civic review required for continuation. The language contained no power to defer recognition indefinitely because weather remained difficult.

At the upper archive desk, Pera prepared a retrieval report. She listed the originating order, six continuations, administrative inheritance notices, the missing page, and current address references. Her summary avoided conclusions. Precision gave the facts their own pressure.

Senn attached the report to her origin trace and requested access to the external address ledgers. The system denied the request under the same thermal service precinct category she was challenging.

She appealed through field verification. This time the travel office accepted the filing and placed her name in the blank traveler field beside Dael's.

"Destination still masked," Pera said.

"It will appear when the route opens."

“Comforting.”

On the desk between them, the current index printout showed weekly household updates feeding an account that claimed equipment-only occupancy. New addresses changed heat demand. Birth-related additions changed reserve forecasts. Local burial use altered furnace schedules. The Conservatory trusted each reference enough to balance weather against it.

Senn folded the printout beside her travel authorization. Order 9 had begun as a five-year exception for construction work. Thirty-one years later, live address-ledger references still entered through its equipment category, carrying households into the calculation without carrying their right to refuse.

Chapter 6 — The City Under Winter

The reflected dawn failed while Senn still had one boot on the tram step.

A white seam had been growing along the eastern cut, narrow enough to mistake for frost on the glass. Dael had watched it through the final descent from the ridge station. When the seam should have opened across Lorn Dusk, it contracted to a pin, trembled, and disappeared.

Nobody on the platform looked up twice.

Porters kept unloading insulated grain bins. Two children dragged a sled of ceramic heat vanes between the rails. A woman in a quilted coat turned the dial on a public light post, extending its lamp by another hour with the practiced annoyance of someone correcting a familiar lie.

Senn stepped down into air that bit through her trouser seams. “The transit schedule marked a dawn window.”

“Transit schedules mark many ambitions,” Dael said.

His breath smoked under the platform lamps. Above them, permanent night remained complete except for a green auroral thread and the red warning points on radiator towers 14 and 15. Their vibration traveled through the rails into Senn's boot soles, too low to hear cleanly. She felt it in her teeth.

A station board clicked from REFLECTED DAWN to MUNICIPAL LIGHT CONSERVATION. No cancellation notice followed. No cause appeared. The board simply revised the present as if no other present had been promised.

Senn took out her slate. “Which mirror carried the window?”

“Not yet.” Dael closed his hand over its edge. His burned fingers did not straighten, even inside thick gloves. “You came to see a place. Let it arrive before you turn it into a fault code.”

She considered telling him that the fault code had arrived first. Instead she put the slate away.

A person waited beyond the freight arch with a lantern hung from a hooked staff. They wore a mechanic's coat patched at both elbows and carried no Conservatory insignia. Gray hair showed beneath a wool cap. Their gaze settled on Senn, moved to Dael, then returned to the clean seams of Senn's audit coat.

"Dael Orro," they said. "You have taken your time."

"I brought an auditor. That made every gate slower."

"Auditors increase in mass near locked doors."

Senn offered her hand. "Senn Vale."

"Hesh Dara." Their mitten touched hers once. "Keeper of the address ledger, because a place excluded from the map has to appoint someone to remember where its doors are."

Hesh led them under the freight arch before Senn could answer. Lorn Dusk descended through a shallow basalt basin around the two radiator towers. From the ridge, Conservatory diagrams rendered the basin as service roads, heat conduits, and maintenance sheds. At street level, its geometry belonged to use rather than planning. Enclosed bridges joined roofs to preserve warmth. Greenhouse windows glowed violet behind frost shutters. Painted signs advertised vane repair, fermented root cakes, coat mending, and three performances at the coolant-cistern theater.

The failed dawn changed work without stopping it. Shopkeepers clipped portable lamps above counters. A school procession crossed the main lane carrying shared heat bricks under canvas. Mechanics at an open wall recess shifted a household exchanger from reflected-light mode to stored return heat. Nobody behaved as though darkness proved an emergency. Everyone paid for it in small labor.

Senn watched an old man lift two heat bricks from a communal cart. "How often do windows cancel without notice?"

Hesh kept walking. "You have asked for a total before learning what we count."

"I asked how often."

"Then you will dislike the answer until you understand the nouns."

Dael made a quiet sound that could have meant sympathy for either of them.

Their route narrowed between buildings whose outer walls shared a continuous copper pipe at shoulder height. Residents pressed gloved palms to inspection plates as they passed. Every fifth doorway had a ceramic tag showing current wall temperature and the next household's duty shift.

Hesh stopped beside a plate marked 42.6. "Shared heat wall. Return flow comes off tower coolant after the exchanger strips industrial contaminants. Every address accepts a temperature band and a maintenance watch. When a reflected window arrives, domestic demand falls and we bank the excess. When a window disappears, somebody feeds the wall."

A teenage mechanic crouched below the pipe with a ceramic wrench. Hesh

asked, "Loss?"

"Point six across the western run."

"Valve or seam?"

"Seam near the school coupling. Mara took felt and clamps."

"Put the clinic branch above domestic reserve until she closes it."

The mechanic turned the wrench one notch. Heat clicked through the pipe. No central dispatcher authorized the change, yet each doorway tag updated as the local control loop accepted it.

Senn crouched beside him. "Does this meter feed the Conservatory?"

"Tower service does." He looked to Hesh before continuing. "Household tags feed our hall."

"Why separate them?"

"Because your ledger calls my kitchen a coolant accessory."

Hesh thanked him and moved on.

Cold collected in Senn's cuffs. She had expected hardship because the instruments showed hardship. Expectation had not supplied workshops, school duty, theater notices, or the quick resentment of a mechanic who knew precisely how his kitchen entered her accounts. The place required no romance to disprove its category. It only required doors.

At the next junction, three women rolled insulated soil trays from a greenhouse annex. Pale shoots stood in neat rows under low amber lamps. One woman held a tray toward Dael.

"Eyr stock," she said. "Your aunt's bean line, unless she lied to improve the sale."

"She would call that calibration." Dael pinched one leaf between his fingertips. "Too much blue in the nursery light."

"We lost the blue quarter with dawn."

He looked toward the dark cut where the reflected seam had vanished. "Use amber for six hours, then half-cycle the violet. Don't chase growth with heat."

Senn heard the familiarity beneath his instruction. "You have worked here recently."

Dael released the leaf. "Recently covers useful ground."

"How much ground?"

Hesh opened a frost-stiff door. "You may interrogate him after tea. Lorn Dusk has endured winter without the additional burden of watching two Conservatory employees quarrel in a lane."

Warm air touched Senn's face. The address hall occupied a former parts depot with a high arched ceiling. Shelves held bound books instead of tower bearings. A

communal stove burned pressed greenhouse waste near the entrance. On the far wall, thousands of names had been painted in narrow white lines, grouped by street and household rather than year.

The room contained more people than Senn expected. A birth clerk wrote beside a steaming kettle. Two couriers sorted maintenance slips. An elderly couple argued over whether a lane number had moved when a bridge closed. At a long table, a child copied names from a household card into a practice book.

Hesh hung the lantern from a ceiling hook. "Coats stay on. The western seam is losing heat."

Senn approached the shelves. The oldest volumes used rough construction paper. Later books carried leather corners, stitched repairs, and heat-darkened labels. Each spine listed a range of addresses. Several began before the emergency order's five-year limit could have ended.

"Continuous?" she asked.

"From the first camp row."

"Births and burials?"

"Separate indexes, cross-bound by address."

"Civic heat records?"

"Wall logs downstairs."

The Charter tests assembled themselves in her mind: continuous heat, an address ledger, local births or burials. Hesh had named all three without citing law.

Senn set her case on the long table and removed a pair of archive gloves. "I request permission to inspect and copy the ledger sections corresponding to current tower telemetry."

"No," Hesh said.

The refusal came without anger. Senn had encountered officials who denied access through delay, procedural ambiguity, or a sudden need to consult absent superiors. Hesh simply stood between her and the shelves.

"I have an open origin trace carrying protected climate-floor implications."

"You have a Conservatory seal."

"That seal permits evidentiary collection."

"From recognized districts." Hesh took a cup from the stove shelf. "Your permit cannot decide whether it applies here without first deciding the matter under dispute."

Senn disliked the accuracy more than the refusal. "A witnessed copy would preserve your custody."

"Custody has preserved itself for three decades."

Dael accepted a cup from the birth clerk and did not intervene.

“Without documentary comparison,” Senn said, “policy accounting will call my field observations anecdotal.”

“Your office called our addresses equipment labels when we sent them voluntarily.”

“That happened before my trace.”

“Every central visitor believes history began when their file opened.”

The child at the table stopped writing. Hesh noticed and lowered their voice, though none of the force left it.

Senn folded the archive gloves together. “What condition would permit inspection?”

“Inspection has begun. Copying has not.”

“I am looking at spines.”

“You are looking at a room that your maps deny. Try to gather evidence from it.”

Hesh gave Senn a cup. The tea tasted of roasted root and mineral-heavy water. Around them, clerks continued their work. A courier brought three household changes to the table: one family moving across the west bridge, a mechanic taking a room above the vane shop, and a baby assigned the same address as her mother. The birth clerk challenged the bridge number. The elderly couple joined the dispute. Within two minutes the room resolved which door would receive emergency heat if the west bridge failed.

No one consulted the Conservatory.

Before the ink dried, a delivery worker came in with a heater strapped to his back. He had carried it from an empty room on Lantern Row to a family above the market whose youngest child had developed a cough. The transfer needed two address marks: one to show where the heater had left the wall balance, another to assign responsibility for its filters. Lio Marr checked both against a paper street diagram patched with translucent cloth.

Senn asked why the heater did not remain attached to its registered room.

“Rooms do not breathe,” Lio said. “People do.”

The answer exposed another category error, local and quickly corrected. A fixed asset register would have preserved the heater's location while defeating its use. Lorn Dusk kept both facts: which wall owned the machine and which lungs needed it tonight.

Hesh showed Senn the reverse of the transfer slip. Three earlier loans filled the margins, each signed by the receiving household and the duty mechanic. “Our records move because our heat moves. If you copy one page without its relations, your office will call the crossings inconsistent.”

“Are they reconciled at the end of each winter turn?”

“Every six days during ordinary load. Every night during a cancellation.”

Senn examined the signatures without touching the slip. A clean central record would have condensed the heater into domestic demand. Here, its movement joined a child, a filter schedule, two rooms, and the person obliged to bring it back. The detail did not weaken evidentiary value. It explained why a total alone could not carry custody.

Hesh waited until the entries had dried, then took Senn through a rear corridor. Chalk bars covered its plaster from waist height to the ceiling. Some stood alone. Others formed rows with dates and tiny annotations. Fresh marks showed bright white; older ones had sunk into the gray wall beneath hand grease and stove smoke.

“This morning?” Senn asked.

Hesh drew a short bar beside the door. “Cancelled window. Twenty-three minutes promised.”

“Why chalk?”

“Because the public schedule can replace its own record. Chalk requires a person to erase it.”

Several marks carried circles. A few had been crossed in blue pigment.

“Blue means restored within the same turn,” Hesh said. “Circle means a clinic, school, or nursery load depended on the light. A diagonal cut means notice arrived before we committed heat.”

Senn found very few diagonals.

Near the floor, a child's shorter marks clustered in an uneven row. One had a date but no duration. Hesh touched it with two fingers.

“Ressa made those when she could first hold chalk. The window vanished after children had assembled to see it. We call that a broken season.”

“Not every cancellation?”

“No. Weather changes. Machinery fails. A promise breaks when someone who could have warned us chooses not to count the people waiting.”

The distinction resisted Senn's categories because it joined service, notice, and standing in one local term. A broken season did not mean unpleasant weather. It recorded a civic relationship that had failed.

She took out her paper notebook rather than the slate. “May I copy the key for the marks?”

“You may write what I say.”

Hesh dictated the symbols. Senn recorded each definition exactly. At the end, they added, “No total without the associated wall log.”

“Because dependency varies.”

“Because a missed light window can cost a tray of beans, an hour of school, or a

body. The chalk does not pretend those carry one unit.”

A radiator pulse passed through the corridor. Dust slipped from the upper plaster. The vibration strengthened, held for five breaths, then receded.

Dael put down his cup. “Tower 15 changed load.”

No alarm sounded. Hesh opened the basement door, and cold coolant odor rose from below. They descended into a low service room where copper returns entered the building through ceramic collars. Four residents already stood at the control rack. The teenage mechanic from the lane called temperatures while another person adjusted branch gates.

“West seam closed,” Mara reported. Frost whitened her sleeves. “Tower return fell one point eight.”

“Dawn cancellation plus industrial step,” Dael said. He leaned over the analog pressure tubes. “You are drawing the clinic reserve early.”

“We drew it when the school coupling fell.” Hesh checked the wall chart. “Can tower service spare two degrees?”

Dael's hand hovered over a sealed Conservatory control plate. Breaking it would place his initials in another maintenance history. Senn recognized the pause from the mirror offset: not uncertainty about what to do, but calculation of how much concealment the action required.

“Do not touch it,” she said.

Four faces turned toward her.

Dael's expression closed. “Then the western wall drops below band in forty minutes.”

“I did not say leave it.” Senn pointed to the manual bypass beside the sealed plate. “Can local authority open that gate?”

Mara nodded. “For equipment protection.”

“Does the rule define occupied heat walls as equipment?”

Hesh gave a humorless laugh. “When cold harms us, we become residents. When warmth reaches us, we become equipment.”

“Open the bypass under local equipment authority,” Senn said. “Record school, clinic, and domestic demand separately. Dael can advise without entering the control.”

Mara opened the gate. Pressure moved through the tubes, sluggish at first, then steady. The wall temperature climbed by tenths. Dael watched the joints for strain and told the crew where to listen for hammer in the return pipe.

Senn wrote the entire operation into her notebook. The same classification that denied habitation granted enough maintenance discretion to prevent immediate freezing. Its contradiction had become a tool people needed to survive.

When the western run stabilized, Hesh brought them to the coolant-cistern

theater. The disused tank formed a deep circular room lined with ceramic tiles. Seats descended around a low stage built over old pipe anchors. During heat emergencies, Hesh explained, insulated curtains divided the space into sleeping bays because the buried cistern retained warmth longer than street-level halls.

Tonight, children rehearsed a weather pageant under portable lamps. One child wore a silver mirror mask. Another operated a canvas cloud on a pulley. The actor playing winter had wrapped herself in so many coats that she could barely bend her knees.

A teacher halted the rehearsal as Hesh entered. "We lost the dawn cue."

"Keep the scene," Hesh said. "Change the line."

The mirror child lifted her mask. "Again?"

"Schedules change. Plays remember."

Senn stood at the upper rail while the children revised their entrance. The winter actor crossed the stage first, dragging strips of white cloth. The cloud followed. Last came the mirror, late and visibly carried by a child whose shoes flashed beneath the costume.

"You wanted proof of a city," Hesh said beside her. "Cities contain bad theater."

"It is not bad."

"You have central standards."

"We have larger budgets."

Hesh's mouth shifted by a fraction. "That can imitate quality from a distance."

After rehearsal, they returned to the address hall. More people had gathered, summoned not by Hesh but by news of the auditor. They brought household cards, burial copies, heater repairs, school attendance books, and clinic-window requests. Senn saw enough documentation to bury any claim of temporary occupancy. She also saw how easily she could reduce it to a perfect Charter checklist and repeat her old mistake in a new form.

She opened her case but left the archive gloves inside.

"My first request was premature," she said.

A man near the stove asked, "Does that mean you withdraw it?"

"No. It means I asked for your evidence before learning what your evidence protects."

Hesh sat at the head of the long table. "Better phrasing does not earn a ledger."

"I know." Senn placed her notebook before them, open to the chalk key. "Tell me the conditions."

"Names first. Not totals, not representative cases. You will hear who kept each record, which wall they lived behind, and what happened when the scheduled season broke. After that, you may ask what can leave this room."

The demand threatened every efficient instinct Senn possessed. Eight thousand residents could not fit into an audit interview. Yet Hesh had not said every resident. They had said the names attached to whatever record Senn hoped to carry away.

Dael leaned against the stove wall, waiting without rescue.

Senn removed the copying lens from her case and set it on the table with its cover closed. "No images tonight."

Hesh called the birth clerk forward. She introduced herself as Lio Marr, keeper of current household changes and the western bridge register. Beside her, the teenage mechanic gave his name, address, and duty relation to the school coupling. Mara followed with the seam repair, then the clinic branch she had protected.

Senn wrote each name before the associated quantity.

Outside, tower vibration passed through Lorn Dusk's shared walls. The promised dawn did not come back. In the hall, Hesh opened the first household book but kept it on their side of the table.

Senn listened.

Chapter 7 — People Counted as Weather

Senn balanced Hesh's oldest address ledger on two felt blocks while live tower figures crawled across her slate.

The ledger remained on Hesh's side of the table. Senn had earned inspection, not custody, after a night of names and heating histories. At each page turn, Lio Marr recorded the folio number and checked Senn's bare hands for chalk, ink, or oil. Copying lens, stylus camera, and archive film stayed locked in Senn's case.

Dael had gone to sleep on a cot above the vane shop. Senn suspected he had not slept, but his absence removed one source of useful evasion. Across the address hall, dawn-shift clerks ate root cakes while settling household changes. Tower vibration made the tea in Senn's cup quiver.

"Page," Hesh said.

Senn read the first current household entry aloud. "Western Bridge, heat wall branch C, rooms twelve through fifteen. Six adults, four children. One medical reserve connection. School coupling south."

Hesh turned the volume without letting her touch it. "Telemetry."

She opened the Conservatory maintenance feed for the same branch. Tower 15 listed no household demand. Under AUXILIARY EQUIPMENT OCCUPANCY, four decimal loads appeared: baseline thermal retention, daytime cycling, reserve draw, and intermittent instructional operation.

Senn converted each quantity from radiator-return loss into expected interior use. The calculation took less than a minute.

"Baseline covers six adult-equivalent bodies at sleeping temperature," she said. "Daytime cycling adds four smaller occupancy curves. Reserve draw matches one medical heater. Instructional operation follows your school hours."

Nobody at the table answered.

She checked the next address. Three adults worked rotating tower shifts, which altered their heat use across the day. Conservatory telemetry described the variation as mobile maintenance demand. A baby born seven months earlier appeared in the hall's household book. The central feed had registered a new low-volume heat source eleven days after the birth, then classified it as sensor drift until a quarterly average absorbed it.

"Why eleven days?" Lio asked.

"The Almanac requires persistence before accepting a new equipment load."

"So it waited to see whether he would continue existing."

Senn looked at the baby's name. "That describes the calculation."

"It does not improve it."

"No."

Hesh placed a narrow paper strip beside the book. On it, the child's mother had recorded heater use during his first fever. Senn entered the dates manually. The same rise appeared in tower telemetry as temporary coolant inefficiency.

Each euphemism preserved physical truth. Heat had gone somewhere. Pumps had carried it, walls had retained it, warm bodies had altered return temperatures. The instruments counted every consequence of human presence while policy refused the presence itself.

Senn built a comparison grid with three columns. The first held addresses. The second held local civic loads. The third held Conservatory categories. Hesh would not allow names into the slate, so she used household codes assigned by Lio for the witnessed session.

Western Bridge C became thermal retention, reserve draw, and instructional operation.

Lantern Row 8 became distributed valve protection and nonproductive moisture control. The latter matched cooking steam.

Market Loft 3 became elevated nocturnal leakage. Two elderly sisters lived there and kept their wall warmer because one had damaged lungs.

At the fourth page, Senn stopped converting. "How many addresses feed tower 14?"

"Current or historical?" Hesh asked.

"Current first."

Lio gave a number from the daily register. Senn queried the tower bundle for independently cycling loads that met domestic heat profiles. The result matched, except for seven entries.

"Seven absent?" Hesh said.

"Seven more in telemetry than the current ledger."

Lio pulled a bridge-closure sheet. Five households had moved during a pipe repair. Their old branches still carried minimum heat to prevent cracking. One extra load served the theater's stored costumes. The last belonged to a public washroom.

"The feed overcounts occupied addresses," Senn said.

"By counting empty heated rooms," Hesh replied.

"Yes. Which proves it cannot distinguish an inhabited room from protected fabric unless policy gives it a civic record."

"Your office had the civic record."

Senn enlarged the source field attached to equipment occupancy. An old registry code appeared, followed by a note: LOCAL ADDRESS REFERENCES NONAUTHORITATIVE.

"Who marked them nonauthoritative?"

Hesh drew the book closer. "That question belongs to your house."

By midday, the comparison grid held fifty addresses. Every clinic reserve matched a named medical branch. Every school load followed actual attendance windows, adjusted for cancelled light. Domestic use resolved to household size within the ordinary variation for insulation, shift work, age, and illness.

One discrepancy remained in the clinic column. The local ledger showed a sterilizer cycle every third morning, yet tower telemetry carried a smooth daily draw. Senn asked Nima Sol's duty assistant to bring the clinic switch book. A man named Per Jalo arrived with a narrow volume, a coil thermometer, and impatience sharpened by a missed meal.

"We bank heat on cycle morning," he said. "The sterilizer takes it at noon. Your tower sees the bank fill every day because the wall controller limits the rise."

Senn drew the controller curve on paper. "If I remove household baseline, the stored increment should form three equal steps."

"It will form two equal steps and one smaller one. Laundry shares the third return."

She recomputed. The curve separated exactly as he described. What appeared centrally as constant equipment demand contained sterilization, laundry, and a deliberate reserve for clinic instruments that could not freeze between cycles.

"Who authorizes the bank?" Senn asked.

"Clinic keeper and western wall duty."

"Does tower control receive that authority?"

Per turned the switch book around. Two signatures accompanied each cycle. "Tower control receives the load. Authority remains here because tower control claims we are a tool shed."

Hesh asked Senn to include the switch book in her comparison grid.

"I can cite its existence," she said. "You have not permitted a copy."

"Then inspect every entry in the current turn."

Per read dates while Lio checked signatures. Senn compared them against twelve live-history points. Eleven aligned within measurement tolerance. The last ran warm by enough to suggest an extra heater.

"That day?" she asked.

Per touched the margin. "A patient could not leave after treatment. We opened recovery bed two."

Central telemetry had labeled the rise adaptive enclosure stabilization. The phrase could have described a valve housing. It had measured a person too weak to walk home.

Senn added a fourth category to her grid: local decision. Numbers alone showed use, but governance showed habitation. People scheduled scarce heat, assigned duties, witnessed exceptions, and argued about competing needs. Machinery did none of those things without an accountable instruction.

The clinic assistant watched her write. "Will that make us real?"

"You are real without my finding."

"Will it make your office act as if we are?"

Senn capped the pen before answering. "It will remove one excuse."

Per accepted neither comfort nor promise from that. He took his thermometer and went back to the clinic.

Next, Senn tested whether central forecasting predicted individuals closely enough to expose them while denying them status. She selected a school branch with Hesh's permission and overlaid five days of load. Arrival peaks showed children bringing cold clothing into warm rooms. Midday dips marked greenhouse practice. A late rise followed an evening class for tower apprentices.

"Does the Conservatory publish these profiles?" Hesh asked.

"Only aggregates outside protected maintenance access."

"Protected from whom?"

"Competitors, sabotage, household identification."

"We receive none of that protection because the households officially do not exist."

The point required no elaboration. Senn reduced the slate to hourly blocks

before allowing anyone else to view it. Even here, evidence needed boundaries. Proving surveillance did not authorize more surveillance.

Only after those tests did Senn ask the hall clerks to choose three records she had not seen. She wanted to rule out a curated sample. Hesh chose none of them. Lio asked a courier, the child practicing address entries, and the elderly man who had argued about the bridge number.

The courier brought a workshop household above a ceramic kiln. Its heat signature should have been difficult to separate from industrial use. The ledger tracked sleeping rooms by the hour and subtracted kiln recovery through a manual vane reading. Conservatory telemetry carried the residual as operator-presence compensation, a phrase that acknowledged workers without granting them homes.

The child chose her own building. Nine people occupied four rooms around a narrow stair. Two attended school. One worked nights at tower 15. A greenhouse lamp warmed the landing because an inner room had no window. The central categories reproduced each cycle exactly.

Last came the old man's closed bridge address. When the bridge failed, his household moved for nineteen days but continued heating the original wall to protect pipes. The Almanac had split them into two equipment profiles during the move, then merged the demand after their return. Local records showed one family occupying two civic obligations for a defined interval.

Senn pressed her thumb against the edge of the slate. "The classification has more information about your daily life than many recognized district schedules."

"Recognized districts call that forecasting," Hesh said.

"Here it becomes machinery."

"Here it becomes permission."

The afternoon light window arrived on schedule. A pale band opened high above the basin, reflected by mirrors too distant to see. Nobody left the hall. Their faces brightened by a few degrees while frost on the upper windows turned translucent. Senn watched the telemetry respond. School lamps stepped down. Heat-wall draw eased. Greenhouse shutters opened. The Almanac recorded reduced equipment occupancy demand.

On paper, Hesh noted: REFLECTED WINDOW RECEIVED, FULL DURATION PENDING.

"Why pending?" Senn asked.

"Because arrival does not guarantee completion."

The answer sounded severe until the reflected band flickered. Several clerks looked up. Light steadied after two breaths, but no one crossed out the caution.

Senn requested the policy objective associated with the tower bundle. Her origin-trace authority admitted her one layer deeper than it had in Orison. Text appeared above the live feed:

MAINTAIN THERMAL SERVICE FUNCTION. LIMIT EQUIPMENT OCCUPANCY LOSS WITHIN ACCEPTED PRECINCT TOLERANCE. PRIORITIZE REGISTERED HABITATION FLOORS AND CENTRAL CROP CONTINUITY.

Hesh read over her shoulder. "We lose after registered habitation because we do not count as registered habitation."

"Yes."

"What does accepted mean?"

"That an authorized order defined the risk tolerance."

"Accepted by whom?"

Senn searched the field. It linked back to the renewal chain Pera had found, then stopped at the missing signature page. "The current schedule inherited acceptance. I cannot yet identify the last human review."

"You can identify who did not accept it." Hesh tapped the address book.

The reflected light strengthened. A warm stripe moved down the wall of names. For several minutes, each painted line carried its own thin shadow.

Senn exported no data. Instead she wrote a formal observation on paper and asked Hesh to read it before she sealed it:

Live Conservatory telemetry for radiator precincts 14 and 15 resolves into continuous domestic heat, medical reserve, educational operation, and locally governed civic infrastructure corresponding to witnessed entries in the Lorn Dusk address ledger. Policy accounting classifies these loads as equipment occupancy despite instrument patterns consistent with human habitation.

Hesh crossed out *consistent with*.

"The patterns do not resemble habitation," they said. "They measure it."

Senn considered evidentiary caution. "Telemetry alone cannot prove names."

"The ledger supplies names."

"Which I cannot cite until you release a copy."

"You are using our refusal to weaken what you have seen."

"I am stating what another auditor can reproduce without privileged access."

Hesh pushed the paper back. "Then write two claims. One for what your machine proves. One for what we prove."

Senn revised:

Telemetry proves continuous human-scale heating, clinic, school, and domestic cycles within a category designated for machinery. Witnessed local records identify the people, addresses, and civic obligations generating those cycles.

Hesh read the sentences twice. "Better."

The light window completed. Lio drew a blue cross through the morning's

cancellation mark but left its chalk bar visible beneath the pigment. Restored within the same turn, Senn remembered. A service could arrive late and still owe an account of the waiting.

Dael entered near evening carrying a pressure gauge and three bowls of stew. "Tower 15's return manifold disagrees with its own maintenance summary."

"By how much?" Senn asked.

"Enough that I need the histories before I answer. Not enough to interrupt your constitutional court."

"This is an audit."

Hesh accepted a bowl. "She has learned that nouns matter. We have not yet reached adjectives."

Dael set the gauge beside Senn's case. "Did the loads resolve?"

"You knew they would."

"I knew what some of them served."

"All fifty matched."

His eyes moved to the open policy objective. "That language used to say transient operator load."

"When?"

"Before my license."

Hesh put down their spoon. "You have seen earlier wording?"

Dael rubbed the scarred joint of his forefinger. "In Eyr training copies. The categories changed as families grew, but never toward residence. Operators became occupancy. Temporary shelters became thermal enclosures. The system learned to describe us more accurately without naming us."

Senn added his statement to the witness sheet. "Will you authenticate a training copy if Pera finds one?"

"Yes."

"Under your license?"

"That question has delayed twelve years of honest work."

Hesh watched him with an expression Senn could not interpret. Eyr origin had shaped his access to Conservatory work, but Hesh did not turn the admission into solidarity. Dael had left. He had helped in secret. Both facts remained present.

After the hall closed to routine traffic, Hesh brought out three proposed ledger pages. They did not choose the oldest or most tragic entries. One covered Western Bridge C, including the school coupling and medical branch. Another covered Market Loft 3, with the sisters' warmer wall band. The third recorded a week of moves during the bridge closure.

"Why these?" Senn asked.

"They show ordinary governance," Hesh said. "Your institution understands disaster better than life. We will not prove residence by presenting ourselves only at the point of injury."

The pages contained names. Senn felt the condition before Hesh stated it.

"Witnessed copy," they said. "Lio operates the lens. You receive sealed images with no permission to detach household names from their loads. Any public filing may use addresses only with our review. The originals remain here. Your chain of custody begins with this table, not with your seal."

Senn opened her case and slid the copying lens across the wood. "Agreed, subject to one limitation. I cannot give you veto power over an audit finding."

"Not a veto. A right to identify mistranscription and loss of context."

"That I can grant."

Lio cleaned the lens plate with a square of boiled cloth. Hesh positioned the first book on felt supports, pressed each corner flat with ceramic weights, and read the page number aloud. Senn entered date, time, room temperature, witnesses, and seal condition. Dael signed only as observer.

The lens made a soft click.

One page became evidence without leaving the people who had kept it.

They repeated the process twice. On the final image, a shadow from the stove crossed the lower margin. Senn rejected the copy before Hesh could object. Lio repositioned the lamp, and the second exposure caught every entry cleanly.

Senn sealed the three images in her origin-trace packet. The packet asked her to classify the submission: measurement error, unauthorized allocation, archival discrepancy, district-boundary conflict, or other.

None described people accurately counted as weather.

She selected OTHER and opened the free field.

Dael read from across the table. "You are filing tonight?"

"The evidence will not improve by sleeping."

"The towers might worsen."

"Then your evidence will join mine."

Hesh stood behind her, close enough to see each word. Senn began with the Charter definition rather than the winter debit. Continuous civic heat. Address ledger. Local birth and burial records. She cited the live telemetry comparison, the witnessed pages, and the policy objective that subordinated equipment occupancy to registered districts.

At the remedy field, she requested no immediate schedule halt. The choice cost her. Continuing the debit meant continuing an unlawful burden; freezing every transfer without a thermal model could move danger into other homes. She asked instead for provisional protection of climate-floor evidence, a ban on destroying or

condensing precinct records, and an expedited determination of habitation status.

The form required a title.

Senn wrote: HABITATION CHALLENGE: THERMAL SERVICE PRECINCTS 14 AND 15.

Hesh touched the page title. "Lorn Dusk."

"Policy needs the precinct numbers to bind the active schedule."

"People need the name to know the challenge includes them."

Senn revised: HABITATION CHALLENGE: LORN DUSK / PRECINCTS 14 AND 15.

She added Eyr and Nacre Fold as related unresolved allocations, not yet evidenced by local records. Dael supplied the instrument bundle identifiers without comment.

The Conservatory seal field pulsed red. Filing from an unrecognized district required a registered civic node, which Lorn Dusk officially lacked. Senn could route through the tower maintenance terminal, but that would reproduce the category under dispute.

Lio pointed toward the public light controller. "It receives schedule notices."

"Not civic filings," Senn said.

"Does it have a return channel?"

"For fault acknowledgement."

Hesh understood first. "Then acknowledge a fault."

Senn connected her slate to the controller. Its narrow return channel allowed two hundred characters and an instrument attachment. She sent the filing seal as a schedule fault, citing denial of protected habitation review. The system rejected the first attempt because no recognized population could experience the fault.

On the second attempt, she attached the tower telemetry proving human-scale loads. The controller hesitated. Policy logic encountered physical fact, failed to reconcile them, and elevated the packet to her open origin trace.

A receipt appeared.

Hesh read it aloud. "Submission accepted pending standing determination."

"Circular," Dael said.

"Recorded," Senn replied.

She printed the receipt on the hall's fading thermal paper. One copy went into her case. Hesh bound the other behind the three source pages.

Outside, municipal lamps dimmed for the sleep interval. Heat kept moving through the shared wall. On the table, the address ledger remained open beside a filing that could no longer claim nobody lived at its source.

Interlude I — Order Nine

****EMERGENCY MEETING RECORD / YEAR 44 AC / PRESSUREWORKS ROOM 3****

The ninth meeting began at 04:10 with two radiator foundations open to frost and a construction population scheduled to depart before winter turn.

Present: Deputy Curator for Heat Export; Choir works engineer; Charter counsel; camp logistics officer; Almanac policy clerk; recording secretary.

The works engineer reported that towers 14 through 18 could not accept full load until coolant trenches closed. Temporary camps contained rotating crews only. No civic charter had been issued. Food, heat, medicine, and sanitation traveled through construction accounts.

Charter counsel asked whether any worker intended to remain after commissioning.

The logistics officer answered: "Not under the current contracts."

Counsel requested language limiting the exemption to five years or completion of the radiator works, whichever came first.

The policy clerk proposed: THERMAL SERVICE PRECINCT. OCCUPANCY LOAD TO BE TREATED AS EQUIPMENT-DEPENDENT FOR PURPOSES OF CLIMATE-FLOOR ALLOCATION.

Question: Would personnel retain workplace safety minima?

Answer: Yes. Equipment protection tolerances exceeded the minimum required for temporary sleeping quarters.

Question: Would births, schools, domestic heat, or local burial authority exist inside a service precinct?

Answer: No such civic functions were planned.

The secretary recorded a pause of seven minutes while tower 16 lost pump pressure. When the meeting resumed, the works engineer recommended immediate adoption. A crop-light transfer waited on confirmed radiator capacity. Delay would reduce seed starts in four ribbon districts.

Order 9 passed without objection at 05:02.

Order review status: ****review required****.

Expiry field: FIVE YEARS.

****ATTACHMENT / CAMP SERVICES / YEAR 44 AC****

Beds authorized: 860 rotating.

Heat walls: industrial dormitory standard.

Medical provision: first-aid station, no inpatient reserve.

Education: none.

Address ledger: equipment inventory only.

Burial authority: transfer to nearest chartered district.

Margin note in brown ink: *Families not permitted under works insurance.*

****FIRST RENEWAL ABSTRACT / YEAR 49 AC****

Tower commissioning remained incomplete at three sites. Permanent maintenance staffing exceeded original projections. Service housing had expanded beyond dormitory rows.

Local submission reported forty-one children receiving instruction in a converted valve store. The submission requested recognition of a school heat cycle.

Policy disposition: instructional load may be entered under operator continuity. No change to precinct category.

A bound address book accompanied the request. Its pages listed doors, household occupants, emergency heat duties, and two local births. The receiving clerk indexed it under equipment location references.

Reviewer's note: *Reclassification during active commissioning could interrupt radiator guarantees supporting central crop schedules. Renew for limited continuity. Survey after works completion.*

Renewal term: three years.

Renewal review status remained ****review required****.

****BURIAL TRANSFER EXCEPTION / YEAR 50 AC****

Request originated from precinct 14 after ridge transit closed for eleven days. Family asked to bury a tower mechanic locally rather than retain the body in an unheated freight store.

Charter counsel approved one emergency burial without district implication.

Coordinates entered into the works map.

Name entered into a local wall record.

Central index label: PERSONNEL DISPOSITION / EQUIPMENT SITE.

No habitation review opened.

****SECOND RENEWAL EXCERPT / YEAR 52 AC****

Commissioning certificate now covered all five towers. Works authority recommended dissolution of the camps.

Maintenance division objected. Trained crews lived adjacent to equipment; moving them to the ribbon would increase response time beyond bearing-failure tolerance. Existing households had built heat walls tied to coolant return.

A representative from precinct 11 submitted apprenticeship rolls. A representative from precincts 14 and 15 submitted school attendance, heater duty, and burial records.

Minutes summarized both submissions as continuity data.

One reviewer wrote: *Temporary description no longer accurate.*

A second hand answered in blue thermal ink: *Operational dependence remains accurate. Category governs service, not settlement form.*

Renewal approved pending policy survey.

The pending-action field still read **review required**.

****POLICY SURVEY REQUEST / YEAR 53 AC****

Question 1: Do precincts sustain continuous civic heat?

Response omitted. Tower-return telemetry attached.

Question 2: Do precincts maintain address ledgers?

Response: Local equipment-location books exist but lack Conservatory authority.

Question 3: Do births or burials occur locally?

Response: Personnel events have been recorded for logistical continuity.

Survey conclusion: Insufficient evidence of chartered habitation.

Routing note: *Do not circulate outside heat-export policy. Reclassification may alter active bloom balancing.*

That year, the first expanded crop-light transfer entered the Almanac. Darkward loads accepted longer winter exposure within inherited equipment tolerances.

****THIRD AND FOURTH RENEWALS / CONSOLIDATED ABSTRACT****

Population language disappeared from the header.

The third renewal cited radiator stability, maintenance response, and central crop continuity. An annex listed domestic heater profiles but called them enclosure retention. Clinic reserve draw appeared as instrument protection. School lamps appeared as operator training load.

The fourth renewal inherited every policy category unchanged. Its reviewer requested updated surveys from three precincts.

Lorn Dusk sent an address total and copies of twelve household pages.

Eyr sent apprenticeship completions, birth entries, and ceramic-vane workshop registrations.

Nacre Fold sent a clinic ledger and local burial coordinates.

The records office separated each submission from the renewal form. Address pages went to equipment indexing. Birth entries went to staffing continuity. Clinic records went to radiator-risk modeling. Burials went to works-site safety.

No single file retained the fact that all four categories described the same families.

Fourth renewal term: two years.

Fourth-renewal disposition preserved **review required**.

****CROP EMERGENCY ANNEX / YEAR 58 AC****

Fungal loss crossed three staple reserves. Central greenhouse projections

showed failure under ordinary bloom allocation. The Conservatory ordered maximum viable light for seed recovery, hospital food production, and protected nursery stock.

Heat-export modeling required continued darkward precinct tolerance. Immediate recognition of household climate floors would remove capacity from the emergency schedule before alternate shade or radiator repairs could be deployed.

A technical note stated: *Service records now indicate permanent households, multigenerational occupancy, local schooling, and independent heat governance. Existing category does not describe settlement conditions.*

Below it, an unsigned policy response read: *Description and allocation function must be distinguished during emergency continuity. Reclassification deferred until crop reserve recovers.*

The fifth renewal authorized the existing category for one additional emergency term.

Its signature sheet carried a First Curator seal. The archived abstract preserved the office, date, and authority but not the signatory name.

Review field: **review required upon crop stabilization**.

AUTOMATED STATUS NOTICE / YEAR 60 AC

Crop reserves recovered above emergency threshold.

No policy survey had been assigned an active officer. Heat-export schedules depended on the current precinct codes. The Almanac requested disposition before the next bloom turn.

Administrative inheritance selected the latest valid authorization.

A clerk opened the status notice, marked the crop emergency closed, and forwarded radiator maintenance reports to engineering. The precinct review field remained unassigned.

At 18:44, the inheritance service tested whether Order 9 had a superseding instrument.

Result: none located.

It tested whether the originating equipment still operated.

Result: active.

It tested whether dependent schedules referenced the category.

Result: active dependencies found.

The service retained the thermal service precinct classification. A nightly policy copy propagated the result into mirror scheduling, heat-export forecasts, archive indexes, and the next turn's crop plan. No clerk received a warning because inheritance counted as continuity rather than amendment. Local records kept accumulating under the old labels while each dependent schedule made later review appear more disruptive.

In the copied header, one phrase changed without a meeting, witness list, or new signature.

****review required**** became ****continue until superseded****.

Act II — The Cost of Legibility

Chapter 8 — Forty-Six Days

Dael broke the seal on tower 15's history cabinet with Senn watching his hands.

The cabinet had not opened cleanly in nine years. Frost sealed the lower hinge, and the authorization wafer flashed amber because his license allowed remote maintenance review, not local extraction of protected history coils. He warmed the hinge with his palm heater, entered his Conservatory number, and accepted the violation notice.

"You could request emergency access," Senn said.

"Then Orison would decide whether this counts as an emergency."

Hesh stood at the service-room door with two Lorn Dusk mechanics. "We decided when the return manifold dropped."

Dael pulled the cabinet open. Cold metal scraped across the floor. Inside, ceramic memory coils sat in numbered slots from Year 44 onward, each one recording radiator load, inlet temperature, bearing vibration, coolant pressure, and maintenance interventions. Central summaries retained ten years at full resolution. The local coils had kept all thirty-one.

He removed the oldest coil using both hands. Burns tightened the fingers of his left hand when cold reached them. Senn noticed, as she noticed anything that impaired measurement, but said nothing.

A portable reader waited on the workbench. Mara had built its frame from a school-lamp ballast and two ceramic vane brackets. The instrument would offend Conservatory procurement. It also held calibration within half a degree.

"Source?" Senn asked.

"Eyr apprenticeship pattern," Mara replied. "Dael pretends he invented it whenever central engineers visit."

"Eyr patterns use three brackets."

"We had two."

"Then you improved it."

Senn connected her slate through an isolation loop. "No edits pass from my

device to the coils.”

Dael checked the loop himself. A green telltale lit on the reader. Only then did he seat the first coil.

Tower history opened as a stack of narrow traces. Winter turns appeared in blue, reflected windows in white, industrial heat-export steps in red. Dael had learned to read the shapes before he learned the policy names. At eleven, in Eyr, he could identify a failing coolant pump by the shiver it put through a wall cup. His apprenticeship exam had asked him to convert that knowledge into approved units and forget who drank from the cup.

“Start with baseline,” Senn said.

“Baseline changed.”

“Then show each change.”

He aligned the original Order 9 schedule with current tower duty. Construction years carried irregular demand. Crews arrived and left. Dormitories heated in blocks, then went cold. After the first renewal, the traces settled into household rhythms. Radiator export rose as central bloom transfers expanded. Reflected windows shortened by minutes, then hours, then whole service days.

Dael marked every winter extension beyond the settlement's nominal schedule. Senn created a parallel table and made him justify each boundary.

“That blue shoulder could be weather variance,” she said.

“Not with a red export step twelve minutes earlier.”

“The tower accepted more central heat.”

“And local light dropped to keep the darkward exchange inside shear tolerance.”

“Causal link?”

He enlarged the control sequence. EXPORT REQUEST ACCEPTED appeared first. PRECINCT WINDOW MODIFIED followed. No storm measurement intervened.

Senn entered the day.

They worked through three coils before the room warmed enough to soften the frost on Dael's cuffs. Hesh's mechanics rotated out for wall duty. Mara stayed, checking the reader against analog gauges whenever a trace showed impossible smoothness. Two such sections came from central archive compression; the local coil preserved real vibration beneath the summary.

By the eighth winter turn, the pattern no longer required argument. Extra cold accumulated whenever Orison and the six central cities extended bloom. Some turns gave Lorn Dusk several days back through late reflected windows. Other turns carried the deficit forward under heat-export necessity.

Senn asked, “What averaging interval does policy use?”

“One turn.”

“That conceals carryover.”

"It calls carryover a new baseline."

"Use rolling six-turn windows."

Dael did. The first interval averaged nineteen additional winter days. Later windows climbed through twenty-seven, thirty-five, and forty-two. The expanded crop transfer pushed the curve higher. For the most recent twelve turns, Lorn Dusk averaged just above forty-eight.

Hesh brought food at the sixth hour and found none of them eating. They set bowls directly over Senn's notes until she moved the paper.

"What does the number say?" they asked.

"Lorn Dusk alone runs higher than the combined precinct estimate," Senn said. "We need Eyr and Nacre Fold histories before asserting the burden across all three."

Dael opened a side index. "We have mirrored service packets."

"Authorized?"

"No."

Hesh looked at him. "How did they arrive?"

"Maintenance crews exchange failure patterns. Central summaries remove too much."

"Does Eyr know you kept them here?"

"Their tower keepers know."

"That did not answer the question."

Dael set down his spoon. "Household councils did not authorize evidence transfer. The packets contain tower data, not address records."

Senn closed the side index. "We can inspect technical history. We cannot use local civic loads without custody."

"They still answer the duration question," he said.

"If you authenticate source and transmission."

His own hidden practices kept turning into procedural work. For years, secrecy had let him act faster. Under Senn's attention, every useful shortcut developed a constituency he had failed to ask.

They opened the Eyr packet first. Tower 11's ceramic-vane signatures felt familiar enough to become smell and texture in Dael's memory: kiln dust, mineral glaze, hot wool drying over wall pipes. The packet carried checksums from three maintenance shops. He named each shop and the keeper who had sealed its section.

Eyr's winter extensions ran slightly below Lorn Dusk's. Nacre Fold's lava-tube insulation reduced domestic loss, but its narrower reflected-light path produced longer outages when mirrors shifted. Senn made separate calculations for

duration, temperature depth, and clinic interruptions. She refused to turn unlike harms into one quantity.

"For schedule duration only," Dael said, "weight the three by inhabited load."

"Population?"

"Heat profiles. We do not have authorized population records for two settlements."

"That repeats the category problem."

"It avoids inventing people while still measuring where winter landed."

Senn considered the formula. "Calculate both unweighted and heat-load weighted. Label the limitations."

The two results differed by less than a day. Dael reran them with uncertain start boundaries, deleted compressed years, and conservative assumptions that treated partial cancellations as ordinary winter. The range tightened around forty-five to forty-seven.

He entered the midpoint in words rather than digits: **forty-six additional winter days per turn, average across Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold**.

Hesh read it from behind his shoulder. "People here know winter grew."

"I know."

"They will ask why this number matters more than their memory."

"It does not. It matters to a system that moved the days and pretended they had no destination."

Senn initialed the calculation. "It also defines the dependency. Removing forty-six days from one side puts the heat somewhere else."

No one mistook the proof for a remedy.

On the second morning, Dael turned from schedule histories to machinery. Tower 15's vibration trace carried a narrow harmonic at three times shaft frequency. It appeared only under high export. Central maintenance had classified it as sensor resonance.

Mara pressed a metal listening rod against the return pipe and offered him the padded end. A rough pulse struck through the rod every third rotation.

"Bearing cage," Dael said.

"Which one?" Senn asked.

"Upper secondary, probably. We need a shutdown inspection."

"When can it stop?"

Dael checked the forward export schedule. "Not during the next bloom step without moving load to tower 14."

"Can 14 carry it?"

Mara answered first. "Not at listed tolerance."

They opened tower 14's service history. Coolant pressure had begun falling after each high-load cycle, recovering too slowly for ordinary seal contraction. Dael traced the decline to a flange installed during a rushed overhaul. Its thermal expansion coefficient differed from the pipe collar by a small amount. Thirty cycles had turned that difference into a leak that appeared only when the tower cooled.

"Two towers," Senn said.

"Here." Dael opened Eyr's packet. Tower 11 showed vane-control lag under rapid export steps. The ceramic vanes moved correctly once positioned, but an actuator drew increasing current. One hard correction could stall it between angles.

Nacre Fold's packet added tower 17. Its intake screen had collected shell-lime dust from settlement repairs. The pressure loss remained below emergency tolerance because local crews cleaned it twice as often as central maintenance assumed. Recent traces showed cleaning no longer restored full flow.

Senn listed them. "Four radiator towers."

"Four urgent," Dael said. "Others need ordinary work."

"Define urgent."

"Tower 15 risks bearing damage under sustained high export. Tower 14 loses coolant during recovery. Eleven may fail to angle its vanes during a fast load step. Seventeen cannot reach listed intake flow."

"Could all four fail together?"

"Anything could. That question does not help."

"Could one schedule event stress all four together?"

He looked at the central bloom trace. "Yes. A sudden cancellation of the darkward debit would transfer heat and control demand across the same network."

Senn wrote without triumph. Evidence kept removing easy choices.

A history trace could justify opening machinery, not condemn it. Dael told Mara to request a reduced-load inspection on tower 15. The reply granted fourteen minutes between export steps. Fourteen minutes allowed no bearing removal, but it permitted a listening survey and oil sample if everyone moved before the load fell.

They crossed the covered service bridge in hard-soled boots. Tower vibration strengthened until each handrail buzzed. Beyond the insulated windows, radiator fins rose into blackness, shedding a faint heat shimmer that bent the stars. Frost retreated from the tower base in a perfect arc.

Mara closed the secondary load gate. Dael watched shaft speed descend while Senn called time from the doorway. At half load, he pressed three wax pickups against the bearing housing. The first flattened evenly. A fine repeated ridge

marked the second. The third came away with a ridge deep enough to feel through his glove.

"Cage strike confirmed," he said.

"Time," Senn called. "Nine minutes."

Dael opened the oil port. Black lubricant filled the sampling tube, carrying bright metal flecks that turned under his lamp. A sensor-resonance fault could not shed steel.

Mara swore under her breath. "How long?"

"At current high-load frequency, I will not guess."

Senn stepped closer. "Give a range."

"Days under continuous maximum export. Several turns under ordinary cycling. Every strike damages the race."

"Can it be replaced locally?"

"Upper secondary requires a lift cradle. Lorn Dusk's cradle failed certification because a central inspector counted patched cables as automatic rejection."

"The cables hold above rated load," Mara said.

"I know. A hearing about procurement will not lift this bearing."

Four minutes remained. Dael sealed the oil port, pulled the pickups, and signaled for return to load. The gate resisted at three-quarters travel. Mara struck its actuator casing with the heel of her wrench, once, at a point worn pale by earlier blows. The motor caught and opened.

Senn recorded the strike. "Routine method?"

"Approved method failed years ago," Mara said. "This method works."

"That answer belongs in the repair request."

"It has appeared in six."

Back inside, Dael compared the sample with a preserved tube from the prior winter turn. Metal content had more than doubled. He sealed both under Hesh's local witness stamp and Senn's audit mark.

Tower 14 required a different test. Its coolant loss appeared only during recovery, so the crew could not inspect it between export steps. They routed a low-temperature diagnostic loop through the suspect flange and painted the collar with white frost compound. As pressure rose, a narrow wet line opened along the lower seam. It vanished when the pipe warmed.

Senn crouched beside the collar. "How much per cycle?"

"Too little to trigger inventory variance," Dael said. "Enough to empty the local reserve after repeated hard recoveries."

"Central history shows reserve within target."

"Because crews refill from domestic treatment stock and list it as line flushing."

Hesh had joined them for the test. "Another false cause."

Mara wiped the seam. "Another way not to lose a tower while procurement considers a flange."

Dael asked for the refill slips. Each transfer from domestic treatment reduced contingency water for the shared wall. Mechanical degradation did not remain mechanical in a settlement built around tower return. A leaking flange borrowed from household resilience, then central summaries called both systems adequate.

Eyr sent a live vane diagnostic when its keepers received Senn's sealed inquiry. The actuator on tower 11 took six seconds longer to cross the final angle than its controller reported. Dael recognized the false completion signal: current dropped when the drive encountered resistance, and old logic interpreted the drop as arrival. A ceramic vane could therefore stop short while the schedule believed it had reached position.

Nacre Fold answered with intake photographs. Shell-lime coated the screen supports beyond reach of ordinary cleaning rods. The local crew had improvised brushes from greenhouse fiber, but each pass loosened material that lodged deeper in the radiator channel. Full cleaning required a shutdown and access cage.

Senn aligned all four repair needs against the coming schedule. "Each request failed for a different reason."

"Lift certification, low inventory loss, controller reporting, shutdown priority," Dael said.

"What joins them?"

"The category. Central planning expects equipment sites to spend no domestic reserve, train no local crews outside Conservatory licensing, and need no service window beyond predicted machinery tolerance."

Hesh added, "It expects us to maintain the towers without consuming a season."

Dael sent urgent work notices before the next load step could begin. He attached oil flecks, flange images, live vane lag, and Nacre Fold's blocked intake. For once, no false cause protected the request. The notices named household consequences beside equipment risks.

Near midday, tower 15 requested a clinic-window adjustment. The service panel displayed the ordinary sequence: reflected light scheduled in twenty minutes, central export step arriving in twelve, local heat wall projected to fall below clinic reserve for eight minutes. Official control would preserve radiator duty and let the local load dip because equipment occupancy remained within accepted tolerance.

Dael reached for the offset field.

"Wait," Senn said.

A clinic indicator glowed amber on the local rack. Hesh had not yet arrived. Mara stood by the manual gate but did not open it.

Dael entered a mirror-lattice correction of 0.07 percent, enough to advance the

reflected edge and warm the clinic branch before export rose. He labeled it sensor phase compensation. That lie fit within maintenance tolerance and would pass routine review.

Senn watched every entry. "How many times?"

"In this history or my career?"

"Begin with this history."

He queried his initials. The result filled more lines than the display could show.

"Twelve years," he said. "Not every correction served clinics. Some held schools, nurseries, or domestic walls during tower work."

"How many records use false causes?"

"Most. An honest cause would have routed the request through a district authority Lorn Dusk does not possess."

The reflected-light indicator shifted from amber to white. In the clinic branch, reserve temperature stopped falling.

Senn asked, "Did any offset take a recognized district below floor?"

"No."

"Did you draw only from tolerance?"

"Usually."

"Usually does not close an audit."

"Three times I delayed Orison greenhouse edge light by under four minutes. Once I increased tower wear by holding export at an inefficient angle. Twice I used an unassigned maintenance margin that policy would have returned to central crop continuity."

"Any storm risk?"

"Measured increase below reporting threshold."

"Not zero."

"Correct."

He waited for accusation. Senn asked for the raw entries instead.

Dael opened each flagged correction and named its purpose from his private maintenance marks. A short diagonal meant clinic. Two dots meant school. A hooked line meant a heat wall at pipe-risk temperature. The marks did not appear in central records. He had built a second language inside approved notation, as local ledgers had built civic truth inside equipment references.

Hesh came in during the review and saw the marks. "You never gave us this index."

"It could identify the adjustments."

"It could let us verify whom you chose."

"I chose the lowest temperature against the next available window."

"You chose."

Dael felt the room contract around the verb. "Yes."

"Did Nacre Fold know when you preferred an Eyr clinic?"

"No."

"Did Lorn Dusk know when you spent tower wear on Orison delay?"

"No."

Secret protection had spared people. It had also reserved authority to one engineer who could leave whenever his license demanded it. Dael had called that caution because the alternative looked like exposure. Hesh made it look like government without witnesses.

Senn turned the slate toward them. "I will include the falsifications in the habitation case."

Dael expected fear and found relief mixed through it. "My license number?"

"Yes."

Hesh asked, "And their purpose?"

"Each entry will name the protected load, the available alternatives, and the harm avoided where the records support it. I will not classify concealment as measurement fraud. The measurements remain accurate. The stated maintenance causes do not."

"That distinction may not save him," Hesh said.

"It should not disappear to save me," Dael replied.

Senn drafted the annex at the workbench. She described his unauthorized offsets, false cause labels, use of tolerance, and failure to obtain local consent. Then she recorded the clinics kept above reserve, school couplings protected, and pipe freezes prevented. Neither column cancelled the other.

Dael signed beneath the statement. Hesh added a witness line noting that local councils had not authorized the hidden allocation choices. Mara authenticated the tower traces.

The filing seal accepted all three signatures. Its receipt included the urgent repair notices, linking concealed heat choices to machinery already spending its remaining margin.

Behind them, the clinic window arrived seven minutes early under Dael's false label. Its light moved across the service-room pipes while Senn attached the truth about it to her case.

Chapter 9 — The Fifth Renewal

Pera found the missing signature sheet inside a fungus quarantine order.

Her message reached Senn before the return tram cleared Lorn Dusk's basin. It contained no greeting, only an archive location and a warning not to request the file digitally. Senn read it twice while tower light receded behind the tram. Dael slept opposite her with one hand wrapped around his tool case.

At the Conservatory, dawn had begun over Orison. Bloom mirrors warmed the pressureworks windows until frost withdrew from the red glass. Senn left her travel case with security, carried the sealed ledger copies under her coat, and descended to the crop-emergency annex.

Pera waited between compact shelves wearing dust sleeves over her uniform. Blue ink marked one cheek. Three archive boxes occupied the floor around her, each labeled FUNGAL CONTAINMENT / SEED TRANSFER.

"You said quarantine order," Senn whispered.

"I said location." Pera checked the aisle behind Senn. "The order itself concerns blight barriers. Its attachment bundle concerns emergency bloom authority, which concerns radiator capacity, which apparently concerns where senior officials hide pages they do not want renewal clerks to inherit."

"Who filed it?"

"A crop secretary seventeen years ago. She indexed by the annex's first instrument, not by every paper inside. Either she was careless in a useful direction or careful in one."

Pera knelt beside the middle box. Its original string had been replaced by a modern archive band. She held out a custody form.

Senn signed before touching anything. "Show me the sequence."

"The Order 9 renewal file ends with an attachment stub. CROP-EMERGENCY CAPACITY OPINION, seven pages. The central index preserves pages one through five. Page six appears in the crop annex. Page seven contains the signature field."

"Authentication?"

"Paper stock matches emergency executive forms from the year. Seal fibers continue across the fold. Blue thermal ink aging fits within two months. I have not tested pressure impression because that would require opening a conservation request."

"Do that now."

"It alerts the First Curator."

"So will my custody entry."

Pera's mouth tightened. "I had hoped to enjoy six more minutes of being merely nervous."

She lifted a packet from beneath the quarantine order. Brown spotting marked its edges, residue from the crop fungus samples once stored nearby. Pera had enclosed the pages in clear preservation leaves. Senn read the capacity opinion from the beginning.

The crop emergency had not been rhetorical. A fungal strain had crossed three staple reserves in one rain turn. Infected grain could not be recovered. Nursery stock required maximum clean light to reach transplant size before stored food fell below the public ration floor. The Conservatory modeled alternatives: shade reductions, hospital garden conversion, emergency imports from outer ribbon towns, delayed seed starts, increased radiator export.

Every model lost food.

The selected plan lost least. It extended central bloom, drove darkward heat export near tower tolerance, and preserved the thermal service precinct category so household floors would not constrain the emergency schedule.

Page four listed settlement records received from Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold. Address books. Schools. Clinic reserves. Burial coordinates. Page five summarized them under one sentence:

Service records now demonstrate permanent households and civic functions
inconsistent with temporary construction occupancy.

Senn looked at Pera. "The renewal abstract kept that sentence."

"Without the attachments."

"The fifth renewal proceeded anyway."

Pera turned page six.

A handwritten note crossed the printed recommendation. The script moved in small, controlled angles, blue faded toward brown where fingers had held the sheet.

Recognizing habitation now would compel immediate floor allocation during a crop emergency. Current models cannot meet both obligations without ration failure. Renew for the emergency term. Open a full status review when reserve recovers.

Below the note, page seven carried a seal and signature.

Ceryn Ahl.

The name produced no shock. Its pressure grooves only gave a hand to the decision already outlined by every restriction, inherited phrase, and missing attachment. Blue ink sat deeper where the signature had driven it into the paper grain.

Pera said, "Pressure test?"

"Yes."

They carried the preservation leaf to the archive bench. Pera placed polarized

film above the signature and lowered a cold lamp. Pressure grooves appeared across paper fibers. The pen had paused after Ceryn's family name, then pressed harder into the authorization line.

Pera compared the grooves against an authenticated emergency directive from the same month. Stroke angle, letter joins, pressure cadence, and seal placement aligned.

"She signed it," Pera said.

"Write the finding as authentication, not accusation."

"I know my work."

"I know." Senn softened her voice. "I am reminding myself."

They photographed the sheet under dual custody. Pera sealed the image to the origin trace and cross-indexed the physical page under Order 9, crop emergency, habitation records, and First Curator authority. Each new index made future disappearance harder.

Senn asked for the attachment stub from the original renewal file. Pera produced a paper impression rather than the bound volume, preserving the archival rule against moving two linked originals into one room. The stub carried seven tiny punctures where a brass tie had once held the packet. Page seven in the crop annex carried matching holes, including one offset near the lower edge.

"Somebody separated it after signature," Senn said.

"Before the thermal ink aged fully," Pera replied. "See the brown transfer around the top hole? The pages rested together long enough for ink residue to mark the stub."

"Can you date the separation?"

"Within a season, perhaps. Not closely enough to name a person."

They examined routing stamps. The packet had moved from crop authority to the First Curator's office, then to emergency implementation. A final stamp routed the technical opinion to policy archives. Beside it, in a different hand, someone sent the quarantine order and its attachments to crop containment storage.

"Deliberate concealment?" Senn asked.

"Possible. Also possible that a clerk saw fungus documents and filed by contamination protocol. I will not turn untidy custody into intent."

"Good."

Pera frowned. "You could sound less pleased when I resist your theory."

"I am pleased by resistance that improves evidence."

"That must make you delightful at meals."

Senn requested the ration implementation records cited in the capacity opinion. Pera retrieved microfilm from a side drawer and fed it through a hand viewer. The emergency became physical in columns no model summary could soften. Grain

stores declined each day. Nursery trays failed fungal screening and went to incineration. Municipal kitchens substituted root paste for two meals, then reduced portions again when a storage vault developed mold.

One district requested permission to mill seed reserve into food. The Conservatory denied it because eating the seed would preserve people for a month and destroy the next planting. Another order redirected hospital greenhouse light to clean staple shoots. Clinic administrators objected, then signed after receiving projections that showed ration collapse reaching their wards.

“Ceryn approved all of these,” Pera said.

Senn followed the seal marks. “She also rejected a proposal to cut outer-town rain below crop floor.”

“That would help her defense.”

“It belongs in the evidence for that reason.”

A page of nursery temperatures showed how close the plan had come to failure. Three nights of inadequate light left seedlings below transplant threshold. Extra bloom on the fourth morning recovered enough growth to continue. The corresponding export authorization cited the thermal service precinct tolerance.

Senn placed the two records side by side: green shoots saved in Orison, households denied a floor darkward. Neither page invalidated the other. Together they documented a choice made under scarcity, then carried far past its stated end.

Pera found the reserve-recovery notice six folders later. It declared the crop emergency closed and released executive controls. No habitation review order accompanied it.

“Was the promised review ever opened under another case number?” Senn asked.

“I searched status, precinct, radiator, occupancy, and emergency succession. Nothing.”

“Search civic heat and address authority.”

Pera did. The index returned local submissions routed to equipment records, the same fragments Senn had seen in the historical chain. It returned no review.

“Then the omission has edges,” Senn said. “A trigger date, an assigned authority, and no action.”

“An omission with excellent filing habits.”

The conservation notice chimed before Pera finished.

FIRST CURATOR ACCESS REQUEST / ANNEX AISLE C.

Pera looked at Senn. “That took four minutes.”

“You were promised six.”

“Institutions continue disappointing me in measurable units.”

Ceryn entered without an escort. She wore no ceremonial coat, only a gray work jacket with the Conservatory seal at the throat. Her hair remained pinned from the overnight schedule session. Fatigue showed around her eyes but did not loosen her posture.

"Has the page been authenticated?" she asked.

Pera answered, "Preliminary pressure, ink, paper, and seal comparison all support authenticity. Full archival report pending."

"Do not call it preliminary once you have four independent matches."

Pera glanced at Senn, then corrected the form. "Authenticated."

Ceryn read the custody sequence. She did not ask to remove the page or challenge the search authority. "Who else has access?"

"Origin-trace principals," Senn said. "Pera, me, policy archive supervision upon seal, and any habitation proceeding authorized from the challenge."

"Not Dael?"

"Not until his role requires it."

"Not Hesh Dara?"

"They receive evidentiary notice because the page references their records. The image remains protected until a proceeding sets access."

Ceryn rested two fingers on the bench, outside the preservation boundary. "Correct."

The word angered Senn more than obstruction might have. "You knew."

"Yes."

"Permanent households. Schools. Burials."

"Yes."

"Then you signed the fifth renewal under a category you knew had become false."

Ceryn looked toward Pera. "Complete the index. Auditor Vale and I will use the old pump gallery."

Pera held her ground. "Do you want me absent as archivist or as witness?"

"Neither. I want the page sealed before conversation produces claims about its handling."

That answer also proved correct. Pera finished the cross-index, locked the sheet into a fire drawer, and gave each woman a custody receipt. Only then did Ceryn lead Senn upstairs.

The old pump gallery overlooked Orison's lower canals. Decommissioned pistons stood between windows, their black iron polished by generations of maintenance hands. Morning light reached the apricot terraces. Hive boxes opened in sequence. From here, spring showed none of its darkward accounting.

Ceryn stopped beside a pressure wheel taller than Senn. "Ask directly."

"Why did you renew?"

"Because the fungal failure had destroyed two staple strains and contaminated a third. We had seed for one clean planting. If the nursery cycle failed, the next ration schedule fell below survival reserve across the central ribbon."

"You had other models."

"Each killed more people."

"Show me."

Ceryn went to a dormant service desk and entered an executive archive key. She did not hesitate over the access warning. Crop-emergency simulations opened across the old slate.

One model recognized the service precincts immediately and granted every household a climate floor. Radiator export fell. Central greenhouse temperatures dropped. Seed starts failed across three staple nurseries. Another preserved seed light by cutting hospital gardens and school meals. A third transferred the burden to outer agricultural towns already near rain minimum. None maintained every protected floor because the emergency stock, shade capacity, and radiator performance could not support them simultaneously.

"What did your selected plan prevent?" Senn asked.

"Projected ration collapse in eleven cities. The uncertainty band ran wide. At its median, several hundred thousand people lost staple minimum for at least one winter turn."

"Projected deaths?"

"I will not give you a clean number from a model that depended on household compliance, fungal spread, and reserve spoilage. We expected mass mortality under the worst branch. We expected severe hunger under the best."

Ceryn opened ration records. Portions narrowed after the plan began but stayed above survival reserve. Seedling mortality fell. The next crop reached transplant readiness with three days of stock remaining.

"I prevented a famine," she said. "Not alone. Growers burned infected fields. Clinic gardens surrendered light. Tower crews carried export above preferred load. The plan prevented it."

"And Lorn Dusk paid."

"Yes."

"Without standing."

"Yes."

Ceryn never lied about a number once asked. Senn had respected that discipline when she mistook measurement honesty for governing honesty.

"Your note promises a full review when reserve recovers."

"It should have opened."

"Who stopped it?"

"I did not assign it."

"That is not an answer about a machine."

"No." Ceryn closed the ration display. "The emergency ended unevenly. Reserves recovered, then a mirror failure reduced bloom capacity. Tower 16 required a rebuild. Two cities had built hospital schedules around the extension. Every turn presented a reason to delay a correction that remained physically dangerous."

"How long before delay became policy?"

"Immediately, though I did not call it that."

Outside, canal chimes announced the nursery shift. Workers moved shutters from the lower greenhouse roofs.

Senn asked, "Did you read later household submissions?"

"Summaries."

"Did they alter your understanding?"

"They increased the scale of the obligation, not its nature."

"Why preserve the false category rather than create standing with staged implementation?"

Ceryn's gaze followed the mirror line down the canal. "Because the Charter did not clearly separate recognition from immediate floor allocation under an active schedule. Legal counsel predicted injunctions. Central cities would have fought any weather loss. The Conservatory could enforce a deferred review; it could not guarantee an orderly constitutional case while food systems depended on the result."

"So you denied the districts the standing needed to argue for one."

"I held a system inside the only authority available to me."

The sentence came close to turning power into necessity. Senn opened the Lorn Dusk telemetry on her slate. "This system measured infants as new equipment loads. It classified clinic recovery as enclosure stabilization. It used domestic treatment water to conceal a tower leak. Did you know that level of consequence?"

"No."

"Would it have changed your emergency decision?"

Ceryn took time. "During the first crop turn, perhaps not."

"And after?"

"Yes."

Senn believed her. Belief did not repair the years between.

A service clerk arrived at the gallery door with two printed schedules. Ceryn signed one and sent the other back for revised wind limits. Even inside confession, weather continued demanding administration.

When they stood alone again, Ceryn said, "Your habitation challenge will trigger a classification conflict. Rul Fen already represents municipal petitioners who claim immediate standing would invalidate active crop allocations. If the matter opens publicly before correction models exist, every district will defend its own floor through emergency filings."

"Then build correction models."

"We are. Quietly."

"With whose participation?"

"Conservatory engineering, Charter counsel, selected municipal load officers."

"None from Lorn Dusk, Eyr, or Nacre Fold."

"Not while their legal status remains contested."

"Which your renewal ensured."

Ceryn's face tightened. "Yes."

The admission left no useful target for Senn's anger. She folded the custody receipt and placed it in her notebook.

Ceryn moved to the next piston. "I can order a staged review. First, authenticate the records internally. Second, model recognition under controlled assumptions. Third, invite local custodians as technical witnesses. If the result supports standing, we bring a complete remedy to the delegates rather than a crisis."

"How long?"

"Six months."

"Winter continues under the inherited debit?"

"Reduced where safe."

"Who decides safe?"

"The Conservatory."

"Who decides which local custodians qualify?"

"Archive and policy offices."

"Who has standing during the review?"

Ceryn did not answer at once. "Formally, no district until determination."

Senn looked through the red glass. Orison's bloom warmed canal stones while workers opened school roofs to the extended morning. Those uses mattered. Hospital gardens mattered. Crop continuity mattered. Ceryn's offer protected all of them from a disorderly fight by asking the harmed settlements to remain evidence instead of participants.

"Hesh permitted three ledger pages to leave Lorn Dusk," Senn said. "They required names to remain attached because your summaries separated every civic fact until no people survived the filing."

"I read the challenge."

"You read an audit abstraction. They should decide how their records enter remedy."

"A public case could produce an immediate halt."

"Then we show why an immediate halt creates danger. We do not prevent them from arguing because their argument may prevail."

Ceryn's voice stayed controlled. "Auditor Vale, authority carries responsibility for outcomes, not only procedure."

"So does exclusion."

"I have described the outcome I prevented."

"And the category continued after that outcome ended."

A mirror adjustment moved copper light across the gallery. It passed over Ceryn's hands, revealing ink in the creases of one thumb.

Senn took out her slate and opened the habitation challenge. The signature-sheet authentication field waited for an attachment. Adding it would elevate the case beyond a technical classification dispute. It would state that a named First Curator had knowingly preserved a false category during emergency governance.

Ceryn watched without reaching for the device. "If you file now, I cannot contain the proceeding."

"That should not depend on your containment."

"I can keep municipal counsel from seeking immediate injunctive relief during a staged review."

"By keeping the districts outside it."

"By arriving with a survivable proposal."

Senn attached the authenticated page. "Standing cannot wait until everyone with standing has agreed the answer."

She marked the crop models protected but discoverable, preventing their use as public spectacle while preserving them for the case. She included Ceryn's admission that the emergency decision had knowingly deferred habitation recognition. She did not call the famine invented, the model fraudulent, or the prevention meaningless.

The filing seal asked whether the First Curator offered administrative resolution.

Senn selected YES.

It asked whether she accepted.

She selected NO and entered the reason: AFFECTED DISTRICTS REMAIN WITHOUT STANDING IN THE PROPOSED REVIEW.

Ceryn read the line. “You may force a hearing before you have a remedy.”

“Then we will arrive without pretending proof and remedy are the same work.”

Senn pressed her thumb to the seal.

The fifth renewal joined the habitation challenge. Below them, Orison's nursery chimes continued through a spring that Ceryn had once saved. Neither woman looked away from the measured light.

Chapter 10 — The Thermodynamics of Refusal

Senn pulled the winter debit out of the lattice with two fingers and watched Orison turn white.

The simulation translated heat into color. Green held within scheduled range, amber marked stress, white meant the model had exceeded a material or civic limit. The first pale seam appeared beneath the central canal. It widened through the greenhouse terraces before Senn had moved her hand away from the control glass.

“Reset it,” she said.

Dael remained beside the instrument rack. “You asked for cancellation.”

“I asked you to remove an unlawful burden. I did not ask the model to invent heat.”

“It did not.” He tapped the narrow blue bars at the darkward edge. “You stopped exporting it.”

The lattice room occupied a windowless vault below the Conservatory, built when weather calculations still required coolant pipes thicker than a person's waist. Modern slates lined the old pipe channels. Their combined display curved around a waist-high map of the terminator ribbon: six hundred twenty kilometers of farms, cities, radiator fields, canals, and wind corridors reduced to light under glass. Condensation gathered on the dormant pipes overhead and fell at measured intervals into floor drains.

Hesh stood on the far side of the map with both hands resting on their ledger case. They had refused the chair offered by policy staff. They had also refused to let the simulation call Lorn Dusk a service precinct. Pera had entered the population, domestic heat, clinic reserves, school cycles, births, and burials as witnessed provisional data. For the first time, the lattice displayed a narrow inhabited band around towers 14 and 15.

Senn enlarged the white seam. “Which limit?”

"Canal stone storage first," Dael said. "Then hospital reservoirs. Greenhouse skins begin venting on day four."

"Those systems receive eleven days they should never have had."

"Material does not care how its schedule became unlawful."

Hesh opened the ledger case but did not remove a book. "Show us the days."

Dael sent the simulation back to its starting state. Orison returned to green. Lorn Dusk glowed dull blue, its color clipped at the bottom of the public legend until Pera's provisional data forced the scale lower. Four radiator towers carried amber points. Thin red threads marked known maintenance restrictions.

He entered Senn's instruction again: cancel all inherited winter transfers at the next schedule boundary, restore every darkward district to its climate floor, preserve current central light allocations until their authorized end. The lattice advanced one day at a time.

On the second day, radiator demand dropped. Heat remained in the atmospheric exchange instead of leaving through the darkward towers. The central ribbon absorbed part of it. Wind carried the rest starward, where shade schedules had already been committed to crop corridors.

By day four, Orison's greenhouse roofs vented in staggered pulses. Their warm air entered the canal corridor and climbed. The lattice drew a white hook above the eastern terraces.

"Why does bloom continue?" Hesh asked.

"Because those orders have separate authority," Senn said. "They are not written as benefits from the debit."

"Then your cancellation cancels our cold but protects their flowers."

"For the remainder of the issued order."

Hesh looked at her across the map. "Law seems to have excellent brakes when comfort might strike a wall."

Senn accepted the hit. "I can freeze inheritance. I cannot make an issued mirror angle disappear without a safety finding."

"Then find one honestly."

Dael advanced the model. On day six, the hook bent over the city. Air moving darkward met a denser return current above the radiator road. The interface tightened into a narrow yellow plane.

"Here," he said. "The morning pressure releases have nowhere broad to spread. The east array keeps warming the lower canal. Darkward export has fallen faster than central storage."

Senn rotated the wind field. The yellow plane looked almost delicate, a translucent fold above the model roofs. "Probability?"

"Still below intervention threshold."

“Do not protect me with a threshold. Give me the distribution.”

Dael opened the uncertainty bands. Twelve plausible runs fanned around the central line. In five, the fold loosened over uncultivated stone. Four struck the upper greenhouse tiers with damaging gusts. Two drove hail through the hospital reservoir roofs. The final run carried the front south and tore three kite tethers above a school district.

Hesh read each outcome without comment. Their thumb moved along the worn edge of the ledger case.

Day seven brought amber across the hospital storage field. Day eight whitened two school roofs and pushed the wind fold down toward inhabited streets. After nine days, the model labeled the formation a shear storm.

Senn walked around the table until she stood beside Dael. “You tuned this against the cancellation.”

“No.”

“You selected a central demand curve that assumes every discretionary bloom order survives.”

“I selected the orders already issued.”

“Policy could revoke them.”

“Policy can revoke a sentence. Crews still have to turn two hundred forty orbital surfaces without crossing adjacent light corridors. Canal shutters need a cooling sequence. Seed rooms cannot shed stored heat into occupied wards. Kite pilots need acceptable air.”

She pointed to Orison's white core. “How much of this comes from the hidden eleven days?”

“Most of the excess over the turn. Not most of the heat already in stone.”

“Then begin their reduction now.”

“With which mirror?”

The question came flat and practical. Dael opened the Choir schedule. Lines filled the wall from floor to ceiling, each showing an angle, transfer interval, ground track, and fallback position. Mirror 117 carried his small clinic offset in faded amber. Forty-three surfaces contributed directly or indirectly to Orison's current bloom. Moving one changed glare along tram routes or stole a planned window from another district. Moving several together altered the upper-air heating pattern faster than shade kites could answer.

Senn chose a sequence that reduced the eastern terraces first. The simulation accepted her hand entries, then marked three crop corridors below germination floor.

“Those are surplus beds,” she said.

“Two are,” Dael replied. “The third supplies hospital meal reserves.”

She shifted the cut south. A school-heating warning appeared.

"Buildings can close for three days."

"Children go somewhere when buildings close."

Hesh's mouth tightened. "That argument has been used against us for twenty-two years."

Dael looked away from the display. "I know."

"Do you?" Hesh asked. "You show a school warning here and every hand stops. Our school loses a reflected morning, so the ledger calls the heaters equipment demand."

"I falsified windows to keep your clinic warm."

"You kept some people alive without giving us authority to refuse the next loss. I am grateful for the heat. I am not grateful for the silence attached to it."

The pipes clicked overhead as coolant changed pressure in another vault. Dael rubbed the scarred fingers of his left hand against his coat seam. Senn had seen him use those fingers against hot fabric, testing tension through pain he no longer fully registered. Now he kept them closed.

"We are not measuring gratitude," Senn said. "Run a simultaneous reduction. Darkward restoration paired with central bloom cancellation at the same thermal rate."

Dael obeyed. The model dimmed Orison as Lorn Dusk warmed. For half a day, the transfer appeared balanced. Then the atmosphere distinguished light from radiator export. Reduced mirrors cooled surfaces from above; reduced tower duty retained heat in moving air. The two changes met at different heights and times. A shear line formed farther west, weaker at first, then sharpened over the canal road.

Senn slowed the run to hourly steps. "What keeps it from coupling?"

"Shade between the heated ground and the return layer. Distributed, not one large block."

"Use the reserve fleet."

"Committed."

"All thirty-six?"

"Thirty maintain active schedules. Five cover mechanical or storm contingency. One is under recertification."

"Reserve six," she said.

Dael gave her a look that belonged more properly to Tovin. "You have read the policy capacity. You have not held the fabric."

"The reserve exists for instability."

"It exists on paper at full area. Its last edge test showed unequal draw."

"Unsafe?"

"Unknown until Tovin completes the frame run."

Hesh pulled a chair closer and sat at last. "Your system has a hidden city, a false legal category, four failing towers, and a reserve nobody has tested. Which part did you intend to tell us before asking for another winter?"

No one answered quickly enough.

Senn cleared the model and entered only the Charter constraints. Every inhabited district would receive its climate floor. Every issued share above that floor could be altered. No location could carry an unnamed debit. The lattice rejected the run before weather calculation began.

MISSING ALLOCATION AUTHORITY, the wall reported.

"That is the point," she said.

Dael read the rejection. "The machine cannot distribute a burden without a rule."

"It distributed one for decades."

"It had a rule. A wrong one."

"Then equalize it."

"By population? Area? Existing use? Available radiator distance?"

Hesh leaned forward. "Not population."

Senn turned. "I have not proposed a final basis."

"You entered equality as if a person could tell us what the unit means later. Large districts with little surplus would pay more because they contain more bodies. That gives poverty an arithmetic penalty."

"Equal thermal contribution, then."

"From what?"

The question stopped her. A thermal unit taken from a greenhouse above survival heat did not equal one taken from a decorative canal. A cold hour imposed on a clinic did not match a cold hour in an empty tram hall, though both balanced the same account. The ledger could convert each into energy. It could not select which loss remained tolerable.

Dael rebuilt the starting state and highlighted every district's declared climate floor. Broad green bands appeared across the ribbon. Lorn Dusk's provisional band came up hard against measured demand, leaving almost no room between life and scheduled weather. Orison displayed a thick layer above floor.

"Can you give them that now?" Senn asked.

"Not with a switch."

"That answer preserves the present harm."

"No. It describes the time constant."

"People freeze during time constants."

"People die in shear storms."

Their voices stayed low, which made the quarrel carry farther in the sealed room. Hesh watched each of them as if checking two instruments that disagreed.

Senn opened the emergency authority panel. "I can issue a corrective freeze on every bloom extension derived from the debit."

Dael placed his palm over the seal field before she could touch it. "Then maintenance inherits an impossible order. Crews either violate your freeze or watch the storm form."

"Move your hand."

"Name the safe first angle."

"I am not the lattice engineer."

"Yet you are prepared to command the lattice."

Hesh struck the ledger case once against the table. The small sound cut through them.

"Enough," they said. "Dael, take your hand away. Senn, close the authority panel."

Neither moved.

Hesh rose. "I came because you told us the central city could not claim ignorance once the records opened. I did not come to watch one of you make a threat and the other make physics into a veto."

Dael withdrew his hand first. Senn closed the panel.

"Lorn Dusk wants the debit cancelled," Hesh continued. "We have wanted it cancelled since before anyone let us know its administrative name. We will not consent to another turn of imposed cold. We will also not call a storm over children justice because an auditor needs clean hands."

Senn felt the words settle with more weight than Ceryn's defense had carried. Ceryn had offered staged review while retaining control. Hesh demanded an end to the wrong and denied Senn the innocence of haste.

"What do you consent to?" she asked.

"Recognition now. Authority to see and challenge every schedule touching our floor. A correction we help design. No new debit inherited while people debate."

"The existing schedule still runs."

"Then put our name on every hour it takes."

Dael zoomed out from Orison. Beyond the city, weather shares intersected across the ribbon: rain held for Caldriфт, orchard warmth in Nacre districts unrelated to Nacre Fold, industrial shade along western reservoirs, unused preferences, emergency margins, ceremonial dawns, transit glare limits. The

hidden transfer had survived partly because policy treated the correction as a choice between Orison and three gray sectors. The larger system contained more levers, though none came free.

"We need room below every declared surplus," he said. "Not merely Orison's."

Hesh shook their head. "Declared by whom?"

"Each district."

"Then wealthy districts will rename comfort as essential before the request arrives."

Senn studied the bands. "We audit the floor, not the preference. Continuous heat, medical reserve, food germination, schools, domestic survival. Everything above needs its authority shown."

"Who decides what a school needs?" Hesh asked.

"The district supplies evidence."

"To an office that called ours equipment."

Senn removed the Conservatory's default floor values. Half the green bands disappeared, leaving raw measurements and local declarations side by side. "Then the office does not decide alone."

Dael began a new run without being asked. He restored Lorn Dusk only by a small increment for the first day, paired it with several minor shade changes across unoccupied industrial surfaces, and reduced Orison's decorative canal light after the public bloom interval. The model advanced. No white seam appeared. On day three, however, a western reservoir lost enough evaporation to alter a rain order. He stopped.

"Failure?" Senn asked.

"Consequence."

"Can it move?"

"If the reservoir district accepts later rain."

"Would its climate floor hold?"

"Yes."

Hesh came around the table. "Show the people who would be asked."

Dael opened the district layer. A municipal council, water cooperative, and two farming associations governed the preference. None had participated in the hidden transfer. All would see less predictable water if they agreed.

"That resembles consent," Hesh said. "Do not mistake resemblance for completion."

They worked through the meal chime. Pera sent up paper packets from the archive: Charter floor definitions, dormant challenge procedures, district contact authorities, and the fifth renewal sheet whose signature had changed the nature of

Senn's case. No single procedure allowed an unrecognized settlement to negotiate planetary weather. A habitation challenge could establish standing, but policy classification delayed its hearing. An emergency safety order could change mirror schedules, but only to prevent quantified physical danger. Audit protection could release evidence, not allocate seasons.

Senn arranged the papers around the glowing map. "We have treated standing as the reward after a remedy."

Hesh traced the edge of the habitation form. "Standing must come before you decide which remedy counts."

"Provisional recognition could invalidate the debit without commanding an immediate physical reversal."

Dael considered it. "The lattice would still need an interim rule."

"No inherited increase. Every present burden visible by district and hour. Restoration paced at the fastest rate that stays below safety thresholds. Any delay requires a named finding."

"Signed by whom?"

"Conservatory engineering, audit, and an affected district representative."

Hesh's expression did not soften. "One district representative from each side of the transfer."

"Agreed."

"Local records define our floor until a hearing reviews them openly."

Dael enlarged the wind field again. "If a local declaration exceeds physical capacity?"

"Then you show the constraint," Hesh said. "You do not erase the residents."

The last simulation began with no dramatic switch. Lorn Dusk's band rose by measured steps. Orison surrendered canal warmth, an unused commercial light rehearsal, and part of a greenhouse overrun. Two other districts contributed small shade margins subject to consent. The model reached day six without whitening. On day seven, a shear warning appeared, broad rather than sharp. Dael changed no values; he marked the place where additional agreements or reserve capacity would be needed.

By nine days, the central ribbon remained below material limits. Lorn Dusk had not yet recovered its whole climate floor. The result satisfied nobody, which made it more credible than the clean alternatives.

Dael printed the thermal cross-section on translucent film. Heat layers showed as brown contours, their handled edges already fading where his thumb pressed the sheet. He laid it over the district schedule and punched registration holes through both pages. The misalignment became physical: restoration rose at the darkward ground while retained atmospheric heat traveled hundreds of meters above it.

"Take these apart in a hearing and someone will claim the schedules balance," he said.

"Then fasten them," Senn replied.

He threaded copper wire through the holes. Hesh added a third sheet listing the promised windows Lorn Dusk had lost during the active order. Instead of aligning neatly, the dates crossed Dael's contours at irregular intervals.

"Now nobody gets to present air without people," they said.

Senn checked the model's source bundle. It still called Orison's canal light an urban continuity requirement. She opened the designation and attached photographs from the bloom terraces: apricot walls, public tram displays, the decorative western reach where no hospital reservoir or seed bed depended on the warmth. The essential portions remained protected. The rest acquired an evidence flag.

A facilities clerk knocked and offered to clear the room for the night shift. Senn requested two more hours under active audit authority. Hesh requested food. Dael requested a replacement coolant cup for the rack, because argument had not exempted the processors from heat. Each demand entered a different office, and each had to be named before anyone acted.

Senn saved the run under no remedy name. Naming it too early would let policy defend the label instead of the work.

"What have we agreed?" Dael asked.

Hesh closed their ledger case. "Not enough."

"That is accurate but difficult to enter."

"Enter this: Lorn Dusk refuses continued unrepresented harm. We also refuse an unrepresented correction imposed on somebody else."

Senn wrote the sentence into the simulation record. Beneath it she added the procedural needs: provisional habitation standing, shared access to floor evidence, visible interim burdens, distributed options, engineering findings attached to any delay.

Dael read over her shoulder. "You have not cancelled the debit."

"No." The admission hurt more than the earlier argument. "I have stopped pretending cancellation is one act."

Hesh took the stylus from her and placed a line before every proposed technical step. "Standing first," they said.

The three of them looked at the altered sequence. No switch led it. A name did.

Chapter 11 — The Names in the Heat Wall

Hesh lifted the first heat brick before Senn had removed her coat.

Warmth left a dark rectangle on the plaster. Beneath it, someone had written a name in charcoal, then covered the letters when the brick went back into its wall cradle. Hesh carried the dense ceramic block to a handcart and exposed another name.

"Records room is behind the wall," they said. "Help if you want to enter."

Senn set her document case beside the stove. The address hall had emptied after the late meal, though voices traveled from the workshop corridor and radiator vibration trembled through the floor. Heat bricks lined the inner wall in stacked iron cradles. During a reflected-light window, surplus warmth charged their ceramic cores. Residents moved them to bedrooms, the school, or the clinic as need changed. Tonight the bricks had to come out before the records door could open.

She gripped one through folded canvas. Its weight drew at her shoulders. "Why build access behind working storage?"

"Because the records need steady temperature," Hesh replied. "People need the bricks. Space serves twice here."

The charcoal names emerged one by one: PEL ARU. SIVA NEM. OLAN TIR. Each occupied the plaster directly behind a brick cradle. Some letters had blurred from decades of heat and handling. Others looked recent enough to stain a finger.

Senn placed her brick on the cart. "Deaths?"

"People whose last winter involved this wall."

"Involved how?"

"That question waits for Nima Sol."

They cleared three vertical rows. A narrow metal door appeared, its surface patched where repeated heating had warped the hinges. Hesh unlocked it with two keys and made Senn sign a paper entry sheet before crossing the threshold.

Shelves filled the room from floor to pipework. Address ledgers stood upright in oilcloth wrappers. Clinic registers occupied gray boxes. Heating records hung from metal rods by month, their paper strips notched where temperatures crossed warning values. Burial notices, school absence books, radiator incident reports, and requests for reflected dawn had separate shelves. Nothing resembled the compact evidence packet Senn had expected.

"You asked for the full record," Hesh said.

"I did."

"This is what full looks like before an archive makes it convenient."

Nima waited at a folding table near the back. She wore a clinic coat with the cuffs turned twice and had tied her dark hair out of her face using a strip of instrument cloth. Three stacks of files stood before her. A fourth chair held a kettle

and cups.

"You brought the auditor," she said.

"The auditor carried four bricks."

"Then her causal contribution to the door is established."

Senn sat opposite her. "You are Nima Sol."

"Physician, not statistician. That distinction may become important before morning."

Hesh took the remaining chair. "Begin with Pel."

Nima drew the first file from the left stack. Pel Aru had repaired condensation traps in tower 15 and lived with his daughter above the tool exchange. During a winter extension twelve years earlier, his district heater allocation fell below the domestic request for six consecutive nights. The local clinic noted numbness in his right foot, then tissue injury. A reflected clinic window arrived two days late. Pel developed fever after debridement and died under antibiotic shortage protocols.

"Could warmer weather have prevented his death?" Senn asked.

"Yes."

"Can you establish that the transferred winter caused it?"

"No."

The clean refusal made Senn look up.

Nima folded her hands over the file. "He had vascular disease. He delayed treatment because his shift team lacked a replacement. The clinic's drug order had also been reduced after a transport fault. Cold initiated the injury. Delay worsened it. Supply constrained treatment. If you ask for one cause, the record will not give it."

"What can it give?"

"An exposure path. Temperature below the requested domestic floor. Duration. Injury consistent with exposure. Treatment conditions altered by withheld light or heating. A comparison with residents of similar age and illness during ordinary schedules."

Hesh touched the charcoal rubbing attached to Pel's file. "And his name."

Senn wrote each link on a separate line. "Who certified the temperature instrument?"

"I did not expect that to be your first objection."

"It is not an objection. If policy can break the path by discrediting one sensor, they will."

"The heat-wall probe received Conservatory calibration every second turn until nine years ago. After that, Dael arranged comparison checks through tower maintenance. Those lack civic certification."

"Do you have the comparison sheets?"

Hesh pointed to a rod of folded pages above her head.

Senn fetched them. Dael's initials appeared on the margins, beside two local mechanics and a clinic orderly. The readings tracked a certified tower intake probe within tolerance. Unauthorized evidence, physically sound. She attached the sheets to Pel's chain without pretending the certification problem away.

Siva Nem's file came next. Siva had taught the lower school and used a portable oxygen concentrator after a dust illness. A cancelled dawn window forced the school onto stored power. When domestic heating demand rose that evening, equipment-priority rules protected tower pumps but not household medical devices. Siva's concentrator lost power for forty-three minutes. She recovered, then died six weeks later after repeated respiratory infections.

"Too remote?" Hesh asked.

Nima answered before Senn could. "For individual attribution, probably. For population risk, perhaps not. We retain her because the winter altered the chain. We mark uncertainty rather than erasing her."

Senn examined the power log. Conservatory telemetry had counted the concentrator draw inside equipment occupancy. The machine existed in the central record. Siva did not.

Olan Tir had fallen from an exterior radiator stair during ice accumulation. The official incident blamed a boot cleat. Local weather records showed that a promised warming interval had been reassigned after the stair crew began work. He died on impact. Nima classified the association as strong but distinguished it from cold-exposure mortality.

"Policy will say you mixed categories," Senn said.

"I separated them in every table."

"They will say the headline does not."

"There is no headline yet."

Hesh watched Senn sharpen her pencil. "You sound disappointed."

"I sound cautious."

"You arrived angry enough to cancel a planetary transfer in one motion. Now the dead require caution."

Senn set the pencil down. "The dead require proof that survives people who benefit from doubting them."

"Survives for whom?"

"For a hearing."

"We survived without one."

Nima pushed a cup toward each of them. "You can argue over ownership after we keep the records from being dismissed."

Steam carried the mineral smell of heat-wall water. Senn drank and found it bitter with dried leaf. Her fingers had stiffened after moving the bricks. The room itself stayed cool to protect paper, forcing them to work in coats while warmth waited on the other side of plaster.

They continued through the first shelf. Ressa's grandfather, Mal En, had died after a heater ration forced three households into one room during a respiratory outbreak. A newborn named Iri survived her first cold injury but developed renal complications before her second birthday. Two tower workers suffered coolant burns because an extended radiator run shortened a maintenance cooling interval. One later died from infection. Nima never let Senn merge their paths merely because the winter transfer touched each one.

At midnight, Hesh brought in a tray of grain cakes from the communal stove. Grease marked the file guards despite their care. Senn replaced one sheet and recorded the handling change.

"You make a note when food touches paper," Hesh said.

"Someone examining the stain later should know it happened tonight."

"Do you make notes when policy touches people?"

"That is why I am here."

The answer sounded insufficient even to her.

A narrow blue ledger near the bottom shelf bore the title TENANCY AND HEAT EXCEPTIONS. Senn opened it expecting Lorn Dusk addresses. The first pages listed temporary greenhouse quarters occupied by workers whose names never entered the main address book because their employers claimed rotational housing.

"Tenant growers," she said.

Hesh leaned over. "You know the form."

Caldrift used an older version. Eight years earlier, Senn had treated leaseholder records as the legal destination for storm-loss compensation. The field surveys listed families cultivating each parcel, but the payment protocol recognized only title and active lease at disbursement. Twelve households lost their agreements during the delay. Landholders received compensation for crops the departing families had planted.

Nima turned the ledger toward herself. "Your signature?"

"Not here." Senn kept her hands flat. "In Caldrift."

"What happened?"

She could have described the appeal. She could have explained that no rule then allowed an auditor to suspend title-based disbursement, that the total crop loss had been measured correctly, that later review changed the forms. Those facts had protected her license. None had returned the farms.

"I approved a reconciliation by parcels," she said. "The losses belonged to

tenant growers. The payment followed the leases after the growers could no longer hold them."

"How many?" Hesh asked.

"Twelve households lost their land before payment."

"Did you know their names?"

"Not when I signed."

"Did the records contain them?"

"Yes."

Hesh closed the blue ledger. "Then you have seen this trick before."

"Not with winter."

"The weather changes. The trick keeps its coat."

Nima reached into her middle stack and removed a table with no personal identifiers. Age bands occupied one axis. Exposure categories occupied the other. Senn saw why the conversation had turned.

"This summary will travel faster than those shelves," Nima said. "It must. No delegate will read every clinic note before acting. But once a total leaves this room, people will argue with the total and forget what it summarizes."

"Then the chain needs an annex."

"Annexes disappear."

"Not under protected audit procedure."

Hesh gave a dry laugh. "A protected procedure issued by the office protecting its own classification."

Senn drew the blank summary closer. "Attach a reversible index. Every included case gets a local record key. Public material can protect medical details, but authorized review must move from any row back to a person, place, exposure interval, and uncertainty grade."

"Who holds the key?" Nima asked.

"You do. Hesh holds a witnessed copy. The archive preserves a sealed copy."

"What happens when Ceryn classifies it?"

"She can restrict medical information. She cannot legally suppress evidence attached to an active habitation challenge if the evidence establishes standing or harm."

"Can she call it preliminary?"

"Yes."

"Can she delay it?"

"Yes."

Hesh's gaze did not leave Senn. "Honest answers improve a poor offer."

Senn turned the table over. On its blank back she drafted an evidence rule: no aggregate assertion without a countable case register; no case register without names retained by the originating district; uncertainty expressed per causal path; exclusions logged with reasons; additions witnessed; revisions preserved rather than overwritten.

Nima read it twice. "You keep saying count."

"Eventually someone will demand one."

"Someone always does. A number looks governable."

"Then we make the number answerable."

Hesh stood and took a key from a chain beneath their shirt. "You have seen the selected files. The full death register sits in the second room."

Senn looked toward the back wall. No door showed between the shelves.

Nima moved two hanging rods aside. A recessed panel carried a keyhole and a strip of dark cloth around its edges. Hesh unlocked it. Cold air moved out, dry and faintly scented with paper preservative.

The second room held no desks. Bound volumes occupied shallow shelves, each spine marked by year. Small cloth packets rested beside some books: a school badge, a cracked heater dial, boot cleats, a child's knitted cuff. The objects did not prove causation. They prevented the records from becoming only clinical abstractions.

Senn stopped before the most recent volume. "How many files have you classified?"

"Enough to know the methods need independent review," Nima said.

"That was not my question."

"No aggregate total," Hesh said. "Not until the complete attribution joins Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold. If you carry a partial number out, Orison will spend it as if the omissions were certainty."

Senn nodded. Her impatience did not create entitlement.

They took the current volume to the outer table. Each entry began with an address and name, followed by birth date, occupation, household heat source, incident or illness, medical finding, weather interval, instrument references, and Nima's causal grade. Cross-references led to district heating strips and tower duty logs. Some entries ended EXCLUDE FROM ATTRIBUTION while remaining in the historical record.

"Why retain excluded cases in the working register?" Senn asked.

"To prove we did not select only what favored us."

A man named Cor Venn had died during an extended winter, but his room stayed above heating floor and his illness showed no cold sensitivity. Excluded. A transport collision occurred on a clear road after a light cancellation. Excluded. A

woman missed medicine when a lift battery failed, though district power remained adequate. Uncertain equipment link, excluded pending engineering review.

The exclusions gave the included files harder edges. They also showed the labor behind restraint. Nima had not turned grief into a claim indiscriminately.

A heating strip from the fourteenth year carried a puzzling gap. Temperatures ran in blue ink from midnight to the fifth hour, vanished for ninety minutes, then resumed two degrees higher. The matching clinic register documented three cold injuries during that interval.

"Instrument failure?" Senn asked.

"Wall power failed," Nima said. "We reconstructed from room thermometers."

"Where are those readings?"

Hesh brought down a school exercise book. Fourteen households had written times and temperatures across pages meant for geometry. Different hands used different decimal habits. One person rounded to whole degrees. Another recorded the kitchen and sleeping room separately. A third wrote only COLD ENOUGH TO MOVE BABY TO WALL.

Senn arranged the entries by address. "Policy counsel will call this uncalibrated testimony."

"It is uncalibrated testimony," Nima replied. "Do not improve its name."

"We can test it against the recovery curve. Once wall power returned, the certified strip shows how quickly each zone warmed. If the household readings fit the building response, they support the missing interval."

Hesh found the maintenance diagram. Together they traced shared pipes from the wall exchanger into four residential branches. Senn entered the later temperatures, exterior air, brick distribution, and pipe lengths into a simple decay model. Eleven household readings fell within the broad physical range. Two sat outside it but corresponded to rooms using portable heaters. One lacked a time and could not be placed.

Nima changed no source. She added a note distinguishing contemporary observation from later reconstruction.

"Would you include the injuries?" Hesh asked.

"For exposure association, yes. For any narrower claim, the uncertainty remains high."

"Three people felt the cold without high uncertainty."

"The cold is certain," Senn said. "Its contribution to each later condition needs a grade."

Hesh copied her wording into the margin, then underlined **contribution**. "Better than cause."

Another problem surfaced in the burial register. Two residents shared the name

Lina Vey, one born thirty years before the other. A clinic key had attached the younger woman's heating history to the elder woman's respiratory file. Nima swore softly and opened both address books.

Senn followed the error through six references. Correcting it removed one apparent exposure and added a different missed-medicine interval. The likely classification changed. More important, the sealed index now showed how the error entered and who amended it.

"This will be used against the whole record," Nima said.

"Only if we hide it." Senn drew one line through the mistaken key, leaving every character readable. "An auditable correction strengthens the method."

"Central archives say that after mistakes involving paper," Hesh said. "With people, they prefer a blank field."

Senn passed them the correction form. "Then sign beside mine."

Their three signatures crowded the narrow margin. No one mistook the repair for cleanliness.

Toward morning, Senn took a shift reading entries aloud while Hesh checked the address ledger and Nima matched clinic keys. The names changed the cadence of the work. Each forced her mouth to stop before the dates and categories resumed. No line could slide silently into the next.

"Ela Sor," she read. "Heat-wall address C-seventeen. Greenhouse mechanic. Exposure interval begins on the sixth night after a missed light window."

Hesh found the household page. "Three residents at that address then. One moved to Eyr the following turn."

Nima corrected the comparison group. "That move matters. Eyr's winter interval differed by four days."

Senn logged the revision instead of replacing the old field. Her Caldrift reconciliation had treated departures as administrative noise. Here, movement remained part of the evidence.

Dawn never reached Lorn Dusk directly. The hour announced itself through a change in radiator load and footsteps outside the hall. Someone began returning charged bricks from the night rooms. The metal door would soon need closing so the wall could work again.

Hesh gathered the case keys. "Decision time."

Senn looked at the shelves, the incomplete regional table, and the provisional index. Accepting the record did not certify every causal claim. Refusing it until central methods made it tidy would repeat the failure that had brought her here.

"I accept the full local record into the habitation audit," she said. "Clinical conclusions remain subject to independent attribution. Exclusions remain visible. Medical details stay sealed except to authorized reviewers."

Nima waited. "And the summary?"

"No count leaves its case index. No case index loses the district-held names."

Hesh placed one key on the table between them. "Write that as a condition, not a promise."

Senn wrote it on the intake form. Nima signed as originating custodian. Hesh signed as ledger keeper. Senn pressed her audit seal below both.

Outside, residents lifted the heat bricks from the cart. The door narrowed row by row as warm ceramic returned to the cradles. Pel Aru disappeared first, then Siva Nem, then Olan Tir. Their charcoal letters remained behind the working wall, attached to the heat it had held and failed to hold.

Senn carried no total away. She carried the key map, three signatures, and a rule that any future number had to open back into names.

Chapter 12 — Reserve Six

Tovin drove his boot into the lower spar and felt reserve 6 answer with a shiver it should not have had.

"Slack the starward corner," he called.

Two riggers eased the test lines through their brakes. Black kite fabric sagged across the hangar frame, swallowing the red work lamps in a shape forty meters wide. The membrane never flew whole inside the ground facility. Crews unfolded one cell at a time across an articulated steel rig, pulled it to simulated wind load, and listened for failures too small for instruments to find early.

The shiver came again beneath Tovin's sole. Not a snap. More like a moth striking paper, faint and quick.

"Hold at eighteen percent."

Cal, the senior rigger at the starward winch, locked her brake. "Gauge says clean."

"Gauge has no foot."

"It has calibration."

"My foot passed recertification last month."

Laughter moved around the frame without loosening anyone's hands. Tovin crouched on the spar and pressed his palm to the fabric seam. Reserve kites spent most of their lives folded in dry nitrogen, which made policy officials imagine they did not age. Adhesives continued curing. Conductive threads took a set. Micrometeoroid patches stiffened beside untouched film. A machine could rest itself into weakness.

Beyond the hangar doors, Orison's bloom light struck the apron hard enough to

sharpen every tether shadow. Flight crews worked beneath open canopies on two active kites, replacing control vanes before the next pressure shift. The air smelled of hot dust and polymer sealant.

"Take it to twenty," Tovin said.

Cal raised one finger, relayed the command, and turned both winches by a quarter mark. The membrane drew flat. Tovin felt the left diagonal load through the spar. The right side lagged.

A pale line opened near the cell boundary.

"Drop!"

Brakes released. Fabric collapsed into the catch net with a dry rush. One technician slapped the emergency stop after the motion had already ended.

Tovin climbed down, ducked under the rig, and found the line. It measured no longer than his hand. The top coating had separated from its reinforcement, exposing a silver conductive mesh. Under flight load, a tear could follow the mesh across three cells before automatic reefing responded.

Cal lay beside him on the net. "Storage crease?"

"Too straight."

"Patch edge?"

"No patch in this panel."

Someone at the hangar door said, "Policy lists full area available."

Tovin knew the voice. He stayed under the fabric. "Policy can come hold this corner at altitude."

Senn crouched outside the netting, her auditor's case balanced against one knee. Dust from darkward travel marked the hem of her coat. She looked as though she had slept on paper and found the paper argumentative.

"I need to know what Orison can surrender," she said.

"You came to a good place. We just surrendered one kite."

"Temporarily?"

Cal whistled through her teeth and crawled toward the access edge. Tovin followed. Standing upright, he handed Senn a strip of red fault tape.

"Mark the spot," he said.

She looked at the tape. "I am not certified on membrane work."

"Neither are most people who quote reserve capacity."

Senn took the point. She crawled beneath the lowered cell while Tovin directed her to the exposed mesh. Her tape flag went beside his chalk circle, careful not to touch the damaged coating.

"Fabric fault," she said.

"Good. Now the official record has discovered matter."

Cal began photographing the seam with a scale strip. The rest of the crew checked adjacent folds. Tovin opened the kite's maintenance history at a standing console. Reserve 6 had passed electrical continuity, gas storage, and control-vane tests. Its last full tension run occurred nineteen months earlier. Policy assumed annual testing, but two emergency deployments of other craft had displaced this one from the frame schedule.

Senn read the delay note. "You signed the postponement."

"I had one rig and three kites that had actually flown through grit."

"You also signed full reserve availability six weeks later."

"The control systems were available. Fabric certification stayed conditional."

"The Almanac sees a whole kite."

"The Almanac sees the capacity field policy asks us to fill."

"You filled it."

Tovin enlarged the form and pointed to a code beneath the green status mark. "R-six-C. Conditional membrane validation."

"Does seasonal accounting ingest that code?"

"No."

"Did you know?"

"I knew scheduling treated reserve numbers as planning values, not launch promises."

"That means yes."

He closed the history harder than necessary. "Welcome home, Senn."

Cal glanced from one sibling to the other. "I can clear the crew."

"No," Tovin said. "If auditors only hear maintenance disputes after workers leave, they think equipment repairs itself between sentences."

Senn set her case on the scarred workbench. "Immediate cancellation produces a shear front over Orison. Distributed shade could slow it. Dael says this reserve may provide part of the response."

"Dael said *may*?"

"Yes."

"Then he has learned manners."

"What can it provide?"

Tovin looked back at the slack membrane. "Today? A repair problem."

"After repair."

"Unknown until full-load test, edge-control test, conductivity scan, vane synchronization, pack cycle, and a flight corridor."

"How long?"

"If this separation stays local, three days. If the roll shares the defect, we replace cells. Replacement stock needs cutting and cure time."

"Maximum?"

"Stop asking maintenance for one number when the inspection has not reached the second fold."

Her jaw set. In childhood, that expression preceded lists. Senn had used lists to prove Tovin took the long irrigation route, borrowed tools without returning them, or ate preserved fruit assigned to winter. He had learned to irritate her by confessing to adjacent offenses she had not measured.

"Caldrift taught us to inspect before rain," she said.

"Caldrift taught us rain arrived whether the form closed or not."

Their hometown entered the hangar between them: low stone cisterns, seed roofs, their mother's weather notes pinned with kitchen knives when wind found the shutters. Senn had left for accounting. Tovin had left for machines that could be reached with both hands. Each believed the other had chosen distance.

A rigger called from the net. "Second separation, same diagonal."

Tovin went back under. This fault ran along an internal conductor eight meters from the first. He pressed a light through the film and saw tiny clouding around the adhesive bond.

"Bad cure batch," Cal said beside him.

"Or storage solvent."

"Panel numbers?"

They read the edge marks. Both cells came from the same manufacturing roll, installed after a hail puncture six years earlier. Four other cells shared that roll.

Tovin ordered all six isolated. The crew clipped colored tabs along their boundaries and moved support nets before releasing the seams. Every step reduced the kite's usable area.

Senn watched without interrupting until the cell map appeared on the console. "How much shade remains if those six are reefed?"

"Enough for local glare control. Not enough to spread the whole Orison heat plume."

"Can active kites contribute?"

"They already contribute to other schedules."

"Above district floors?"

"Some. I pilot fabric, not constitutional distinctions."

"You schedule maintenance against municipal priorities."

"I receive priorities."

"And decide which machine flies."

Tovin pulled off his gloves. Sweat had collected beneath the cuffs. "Say what you came to accuse me of."

"I came to ask what Orison can surrender."

"Ask Orison. The city built eleven extra days into every dependency it could name. Now you want workers to remove them while everyone who enjoyed the light calls the consequences technical."

"I know the consequences are physical."

"You know after Dael made you run the model."

The hurt crossed her face before control returned. Tovin regretted the sentence and remained angry enough not to retrieve it.

Senn opened her case. Inside lay thermal cross-sections wired to district records. The pages looked used rather than presented. "This is what immediate cancellation does. I refused to believe safety could justify delay until I saw the layers separate."

"Safety does justify delay."

"Not silence."

"No. But exposure changes demand before crews can change machines. Public challenge freezes signatures. Districts protect their allocations. Pilots receive schedules with no legal path through them."

"You are afraid the Conservatory will ground the reserve fleet."

"I am afraid you will prove the whole system unlawful before anyone has authority to keep it alive."

"An unlawful system is already failing people."

"So is a torn kite."

Her palm flattened over the wired records. "What would you have me do? Leave Lorn Dusk below floor because our forms hid a conditional code?"

"I would have you bring the people who turn the winches into the room before issuing the correction."

"They do not have standing."

"Neither do those crews when policy closes. We get liability."

Cal came to the bench holding a cut sample from the faulty seam. "You both keep using workers as if we are not within speaking distance."

Tovin looked at her.

She placed the sample under a magnifier. "Give us a staged demand curve. We can tell you which parts are impossible. Give us an emergency shutdown and we will tell you it is unsafe, because it is."

Senn nodded once. "Will you participate under audit protection?"

"Will participation suspend my license?"

"Not for disclosing an existing condition."

"That sounded narrower than I hoped."

"It is as broad as my authority."

Cal smiled without humor. "Runs in the family."

The inspection continued. Two of the remaining four suspect cells showed early clouding but no open separation. Tovin cut power to their conductive mesh and ordered tensile coupons from every seam. Repair stock covered three full cells. The other three required material from a retired kite panel stored across the city.

He called the depot. Its manager refused release because retired membrane remained emergency inventory under municipal seal.

"Tell them active reserve repair," Tovin said.

"They want an incident number."

"The incident is in front of me."

"System wants digits."

Senn reached for the terminal. Tovin blocked her with an elbow.

"Maintenance finding first," he said. "Your seal after."

Together they built the record. Cal described the audible vibration and coating separation. Tovin classified flight consequence and isolated the affected roll. Senn attached the difference between listed planning capacity and tested deployable area. When the form asked whether public safety faced immediate risk, none of the offered answers fit. *No* would keep the depot closed. *Yes* could ground the fleet.

"Conditional risk under schedule change," Senn said.

"No field."

"Add a statement."

"The system ignores remarks for release authority."

She opened the form definition. "Then we challenge the field."

"A field challenge takes five days."

Tovin selected YES and constrained it manually: RISK ARISES ONLY IF RESERVE SIX IS ASSIGNED ABOVE CURRENT TESTED AREA. NO ACTIVE SCHEDULE RELIES ON THAT AREA. MATERIAL REQUESTED TO RESTORE CONTINGENCY.

Senn read it. "Accurate."

"It may still trigger fleet review."

"I will attach an audit finding against automatic grounding."

They both sealed the incident. The depot released the retired panel within seven minutes.

No triumph followed. A tug had to cross Orison during bloom traffic, the material needed contamination inspection, and the crew faced a night cure if they wanted the next tension test on time. Tovin assigned shifts. Two riggers objected to the hours. Cal revised the sequence so each seam team received a rest interval. The repair lengthened by four hours and became less likely to fail through fatigue.

Before cutting the retired panel, Cal rolled a strip into the inspection hood. Ultraviolet lamps revealed three old crease lines and a repair stamp from a kite scrapped after lightning damage. The depot manifest had labeled the whole roll reusable.

"Not this end," she said.

Tovin measured past the last fluorescent trace. Clean material remained for two full cells and most of a third. They could splice the final section, but every splice added a tension discontinuity.

Senn watched Cal mark the cutting path with weighted cord. "Can another reserve donate a panel?"

"Then another reserve loses certification," Tovin said.

"What about new stock?"

"Seven days from the fabric works if their coating line has no crop-film priority."

"Could we certify reduced area now and add the final cell later?"

Cal answered. "Yes, if policy stops calling reduced area a failure. We would reef the damaged corner, rebalance the vane table, and fly at sixty-eight percent."

Tovin opened the control model. Reefing changed more than area. One edge would carry higher flutter, while the guidance vanes spent extra power keeping the shortened shape aligned. He entered the measured clean cells rather than the nominal panel. Battery reserve fell below storm standard but remained above ordinary deployment threshold.

"Useful for staged shade," he said. "Not a storm intercept."

Senn wrote the distinction into her notes. "What restores storm capacity?"

"New third cell, full cure, another frame pull, then a pack cycle. No shortcuts."

The crew trimmed the usable fabric with heated blades. Polymer fumes entered the hood extraction and left a faint sweet odor in the work bay. Tovin helped align the first seam. Conductive threads had to overlap within a finger's width without touching the reinforcement braid. Cal rejected their first placement because one corner creased under its own weight.

They lifted, cleaned, and aligned it again.

Senn held the far edge under instruction. Her hands stayed rigid until Tovin told her the membrane needed support, not restraint.

"You cannot order it flat," he said.

"I noticed."

“Let it find the frame marks.”

Material relaxed between their gloves. The silver traces settled over the alignment grid. Cal lowered the bonding bar and began the timed cure. For twelve minutes nobody could improve the seam by touching it.

Senn studied the schedule. “This is what I need for bloom reduction.”

“A shift roster?”

“A sequence that identifies resistance instead of hiding it inside a capacity value.”

“Flowers do not have seam teams.”

“Canal shutters do. Greenhouse operators do. Hospital reservoirs do.”

Tovin took a clean slate and opened Orison's current bloom demand. He rarely saw it as a civic whole. His screen usually received only the shade response: glare caps, high-air temperature ceilings, emergency margins. Senn separated demands into protected floors, operational dependencies, and discretionary uses. Decorative canal warmth occupied more capacity than Tovin expected. Commercial night bloom occupied less, but its timing forced three kite transitions.

“If you remove this block,” he said, “kite 12 can hold one angle instead of turning twice. That gives us a wider response margin.”

“Crop effect?”

“None from shade. Ask the greenhouse side about stored heat.”

They called a bloom engineer named Varo, who objected before the graph finished loading. The commercial block supported flower contracts and evening tram traffic. Senn asked for floor evidence. Varo supplied none. Tovin asked what equipment required the heat. Two canal pumps needed freeze protection, but they could draw from stored water if the decorative lights ended gradually.

“Gradually means what?” Senn asked.

Varo wanted six days. Tovin tested four. Pump load spiked on the second night. Five kept the system inside ordinary duty.

They moved to the western apricot walls. Removing light too fast risked bud loss, which would reduce fruit set rather than threaten staple supply. Varo called that distinction politically naive. Senn called it relevant. Tovin entered a two-stage reduction and watched kite transitions simplify.

Hours passed in specific surrender. A school bridge could lose evening glare while keeping classroom heat. The central tram hall could accept colder glass if crews treated condensation before the change. Two nursery blocks needed their full start, then could shorten extension light. Hospital reservoirs remained untouched. Seed storage retained its floor.

None of these decisions repaired Lorn Dusk by itself. Together they created room in the shade schedule for a slower thermal correction.

At the meal break, Tovin found a message from their mother. Caldrift expected late rain, and she wanted to know whether Senn planned to visit before the cistern festival. No mention of planetary injustice, torn fabric, or public schedules. Their mother assumed weather work remained difficult and meals still happened.

He showed the note to Senn.

"She asks you because you answer," Senn said.

"She asks me because you turn travel into an ethical allocation problem."

"Tell her after the hearing."

"No hearing has been scheduled."

"It will be."

Tovin leaned against the bench. "That certainty scares me more than your doubts."

Her expression changed, not into apology. Senn rarely used apology where a correction could be made. "Then I will say this precisely. I intend to release the challenge if policy blocks it. I do not know what municipal demand will do afterward. I need your model before that happens."

"You want a safe emergency shutdown."

"I want to know whether one exists."

"It does not."

"You have not modeled every sequence."

"I know the fleet. Shutdown sends demand discontinuities into machines already carrying active weather. Safe work comes from staged change, spare fabric, crews with sleep, and districts accepting outcomes they did not request."

Senn closed Varo's feed. "Model the staged bloom reduction, then."

"Under whose authority?"

"Technical contingency planning. No schedule change yet."

"Ceryn can classify it."

"Not the maintenance inputs. Keep copies with the crews."

Cal returned with the depot panel wrapped around a clean tube. "We already do."

Tovin looked from the replacement fabric to Senn's wired evidence. Exposure had arrived regardless of whether workers wanted it. His choice concerned whether the first public demand would meet a blank capacity field or an honest sequence.

He created a new model and entered five days for decorative canal reduction, staged apricot cuts, protected hospital and seed loads, simplified kite transitions, and reserve 6 at only the area its repaired cells could prove.

"I will run this," he said. "I will put crew hours, cure times, weather corridors,

and every conditional reserve in the output.”

Senn waited for the rest.

Tovin gave it to her. “I will not promise a safe emergency shutdown. Do not quote a range as one.”

Behind them, the riggers unrolled replacement membrane beneath the lowered kite. Light passed through the thin material in a copper stain. Nobody called it ready.

Chapter 13 — The Public Forecast

The tram glass promised perfect bloom while Nima Sol excluded a dead child from the attribution.

Gold letters traveled across the window behind her: ORISON BLOOM CONTINUES AT FULL BRIGHTNESS. CANAL WARMING ON SCHEDULE. POLLINATOR CONDITIONS EXCELLENT. The words passed over her clinic coat and vanished into the frame.

Nima drew a line through case NF-044. “No defensible weather link.”

Hesh turned the Nacre Fold register around. “The medicine transport missed its light corridor.”

“Because the carrier launched late,” Nima said. “Weather narrowed the margin. It did not create the delay.”

“The child still waited in cold.”

“She remains in the death record. She does not enter this claim.”

Senn watched Hesh press two fingers to the page. They had argued for restraint in Lorn Dusk, but another district's child made exclusion harder. Pera sat at the end of the archive table, entering the reason in both the sealed case index and public methodological annex.

“Do not write unrelated,” Hesh said.

Pera looked up. “I wrote insufficient causal contribution under stated standard.”

“Good.”

The four of them had worked since the first public chime in a borrowed records room above Orison's east tram station. Nima had refused the Conservatory clinic because its access system logged patient keys before the audit seal engaged. Hesh distrusted every room whose locks answered to Ceryn. Pera found a municipal lease archive with paper blinds, a working heat plate, and a view of three forecast screens nobody could switch off from inside.

Eyr's files occupied the left table. Nacre Fold's occupied the right. Lorn Dusk's case map hung on the wall, names protected beneath folded paper strips but local keys visible. The regional table remained blank in its final field.

Senn opened the next Nacre file. "NF-045. Mara Pell. Age sixty-two at death. Shell-lime worker."

Nima found the clinic extract. "Chronic lung scarring. Two cold admissions before the disputed interval, four during it."

Hesh read the heating record. "Domestic rooms below local request on eleven nights. Clinic light shortened twice."

"Comparison?" Senn asked.

Pera passed across a chart. Residents with equivalent lung scores in recognized districts showed fewer admissions after adjustment for age, prior illness, and household size. The sample stayed small. Confidence bands overlapped at their edges.

"Associated," Nima said. "Not individually attributable."

"Then she contributes to the population estimate but not the high-specificity case set."

"Correct."

Senn entered the grade. Every distinction slowed the work and strengthened the result. They were not counting bodies. They were estimating excess deaths against a world that had never run the same twenty-two years without transferred winter. Causal proof had to be assembled from comparisons, exposure timing, clinic records, instrument histories, and known pathways. No alternate Meral waited nearby as a control.

A knock sounded. Pera covered the key map before opening the door.

The station clerk delivered four cups and a notice that forecast maintenance would brighten the west screen at midday. "Municipal publicity wants the colors consistent across the canal."

"Can we ask them to dim it?" Hesh said.

"During perfect bloom?" The clerk looked alarmed by the phrase alone. "Not without a visual continuity finding."

Pera accepted the cups. "We are conducting one."

After the door closed, the glass announced eleven additional public garden events. Senn could see one below the station: workers tying pale ribbons along the canal rail, children carrying paper flowers, vendors unfolding shade awnings against the light whose perfection needed advertising.

Nima moved to the Eyr files. Their clinic records used ceramic tags that had been photographed and indexed by Dael's former apprenticeship office. Several years lacked complete domestic temperatures because tower instruments recorded only intake and exhaust. Local heat-vane positions supplied a proxy. Each vane bent at a known temperature range, and apprentices had logged their morning angles as part of training.

"Counsel will call this folklore," Pera said.

"Counsel can reproduce the calibration," Senn replied.

They compared vane angles with years containing certified probes. The relationship held within a range broad enough for exposure bands, not precise household values. Nima lowered the grade for seven cases. Hesh objected to two. They reopened both.

One concerned a tower mechanic named Es Dar who died after working a prolonged exterior shift. His supervisor's log showed standard duration. His partner's household note claimed the shift ran three hours longer because the relief tram lost its light window.

"Transport archive?" Senn asked.

Pera searched the municipal copies. "Eyr does not legally operate a civic tram."

"It has moved workers for thirty years," Hesh said.

"Officially, tower 11 operates a maintenance carriage."

The equipment schedule recorded a stalled carriage and delayed relief. Human shift records omitted the delay because payroll closed against standard hours.

Nima revised the exposure path. "Strong association. Infection after cold injury remains multifactorial."

Senn attached both categories. The same classification trick recurred at every scale. A tram became a carriage. A household became equipment occupancy. An extended shift became standard because wages recognized no extension. Measurements survived while names lost their civic connections.

At midday, the west screen brightened. Golden light filled the room, bleaching blue ink until Pera lowered the paper blinds. Heat still entered through the glass.

"Public forecast says the day holds within ideal pedestrian range," Pera said.

Hesh touched the warming table. "Does it say for which pedestrian?"

No one answered. They returned to work.

A harder dispute waited in the nutrition files. Nacre Fold had recorded low-weight births after three winters when greenhouse light failed during fungal outbreaks. The local report attributed the entire change to reduced food variety. Nima separated maternal cold exposure, infection, household crowding, and ration composition, then found the records could not distinguish them reliably.

"Exclude the birth outcomes," she said.

Hesh paced to the window. Beyond the blind, projected apricot petals slid across the tram glass. "If a consequence spreads across a household, your method loses it because no clinic line can hold the whole path."

"My method loses claims it cannot defend."

"Policy created the missing records."

“That does not let medicine create certainty in reply.”

Senn opened the ration ledgers instead of resolving the argument. Deliveries to Nacre Fold fell during the same intervals, but total food mass stayed above emergency floor. Variety narrowed sharply. Protein cultures arrived late. A central analyst might call the difference discomfort. Birth records suggested more, though comparison years included a separate greenhouse fungus.

“Keep the data in the contextual annex,” Senn said. “Do not use it in the mortality estimate. State that exclusion may undercount diffuse effects.”

Nima agreed. Hesh made her add who would review the question later. Pera created a research limitation section rather than burying it below methods.

Next came baseline selection. Conservatory tables compared darkward residents with all of Meral, whose age distribution and medical access differed. Nima had built matched groups from cold-edge districts, but recognized districts received more reliable light. Rul Fen would claim no true comparator existed.

“He will be right,” Senn said.

Pera stared at her. “That is inconvenient.”

“Write it.”

They ran three baselines: planetary, cold-edge recognized districts, and each settlement's own ordinary-schedule years. Planetary comparison produced the largest excess. Internal comparison produced the smallest, partly because no year escaped the inherited burden entirely. The matched district approach fell between them.

Nima chose the internal result as the conservative floor for cold-linked mortality and used matched districts only where medical access could be adjusted. Her pencil moved several cases out of the high-specificity set.

Hesh read every removal. “A lower estimate will become the truth people repeat.”

“A higher estimate with weak assumptions will become the flaw they repeat,” Nima said.

Senn added the full range to the methods display. “The central figure must never travel without the uncertainty interval and exclusion rule.”

“Numbers shed luggage,” Hesh replied.

“Then we fasten it.” Pera created a display object in which copying the central field automatically copied years, range, method version, and annex link. A person could still retype the figure alone, but the official record would resist effortless separation.

The forecast screen changed from bloom conditions to a smiling map of school garden openings. One highlighted terrace stood above a canal heated partly by the concealed transfer. Children released paper-winged pollinators into air warm enough for municipal bees.

Pera lowered the blind another finger's width. "Would showing this beside the report count as editorializing?"

"Yes," Senn said.

"Pity."

A technical objection arrived from the Conservatory archive before Senn had transmitted anything. Automated validation rejected Lorn Dusk's oldest burial years because local date notation preceded the current civic calendar format. Pera swore, then pulled two Order 9 supply manifests whose dates used both systems. The manifests mapped local winter turns to Conservatory years.

"Emergency clerks accidentally authenticated the people their order denied," she said.

Conversion shifted four exposure intervals by one day. Nima reran the affected cases. One medicine delay no longer overlapped a cancelled window and moved to exclusion. Another cold interval lengthened.

Senn made Pera preserve the rejected import, the date bridge, and the corrected run. "No invisible cleaning."

"I have started hearing that sentence in my sleep."

"Good archival training."

"Poor sleep training."

The first complete model run finished after the meal hour. Nima stood behind Senn as the slate processed district exposure intervals, baseline mortality, age and illness adjustments, specific high-confidence pathways, and uncertainty from missing measurements. The result appeared as a range.

Its center exceeded the figure local advocates had used in private. Hesh stared at it without satisfaction.

"Run exclusions as zero contribution," Senn said.

"They already are," Nima replied.

"Run every uncertain instrument year at the warm boundary."

Pera saved the primary result and labeled the next test CONSERVATIVE EXPOSURE ASSUMPTION. Eyr's temperature bands shifted. Nacre Fold's comparison weakened. The center fell, but not enough to change the scale of the finding.

"Now remove accident pathways," Hesh said.

Nima did. Radiator falls, coolant injuries, transport failures, and maintenance incidents left the model. Only cold exposure, delayed medicine tied directly to withheld service, respiratory risk, and documented crop-light nutrition effects remained. The range narrowed.

Senn read the central estimate. "We need independent replication."

"You asked me to complete the attribution," Nima said.

"I asked you to make it defensible. One model on one slate is not enough."

Pera opened the sealed methods package. "The Conservatory health office can replicate."

"Ceryn controls its classification."

"Three recognized district clinics have mortality analysts. Give each a blinded bundle."

Hesh looked at the name index under its paper covers. "Blinded from people?"

"Blinded from district and policy category," Nima said. "They receive exposure bands, comparison data, outcomes, and method. Names remain attached here. We test whether knowing darkward origin changes judgment."

Senn authorized three protected review copies. Pera generated random case keys while Hesh witnessed the map between temporary keys and local records. The transmission would take less than an hour. Replies could take days.

A message from the Conservatory arrived before any reviewer answered. First Curator Ceryn Ahl required Senn's presence at the Season Table with all preliminary health findings. Her order cited planetary stability and restricted policy material.

"She knows," Pera said.

"She knows records moved under the challenge," Senn replied. "Not the result unless the room leaks."

Hesh examined the air vent.

"That was not metaphorical," Pera said.

They checked seals. No breach appeared. Senn suspected inference rather than spying. Ceryn knew which records existed and what twenty-two years of winter could contain. She had signed the renewal while permanent households remained.

"Finish the annex before we go," Senn said.

Pera bound the methods, exclusions, instrument limitations, comparison definitions, alternate runs, and reversible case index into one digital package. Medical details stayed encrypted behind district-held keys. Hesh signed custody. Nima signed clinical method. Senn signed audit intake.

The complete table still waited for independent review.

At the Conservatory, perfect bloom covered the exterior walls in projected apricot branches. Visitors stood beneath them for pictures while Senn's group entered through the staff door. The old pressureworks windows cast red bars across the Season Table chamber.

Ceryn waited with two policy counsel and Rul Fen, counsel for the central cities. No health officer attended.

"You brought a district claimant into a restricted technical review," Ceryn said.

"Hesh holds source custody."

"They lack recognized district status."

"The active challenge concerns that denial. Excluding them would contaminate the evidence chain."

Rul folded his hands. "Orison's forecast has already issued. Any suggestion of mass casualty attribution could alter demand before engineering has a stable alternative."

Nima put her case on the table. "Then listen carefully enough not to suggest what we have not concluded."

Ceryn's attention settled on her. "Doctor Sol, has your review produced a number?"

"A provisional central estimate pending independent replication."

"Give it to me."

"No," Senn said.

Ceryn did not raise her voice. "You have no authority to withhold evidence from the First Curator during a planetary risk review."

"I have authority to protect preliminary audit material from policy use before method and source conditions attach. You asked for a number. The evidence is not one field."

Rul opened a city dependency map. Hospitals, schools, crop starts, transit, and municipal heat glowed across seven central districts. "Public release without remedy planning could cause councils to refuse transfers. Forecast schedules rely on reciprocal demand. The atmosphere will respond before procedure does."

Hesh stood behind an unlit section of the table. "Your concern is that named cities may refuse burdens once they see who paid them."

"My concern includes that," Rul said. "It also includes clinics losing heat because frightened councils lock every discretionary share."

The honesty prevented easy dismissal.

Ceryn requested the method package. Senn transmitted the protected header, which displayed scope and review state but not patient keys. The First Curator read the causal standards, alternate assumptions, and pending replication notices.

"This falls under sensitive infrastructure mortality analysis," Ceryn said. "Policy rule sixteen permits temporary classification."

"For a specific threat," Pera said.

One counsel turned toward her. "Archive clerks do not interpret policy at the Table."

"This one does when a rule changes the custody status of her annex." Pera pointed to the citation. "Rule sixteen covers information that identifies vulnerable infrastructure. The public table can redact clinic locations and instrument weaknesses. It does not authorize suppression of aggregate findings or habitation

evidence.”

Ceryn looked at the junior clerk for a long second. “Who asked you to prepare a public annex?”

“The audit form did.”

“Which form?”

“Habitation challenge procedure eight. Evidence affecting standing must carry a reviewable basis.”

Senn recognized the narrow smile Pera used when fear had found something exact to hold.

Ceryn changed approach. “Then I classify the complete package pending redaction review.”

“Classification would include the annex,” Pera said. “A preservation copy has already entered the protected archive queue under challenge custody.”

“You moved it before policy review?”

“I preserved it before policy alteration. Those are different verbs.”

The counsel beside Ceryn began drafting an order.

Senn's slate signaled the first independent response. A recognized district clinic had replicated Nima's method within the stated range. The reviewer challenged one comparison band but found the central estimate supported. Two minutes later, the second response arrived with a lower estimate under different respiratory assumptions. Its uncertainty still included Nima's result.

Everyone at the table saw the alerts.

“Do not open those into this meeting,” Ceryn said.

Senn opened them. Protected audit procedure required review findings to join the package when received. She logged the critiques, reran the respiratory sensitivity, and watched the central estimate move by less than one percent.

The third reviewer requested raw code and flagged possible duplicate matching between an Eyr clinic key and transport record. Pera traced the keys. Two sources described one person. Nima removed the duplicate pathway, though the model had already prevented two deaths from being assigned. The correction altered weighting, not the case count.

Hours tightened around a single field. Outside the chamber, forecast chimes announced another ideal bloom interval. Inside, Ceryn's counsel completed a temporary classification order. Pera's archive queue reported preservation complete.

The third replication arrived.

Nima read it first. She checked the conservative model, the district ranges, and the specific-case annex. Then she wrote the defensible attribution in the final field: 317 excess deaths across twenty-two years.

Hesh did not look at the figure. "Open the names."

Pera unfolded the covers over the local key maps. Rows of names did not appear on the public layer, but every case resolved to district custody. Hesh tested three at random. One opened into a burial record and heat-wall strip. Another led to a Nacre clinic file with shell-lime exposure separated from winter contribution. The third reached an excluded Eyr case, proving the denominator retained decisions against the claim.

Ceryn read the result. Control left her face only in the stillness around her mouth.

"This report remains classified until stability planning closes," she said.

"No," Senn replied.

Rul pushed back his chair. "Auditor, municipal demand will react within minutes."

"It should react to evidence."

"It may react by refusing every transfer, lawful or not."

"Then engineering needs to know the reaction is coming."

Ceryn placed her seal against the order. "I am directing you."

Senn opened habitation challenge procedure eight. The protected route allowed an auditor to release evidence jointly establishing unrecognized habitation and material harm when policy action would otherwise prevent timely review. It required source custody, independent method replication, privacy redaction, stated uncertainty, and personal acceptance of disciplinary review.

Every condition now had a mark beside it.

She joined the habitation challenge to the attribution package. The address ledgers established continuous civic heat, births, burials, and households. The report established consequences associated with treating those households as infrastructure. Pera attached the complete public annex and preservation checksum. Nima approved the medical redactions. Hesh approved district custody language.

"Once you seal that," Ceryn said, "you cannot control what the cities do with it."

"I could not control what they did without it."

Senn pressed her thumb to the protected release.

Across Orison, the public forecast vanished from tram glass and water towers. For one breath, the screens held only their own pale reflection. Then the habitation challenge appeared beside the attribution. The green bloom band contracted to an upper corner while the names filled the remaining glass.

Chapter 14 — A Necessary Shadow

The first refusal reached Tovin while reserve 6 hung half packed above the launch cradle.

A municipal seal flashed across the hangar console, canceling West Canal's acceptance of the next shade interval. Two more notices followed before he finished reading it. Upper Orison withdrew a heat export. Apricot Ward locked its reflected-light allotment pending legal review. Each council cited the newly released attribution and declared that no local weather share would move until the Conservatory proved where it went.

Above the console, black membrane descended in careful folds between Cal's gloved hands. The repaired kite had passed a reduced-area tension test at dawn. Its damaged corner remained reefed, its vane table had been rebuilt for the shorter edge, and its battery margin allowed one ordinary deployment. Policy still displayed a green reserve symbol as if those conditions could be folded away with the fabric.

"Stop the pack," Tovin called.

Winches halted. Cal held the membrane off the cradle while two riggers secured the suspended fold with padded clamps.

Senn came through the hangar door carrying no coat and three active slates. Public forecast light, stripped of its bloom colors, made her face look gray. "How many?"

"Three refusals."

"Seven." She laid the slates on his console. "Four went to scheduling rather than fleet control."

Tovin opened the next mirror sequence. Its orderly bands broke apart as each canceled transfer propagated. A shade interval over West Canal had balanced mirror 82's hospital corridor. Without that shade, the schedule shortened the corridor to contain surface heat. Apricot Ward's locked light forced mirror 117 to hold a starward angle longer, warming air above the eastern terraces. Upper Orison's withdrawn export left the resulting heat nowhere to go before a darkward current reached the city.

"How long since release?" he asked.

"Thirty-eight minutes."

"Fast work."

"Fear has good clerks."

A pressure alarm sounded at the meteorology desk. Cal passed the hanging fold to another rigger and crossed to the wind display. Two air masses appeared as pale sheets, one rising from Orison's heated stone, another sliding starward from the night ribbon. Their predicted margins touched above the eastern greenhouses.

Tovin enlarged the shear layer. "That seam did not exist on the morning run."

"It existed as dispersed risk," Senn said. "The refusals have concentrated it."

"Which district moved first?"

"Lower Glass. They canceled a cold transfer after the report named Nacre Fold. The others copied the action without copying its destination."

The distinction mattered physically and nowhere else. Lower Glass had rejected a transfer connected to the concealed burden. West Canal had rejected lawful shade exchanged with another recognized district. Municipal offices now treated every movement of cold as suspected theft. Demand did not know the difference between caution and panic once it reached the mirror queue.

Cal traced the forming seam with one blunt fingernail. "When does it tighten?"

"Run current commitments," Tovin said.

Senn linked her audit feed. The lattice advanced across the afternoon. Heat gathered over the canal stone, lifted through the greenhouse terraces, and met the darkward flow after the meal chime. Yellow spread along the contact. By evening, a red hook curved toward three school roofs and the eastern staple beds.

No one in the hangar mistook the color for weather. Red meant crews securing glass, clinics preparing for impact injuries, canal gates lowering before wind drove water over their margins. It meant people under roofs built for the gust band they had been promised.

Tovin stopped the run at the first warning. "We can blunt the warm side with shade."

Senn looked up at the suspended kite. "At sixty-eight percent."

"Sixty-seven after pack allowance. Do not improve my machine while I am standing beside it."

"Can it reach the eastern corridor?"

"Not under the published plan." He opened the flight paths. "Corridor three crosses mirror control space during the hospital turn. Corridor four takes us around, but the seam closes before arrival."

"Then move the hospital turn."

A scheduler at the neighboring desk answered without invitation. "South Clinic refuses transfer changes. Their council locked all light after the release."

Senn gathered the seven notices into one column. "The clinic did not refuse its own light."

"They refused any adjustment touching it."

"That is not the same authority."

"It gives the same command to my desk."

Tovin watched the red hook deepen. An argument over authority could outlive

the roofs. "Who controls corridor three?"

"Mirror crews 82, 117, and 204," the scheduler said. "Separate municipal contracts."

"Put their leads on voice."

Only crew 82 answered. Its lead, Iven Marr, appeared against a service-room wall patterned with old burn marks. "We received a hold order."

"You also received a shear warning."

"Municipal counsel says no transfers until destination review."

Tovin sent the flight overlay. "I need ninety seconds of angle clearance to lift reserve 6 through your corridor. Your hospital delivery stays whole. Arrival shifts by four minutes."

"Four minutes enters our variance record."

"So enter it."

"Under whose order?"

"Mine."

Iven's expression did not change. "Fleet coordination cannot alter a mirror contract."

"Correct. You will alter it under immediate equipment protection."

"Counsel excluded demand disputes from that clause."

"This is a kite crossing, not a demand dispute."

Senn leaned toward the voice pickup. "The protected audit release suspends no safety authority. I will sign that finding."

Iven glanced away, likely toward workers listening outside his camera. "Your last signature created the hold."

The words found Senn cleanly. Her shoulders drew back, but she did not defend the release. "Yes. The evidence changed demand. Current safety law still applies."

Tovin waited. He knew the difference between giving a crew lead facts and offering her a place to hide. Iven needed a reason she could repeat with her workers' names attached.

"Your mirror keeps its destination," he said. "You accept a four-minute timing variance so a certified reserve craft can cross. I log the lost minutes against fleet emergency use, not against South Clinic. If the council wants to call that an unlawful transfer, they can explain which district received the four minutes."

"None receives them?"

"The sky does."

Iven read the overlay again. "Crew 82 accepts temporary delay for corridor clearance. Send the exact clock."

One band opened in the schedule. It did not reach launch altitude.

Crew 117 refused voice twice, then returned text demanding written proof that its adjustment would not recreate the winter debit. Senn drafted a narrow finding while Tovin calculated the crossing. Mirror 117 had to rotate starward by less than a degree, reducing light on an ornamental apricot wall. The saved heat entered no darkward account. It simply did not enter Orison.

"Call the wall operator," Tovin said.

Varo answered from a greenhouse control walk. Behind him, workers watched public screens carrying the attribution range and names of the three settlements. "We have a full-light commitment."

"You have decorative bloom."

"I have eight thousand visitors expected this afternoon and a council order against unscheduled shade."

"Then expect them in coats."

Varo's mouth tightened. "Easy to say from a hangar."

Tovin turned the camera toward reserve 6. Riggers stood beneath its imperfect fold, holding repaired fabric above the cradle because he had stopped the pack. "My crew spent the night making policy's green symbol capable of flight. I am asking yours to close one tram wall for six minutes."

"Public reaction is already severe."

"Public wind will be worse."

Senn slid her finding onto the channel. It stated that the proposed shade created no debit, reduced central heat input, and touched no protected service. Varo read each clause.

"Who answers when visitors say Orison darkened because the death count came out?" he asked.

"I do," Senn said.

Tovin shook his head. "We all do. Your crew records the closure. Mine records the launch. Audit records why. Nobody calls the six minutes normal bloom."

Varo looked behind him. A worker in a condensation apron spoke beyond pickup range. Another pointed toward the wall controls.

"Western apricot crew accepts six minutes of temporary shade," Varo said. "We keep heat strips on the upper bridge."

"That gives us mirror 117," the scheduler reported.

Two clearances still left a narrow collision at altitude. Mirror 204 served a seed-start district south of the canal. Its crew lead, Mara En, answered at once and refused before Tovin finished the request.

"Our council has locked every concession," she said. "They think the Conservatory will use voluntary movement as proof that the old allocation can

continue.”

“So do not volunteer a transfer. Accept local shade.”

“On seed roofs.”

“On service glass between the roofs. Eleven minutes, moving strip, no crop cell loses more than forty seconds.”

Mara pulled the proposed track apart. “Your shortened kite carries edge flutter into our mirror wake.”

At last, a useful objection. Tovin opened reserve 6’s measured vane response and removed the nominal certification curve. “Flutter peaks here. We cross below it if your mirror holds two tenths darkward after the strip passes.”

“That points light toward Orison.”

“Toward a canal surface already under shutter.”

“Show temperature.”

Cal fed him the live canal probes. Stored warmth remained high, but closed shutters would reflect most of the brief addition. Tovin modeled the remainder. Surface air gained less heat than the kite removed from the rising plume.

Mara studied both curves. “My crew accepts temporary shade if your pilot holds below the wake ceiling and canal shutters confirm closed.”

“Agreed.”

“I want your name on the flutter assumption.”

“You have it.”

Three crews had accepted visible inconvenience without surrendering weather to an unnamed place. The opened path ran from the launch apron to the eastern heat plume in a thin blue curve.

Tovin keyed the cradle sequence. “Resume pack. Flight configuration.”

Clamps released in order. Cal guided the repaired membrane into its canister while riggers checked each conductive trace at the fold. The earlier delay had cost seven minutes. Beyond the doors, ground vanes shifted toward the city, showing the first pull from the darkward current.

Senn followed him to the equipment rack. “You are flying?”

“I certified the reduced vane table.”

“You coordinated all night.”

“I slept during cure.”

“For how long?”

“Long enough to remain legally disappointing.”

Cal threw him a harness. “Ninety-two minutes. I logged it.”

Senn looked ready to turn fatigue into a prohibition. Tovin tightened the chest

straps before she could find the correct field. "Cal takes guidance. I handle deployment and municipal calls."

"She has had less sleep than you."

"I had four hours," Cal said. "Unlike him, I did not spend two of them arguing with a fabric depot."

That ended the audit. They climbed into the control cabin beside the cradle, close enough to reach the manual cutoffs but never close to the high air. Kite pilots flew pressure and tension through instruments. Heroics at altitude belonged to memorial plaques and bad staffing.

Launch fans lifted the packed craft into the first current. Tovin felt its load through the control grips as the tether paid out. Reduced area made the canister rise unevenly. Cal corrected with two guidance vanes, keeping battery draw inside the measured margin.

"Crew 82 window in forty seconds," the scheduler said.

Mirror light narrowed on the apron. A bright column shifted across the hangar roof, paused, then opened a dim lane through the eastern sky. Tovin guided the canister into it. Four minutes vanished from a hospital schedule without vanishing from its account.

Crew 117 cut the apricot wall. The city's projected blossoms went dark along one tram route. Real leaves behind the glass lost their shine, and pedestrians below stopped to look up. Tovin had no audio from the street, only heat readings dropping by fractions as reserve 6 climbed.

"Approaching seed corridor," Cal said.

Canal shutters confirmed closed. Mirror 204 held its angle while Mara's crew laid the moving strip of shade between crop roofs. Tovin kept below the wake ceiling. The canister shuddered once as the shortened edge met disturbed air.

Cal's hand closed around the reef control. "Flutter rising."

"Within curve."

"Barely."

"Two tenths darkward now."

Mara adjusted the mirror. Light struck the shuttered canal in a hard white patch, then slid away. The shudder eased. Reserve 6 cleared the last service roof with battery margin intact.

Behind its passage, Mara's crew restored light cell by cell instead of swinging the whole mirror at once. Seed technicians confirmed each roof before the next strip brightened. One service pane remained shaded because a worker had found condensation under its frame and refused to certify heat until the seal received inspection. Tovin marked the delay as maintenance, not weather surrender. Eleven minutes grew to thirteen, but the extra time stayed attached to a pane, a defect, and the person who had seen it.

Ahead, the shear front had become visible in the instruments as a pressure ridge. Warm air rose on its starward side. Cold flow pressed beneath it from darkward, sharpening the boundary with every minute of unchanged demand.

Tovin released the first membrane cell.

Black film opened against copper haze. Tension climbed along the repaired seams. Cal fed vane corrections into the shortened edge while he watched the old manufacturing roll take load. One cell, then another, spread above Orison. The reefed corner left the shape asymmetrical, more working sail than policy diagram.

"Seam temperatures stable," Cal said.

"Open to certified area."

Fabric extended across the high current. Its shadow touched the eastern terraces as a faint gray movement, too diffuse to have an edge from the ground. Heat input fell. The rising plume weakened but did not flatten.

A new alarm sounded from West Canal. Its council had ordered shutters reopened to preserve the scheduled pedestrian warmth canceled during launch.

Senn answered before Tovin could. "Keep them closed under immediate shear protection."

A municipal officer appeared on the channel. "Auditor Vale, your release is under disciplinary review. You cannot assign our district a consequence while the challenged schedule remains disputed."

Tovin held the kite angle. "This consequence stays in West Canal. Nothing moves darkward."

"Our public forecast promised full bloom."

"The forecast changed when your council withdrew shade."

"We rejected complicity in an unlawful allocation."

"Then reject it accurately," Senn said. "The old debit remains absent. Your shutters now prevent local heat from entering a shear front."

Silence lasted through three pressure updates. Tovin imagined officials reading the attribution on one screen and a weather warning on another, searching for a choice that carried no stain.

"What duration?" the officer asked.

Senn looked at him.

Tovin ran the stabilized field forward. Reserve 6 could hold this angle for seven hours before battery limits required descent. The immediate shadow blunted the front, yet the next mirror schedule would rebuild the imbalance unless councils released selected commitments. He entered the three crew concessions, locked the concealed transfer at zero, and allowed only locally accepted shade. The model found a narrow path through the turn.

"Nine hours today," he said. "Reduced intervals afterward. Full schedule review

within nine days.”

“You can guarantee resolution?”

“No. I can buy nine days for people to build one.”

The officer authorized closed shutters through the evening chime.

Across the field display, yellow pulled back from the school roofs. Red disappeared last, shrinking to a thin point above an empty service yard before the warning cleared. Hospital light arrived four minutes late and at full quantity. Seed roofs kept their crop exposure. The apricot wall stayed dark.

Cal eased reserve 6 toward its holding track. “Pressure ridge dispersing.”

Tovin did not trust a single indicator. He checked roof gusts, canal margins, hospital reservoirs, greenhouse floor temperatures, and the darkward loads that had once been used as an invisible balancing field. Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold showed no renewed debit. Their cold did not deepen to rescue Orison from its refusals.

Senn remained on the municipal channel as district notices changed from absolute holds to conditional review. Councils had seen that refusal could aim weather at their own roofs. None withdrew its objection to the concealed system. Two asked for proof that their proposed adjustments stayed local. A third demanded crew signatures before accepting shade.

“Send them the launch record,” Tovin said.

“It is not complete.”

“It is true enough to work from. Add corrections when Cal lands the kite.”

Senn transmitted the live record with its conditional certification, named crews, altered minutes, and destinations. No clean capacity figure survived the package. Every shadow touched a place.

By the meal chime, Orison’s public screens carried a revised municipal notice. UNSCHEDULED COOLING IN EFFECT. PROTECTED SERVICES MAINTAINED. The announcement avoided cause, then an audit attachment supplied it. People left canal tables carrying cups in both hands. Tram passengers buttoned coats beneath dark apricot glass. Greenhouse crews lowered interior curtains to hold soil warmth.

Tovin kept reserve 6 aloft until the pressure field separated into ordinary currents. Its repaired seams held. Battery reserve narrowed exactly as the test had predicted, leaving no generous margin for anyone to convert into future policy.

After descent began, Senn stood beside the cabin window and watched shade travel across the terraces. “You were right about what exposure would do to demand.”

He loosened one aching hand from the grip. “That does not make you wrong to release it.”

“No.”

“Try to enjoy agreement before we ruin it.”

Her mouth shifted, almost a smile. Then she checked the settlement loads again.

Evening had not arrived, but Orison’s stones stopped releasing their stored warmth. Breath showed near the tram platforms. Canal frost formed under bridge shadows where public crews spread grit and posted warning lamps. Clinics reported ordinary attendance. Roof teams stood down without opening an injury register.

When the revised forecast named the interval, it used the plain phrase cold afternoon. No district received a debit for it. No municipal total hid where the lost warmth stayed.

Tovin watched people cross the chilled bridges slowly, irritated and alive. Orison spent its first unscheduled cold afternoon, and nobody died.

Act III — Standing in the Storm

Chapter 15 — No Innocent Correction

Senn moved Lorn Dusk eight hundred kilometers starward and watched Orison drown in warm rain.

The model rendered the change without drama. Blue cloud bands thickened over the central terraces. Canal margins flashed amber for overflow. A shear warning opened above the eastern greenhouses, followed by a hospital reservoir alert and nine crop-temperature deviations. Lorn Dusk’s district band, newly inserted for the test, warmed toward its climate floor.

Dael stopped the simulation before the first roof failures appeared. “You cannot move a city with a stylus.”

“I moved its burden.”

“You moved it as if distance had no unit.”

Across the table, Hesh Dara kept both hands around a cup that had gone cold. They had arrived from the darkward transfer station two hours earlier and refused the Conservatory’s offer of a heated guest coat. Chalk dust still marked one cuff. “Run it to nine days.”

Dael glanced at Senn.

“Run it,” she said.

The lattice advanced. On the fourth day, Orison’s canal pumps exceeded drainage capacity. By day six, warm air from the bloom terraces struck a darkward

flow redirected around Lorn Dusk. The collision tightened into a moving seam. Day nine painted a red crescent through Orison's school roofs and staple beds.

Hesh studied the crescent. "How many people receive their proper floor in this version?"

"All eighteen thousand four hundred twenty across the three settlements," Senn said.

"How many central districts fall below theirs?"

"None."

Dael reached into the display and opened the risk layers. "A floor does not protect anyone from a roof coming off. This model preserves annual minimums while concentrating the transition into one weather front."

Senn closed the shear overlay. Beneath it, the transfer looked almost fair. Every inhabited band retained enough heat, light, rain, and wind tolerance to meet the Charter threshold. The figures balanced. Her old Caldrift reconciliation had balanced too, while leases passed out of the hands of people the payment meant to save.

"Then geography constrains the remedy," she said.

"Geography has constrained every remedy since the first mirror," Dael replied.

Hesh set the cup beside the control rail. "You asked us to help build a correction. We did not agree to admire the reasons you cannot make one."

They worked in a borrowed forecasting room below the Season Table. Its ceiling carried old pressure pipes and newer light conduits, a history of climate work added without removing what came before. Through the high interior window, Senn could see clerks preparing the planetary hearing docket. Names entered one column. Districts entered another. Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold appeared only in the evidence index.

She opened the first remedy model again. "Population share. Every district accepts transition burden according to registered inhabitants. No district falls below its floor. Larger districts take more because more people benefit from planetary stability."

Hesh came around the table. "Show the shares without district names."

Senn hid the labels. Pale bars rose from the surface, each proportional to population. Orison carried the highest absolute burden. Three other central cities followed. Near the darkward edge, two bars stood taller than their wealth or infrastructure suggested.

"Put the names back," Hesh said.

The labels returned. One tall bar belonged to a dense foundry district whose residents lived six to a room near public heat ducts. Another belonged to a rain-poor settlement that had taken in families displaced by a reservoir failure. Lorn Dusk's bar remained smaller, though not small.

"You have made crowded poverty expensive," Hesh said. "A district gets punished for keeping households alive closely enough to share walls."

"The proportion follows people, not wealth."

"That distinction comforts the people who own wealth."

Senn expanded the foundry district's account. Its climate floor consumed nearly all scheduled weather. Only a narrow margin of rain preference and high-light timing remained available for trade. Her population model took three times that margin. The deficit did not appear as a floor violation because she had allowed storm-risk tolerance to carry it.

Dael tapped the amber wind figure. "Those roofs use ceramic pins rated for the current gust band. Add this much variance and maintenance crews start choosing which blocks receive replacements."

"I can cap the storm component."

"Then the burden moves into heat."

"Cap that too."

"Then you have stopped using population."

Hesh looked through the interior window at the clerks. "Lorn Dusk has eight thousand one hundred forty residents because families stayed after the construction work ended. Under this model, the proof of habitation becomes a larger invoice."

Senn deleted the population weighting. The bars fell flat.

No innocent correction, she wrote on the paper beside her slate. She did not enter the phrase into the model. Models preferred labels that implied completion.

For the second test, she divided the required transition equally among every district recognized by the current schedule, then added the three settlements as if standing had already been granted. Each received the same quantity of cold acceptance, shade, rain delay, and light reduction. The distribution looked clean enough for a public diagram.

Dael gave it forty seconds.

Eyr breached its wind-shear floor first.

Senn frowned. "Its total allocation remains above minimum."

"Open the direction."

She rotated the weather field. Eyr sat near tower 11 where the darkward outflow narrowed against a ridge. A small shade acceptance there cooled air entering the passage. The same quantity over Orison diffused across canals and heat-storing stone. At Eyr, it accelerated a current aimed at the ceramic-vane quarter.

Dael drew two equal circles on the table. One covered Orison's western terraces. The other covered Eyr's ridge. "Equal quantities do unequal work."

Hesh leaned closer. "Can the share arrive as light instead?"

"Not during that turn. Mirror geometry gives Eyr a narrow reflected window. Shift it and the clinic loses morning heat."

"What about rain delay?"

"The settlement stores little water outside insulated cisterns. Delay costs more there than in a canal city."

Senn changed the burden's composition, trading shade for a later high-light pulse. Tower 11's service deck overheated. She tried cloud water. Ice loading increased on the heat vanes. Each equal exchange met a piece of ground that made equality false.

"Orison can take this quantity," she said.

"Orison can take four times that quantity in diffuse cloud before any floor approaches," Dael answered. "Nacre Fold can accept more cold than Eyr because the lava tube buffers temperature, but less wind variance at the western mouth. Caldrift can delay rain during one seed stage and not another. Equal division ignores the machinery and the soil."

"Population ignores poverty. Equality ignores geography." Hesh counted the rejected premises on two fingers. "What does your law leave us?"

"Rank," Senn said. "Which we are not using."

"Historic benefit," Dael offered.

That model charged Orison and the six central cities according to the bloom days they had inherited. Its moral clarity lasted until Senn opened the hospital dependencies. Extra bloom had entered operating schedules, nursery cycles, public heat storage, school meals, seed starts, and municipal work shifts. Removing every inherited benefit according to its age cut into protected functions even when the city retained enough aggregate climate.

Rul Fen's hearing submission had listed the dependencies in careful categories. Senn distrusted his purpose and respected the numbers. Orison's hospitals warmed sterilization reservoirs during bloom because the light arrived reliably. Staple growers timed fungal controls to a dry interval inside the eleven added days. Public kitchens drew on those harvests. A benefit acquired unlawfully could still become part of someone's survival floor.

Hesh read the hospital column. "How much of this existed before the transfer?"

"Most of the reservoirs. Not the timing."

"So inherited convenience entered protected use."

"In part."

"Lorn Dusk's children entered equipment occupancy." Hesh's voice stayed level. "Orison's convenient timing entered medical necessity. Your categories learn tenderness in one direction."

Senn did not defend them. "Then we separate the floor from everything above

it.”

Dael pulled the physical control rail toward him. “We already protect floors.”

“We protect them after selecting a burden base. Reverse it. Calculate each district’s floor first, using actual habitation and local geography. Lock it. What remains can carry correction.”

The room’s ventilation clicked into its low cycle. Clerks beyond the window rolled the hearing docket into a blue case. Hesh read Senn’s note upside down.

“Everything above minimum?” they asked.

“Not simply minimum. Some uses cannot drop at the same time even if each annual total permits it. Hospital reserves, staple seed starts, safe wind bands, radiator cooling. We define the operational floor for the turn, not a yearly average.”

Dael’s damaged fingers rested on the rail. “Then identify the movable remainder by service type. Rain timing, decorative light, commercial bloom, optional school extensions, excess reservoir warmth, storm tolerance above the safe band.”

“Discretionary surplus,” Senn said.

Hesh’s expression tightened. “Discretionary to whom?”

“A fair objection.” Senn removed the label. “Name it yourself.”

They considered the exposed accounts. “The portion a district can surrender without sending another person below floor. But the district must see the calculation and challenge it.”

“That takes longer.”

“So did counting our dead.”

Dael entered a temporary field name: SURPLUS SUBJECT TO LOCAL REVIEW. “The machine needs a shorter column.”

“It can endure inconvenience,” Hesh said.

Senn restored her original label with a review flag attached. The term mattered less than who controlled its boundary. She set the Almanac to calculate floors from measured civic loads rather than official district status. Gray sectors appeared as provisional habitation bands. For the first time in their workroom model, Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold received locked minima before any surplus allocation began.

The first run failed because Orison’s declared floor included decorative greenhouse walls along three tram routes.

Hesh pointed at the light allotment. “Do patients receive care in the apricot glass?”

“No.”

“Do staple crops grow there?”

“Tourists walk there.”

“Tourists can walk in coats.”

Senn reclassified the walls. Orison’s discretionary margin widened by almost one bloom day.

A second failure came from Eyr. Its apprenticeship kilns appeared as industrial surplus, but Dael objected before the model completed.

“The ceramic vanes keep tower housings intact,” he said. “Close those kilns and the repair stock vanishes in six weeks.”

“Could production slow?” Senn asked.

“By a fifth. More than that breaks the replacement cadence.”

Hesh requested the apprenticeship schedule. Half the kiln time trained workers, yet those workers supplied the only local repair pool permitted near tower 11. They protected the training hours and cut ornamental ceramic production instead.

Nacre Fold offered cold tolerance but little safe wind variance. Caldriфт offered rain timing after its current germination window. The foundry district contributed commercial heat storage while retaining domestic walls. Each place required a different translation from surplus into physical weather.

By the sixth run, the model no longer produced equal bars. It produced narrow colored segments, uneven in quantity and unlike in kind. Orison carried a broad green reduction. Caldriфт carried a blue rain delay. Nacre Fold accepted a measured temperature dip. Two canal districts gave up low-priority cloud water. Lorn Dusk contributed nothing during the first transition interval because its existing schedule did not reach the climate floor.

Dael advanced the simulation through nine days. No shear crescent formed.

“Twenty,” Senn said.

The model crossed the end of the current bloom turn. Four radiator towers remained under repair assumptions, so the available heat-export margin narrowed. Orison’s reduction increased during the next interval. Hospital reservoirs stayed protected. Staple beds retained their dry treatment window. Tram-wall flowers lost light.

Hesh watched the district bands instead of the central graphs. “Lorn Dusk crosses floor on day three.”

“By a narrow margin,” Dael said.

“Keep going.”

At day twenty-seven, a failed-tower contingency pushed Eyr toward its wind limit. Dael distributed the excess across five districts with compatible geography. Each accepted a change smaller than ordinary forecast tolerance. The combined adjustment held Eyr above floor without recreating a sacrificial sink.

Senn checked the hidden assumptions. Population no longer set the burden. Political rank contributed nothing. Historic benefit affected the schedule only where

it had created movable surplus. Local physical constraints shaped the form of each concession. Every climate floor stayed locked.

“What did we smuggle in?” she asked.

Dael opened the maintenance layer. “Perfect telemetry.”

“Remove it.”

He introduced three delayed sensors and one false radiator reading. The distribution controller hesitated, then widened safety margins. Orison lost more discretionary light to preserve the uncertain districts. No floor broke.

Hesh tapped the review flag. “Central staff still decide which use counts as optional.”

“Then district auditors must sign the boundary,” Senn said.

“We do not have district auditors. We do not have districts.”

The hearing docket moved past the window in a clerk’s arms.

Senn looked at the gray labels beneath the provisional bands. “The correction assumes standing before procedure grants it.”

“Good,” Hesh said. “Make them argue against the assumption where everyone can hear.”

They ran the model again with hostile choices. Orison protected commercial bloom as if it served staple crops. A central city understated canal storage. Nacre Fold overclaimed wind vulnerability. Lorn Dusk, given the opportunity, marked its entire reflected-dawn schedule non-discretionary.

Dael audited each claim against physical measurements. Greenhouse species records separated food from display. Canal temperatures exposed stored heat. Wind monitors constrained Nacre Fold’s request. Lorn Dusk’s claim survived because every scheduled dawn remained below the Charter floor once missed windows entered the accounting.

“Fairness needs instruments,” Dael said.

“Instruments need standing,” Hesh replied.

Senn added both requirements to the remedy note. The model could not grant either. It could show what followed if delegates did.

Before they attempted the full run, Dael printed the proposed surplus boundaries on transparent sheets and laid them over the physical weather map. The model had made concessions look divisible. Metal and air still had to perform them. A rain delay in Caldriфт changed reservoir pressure at two downstream gates. Less decorative light in Orison cooled tram glass that normally released stored heat after dusk. Nacre Fold’s colder interval reduced demand on one radiator but increased condensation near its clinic intake.

Dael marked every secondary effect with a grease pencil. “A concession that creates an emergency elsewhere does not belong in the surplus column.”

Hesh picked up the Caldrift sheet. "Who checks consequences outside the district offering it?"

"Conservatory engineers," Senn said.

"Only them?"

She heard the trap before Dael answered. The same institution that had certified an empty service precinct could not retain sole authority over what counted as harmless. "An affected district signs too. If Caldrift moves rain and the downstream canal district receives the change, both review the transfer."

"That gives a city power to refuse every inconvenience," Dael said.

"Not if refusal must cite a floor or physical safety limit. Preference alone cannot block a verified share."

Hesh turned the sheet toward the light. "Then every refusal needs a visible reason. So does every acceptance."

They tested the rule against Orison's tram walls. A municipal planner had classified their stored warmth as pedestrian safety because frost sometimes formed on the upper bridges. Dael pulled maintenance records. The bridges already carried embedded heat strips sized for the coldest ordinary winter. Bloom storage reduced operating cost but did not protect the floor.

Senn moved the wall allotment into surplus. "The city may prefer flowers to electrical draw. Preference does not become necessity because accounting favors it."

"Unless the electrical draw pushes another service down," Dael said.

They followed the power demand through pumping, hospital reserve, and greenhouse ventilation. Even at the coldest modeled interval, existing capacity held with a narrow margin. The wall light remained movable.

A harder claim came from a school district. Its additional bloom hours supported evening lessons for children whose parents worked central greenhouse shifts. Removing them would not threaten heat or food, yet the loss would fall chiefly on families with the least control over work schedules.

Hesh refused Senn's first classification. "Not a climate floor. Not disposable either."

"The remedy cannot preserve every good."

"No. It can refuse to hide which people lose one."

Senn separated physical protection from civic priority. The school hours entered discretionary surplus because surrender would not breach habitation. A burden note required Orison's delegates to defend how they distributed the lost time within the city. The weather model could keep bodies safe. It could not decide whose evening mattered.

Dael drew a box around the note. "That distinction belongs in the hearing."

Otherwise they will call every disputed comfort a technical flaw.”

By midafternoon, the paper map carried a web of signatures that did not yet exist: offering district, receiving district, engineer, local auditor. Hesh added one more line beneath each transfer for the people who maintained the relevant walls, canals, kites, or radiators. “Officials promise weather. Crews discover whether the promise has bolts.”

The requirement slowed their model almost to uselessness. It also made every concession legible. No burden could disappear into a planetary total before touching a named place.

Late on the third day, they reached the first full two-turn run. The forecasting room had accumulated cups, ration wrappers, paper objections, and one ceramic bearing sample Dael used to keep district names from sliding off the table. Orison’s public bloom projection glowed through the high window in cheerful green. Outside, people crossed the hall beneath eleven promised days they had built their lives around.

Senn began the run at current conditions. Reserve 6 held the temporary shade line Tovin had bought. The unlawful debit remained absent. Darkward settlements rose toward protected service. Central districts surrendered different pieces of weather according to verified discretionary surplus.

The first turn ended colder across Orison. Hospital and staple-crop floors held. Three public gardens missed flowering. Canal cafés lost four warm evenings. Schools shortened two light-extended recreation periods while retaining meal growth and classroom heat. The shear field stayed below warning.

During the second turn, four radiator repairs restored export capacity in stages. Orison’s remaining added bloom contracted day by day. Eyr’s clinic kept its morning window. Nacre Fold accepted one colder storage interval inside the lava tube. Caldriest shifted discretionary rain after seed establishment. No district crossed its floor.

The final green segment disappeared from Orison’s account.

“Count it,” Hesh said.

Senn counted the retired days against the original benefit. “Eleven.”

“Duration?”

“Two turns.”

Dael checked the shear plot, then the maintenance tolerances. “Physically survivable under the repair schedule. Uncomfortable. Sensitive to bad data. Not innocent.”

Hesh took the stylus. Beside the result, they wrote: NO FLOOR MAY ENTER THE TRADE.

Senn sealed the model for hearing disclosure. On the table, Orison’s bloom band ended eleven days earlier than the schedule glowing beyond the window. Every

other district still held a visible floor beneath it.

Chapter 16 — The Hearing of Weather

Oren Pell tested the speaking lamps by asking each one to recognize a district that did not officially exist.

“Lorn Dusk,” he said into the first bronze grille.

NO REGISTERED DELEGATION appeared on the chamber band.

“Eyr.”

The display answered: NO REGISTERED DELEGATION.

“Nacre Fold.”

For the third name, the band returned NO REGISTERED DELEGATION.

Pell walked the inner curve of the delegates’ chamber, tried the remaining lamps, and received the same answer eight times. He was seventy and moved with the economy of someone accustomed to canals, councils, and mechanisms that failed by repeating their instructions. At the ninth lamp he turned toward the public benches.

“The recording system works,” he said. “Its answer does not settle the question before us.”

A clerk entered that sentence by hand.

Senn sat at the technical table with Dael on one side and three sealed model cases on the other. Hesh waited two rows behind them in the evidence section, not among the delegates. Their address ledger rested across their knees. The chamber’s circular floor resembled the Season Table stripped of weather light. Forty-one desks faced inward around a shallow well. Above them, pressureworks pipes crossed beneath a glass roof filmed against Varda’s glare.

Ceryn Ahl stood when the opening chime ended. Her gray formal coat carried no Conservatory insignia except a narrow copper thread at the cuff. She had declined the First Curator’s elevated desk and taken a witness station level with the others.

“Chair Pell,” she began, “the Conservatory renews its request that the initial proceeding address technical continuity. Habitation status raises Charter questions beyond climate administration. The current instability requires a bounded review of physical capacity before broader claims enter the schedule.”

Pell adjusted the paper docket rather than looking at her. “Your request classifies the cause as broader and the consequence as technical.”

“It separates competencies.”

“It separates the people who received weather from the people whose weather funded it.”

A murmur moved through the upper gallery. Pell waited until it stopped without striking the chime.

Ceryn kept her hands flat on the witness rail. "If every constitutional claim changes live climate orders before engineering review, Meral will not retain a stable schedule long enough to decide the claim."

"Agreed," Pell said. "No order changes by the opening of this hearing. Your proposed classification remains denied."

The clerk wrote again. Senn watched Ceryn accept the ruling with one measured breath. She did not object twice to decisions she expected to challenge later through detail.

Pell faced the ring. "This hearing concerns habitation, inherited emergency authority, physical remedy, and the policy categories supplied to the Almanac. Technical evidence will be heard as evidence. It will not define the boundary of what the delegates may consider."

At the central-cities table, Rul Fen rearranged five folders into a straight line. He wore a grower's green pin beside his counsel seal, a choice calculated to place soil inside procedure. His clients occupied seven desks around the ring, including Orison's. None looked pleased by Pell's ruling.

Fen rose. "Before evidence, a question of notice."

"State it."

"The submission published thirty-one hours ago includes a remedy model that assigns prospective burden to registered districts. My clients received no opportunity to verify the underlying discretionary calculations."

Senn opened her copy of the filing. "The model is illustrative, not operative."

Fen turned toward her. "Auditor Vale, you have not been recognized."

Pell's mouth tightened by less than a smile. "Counsel, you asked the room a factual question in the direction of the technical table."

"I asked the chair."

"The chair heard an answer. Continue."

Fen's folders remained perfectly aligned. "Illustrative burdens can move markets, alter municipal demand, and induce districts to refuse scheduled transfers. We experienced all three after the attribution release. Calling a public model non-operative does not make it harmless."

Senn thought of reserve 6 holding a shear front while Orison spent its cold afternoon. Fen had earned that point.

Pell ordered the remedy cases held sealed until the dependency record had been heard. Then he recognized Fen for the central cities' preliminary evidence.

A clerk rolled a projection screen into the well. Fen did not begin with flowers or cafés. He displayed hospital sterilization reservoirs across Orison, Vey Canal,

Senra, and four smaller central districts. Each line showed the heat accumulated during inherited bloom intervals and the services scheduled around that accumulation.

"Would the chair prefer quantities by city or service?" Fen asked.

"Service first. Cities after."

Fen called a municipal systems analyst to authenticate the records. She established that eleven hospitals used bloom-timed reservoir warming, though only four depended on it for more than operating economy. Six staple-crop cooperatives scheduled fungal treatment during dry bloom extensions. Twenty-three schools aligned meal-greenhouse cycles with the added light. Canal pumps, tram glass, hatcheries, public kitchens, and seed banks had incorporated the pattern at different levels.

Senn marked each distinction in the margin: dependence, convenience, historical adaptation, protected floor. Fen's strategy required the chamber to hear them as one inherited body.

"Can those systems be changed?" he asked the analyst.

"Yes."

"Without interruption?"

"No."

"Without expense?"

"No."

"Without any increased risk?"

"No climate schedule changes without increased risk somewhere."

Fen let that answer remain.

By midday, the hearing had acquired numbers but no direction. Rul Fen proved that inherited bloom reached farther than decorative terraces. He traced hospital timing into staff shifts, crop windows into public kitchens, and school greenhouses into meal contracts. Orison had not merely enjoyed stolen warmth. It had built civic systems around reliable receipt.

Hesh sat without writing. The address ledger stayed closed beneath their hands.

During a document change, Senn leaned back. "He is making dependence look like authority."

Dael kept his eyes on a tower-demand graph. "He is proving dependence. Do not make his evidence weaker because you dislike where he carries it."

"I know."

"Your pen disagrees."

She looked down. Three hard strokes cut beneath the word *inherited*. Senn turned the page.

Fen called an Orison hospital engineer. The woman described reservoir retrofits made fourteen years earlier, after bloom extensions had become predictable enough to justify removing a backup heater. Reinstalling equivalent capacity would take one turn if parts arrived, longer if the radiator repair program competed for alloys.

"Did your hospital know the bloom interval came from a winter debit?" Fen asked.

"No."

"Did you know any inhabited settlement carried additional cold?"

"No."

"Would you have approved the retrofit if you had known?"

The engineer looked toward Ceryn, then Senn, then the public gallery. "I would have asked whether the transfer had consent. I cannot tell you what the board would have done."

Fen thanked her without trying to improve the answer.

Ceryn questioned the witness next. "If the interval ended tomorrow, could the hospital protect sterilization capacity?"

"For nine days, using reserve electrical heat and postponed non-urgent procedures."

"After nine?"

"We would require supplemental power or restored bloom."

"Could the city supply that power without changing another weather service?"

"Not at current demand."

Ceryn sat. She had placed the danger into the record without defending the source.

Pell invited questions from delegates. A canal district representative asked how many listed systems would actually cross a climate floor if the inherited bloom ended over the staged interval Senn had filed. Fen objected that the remedy remained sealed. Pell allowed a question about dependency but not the unpublished allocation.

The municipal analyst returned to the lamp. Four hospitals required replacement heat or schedule changes. Seven could absorb the loss through existing systems at increased cost. Of the twenty-three schools, five would lose meal-growing capacity unless power shifted from other municipal uses. The rest would lose evening hours, ornamental beds, or predictable timing. Two staple cooperatives faced serious crop risk during the first turn. Four could adjust planting if notified before germination.

Fen asked her to describe the confidence bounds. She opened pale uncertainty bands around every line. Parts supply, radiator repairs, and municipal response widened them. No witness could promise an exact transition without knowing

which districts would offer surplus weather.

"Then fourteen of the systems you named may adapt without crossing a protected floor?" the canal delegate asked.

"More than fourteen may adapt," the analyst said. "Adaptation still has cost."

"Cost and floor are different categories."

"Yes."

Fen stepped back to the grille. "Counsel requests that the phrase *may adapt* not be condensed into *can surrender*. One describes technical possibility. The other assigns obligation."

Pell directed the clerk to preserve both terms.

Senn understood what Fen had accomplished. He had established the breadth of dependence, then protected every uncertain edge from becoming a concession. Her remedy model did the reverse. It locked floors and exposed uncertainty above them as a place where districts might carry burden. Neither procedure could eliminate judgment. They differed over who received protection while judgment continued.

An Orison delegate requested a live map of the eleven added days. Fen projected the first interval as a green band across civic services. Hospital reservoirs occupied dark green blocks. Staple crops carried a second shade. School food production appeared in narrow stripes. Nearly half the band remained pale: commercial bloom, public-garden timing, heat-storage economy, recreation light, and schedule preferences whose loss would inconvenience the city without breaching habitation.

Hesh opened the address ledger for the first time that day. They did not raise it or interrupt. Senn could see rows of handwritten dates from the technical table. Forty-six additional winter days could not fit into the pale portion of Fen's picture. The diagram showed what Orison had learned to depend on, not what Lorn Dusk had been forced to survive without.

Ceryn requested one correction. "The pale services still contribute indirectly to municipal stability. Commercial bloom employs greenhouse workers. Recreation light affects school attendance. Heat-storage economy preserves electrical reserve."

"Are they protected floors?" Pell asked.

"Not all."

"Then let the record retain their indirect value and their legal distinction."

Fen accepted the wording. His clients whispered among their desks. The hearing had not ordered Orison to surrender a single hour, yet naming the pale band had changed it from inheritance into an arguable claim.

Next came a seed-bank custodian from Senra. Her facility used added bloom for drying rooms whose backup fans had been decommissioned eight years earlier.

She brought a cracked fan bearing and set it on the evidence stand.

"We were told the light interval belonged to the normal planetary plan," she said. "Replacing a working schedule with machines looked wasteful."

Fen asked what ending the interval would do.

"Without replacement fans, moisture loss slows. Some seed lots spoil."

"Food security?"

"For three districts, eventually."

Under questions from Pell, she conceded that new fans could arrive within fifty days and installation would take six. The seed bank had enough dry storage to bridge one turn if other districts accepted temporary lots. No catastrophe followed automatically. Work, expense, and cooperation did.

Senn wrote those three words beneath her model notes. The correction could not promise painless transfer. It had to distinguish pain from a breached floor and require institutions to do the intermediate work they had avoided while hidden winter remained cheap.

Before releasing the witness, Pell asked whether the custodian would have maintained the fans if the source of the added bloom had appeared on her operating ledger.

The woman touched the cracked bearing. "I would have known the light could end."

Pell called a recess for ventilation adjustment. The chamber doors opened, admitting cooler air and the smell of wet coats from the public corridor. Delegates left their desks in clusters. Hesh remained in the evidence row.

Senn carried them a cup from the clerk's urn. "No guest coat, but you will accept bad tea?"

"Bad tea does not claim jurisdiction over my body." Hesh drank and winced. "It may be trying."

Fen approached before Senn could answer. Up close, his grower's pin showed scratches along one leaf.

"Keeper Dara," he said.

"Hesh will do. Keeper has no meaning to your register."

"It has meaning to me."

"Privately."

Fen accepted the correction. "I intend to challenge your seat petition. Not your evidence."

"Those are not separable from where I am sitting."

"My clients received notice from a filing made by an auditor whose office remains inside the respondent institution. If unregistered claimants take district

seats before authentication, every service precinct and temporary camp can acquire allocation rights by assertion.”

Hesh rested one palm on the ledger. “Then authenticate us.”

“That will happen.”

“When?”

“Under the docket, after emergency authority.”

“You will ask whether the Conservatory may keep using the order before you decide whether anyone lived under it.”

Fen looked toward Pell’s empty chair. “I did not write the docket.”

“You intend to use it.”

The return chime ended the exchange.

When the chamber settled, Pell took the address ledger petition first.

Fen rose at once. “Procedural objection. The published sequence places authentication after the dependency record and archival authority.”

“I changed the sequence,” Pell said.

“On what motion?”

“Chair’s authority to resolve participation before extended testimony.”

Fen opened his rule book. Pell waited. The counsel found the clause, read it twice, and closed the cover.

“No objection to authority,” Fen said. “Objection to the requested status.”

A hearing clerk placed three seating markers in the well: DELEGATE, DISTRICT WITNESS, TECHNICAL WITNESS. Hesh came forward carrying the ledger. Senn watched their fingers tighten beneath its leather spine when the speaking lamp failed to recognize their name.

Pell addressed them directly. “State the basis of your request.”

“Lorn Dusk maintains continuous civic heat, an address ledger, local birth records, and burials. Those facts meet the Charter habitation test. I was selected keeper by residents entered in this book. I request a district witness seat.”

Fen asked permission to question.

“Limited to participation,” Pell said.

Counsel faced Hesh across the well. “Has Lorn Dusk received formal recognition as an inhabited district?”

“No.”

“Has it been assigned a delegate?”

“No.”

“Does any current registry identify your selection process as a district election?”

“No current central registry records our elections.”

"Then what authority certifies that you speak for the population claimed in that ledger?"

"The people recorded there."

Fen's tone remained courteous. "That answer may establish community trust. The question concerns planetary procedure."

"Our procedure includes public nomination in the address hall, seven days for objection, and a counted assembly."

"Certified by whom?"

"By three ledger witnesses and the prior keeper."

"Each resident of Lorn Dusk?"

"Yes."

"Each person therefore lacks registered district status."

Hesh looked around the circular desks. "That appears to be why we came."

The public benches stirred again.

Fen turned to Pell. "The petition depends on certifications issued by persons whose standing has not been established. Until authentication, Hesh Dara may testify as an individual witness. A district seat would presume the conclusion."

Senn felt the mechanism close. Lorn Dusk could not certify Hesh because Lorn Dusk lacked standing. It could not establish standing through its chosen keeper because the keeper lacked certification from a recognized district. The circle had no false statement inside it. Procedure produced exclusion by requiring its own result as an entry condition.

Pell asked Hesh, "Do you claim delegate voting authority today?"

"No. I claim the right to speak from the district position when others describe what can be taken from us."

Fen objected to the word *district*.

"Noted," Pell said.

Ceryn requested recognition. "The Conservatory can authenticate the instrument loads attached to Lorn Dusk, including continuous domestic heat, school cycles, medical reserve, and local burial refrigeration."

Hesh turned toward her. "You can authenticate our machines."

"I can authenticate records under my custody."

"You had our records for years."

"Yes." Ceryn did not lower her eyes. "The loads support habitation."

A central delegate asked whether that concession resolved standing.

"No," Fen said. "Physical occupancy and lawful district formation require separate findings."

Senn opened the Charter on her slate. The habitation test contained no formation ritual. Continuous civic heat, address ledger, births or burials. Order 9 had displaced those facts into an equipment category, but it had not amended the Charter.

Pell read the same passage on paper. "Counsel Fen, identify the clause requiring prior district formation."

Fen consulted an aide. "The allocation rules assume a registered district authority."

"Assumption does not add words to the Charter."

"It governs implementation."

"We are determining who may be heard, not yet assigning a weather share."

Fen shifted to notice. Granting a district witness seat could imply recognition before the three settlements' records received full authentication. Other delegates pressed him from both directions. One feared false claims from transient camps. Another asked how a claimant could ever authenticate communal records if no representative could present them. An Eyr maintenance apprentice shouted from the gallery and was removed after refusing to sit.

Through it all, Hesh stood beside the unused marker.

Senn wanted to speak, but her evidence belonged to a later docket section. She wrote Pell a narrow citation instead: CHARTER TEST DEFINES HABITATION BY FACTS, NOT REGISTRY ENTRY. The clerk carried it to the chair with two other notes.

Pell called ten minutes of silent review. No one left. Ventilation pushed cool air through the chamber, lifting the corners of Fen's exhibits. Ceryn read the Charter without moving her lips. Dael watched Hesh. Senn watched the empty district marker at their feet.

At last Pell returned the notes to the clerk.

"The petition asks for a district witness seat. Counsel correctly observes that granting full district status would anticipate a finding. The chair also finds that denying any representative capacity because the claimant lacks the status under dispute would make the hearing incapable of receiving the claim."

Fen rose. "Clarification on scope."

"You will have it."

Pell turned to Hesh. "The chair grants provisional witness standing for purposes of presenting records, questioning evidence that assigns burden to Lorn Dusk, and responding from the designated district position. This grant does not confer a delegate vote, weather-share authority, or final recognition under the Charter."

The clerk reached for the district marker, hesitated, then placed it before Hesh with a gray provisional strip across its base.

"May the record call us Lorn Dusk?" Hesh asked.

Pell looked up at the chamber band, which still displayed NO REGISTERED DELEGATION.

“Yes,” he said. “Enter the name by hand.”

Chapter 17 — The Expired Emergency

Pera warmed the first page of Order 9 between two panes of archival glass until the blue ink darkened enough to testify.

A magnifying camera hung above her hands. Its image filled the chamber screen: paper fibers, brown handling marks, the embossed emergency seal, and a faint thumbprint from someone who had carried the order thirty-one years earlier. She kept the heat plate at sixteen degrees. One more degree would improve the signature and accelerate the paper’s decay.

“State what you are doing,” Oren Pell said.

“I am restoring legibility temporarily through controlled warming. Thermal ink migrates toward the visible range without adding pigment. The process changes contrast, not content.”

Rul Fen rose from the central-cities table. “How can the witness establish that distinction?”

Pera looked at him over the glass. “Because adding pigment requires pigment.”

A few people in the upper gallery laughed. Fear sharpened her humor before it improved her judgment.

Fen waited.

“I also recorded the sheet under cold, ambient, and warmed conditions,” she said. “Fiber alignment and impression depth remain constant. The order has an unbroken archive custody record from Year Forty-four After Choir except for six hours during a pressure leak in Year Fifty-two, when the sealed case moved to the upper vault. Both custodians signed the transfer.”

“Better,” Fen said.

Pera disliked him less for making her correct herself and more for sounding pleased about it.

The speaking lamp lit beneath her. She read the visible title, date, and authority line into the record. ORDER 9: TEMPORARY THERMAL SERVICE PRECINCTS, DARKWARD RADIATOR CONSTRUCTION. The originating council had acted during a genuine construction emergency. Tower crews needed rapid weather allocation around camps not yet intended for permanent settlement. The order classified occupancy as equipment service and suspended ordinary climate-floor treatment.

“For how long?” Pell asked.

Pera moved the glass to the duration clause. "Five years from entry, unless superseded earlier by habitation review."

"Does it authorize renewal?"

"Yes. One-year renewals after inspection of camp occupancy and radiator need."

Fen approached the witness rail with permission. "You said *habitation review*. Read the exact printed language."

Pera adjusted the camera. Blue letters deepened on the screen.

"At the end of the initial term, review required before any continued exemption from Charter climate floors."

"Is the phrase *habitation review* present?"

"No. That describes the clause's function."

"Then confine authentication to language on the page."

Pera placed both palms beside the glass. "The page also requires occupancy inspection."

"On the next line."

"Yes."

"Read it."

"Inspecting authority shall certify absence of permanent domestic heat, local birth or burial record, and continuous non-service residence."

Fen returned to his table. The correction had helped the claim he meant to resist. He wanted the archive exact because any imprecision offered a way to discount it later.

Ceryn Ahl sat at the respondent station with no counsel. When Pell asked whether she challenged the originating order's authenticity, she said no.

"Do you challenge the five-year term?"

"No."

"Do you challenge the review condition?"

"No."

Her answers removed whole branches of hostile questioning. Pera felt no relief. The disputed years remained inside the renewal chain stacked to her right.

She began with the first renewal. The paper matched the original archive stock. A different thermal batch gave the ink a greener cast under heat. Two inspectors certified continued construction activity. Neither completed the domestic-heat field. A handwritten note mentioned six family quarters near tower 14 but classified them as dependents of essential workers.

The second renewal contained twelve such quarters. The third omitted the count and attached a radiator-load summary. By the fourth, local school-cycle demand appeared in the instrument annex while the certification still described temporary

camp services.

Before Pera could move on, Fen asked to inspect the fasteners. A clerk carried the second and third packets to a side table beneath a shielded lamp. Pera followed with the camera. Removing an archival clasp required a record of pressure marks, corrosion, thread direction, and every hole the metal had made. The hearing waited while she measured them.

“Why does this matter?” a delegate asked.

Fen answered before Pera could. “Because a later annex inserted into an older packet cannot prove what the original signer received.”

That was correct. Pera enlarged the second packet’s fold. The blue inspection sheet and family-quarter page shared two pinholes with the same oval deformation toward the lower edge. Copper oxide had migrated through both in one continuous stain. A third hole came from a later archive binding and did not touch the original clasp line.

“These pages were fastened together before the ink finished curing,” Pera said. “A faint transfer from the family-quarter heading appears on the back of the inspection sheet. They cannot establish the day of assembly more closely than the ink batch permits, but the evidence supports an original packet.”

Fen examined the enlargement. “Supports, not proves.”

“Paper rarely obeys courtroom verbs.”

Pell looked over his glasses.

Pera corrected herself. “The probability of later insertion is low given matching thermal batch, edge wear, clasp oxidation, and wet-ink transfer.”

For the third renewal, certainty improved. Its annex numbers had been stamped before text entry, and the occupancy page carried the same clerk’s correction mark as the signature sheet. Pera showed the original numeral beneath the correction: eight family quarters changed to twenty-one. Someone had drawn one line through the smaller count, entered the larger figure, and initialed it.

Hesh requested magnification. “Does that page name Lorn Dusk?”

“No. It names Service Cluster Fourteen.”

“Does the address ledger use that cluster number?”

“On its earliest cover.”

Fen objected. “The Lorn Dusk ledger has not yet been authenticated into this section.”

Pell sustained the objection but allowed Hesh to reserve the comparison. Pera marked the exhibit tab with a small gray flag. The archive had spent decades separating records that described the same households. Procedure now required them to rebuild each connection in the correct order.

A delegate from the northern reservoirs asked why no clerk had rejected the

packet when the family count increased. Pera opened the contemporary filing manual. Emergency renewals received three checks: authorized signature, active order number, and complete page sequence. Clerks did not reassess factual findings unless a required field remained empty.

"Domestic occupancy remained empty," the delegate said.

"The field contained an inheritance mark."

Pera projected it. Two short strokes crossed the box, the old symbol for *prior value continues*. The prior box had also used an inheritance mark. She traced the chain back to the original Order 9 assumption that construction camps contained no permanent residents.

"How many times can a value inherit itself?" Pell asked.

"The manual sets no limit."

"So an assumption can persist without being restated?"

"Yes. Each clerk sees a completed field."

Ceryn requested recognition. "That practice applied across emergency administration, not only these precincts. Inheritance marks prevented service collapse when inspections arrived late."

"Did the practice distinguish a late inspection from no inspection?" Pell asked.

"Not in the field itself. The supporting docket should have done so."

Pera opened the docket numbers. The first renewal linked to six inspection tasks. Four closed. Domestic heat and permanent residence remained pending. When the second renewal arrived, its system copied the pending tasks forward but assigned them a low priority because the renewal packet already carried an authorized signature. By the third, reform clerks migrated only the completed summary, not the pending sub-tasks.

Fen studied the projection. "Are you testifying that the pending tasks vanished?"

"From the active queue. Their original entries remain in the paper docket."

"Through deliberate deletion?"

"No deletion mark appears. The migration rule excluded subordinate tasks attached to an approved order."

The distinction mattered to Pera. No clerk needed to burn a page. A rule about what deserved migration had done quieter work.

Pell directed the original task sheets into evidence. Their corners carried no completion punches. One bore a note from a junior inspector requesting transport to tower 14. The request had been denied during a wind closure and never rescheduled.

"Would that inspection have found permanent habitation?" Hesh asked.

Fen objected to speculation.

Pell sustained the objection.

Hesh changed the question. "Did anyone complete the required visit?"

"Not according to this docket," Pera answered.

The chamber screen still showed the empty punch boxes when Pell returned her to the renewal sequence.

Pell stopped her after the fourth packet. "Does each renewal contain the inspection required by Order 9?"

"Each contains a sheet titled occupancy inspection."

"That does not answer the question."

Pera swallowed. "No. The fields required to prove absence of permanent habitation were incomplete after the first term."

A darkward voice called from the gallery, "Because we were there."

Pell warned the gallery once. Hesh, seated at the provisional district position, did not turn around.

Fen requested the first inspection form. "Are incomplete forms automatically invalid under archive rules?"

"No."

"Can omitted fields inherit prior certified values?"

"In routine administrative records, yes."

"Did the first sheet certify temporary occupancy?"

"It certified continued construction need. The domestic fields remained blank."

"Did an authorized officer sign it?"

"Yes."

"Then an administrator reading the chain could reasonably understand temporary status to continue."

"Only if they ignored the attached family quarters."

Fen's gaze narrowed. "Authentication, Clerk Iven."

Pera looked to Pell.

"The witness may explain what the authenticated packet contains," Pell said. "She may not characterize what a reasonable administrator concludes."

"The packet contains a family-quarter count," Pera said. "Later packets contain school load, medical reserve, address-heating totals, and burial refrigeration."

Each item entered the record separately. Hesh used their questioning right to ask whether those annexes had arrived with the renewals or been attached later.

"Original fasteners," Pera said. "Matching impression stains. They traveled together."

"Could a signer reach the signature page without passing them?"

The question moved beyond authentication, but Pell allowed a physical answer.

"The signature page sits at the back. The annexes are numbered. A person could skip them."

"Could they be absent without the page count showing a gap?"

"No."

Hesh thanked her and sat.

The fifth renewal required a new heat setting. Its signature sheet had spent years misfiled in a crop-emergency annex, compressed against a copper report clasp that left green residue along one edge. Pera replaced the warmed glass with a neutral support and displayed the sheet cold first.

Ceryn's signature remained visible without enhancement.

No one in the chamber needed Pera to name it. The screen carried CERYN AHL in a younger, harder hand beneath the Year Fifty-eight crop-emergency seal.

Pell asked Ceryn whether she authenticated her own signature.

"I do."

"Did you hold signing authority?"

"I did."

"Did the packet contain the note regarding permanent households?"

"It did."

Fen stood. "Chair, the witness's private knowledge of the signing packet may belong to later examination. The current witness authenticates documents."

Pell sustained the objection. Ceryn folded her hands again.

Pera read the renewal aloud. Fungal loss had reduced central grain projections. The council authorized maximum bloom continuity, emergency cloud suppression, and extended heat export. The darkward precinct classification continued for one year, pending post-emergency review.

"Date of crop emergency closure?" Pell asked.

"Year Sixty."

"Was a post-emergency review filed?"

Pera had searched every index that might disguise it. Habitat formation. Service closeout. Radiator workforce. District conversion. Emergency sunset. She had found meeting notices, deferred agendas, and one memorandum transferring unfinished reviews into the new administrative system.

"No completed review appears in the Conservatory archive."

Fen approached with a thin gray volume. "Does absence from one archive prove no review occurred?"

"No."

"Could the planetary council archive hold it?"

"We searched that index."

"Could a district archive hold it?"

"The precincts had no recognized district archive."

"Could the construction authority have retained it?"

"That authority dissolved in Year Sixty-one. Its permanent records transferred to us."

"Could a paper have been lost?"

"Yes."

"Then you cannot prove that no one conducted a review."

"I can prove the renewal chain does not cite one, the inherited field contains no review identifier, the review docket remained open when migrated, and every repository designated by the order lacks a completed record."

Fen rested one hand on the gray book. "But not that no review ever occurred."

"No." Pera hated the smallness of the answer. "Archives prove what institutions preserved. Sometimes that is also what they chose to forget."

"Characterization."

"Sustained," Pell said.

Ceryn requested permission to ask one question. "Clerk Iven, if a review had lawfully continued the exemption, what identifying element would the renewal system require?"

"A review seal number linked to the Charter findings."

"Does any later renewal contain one?"

"No."

Ceryn sat without looking at Fen.

Pera understood the gift and its boundary. Ceryn would not pretend a legal review existed. She had not yet conceded what its absence did to authority.

The chain after Year Sixty arrived on thinner paper. Administrative reform had replaced yearly signature packets with inherited fields. Pera displayed the migration form that converted active emergency directives into machine-readable categories. Each row included originating authority, status, sunset date, review state, and continuation rule.

Order 9's row showed the correct origin. It showed the five-year term. It showed the Year Fifty-eight renewal. In the review field, the original clerk had entered REVIEW REQUIRED.

"What appeared in the continuation rule?" Pell asked.

"Continue until superseded."

"Were those phrases legally equivalent?"

Pera looked toward Fen before answering. "No archival standard treats them as equivalent."

"Do not anticipate my question," Fen said.

"You had the look."

The gallery laughed again. Pell covered the speaking lamp with one hand until quiet returned.

Fen opened the migration manual. "The reform occurred during a backlog of two thousand one hundred six emergency and maintenance orders, correct?"

"Yes."

"Clerks were instructed to preserve active service where interruption might create risk."

"Yes."

"Continuation fields did not renew legal authority. They preserved system behavior pending human disposition."

"That is what the manual says."

"Then automated inheritance did not claim to conduct a review."

"No."

"It did not erase the originating date."

"No."

"It did not conceal the phrase *review required*."

"Not in the migration record."

Fen turned toward the delegates. "The record therefore shows administrative continuity, not forged renewal. Any failure lies in later disposition, which must be considered alongside the continuing physical emergency."

Pell stopped him. "Argument follows testimony."

Fen returned to Pera. "Did the system generate new signatures?"

"No."

"New inspection certificates?"

"No."

"New declarations that the precincts lacked permanent households?"

"No."

"Nothing further."

Hesh rose at their gray-striped marker. "Did the system continue assigning our domestic heat as equipment load?"

"Yes."

"Did it continue withholding the climate floor?"

"Yes."

"Did a person review those outcomes each year?"

"Engineers reviewed thermal quantities. Schedule officers reviewed risk. I found no annual review of habitation status."

"Then what did people inherit?"

Fen objected to breadth.

Pell narrowed the question. "What fields passed forward without new authorization?"

Pera opened the system history. "Equipment-only occupancy. Climate-floor exemption. Winter-debit eligibility. Continue until superseded."

Hesh placed one finger on their ledger. "For how long?"

Pera had calculated the interval by year, month, and filing day. The answer sounded less precise when converted into the language everyone used.

"The original five-year authority expired twenty-six years before this hearing."

Silence held long enough for the ventilation cycle to change.

Fen rose slowly. "Assumes the first renewal lacked effect."

"No," Pera said. "I gave the expiration of the original authority. Later renewals require their own validity. The last signed renewal ended sixteen years ago."

Pell instructed the clerk to enter both durations.

A delegate from a high-rain district asked whether Ceryn's Year Fifty-eight signature could sustain emergency authority while crop effects persisted.

Pera answered from the order. "For one year. The renewal names one year."

"Could general emergency powers continue it?"

"Not through this document."

Ceryn activated her lamp. "The crop emergency orders contained broad scheduling authority."

Pell recognized her.

"They authorized transfers necessary to prevent famine," Ceryn said. "The fungal loss ended as a declared emergency in Year Sixty, but staple recovery remained fragile for three turns. I continued the central bloom schedule under ordinary Conservatory authority after that point."

"Did ordinary authority permit withholding an inhabited district's climate floor?" Pell asked.

"No."

"Did you consider the precincts inhabited?"

Fen objected that Ceryn had not been called for substantive examination.

Pell sustained it and scheduled the question for the next respondent section. The answer still occupied the chamber. Ceryn had conceded the boundary around any defense she might make.

Pera authenticated the last digital extract. It showed twenty-six annual schedule cycles in which the equipment-only category passed from one planning turn to the next. Human officers approved quantities around it. No officer opened the habitation field. Automated inheritance supplied the premise; people repeatedly used the result.

Fen's final cross-examination focused on Pera herself.

"You are a junior archival clerk?"

"Yes."

"You assisted Auditor Vale before the hearing petition?"

"Yes."

"You preserved an annex after the First Curator requested classification?"

"I preserved the complete filing under protected audit procedure."

"Against your superior's instruction."

"Against a request to condense it. The preservation rule outranked the request."

"Do you consider yourself neutral?"

Pera looked at the warmed pages lined across the evidence table. Neutral paper would have remained unreadable. Neutral indexing had kept a signature inside the wrong annex for years.

"I consider myself accountable for whether these are the documents they claim to be."

"That avoids the question."

"Yes."

Fen waited for more. She gave him none.

Pell reviewed the admitted record aloud. Order 9 had created a five-year exemption. Renewals required inspection. The fifth signed renewal carried a one-year term and a pending review. No completed review identifier appeared. Administrative migration preserved service while marking review required. Automated continuation supplied no new legal act.

"The chair makes no final finding on remedy," he said. "The physical consequences remain contested. The authenticity of the admitted chain is established for purposes of this proceeding."

A delegate asked whether the hearing still concerned the Conservatory's discretion to adjust an inherited schedule.

Pell turned to the Charter volume beside his docket. "An agency may exercise discretion within authority. The admitted record presents a prior question: whether

any current authority permits the exemption at all.”

He directed the clerk to change the docket heading. The old line read DISCRETIONARY REVIEW OF WEATHER ALLOCATION 9.7. The clerk lifted the paper strip, exposing clean brass beneath it, and fitted a new one into the holder.

CHARTER VIOLATION: HABITATION FLOOR WITHHELD UNDER EXPIRED EMERGENCY CLASSIFICATION.

Pera lowered the heat plate. Across the evidence table, Order 9’s blue letters began fading toward brown again. The new heading remained black.

Chapter 18 — Winter Arrives Early

Hesh heard radiator 14 lose its bearing through the soles of their feet.

The first vibration passed under the address hall as a low uneven shove. Cups shifted on the communal stove. Chalk dust fell from the wall of missed dawns. A second pulse arrived half a breath later, rougher and shorter, followed by a silence no radiator settlement trusted.

Nima Sol looked up from the hearing transcript. “Fourteen?”

“West bearing.”

The emergency lamp turned amber before Hesh reached the wall panel. Tower telemetry showed a falling coolant rate and a rising housing temperature. Outside, the black sky carried a faint auroral seam. No reflected dawn had been scheduled for another six hours.

A municipal demand notice flashed across the lower panel: CENTRAL TRANSFER REFUSALS ALTER DARKWARD LOAD. EXPECTED WINTER PULSE ARRIVAL: 19 MINUTES.

The hearing had made weather visible. Visibility had made districts afraid. Three central municipalities had refused routine heat transfers while their councils waited to learn whether accepting them implied liability for past harm. Their caution moved into the atmosphere as cold.

Hesh pressed the local alert. “Radiator fault, tower 14. Early winter pulse from starward. Heat-wall keepers to stations. Clinic receives first reserve. Schools hold children indoors.”

Nima gathered her case bag. “Expected depth?”

“Unknown until the tower reports honestly.”

“That would be a refreshing development.”

She left for the clinic at a run.

Hesh opened the address ledger to the emergency pages. The paper form required time, temperature, affected wall segments, and names of duty keepers. It

also required a district authorization number. Lorn Dusk had acquired provisional voice in Orison but still lacked the number needed by its own emergency form.

They crossed out the blank and wrote LORN DUSK.

A third vibration shook the lamp housings. This one ended in a metallic scrape carried through the heat wall. The tower had not stopped. Its damaged bearing had shifted load onto the paired assembly, forcing the radiator vanes to turn against uneven resistance. If crews slowed the tower, Lorn Dusk lost waste heat. If they kept it running, the housing could seize and throw fragments across the service quarter.

Hesh called tower control.

A young mechanic answered over a roar of pumps. "West bearing cage split. We can isolate, but coolant return falls by thirty percent."

"People clear of the housing?"

"Service crew pulling now. Two still above the valve deck."

"Names."

He gave them. Hesh wrote Sora Pellin and Mar Vey beneath the fault time.

"What do you need?"

"Remote load reduction from the Choir. Four degrees vane closure. Replacement ceramic cage. Warm bypass if the pulse hits before isolation."

Lorn Dusk stocked ceramic segments, but not a full cage. Eyr made them. The nearest warm bypass belonged to the Conservatory network that had treated the settlement as equipment.

"Begin isolation," Hesh said. "I will get the load reduction."

The mechanic hesitated. "Under whose authority?"

"Mine until someone warmer objects."

Hesh sent the request through the public hearing channel, attaching Pell's provisional witness order. The network rejected it within three seconds.

REQUESTER LACKS DISTRICT WEATHER AUTHORITY.

They sent it again as radiator infrastructure maintenance. Approval moved into a central queue behind seven municipal transfer disputes.

The floor chilled beneath their boots.

Residents began arriving at the address hall for instructions. Greenhouse workers wore insulated aprons over sleep clothes. Two school keepers brought eight children whose home wall segment had already lost heat. Ressa, older than the child who had once waited beside the first chalk mark but still narrow through the shoulders, carried a box of thermal strips.

"Where do these go?" she asked.

"Doorways first. Mark any wall below twelve."

"Chalk or ink?"

"Chalk. We may need to change it quickly."

She nodded and handed strips to the other children.

Hesh divided the settlement map into heat-wall segments. Clinic and nursery kept full flow. The address hall could surrender half its stove loop. Workshops stopped kilns except the ceramic repair bay. Homes nearest tower 14 would cool first because their walls drew directly from the return line.

A hearing clerk called from Orison. "Keeper Dara, the chair received your emergency filing. Conservatory response requests confirmation that you accept central intervention."

"Intervention in what?"

"Radiator load, mirror preference, municipal heat routing, and emergency shelter support."

"Limited to the active fault and winter pulse."

"I need yes or no."

"You need a form that can record conditions."

"The current form cannot."

"Write them in the margin."

A pause. "The form has no margin."

Hesh looked at their crossed-out ledger field. "Then use paper."

The clerk promised to return with an answer. The floor temperature dropped another fraction.

At eleven minutes, a pressure alarm sounded from the western heat wall. Hesh left the hall with two keepers and a bag of clamps. Cold had already entered the service lane as fine white vapor along the ground. Buildings shared heat through stone channels, so one failed segment could drain its neighbors if isolation gates remained open.

They found the leak behind a bakery. A coupling had contracted around an old gasket. Warm glycol sprayed through the seam and froze into amber beads on the wall.

"Close west four," Hesh told the keeper at the valve.

"That cuts twenty homes."

"It saves sixty."

"Residents?"

"Send them to the theater."

The keeper turned the wheel. Pipe strain fought him through the first quarter rotation. Hesh braced a shoulder against the handle and added their strength. The valve closed with a jolt. On the other side, the twenty homes went quiet.

The coolant-cistern theater had not served coolant for nineteen years. Its curved metal chamber held stepped wooden seating, a small stage, and heat pipes salvaged from tower repairs. During ordinary winters, actors complained that the walls made every whisper audible. During a real fault, the old insulation could hold hundreds of bodies warmer than separate homes.

Hesh sent Ressa ahead with the shelter keys.

"Do we cancel tonight's play?" she asked.

"What is it?"

"*The Curator Marries a Cloud.*"

"Keep the title on the board. People should know what displaced them."

By the time Hesh reached the theater, stage curtains had been tied around the entrance to slow drafts. Ushers stacked sleeping mats in the orchestra aisle. The lighting crew disconnected decorative lamps and routed power to the floor coils. Someone had placed the painted cloud from the play against a wall, its smiling paper face watching emergency cots unfold.

The first evacuees arrived from west four carrying kettles, blankets, medicine tins, and one cage of heat-dazed pollinators. No one needed instruction on how to make a public room survivable. Families took seats by wall segment so keepers could track addresses. Teenagers filled water vessels. Greenhouse mechanics hung thermal curtains across the upper gallery.

Hesh stood on the stage. "This is a warm shelter until west four returns. Register every person at the door. Keep medicines with the clinic table, not under cots. Anyone leaving tells a keeper where."

An older mechanic called, "Did Orison send the pulse?"

"Changed demand sent it. No single switch."

"Convenient."

"Accurate."

"Does accuracy keep my wall warm?"

"No. It keeps us from fixing the wrong pipe."

The mechanic looked away, unsatisfied but listening.

At fourteen minutes, tower control reported Sora and Mar clear of the valve deck. Isolation had begun. Coolant return fell faster than predicted. The shelter coils drew on the same line.

Nima arrived with three clinic staff and six patients wrapped in silver cloth. "Respiratory cases near the stage. Less walking."

"What did the clinic keep?"

"Main reservoir, medicine warmer, one surgery room. We lost the outer beds."

"Deaths?"

"Not yet. Do not turn that into success."

Hesh entered the patient count in the ledger station by the door.

The Orison clerk called again. "Central emergency coordination offers two mirror-hours from reserve alignment and a mobile heater train. Acceptance requires temporary Conservatory command over local distribution."

"No."

Nima heard them. "Ask the heater capacity."

Hesh did.

"Enough for the clinic and one shelter," the clerk said. "Arrival in four hours."

"Mirror time?"

"Earliest window in ninety minutes. It will not stop the pulse but will support recovery."

"Command limited to supplied equipment. Local keepers retain distribution."

"The emergency rule assigns command with aid."

"Order 9 also assigned people to equipment. We have discussed the quality of inherited rules."

The clerk lowered her voice. "Keeper, I cannot alter emergency command from this desk."

"Then find someone who can."

Hesh ended the call and saw Nima watching.

"Four hours may matter," the physician said.

"So may the condition attached."

"Bodies cool faster than jurisdiction changes."

"I know."

"Do you?" Nima pointed toward the silver-wrapped patients. "You can contest command after their temperatures rise."

Hesh felt the ledger under one hand. Every emergency had taught the Conservatory to ask for temporary authority. Temporary had lasted thirty-one years before.

"They take control today," Hesh said, "and tomorrow the hearing record says Lorn Dusk required central management the first time its status mattered."

"Then write a condition they cannot misquote."

The shelter lights flickered. Somewhere beneath the stage, a pump changed pitch.

Hesh called Pell's chamber instead of emergency coordination. The hearing remained in recess for archival review, but his senior clerk answered. Hesh stated the offer, the need, and the disputed command clause.

"Can you accept aid under provisional standing?" the clerk asked.

"I can accept tools. I will not surrender the claim attached to the hands using them."

"Hold."

Waiting took six minutes. Inside that interval, the winter pulse arrived.

Cold struck the cistern walls with a series of small metallic ticks. Condensation whitened on the entrance ribs. Children stopped talking as their breath appeared. The floor coils brightened to full output, then dimmed when tower isolation cut the return temperature.

Keepers moved people down from the upper rows. Thermal curtains closed around the occupied half of the chamber. Nima directed warm bricks toward the respiratory patients and checked fingers by pressing nail beds. Ressa stood at the door counting arrivals from west four.

"Seventy-two," she called.

"Expected?"

"Eighty-one."

Hesh sent two keepers back along the lane with a heat sled. The early pulse pressed against every door they opened. It had no malice and no politics. The cold followed pressure, shade, and available heat. Politics had decided who met it with broken machinery.

Pell came onto the line himself. "I can issue a hearing preservation order. Central aid may enter without prejudice to the habitation claim. Local distribution remains with Lorn Dusk. Conservatory command extends only to orbital alignment and mobile equipment safety."

"Put that language in the public docket."

"It will delay dispatch."

"How long?"

"Two minutes."

"Write it."

Nima closed her eyes but did not object.

The order arrived in ninety seconds. Hesh read every line. ACCEPTANCE SHALL NOT BE CONSTRUED AS CONCESSION OF DISTRICT INCAPACITY, CONSENT TO PRIOR CLASSIFICATION, OR TRANSFER OF LOCAL CIVIC AUTHORITY.

They signed.

Central mirror control reduced load on radiator 14 within four minutes. Tower telemetry steadied, though coolant remained low. The reflected window began its slow orbital approach. A heater train left the Orison transfer depot under local-distribution conditions.

The missing west-four residents arrived before either source of heat. Two had refused to leave a sick animal. Seven had sheltered in the bakery's flour room after the outer door jammed. The heat-sled keepers brought all nine, plus the animal wrapped in a bread cloth.

Ressa corrected the door count. "Eighty-one."

"Write the time beside it."

"Why?"

"Because later someone will say evacuation completed promptly."

"It did."

"Write the time anyway."

Afternoon in Lorn Dusk had no sun to measure it. Hours passed through pump reports, body temperatures, and the declining coolant smell. The shelter settled into work. The play's musicians used their instrument cases as medicine tables. A baker turned emergency grain into flat cakes on the prop forge. Children drew new chalk marks on scraps of black stageboard, one for each heater cycle that held.

A Conservatory coordinator arrived with the mobile train. She presented the public order before touching a valve. Hesh assigned one heater to the clinic and coupled the other to the cistern coils. Central technicians worked beside Lorn Dusk keepers, unfamiliar with local pipe threads but willing to ask.

At the first coupling, an Orison fitter reached for a standard adapter.

"Wrong taper," Ressa said from behind him.

He checked, frowned, and changed parts. "You work heat walls?"

"I mark doors."

"Good mark."

The reflected light window reached the upper greenhouse roofs ninety-three minutes after the pulse. It did not resemble dawn. Mirror geometry sent a narrow silver band across frost-black glass, enough to warm reservoirs but too high to touch the streets. Greenhouses banked what they could. Heat-wall temperatures stopped falling.

Recovery required more than arresting the decline. The coolant cistern held cold in its outer shell after the coils warmed, and every opening of the theater doors shed heat into the lane. Hesh organized arrivals into ten-minute groups. Empty sleds left first with mechanics. Families followed only after a keeper had measured their home wall twice above twelve degrees.

A dispute formed beside the stage when three residents from west four tried to return together. Their rooms shared one internal gate, but the settlement map listed two wall segments because an old workshop conversion split the address line.

"My mother's medicine is there," one woman said.

Nima checked the clinic box. "We have the same dose here."

"She uses her own warmer."

"The warmer has no power if your segment remains isolated."

The woman looked to Hesh. "You let central crews take a heater through our lane."

"I let them bring equipment under our distribution."

"Words."

"Valves," Hesh said. "Your valve remains closed."

They walked her to the wall panel and showed the falling pressure beyond west four. The segment had warmed near the bakery but not at the converted workshop. A single temperature reading would have sent her back into a pocket of cold hidden by the address split.

"Then fix the map," she said.

Hesh handed Ressa the ledger slate. "Two addresses, three heat zones. Mark the third."

Ressa drew a narrow boundary through the block. The emergency produced a civic fact faster than any central registry could accept it.

Technicians tested the theater's upper exhaust before reducing shelter heat. Years of stage dust had clogged one mesh. Two actors removed it with costume brushes while a Conservatory fitter read airflow at the duct. The absurdity helped. People laughed when silver glitter from a cloud costume entered the instrument and made its sample tube sparkle.

By the end of the second hour, four homes reopened, then nine. The shelter population fell by address rather than by impatience. Hesh recorded each release beside the evacuation time, leaving the page untidy and complete.

Tower 14's west bearing remained isolated. The paired assembly carried reduced load. Mechanics installed a temporary cage assembled from local segments while Eyr prepared a full replacement. No one declared the emergency over.

Near the shelter's clinic table, Nima handed Hesh a list: two cases of moderate cold stress, eleven mild, no deaths, one delayed medicine dose. "The heater mattered."

"Yes."

"So did the condition."

Hesh looked at her.

"I can hold both," she said. "You should attempt it."

On the second shelter night, the hearing resumed by remote link. Pell kept the emergency docket open beside the Charter case. Hesh testified from the theater stage while families slept behind the thermal curtains. They described the failed

bearing, the pulse, local evacuation, limited aid, and the public condition on acceptance.

Rul Fen asked whether central resources prevented further harm.

"They helped prevent it."

"Would Lorn Dusk have maintained every climate floor without them?"

"No."

"Does that not demonstrate planetary systems require central discretion during emergency?"

"It demonstrates planetary systems require cooperation. Discretion without our consent created the burden that broke us."

Fen pointed to the mirror intervention. "You consented after the cold arrived."

"We requested load reduction before it arrived. Your system rejected our request because we lacked standing."

The hearing clerk displayed the rejection timestamp. It preceded the pulse by sixteen minutes.

Fen read it and changed direction. "Would automatic acceptance have been safer?"

"Automatic recognition would have been safer."

Pell entered both propositions.

Ceryn appeared on a small screen at the side of the stage. She had spent the recess coordinating mirror load and parts transport. Fatigue loosened the perfect angle of her collar.

"The Conservatory accepts the conditions of the preservation order for all continuing aid," she said. "We will not assert command over local shelter distribution."

Hesh asked, "Will you place that in the operational log, not only the hearing record?"

"Yes."

"Will the Almanac receive Lorn Dusk's clinic and shelter as protected civic loads during the fault?"

Ceryn paused. Changing the input would acknowledge what policy still disputed.

"For emergency modeling," she said, "yes."

The local display changed. Two loads previously grouped under RADIATOR SUPPORT separated into CLINIC and CIVIC SHELTER. Gray remained around the district band, but the system now protected the people inside it by name.

On the third morning, municipal demand shifted again. This time a notice arrived before the atmosphere did. Orison offered to move one discretionary rain preference from its western gardens into the darkward recovery schedule. The

change allowed an additional reflected interval without increasing shear risk over the central canals.

Hesh read the offer twice. It did not mention compensation, benevolence, or emergency command. The attached sheet named the source service, the affected Orison district, the predicted inconvenience, and the Lorn Dusk loads it would support. An elected municipal officer had signed beneath a line stating that the surrender remained voluntary and reviewable.

Ressa leaned over the ledger desk. "Does rain travel here?"

"Not this rain. Giving up its preferred time makes room for our light."

"Will their gardens die?"

"No. They may receive rain during a colder hour."

"Will they complain?"

"Yes."

She considered that. "Then it costs something."

Hesh signed acceptance under the hearing order. Outside the cistern, frost still sealed the lane edges. Inside, the coils carried heat from local pipes, central equipment, and a schedule altered by a district that had chosen a smaller inconvenience.

On the public panel, Orison's rain preference shifted from fixed green to offered blue.

Chapter 19 — The Engineer's Proof

Dael tightened the telemetry collar with his burned fingers while the hearing clerk asked whether he could swear to tell the truth in low orbit.

"Truth has no gravity requirement," he said.

His voice returned through the service ring speakers with a fraction of delay. On the wall screen, Oren Pell sat beneath the chamber docket in Orison. Senn occupied the technical table. Hesh's provisional marker showed beside the open address ledger. Rul Fen had already arranged his folders.

The clerk did not smile. "Can you take the oath safely while working?"

Dael hooked one boot under the deck rail. The service ring provided enough rotational pull to keep tools on a tray, not enough to trust an unsecured body. Below the grated floor, Meral's terminator curved from copper haze into black. Mirror 117 crossed the window as a thin white blade.

"I can stop for nine seconds."

He removed both hands from the collar, raised the right one, and swore to give

complete technical evidence. Then he caught the wrench before a vibration walked it off the tray.

Crew chief Sala Nerin leaned into the camera field. "If the delegates want complete evidence, they can begin with a complete fastener kit."

Pell looked down at a note. "The service manifest lists forty-eight collars."

"It lists forty-eight housings. The replacement kit contains forty-six collars and two apologetic washers."

"Enter that distinction," Pell told the clerk.

Dael returned to work. Tower 14's failed bearing had not damaged orbital machinery, but its abrupt load change exposed a telemetry gap in the Choir. Three mirrors reported commanded angles without reliable edge temperature. The hearing needed a live demonstration of distributed concessions. Dael refused to run it on instruments that could not prove where the heat went.

He seated the collar around a fiber bundle and watched its indicator move from red to amber.

"Engineer Orro," Pell said, "state your present location and task."

"Choir service ring, east maintenance arc. I am restoring redundant telemetry to mirrors 116 through 118 while crews replace a cracked signal trunk. The repair permits us to measure small angle changes independently instead of trusting command confirmation."

"Why testify from there?"

"Because counsel Fen's clients argue our remedy model depends on concessions too small to verify. The instrument that verifies them had a cracked trunk."

Fen rose. "My clients argue more than that."

"I assumed you would supply the rest."

Pell warned Dael to answer questions, not improve them.

Sala passed him a light probe. The new collar reached green. Dael opened the redundant channel. Mirror 117's edge temperature appeared at 42.6 degrees, then split into two readings a tenth apart.

"Ground team, compare."

A technician below answered, "Primary 42.6. Redundant 42.5. Within tolerance."

Dael clipped the probe to his belt. "One restored."

Pell began with credentials. Conservatory license, twenty-one years. Mirror-lattice specialization. Darkward radiator certification obtained after seven years of central service. Dael stated each fact while moving along the handrail toward the next collar.

Fen waited until the biography ended. "Place of birth?"

Senn looked up sharply.

"Eyr," Dael said.

"Did your first license application identify Eyr as a thermal service precinct?"

"No. It identified tower district eleven."

"Was that designation accurate under the registry then in force?"

"It described the same ground with a name the registry permitted."

"Answer yes or no."

"Yes."

Hesh watched him from the small screen. Dael had never told them how he entered the profession. The concealment looked smaller in orbit and meaner in public.

Fen continued. "Would an applicant listing permanent residence in a service precinct have qualified for a Conservatory climate license?"

"No."

"So your career began through an evasive designation."

"It began through the only address category that let an Eyr apprentice sit the examination."

"Your motive does not change the form."

"No."

Pell entered the answer and moved to maintenance history.

Dael called his private adjustment log onto the chamber display. Twelve columns showed date, mirror, requested schedule, actual edge offset, affected clinic, thermal consequence, and compensating action. He had expected the ledger to feel like confession. On the screen it resembled what it had always been: maintenance written small enough to survive.

"When did the first unauthorized adjustment occur?" Pell asked.

"Twelve years ago, during a failed clinic window in Eyr."

"Last?"

"Thirty-two days ago, mirror 117, Lorn Dusk clinic."

"Number of adjustments?"

"Four hundred eighty-three."

A murmur crossed the chamber.

"Were all unauthorized?"

"Not all. One hundred fourteen fit emergency maintenance authority. Two hundred six used tolerance no schedule officer had assigned. The remaining one hundred sixty-three exceeded my authority while staying inside physical safety limits."

Fen approached his lamp. "You made that classification yourself?"

"Yes."

"After the public case began?"

"I maintained it at the time. I added the legal categories later."

"Convenient."

"Maintenance often becomes legible after someone asks the expensive question."

Fen opened the first offset. Dael had moved a mirror edge by a fraction of a degree for eleven minutes. Eyr's clinic received enough additional warmth to protect a medicine reservoir. Orison's outer canal lost heat within routine tolerance. No public forecast changed.

"Did Orison consent?" Fen asked.

"No."

"Did any elected district officer authorize the transfer?"

"No."

"Did you inform the schedule desk?"

"I filed a maintenance variance without the clinic destination."

"You concealed the purpose."

"Yes."

Senn's face remained still. She had already put those falsifications into the case and named their purpose. Hearing him admit concealment altered the air between them anyway.

Fen selected a later entry. "This adjustment removed heat from a school recreation period."

"Eight minutes of reflected light from the outer yard. Classroom heat and meal greenhouse remained unchanged."

"You decided recreation mattered less than a clinic."

"I decided the clinic reservoir would freeze and the yard would not."

"Without authority."

"Correct."

"Do you consider that just?"

"No."

Fen paused. "No?"

"I consider it preferable to ruined medicine. Justice would have required both districts to know the transfer, challenge the priorities, and keep their protected services. My offset did none of that."

The hearing clerk marked the answer. Hesh closed their eyes briefly.

Pell asked why Dael continued for so long.

"Because each correction worked, and because public correction looked impossible. Small unauthorized movements kept clinics warm without pushing a named district below floor. I mistook survivable secrecy for a solution."

"Did anyone else know?"

"Crews knew pieces. Clinic keepers knew windows sometimes arrived. Schedule officers knew variances existed. No one held my complete log until Auditor Vale required it."

Ceryn activated her lamp. "I did not know the destinations."

Dael looked at her image. "You knew darkward service loads required recurrent tolerance adjustments."

"I knew the towers required them."

"The clinics appeared as tower support."

"Yes."

"That sentence contains the problem."

Pell stopped the exchange before it became mutual examination.

Sala touched Dael's shoulder and pointed to the second collar. Its inner seal had folded beneath the housing. He shut his microphone, opened the clamp, and reseated the seal while the chamber reviewed exhibits. Meral turned below them without turning toward its star. From this height, the inhabited ribbon had no district borders. Weather still found every border officials drew.

When he restored sound, Fen asked whether unauthorized offsets proved only that engineers could steal from one district for another.

"Yes, if you stop reading at the violation."

"Where should we continue?"

"At the distribution."

Dael sent twelve years of adjustments into the model display. Hundreds of narrow lines spread across mirrors, shade kites, central canals, and radiator loads. None carried the full clinic burden. Most moved less weather than ordinary forecast error. Together they protected Eyr, Nacre Fold, and Lorn Dusk during failed windows.

Pell asked the clerk to select six entries at random rather than accept Dael's summary. The first moved heat from an Orison nursery canal during a night when no seedlings occupied its beds. The second delayed cloud seeding over Vey Canal by four minutes, enough to preserve reflected light at Nacre Fold's clinic. A third shifted tower load from 14 to 16 after a medicine store fell below temperature.

The fourth looked worse. Dael had taken a dry interval from a central cooperative during fungal treatment. Rain arrived eleven minutes early. Crop loss remained within tolerance, but the grower filed a complaint against forecast error.

"Did you read the complaint?" Fen asked.

"Yes."

"Did you restore the lost service?"

"No. The weather had already happened."

"Did you tell the cooperative why?"

"No."

Fen faced the delegates. "Distributed harm remains harm even when each line looks small."

"Yes," Dael said.

Counsel turned back. "You agree?"

"Your sentence improves when someone admits it. Smallness does not create consent. It changes the physical risk and makes consent possible across many places instead of impossible for one condemned place."

The fifth entry drew on an unassigned mirror margin. No district lost scheduled service, but the angle increased bearing wear on mirror 118. Dael had compensated by shortening a later maintenance test. Sala produced the replacement record. The bearing survived three more years before routine exchange.

A central delegate asked whether deferred maintenance merely moved burden from weather into machinery.

"Often," Dael said. "Every adjustment has a receiving surface. Metal receives what air does not. Crews receive what schedules omit. A lawful model must count those consequences too."

He displayed maintenance hours beside weather segments. The distributed remedy increased telemetry checks and angle changes but reduced peak strain on radiator housings. Total crew time rose during transition, then fell after repairs. Concentration looked administratively simple because it asked fewer people to issue commands. It demanded more dangerous work from crews near the sink.

The sixth random entry belonged to Lorn Dusk's clinic. Dael had advanced a window during an earlier radiator fault, then offset the resulting heat with shade over an empty Orison tram depot. Instrument logs proved the depot lacked passengers during the interval. They also showed two cleaning workers inside.

Hesh activated their lamp. "Were the workers cold?"

"Indoor temperature fell one point two degrees. Above occupational minimum."

"Did they know why?"

"No."

"Would your proposed method notify them?"

"It must. A district signature cannot substitute for notice to people doing the

receiving.”

“That answer adds procedure.”

“It should. My secret version supplied none.”

Hesh entered the two workers into the hearing note beside the clinic transfer. Dael had remembered a depot, a temperature, and a tolerance line. Hesh restored bodies to the segment without denying the clinic’s need.

Pell ordered the random sample attached to the model. “The demonstration will not present distributed adjustment as costless.”

“It is not,” Dael said. “Its advantage comes from keeping each cost above a protected boundary and exposing enough small choices for districts to consent.”

Fen enlarged Orison’s losses. “Four hundred eighty-three unconsented concessions.”

“Correct.”

“Then you have demonstrated repeated taking, not voluntary sharing.”

“I have demonstrated physical capacity. Consent requires government, not a wrench.”

Pell allowed the distinction.

Dael called up the competing single-sink model. It placed the entire correction into an uninhabited darkward tract beyond tower 18. On a flat allocation chart, no district lost weather. In the physical field, cold air accelerated along the nightward slope, struck the radiator plume, and returned toward Nacre Fold as ice-laden wind.

“Advance six days,” he told the model technician.

The sink deepened. Tower housings cooled unevenly. Vane strain rose. The supposed empty tract discharged its burden into inhabited air.

“Move it farther darkward,” Fen said.

“We tried.” Dael displayed the result. “Heat export falls because the radiators cannot couple efficiently through colder, denser flow. Central temperature rises.”

“Divide it among uninhabited tracts.”

“There are not enough physically independent tracts with compatible wind.”

“Use the ocean margin.”

“Cloud ice returns over Senra’s reservoirs.”

Fen requested each run and received it. Dael had modeled the objections before boarding the transfer tug. He trusted counsel to ask for every easy answer because easy answers served Fen’s clients.

Senn took the questioning position after Fen. “Compare equal total burden.”

Dael placed two runs side by side. The left concentrated cold, shade, and storm tolerance into one sacrificial sink. The right divided the same energy consequence

across twenty-seven discretionary segments above local climate floors.

"Peak wind risk?" Senn asked.

"Single sink reaches prohibited shear on day seven. Distributed run stays below district safety limits through both turns."

"Radiator strain?"

"Single sink overloads three housings while underusing six towers. Distribution spreads export across the available geometry."

"Measurement sensitivity?"

"Higher for the distributed run. It needs restored telemetry, published thresholds, and local verification."

"Failure mode if one district withdraws a concession?"

"Burden reallocates only among remaining surplus. If insufficient surplus remains, central bloom contracts faster. No floor enters the trade."

The last sentence made Fen rise. "That claim assumes the proposed classification of floors."

"It assumes the Charter's classification."

"District-level operational floors remain disputed."

"Yes. The physics can honor any floor you define. It cannot decide whether commercial bloom or evening school light belongs inside one."

Senn asked, "Can it identify consequences?"

"Precisely enough for people to choose with their eyes open."

On the service deck, Sala signaled that the cracked trunk splice had cured. Two crew members floated it into the conduit and locked the shield. Dael moved to the third collar.

Pell called a short recess but kept the technical link open. Senn remained at the table after delegates left.

"You could have told me about Eyr," she said through the private maintenance channel.

"Yes."

"Why didn't you?"

"Same reason I wrote clinic as maintenance. A fact hidden long enough starts choosing its own hiding places."

"That is almost an explanation."

"It is the one I have."

Her image broke into signal blocks as he opened the collar housing. "Your license counsel filed during testimony."

"I expected that."

"You also expected me to discover it from a clerk?"

"No. I expected the clerk to wait until the end."

Senn looked down at something outside his camera view. "The notice reads: license suspended pending review. Effective now."

Dael's hands stopped on the tool.

Under ordinary rules, suspension barred him from commanding mirror movement, certifying repairs, or signing a lattice test. It did not change what the cracked trunk needed. Sala had heard through the crew channel. She held out her hand.

"Wrench," she said.

He gave it to her.

"Procedure?"

"You assume repair lead. I advise only if requested. Ground command must authorize continuation under your license."

Sala called ground command, received confirmation, and made him step behind the yellow line painted on the deck. The line had never seemed so literal.

Senn watched from the screen. "Are you all right?"

"No. The collar seal folds if she tightens the upper bolt first."

Sala pointed the wrench at him. "I know how collars work."

"Then I am improving morale."

The hearing reconvened before the third channel came online. Dael returned to the witness rail fixed beside the window. His tool belt remained on a hook beyond the yellow line.

Pell entered the suspension notice. "Does this affect the admissibility of your prior measurements?"

A licensing officer answered from the chamber. "No. It prevents further licensed acts. Existing records remain subject to technical review."

Fen asked whether Dael's demonstration could proceed.

"Under Crew Chief Nerin's authority, with Engineer Orro as witness but not operator."

For the first time in twelve years, Dael had to ask someone else to move the weather he had designed.

Sala restored the final telemetry channel. "Redundant reads available for 116, 117, 118."

Dael checked the values without touching a control. Each pair differed by less than tolerance.

Pell addressed him. "Can you demonstrate the distributed model without exercising your license?"

"I can state the requested angles. Chief Nerin can accept or reject them and issue lawful commands."

"Proceed."

Dael read the test sequence. It used no dangerous quantity of weather: three mirrors altered edge angles within maintenance tolerance, one shade kite accepted a small timing change, and tower loads shifted across redundant channels. The pattern represented the full correction at reduced scale while preserving the same geometry.

Sala challenged his first instruction. "Mirror 116 edge temperature leaves too little uncertainty margin."

"Reduce change by one fifth. Move the remainder to 118."

"Accepted."

She issued the commands. On the chamber display, five district bands changed by amounts almost too small to see. The physical plots showed them clearly. No single tract absorbed the full consequence. Heat export remained stable. Wind shear flattened rather than gathering at one boundary.

Fen requested a sensor failure.

Sala disabled mirror 117's primary channel. Redundant telemetry caught the drift. The controller widened its margin and moved a portion of the burden to available segments. Orison's discretionary bloom line shortened by another fraction.

"Tower loss," Fen said.

Ground command simulated tower 14 offline. The model drew on repaired capacity assumptions for the other three degraded towers, then reduced central benefit when surplus ran out. Lorn Dusk's floor remained fixed.

"Municipal refusal," an Orison delegate demanded.

Sala removed the city's offered rain timing. The system recalculated. Two districts accepted slightly larger voluntary segments already authorized in the test. The remaining deficit came out of Orison's extra bloom rather than darkward heat.

The service ring crossed into the planet's night. Copper light vanished from the window. Instrument panels reflected Dael's face against black glass.

Pell asked the ground technician for the energy balance.

"Closed within measurement tolerance."

"Any climate-floor breach?"

"None in the defined set."

"Any sacrificial sink?"

"No."

"Could current Choir hardware execute this class of distribution?"

“Yes, with telemetry repair and human authorization.”

Fen stood for one last question. “Can you promise every full-scale run will remain safe?”

“No engineer can promise weather.”

“Then what have you proved?”

Dael looked past his own reflection to the invisible ribbon below. “That concentrated harm is not required by the machinery. Small distributed concessions produce a safer field than one sink. The remaining barriers concern authority, floors, consent, maintenance, and willingness to lose surplus.”

Fen did not ask another question.

On the chamber screen, the central delegates conferred over the live plots. One after another, their technical objections changed labels. Not feasible became not yet authorized. Impossible became disputed cost.

Beyond the yellow line, Sala sealed the telemetry housing and entered her licensed signature. Three green channels held steady across the service ring.

Chapter 20 — The Blank Category

Senn turned the Almanac's third policy objective toward the delegates and enlarged it until the letters crossed three panels of the hearing wall.

PROTECT REGISTERED INHABITANTS ABOVE CHARTER CLIMATE FLOORS.

The chamber had been built for canal disputes, not for examining the instructions beneath a planet's weather. Forty-one desks descended toward Oren Pell's narrow table. Behind them, public galleries occupied the old overflow channels, where blue tile still marked the height of floods no one living remembered. Every seat held a person or a stack of copied evidence. The air smelled of wet coats, hot slate, and the mineral dust released by the wall panels.

“Registered where?” Senn asked.

Rul Fen leaned toward his speaking lamp. “The Charter index supplies the district register. We established that on the first day.”

“We established which register supplied the names. I asked what the objective means by registered.”

Fen watched her with the patience counsel used when a witness insisted on making grammar expensive. “Included in the recognized habitation table.”

Senn touched the control strip. Seven central bands brightened on the wall. Beyond them, gray sectors extended darkward toward the radiator towers. Instruments inside those sectors continued reporting heater draw, school cycles, medical reserves, domestic water, and burial-hall temperatures. None of those

readings entered the registered-inhabitant count.

"The objective protects every person already included in this table," she said. "It does not test whether the table has omitted anyone who meets the Charter conditions."

A delegate from the western reservoirs raised two fingers. Pell gave her the lamp.

"Could the Almanac derive habitation from those loads?" she asked.

"Physically, yes. Legally, no. It can infer continuous occupancy. It has no authority to confer civic status. The governing instruction tells it to accept the register."

"Then someone could repair this by changing one input."

"Someone with authority could name the settlements. Until that happens, the system treats their people as something else."

Senn reduced the objective and opened the source chain beneath it. Each pale box carried a policy office, a revision date, and an inheritance mark. The line descended through the Charter register, the current district schedule, the renewal field attached to Order 9, and a classification written thirty-one years earlier for temporary construction camps. At the bottom sat a phrase that had survived every change in weather and every birth recorded darkward.

OCCUPANCY TYPE: EQUIPMENT LOAD.

No one in the gallery spoke. A ventilation gate clicked behind the upper rail and pushed a cool current through the room.

Ceryn Ahl sat at the technical table with her hands resting beside a closed slate. She had refused counsel's offer to screen questions in advance. Her gray Conservatory coat carried no First Curator's clasp today because Pell had required every institutional witness to appear without ceremonial rank. The absence made her look less diminished than exact.

Senn faced her. "Does that term refer only to radiator machinery?"

"It referred to machinery and temporary crews when Order 9 began."

"Does the Almanac distinguish those crews from machines inside this field?"

"No."

"Does any current policy layer tell it that families live there?"

"No."

Pell lifted a hand before the gallery could answer for itself. "Auditor Vale, keep the sequence technical until you reach attribution."

"Yes, Chair."

She opened the second objective.

MINIMIZE VARIANCE IN CENTRAL STAPLE-CROP YIELD.

Projected crop rows replaced the register. Orison's eleven added bloom days appeared as a smooth green extension across hospital gardens, seed nurseries, school kitchens, and commercial terraces. The central crop model did not mark luxury. It marked variance. A decorative wall of apricots and a clinic bed of feverleaf could occupy neighboring cells while both reduced the chance of a poor harvest. Officials had chosen broad continuity because distinguishing among every use required annual argument.

Fen said, "That objective prevented the fungal failure from becoming famine."

"It contributed," Senn replied. "So did seed restrictions, canal quarantine, reserve grain, and labor transfers. I am not auditing whether crop stability matters. I am auditing what the instruction permits the Almanac to spend for it."

She laid the first objective over the second. Registered central inhabitants held protected floors. Their crop variance received priority above discretionary trades during adverse forecasts. Gray service sectors held no protected population, so extra cold imposed there counted as radiator use rather than harm to a district.

The western delegate frowned at the overlay. "Does the optimizer prefer those sectors because they shed heat efficiently?"

"Partly. Darkward geography makes the towers useful. But geography does not require withholding promised dawns from nearby homes. The unregistered category removes the legal floor that would prevent such withholding."

Senn called up two runs from the preserved Almanac archive. The first reconstructed a schedule from twelve years earlier, before Dael's initial clinic adjustment. Under inherited policy, a cold pulse moved through Lorn Dusk to preserve a central seed-start window. The result met every listed constraint. The second run changed one field only: Lorn Dusk entered the habitation table with its measured civic heat and address-ledger status. The Almanac retained the seed window but distributed smaller concessions across nine districts, trimming ornamental bloom, moving two wash-water heating cycles, and accepting a narrow increase in crop variance.

Figures flowed along the wall in amber lines. Nobody needed to imagine a machine awakening to conscience. The same calculations produced different weather because one set of human instructions protected a place and the other described that place as load.

"Probability of floor breach?" Pell asked.

"Under the inherited run, the official record shows none because no floor exists in the gray sector. Apply the Charter floor supported by its actual occupancy, and the breach reaches sixty-eight percent during that pulse."

A central delegate struck his lamp. "Retrospective application creates a legal conclusion inside a technical model."

"Yes," Senn said. "So does retrospective refusal. The inherited run contains a legal conclusion too. It merely arrived early enough to look like equipment

configuration.”

Murmurs moved through the lower desks. Fen requested the lamp and waited for Pell's nod.

“You have shown one alternate classification,” he said. “You have not shown that the Almanac selected the winter debit because of that classification. Central yield could still dominate under any lawful model.”

Senn had expected the objection. She changed the wall from two schedules to a matrix of sixty-four. Pera had recovered the policy snapshots; Dael had supplied clean instrument bundles before his license suspension removed his access. Each row altered one governing term while preserving weather inputs. Every column carried the same forecast field from the disputed turn.

“Runs one through sixteen remove crop-variance priority,” Senn said. “They produce unacceptable central failures and do not represent current law. Runs seventeen through thirty-two preserve crop priority but cap radiator duty. The burden shifts, yet unregistered settlement demand still receives no floor. Runs thirty-three through forty-eight add the three settlements as inhabited districts. Every one protects their minimum before allocating surplus. Runs forty-nine through sixty-four retain the inherited register and delete Dael Orro's unauthorized offsets.”

On the last set, clinic temperatures dropped first.

A soft sound came from the gallery, not a cry, only several people drawing breath at once.

Fen studied the matrix. “Your selection of protected minimums comes from the remedy model now before us.”

“The numerical floors come from existing Charter calculations used for every recognized district. I applied the same method to measured populations and services.”

“Those populations remain disputed for standing purposes.”

“The instruments counted their heat for twenty-two years. The address records counted their households longer. Dispute the legal conclusion if you choose. Do not call the inputs unavailable.”

Ceryn opened her slate at last. A small reflection from its surface moved across her cheek.

Senn shifted to the third objective.

PRESERVE SYSTEM STABILITY WITH MINIMUM DEPARTURE FROM INHERITED SCHEDULES.

That sentence carried the hearing's most respectable danger. Stability kept mirrors from chasing each new demand until wind shear exceeded control. Inheritance preserved hospital routines, planting calendars, canal storage, crew rotations, and public trust in announced seasons. It also gave old mistakes

momentum.

Senn displayed the weighting record. During the crop emergency, departure penalties had tripled. Five years later, after the fungal threat ended, a review notice opened and closed without action. Automated inheritance carried the emergency weights into the next schedule. Later curators adjusted individual crops and storm limits, but nobody returned the category table to review.

“Who approved continued inheritance?” Pell asked.

Ceryn answered before Senn could identify the chain. “My office did, through annual schedule confirmation.”

“Did those confirmations display Order 9?”

“No. They displayed deviations from the prior year. The precinct category did not register as a deviation.”

Fen turned toward her. “First Curator, confine your answer to the record requested.”

Ceryn did not look at him. “The distinction matters. We built a review process that showed change and concealed continuance.”

Senn let the statement settle into the official transcript. Then she opened the annual confirmation screen. It contained thousands of weather weights, each marked changed, held, or inherited. Order 9 appeared only if a reviewer expanded the darkward infrastructure branch, then opened occupancy assumptions, then requested originating authority. The public schedule showed none of those layers.

A delegate from Caldriest asked, “How often did anyone reach that field?”

“Archive access shows six openings in seventeen years,” Senn said. “Three by maintenance engineers tracing load mismatches. Two by policy clerks during software migration. One by me.”

“Did the clerks flag it?”

“One filed a terminology question. The response classified the wording as legacy-compatible.”

Dry laughter broke from the upper gallery. Pell tapped his table once, though his own mouth had tightened.

Senn enlarged the terminology response. Pera's annotation sat beside it in the hearing copy: COMPATIBLE WITH WHAT?

She did not read the annotation aloud. Its presence did enough work.

The audit moved into the physical chain. Instrument readings entered local aggregators every twenty seconds. The aggregators sorted demand by civic status before sending it to the Almanac. Registered clinic heat carried protected priority. Clinic heat inside a service precinct entered continuous operational demand, no different in law from coolant pumps or bearing housings. The optimizer did not erase the clinic. It received the clinic under a field that permitted interruption.

Senn showed a winter morning from Nacre Fold. A medicine cabinet heater requested six more lumen-hours. The local controller labeled the request clinical. The precinct aggregator relabeled the whole bundle as equipment load. A central seed nursery requested the same amount to prevent germination delay. Its district field preserved the request as protected crop continuity.

Both requests reached the optimizer. Only one arrived with people attached.

"Can local technicians alter that label?" the western delegate asked.

"Not without policy credentials. They can adjust timing within tolerance, which explains the small compensations in maintenance records. They cannot establish a climate floor."

"Could the Almanac alert on the mismatch between school-cycle data and infrastructure status?"

"It could, if governors instructed it to test category coherence. No such policy objective exists in the versions we audited."

Fen rose rather than use his lamp. "Now we approach invention. An optimizer can test unlimited inconsistencies if given unlimited authority. Government requires settled inputs."

"Government also requires responsibility for settling them." Senn closed the Nacre trace. "I am not proposing unlimited authority. I am identifying a blank review duty. Current policy asks whether measurements satisfy the categories. It never asks whether the categories still describe the measured world."

"That remains a human judgment."

"Yes."

The single word checked him more effectively than dispute. Fen remained standing for a breath, then sat.

Pell asked Senn to show how the blank review duty behaved under a live forecast rather than a historical one. A clerk loaded the next nine-day weather field, scrubbed of the negotiating group's proposed correction. Amber wind lines gathered starward of Orison. Darkward radiators carried enough spare capacity on paper, though four tower histories now made that paper doubtful.

Senn ran the inherited policy first. The schedule preserved every central hospital reserve and held crop variation under the preferred margin. It also cancelled two reflected-dawn windows near tower 15, reduced Eyr's school heat for eleven hours, and advanced a Nacre Fold radiator cycle into the settlement's local sleep period. Each action appeared on the result panel as infrastructure management.

"Stop there," Pell said. "If those same actions occurred in a registered district, what language would appear?"

"Protected-service breach, protected civic-heat breach, and domestic exposure warning."

"Can you display that without changing allocation?"

Senn copied the physical result into a recognized-district shell. Red warnings covered the three darkward bands. The underlying temperatures did not move by a fraction. Only the labels changed, yet those labels opened mandatory review, local notice, and a prohibition against final authorization.

A delegate who had defended inherited scheduling through four days of hearings removed her glasses. "So the warning system works."

"For communities admitted to its scope."

"Could staff have seen these red fields at any time?"

"Only by performing the same reclassification I just performed. Routine operators lacked authority to do it in a live schedule."

The delegate replaced her glasses with care. "Then access protected the category from the evidence."

"Access helped. More precisely, procedure separated the people who could see the measurements from those allowed to question the label."

Ceryn requested the lamp. "That separation had a safety purpose. Schedule operators cannot improvise constitutional status while mirrors are moving."

Senn nodded. "Agreed. A control-room technician should not rewrite habitation law during a storm. The missing safeguard belongs above operations: periodic category review tied to evidence that contradicts inherited status."

"What review interval?" asked the reservoir delegate.

"Recommendation falls outside this conclusion. The audit can establish a trigger. Continuous domestic heat, active address records, or local birth and burial data would each have forced human review here."

Fen examined the red wall. "You are describing information available across offices that did not share records."

"I am describing information deliberately assigned to different offices. Fragmentation did not happen in the atmosphere. Governors built it into administrative practice."

Pell told the clerk to preserve both runs. On the evidence wall, identical temperatures remained side by side. One version showed routine gray maintenance. The other refused authorization in red.

Pell called a short recess so clerks could cool the wall panels. Delegates left their desks in clusters, but the galleries stayed full. Senn drank from a metal cup behind the witness rail. Her hand had begun to ache from controlling the display. Dael's matrix waited in a locked evidence partition, precise enough to survive the engineer who had made it unavailable to himself by telling the truth.

Ceryn crossed the floor while the lamps remained dark.

"You left out the famine projection," she said.

"It belongs to the reason for the weighting, not the operation of the category."

"Fen will say you separated motive from mechanism because motive weakens your claim."

"My claim concerns mechanism."

"Mechanisms inherit motives."

Senn set down the cup. "They inherit categories. Motives have to be supplied again by living people."

Ceryn looked toward the gray sectors still faintly visible on the cooling wall. "You think that distinction absolves the system and condemns us."

"It assigns action where action occurred."

"That can amount to the same public effect."

"Not for the replacement. If we blame calculation, we replace a tool. If we name the governing choice, we have to change how authority reviews itself."

The clerk called the recess to an end. Ceryn returned to her table without answering.

Senn resumed with a blind test. Pera had stripped district names from twelve historical bundles and asked current policy staff to classify each from its measurements alone. Every reviewer identified Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold as inhabited. They found continuous household heat, civic water, schools, clinics, births, burials, and local maintenance governance. When shown the inherited legal labels afterward, five reviewers requested immediate correction. Two asked for central-risk modeling first. None defended equipment-only occupancy as an accurate description.

"Did you coerce those answers by mentioning this hearing?" Fen asked.

"The test instructions said the bundles concerned a category-coherence audit. Reviewers did not receive the district names or disputed history."

"How many staff participated?"

"Seven. Every currently qualified policy classifier who had not worked on the hearing record."

He examined the signed forms and declined another question.

Senn returned the wall to the three objectives. Protect registered inhabitants. Minimize central crop variance. Preserve stability through inherited schedules. Read separately, each sounded defensible. Combined with the obsolete precinct category, they directed the Almanac to hold central abundance steady by spending cold where law claimed no civic life required protection.

No sabotage appeared in the code review. No hidden optimization term preferred suffering. No measurement failure concealed the homes. Human classifications had produced the result, and annual confirmations had continued it.

Pell folded his hands. "Auditor Vale, state your conclusion without recommendation."

“The Almanac performed the task its governors assigned. It protected the registered table, accepted precinct occupancy as machinery demand, reduced central crop variance, and resisted changes to inherited schedules. The resulting harm did not arise from a failure to optimize. It arose from what government chose to count.”

“Can the system independently correct the error now that contradictory measurements have been shown?”

“No. It can flag a mismatch if instructed. It cannot grant standing, repeal an order, or decide that a legal category has expired.”

Pell turned to Ceryn. “First Curator, do you dispute that limit?”

Ceryn's face held the composure she had brought to famine briefings, classification fights, and the publication of names attached to preventable deaths. She looked first at the policy objectives, then at the gray sectors, and finally toward the gallery where Hesh sat with the address ledger closed across their knees.

“I do not dispute it,” she said.

“Then what correction can the Almanac make under its present authority?”

Ceryn placed both palms on the table. “None that reaches the category itself. The Almanac cannot correct a category its governors refuse to name.”

Chapter 21 — Forty-One Seats

“Standing first,” said the Eyr observer from behind a rail where no delegate's lamp had been installed.

The phrase crossed the chamber without amplification. It reached Senn because the morning galleries had gone quiet after Pell placed the recognition question on the board. Forty-one delegate desks faced him in descending arcs. Three additional tables stood at floor level for counsel, technical witnesses, and communities the hearing had permitted to speak without granting them votes. Eyr's observer occupied none of those. Her authorization covered documentary attendance only.

Rul Fen looked over his shoulder. “Chair, if gallery interventions become argument, procedure has dissolved.”

Oren Pell adjusted the copper clip holding his pages. “Procedure heard the intervention. Procedure will survive.”

A few delegates smiled. The Eyr observer did not.

Pell returned to the board, where two proposed sequences waited in plain black type. The central cities' sequence placed a complete remedy schedule before recognition. A district would receive standing only after the Conservatory certified that its inclusion could be implemented without forcing another district below floor.

The darkward petition placed recognition first and required all later allocation to obey it.

Between those sequences lay the old trap. If Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold remained unrecognized until a safe schedule existed, their losses could continue funding the safety test. If recognition took full operational effect before a transition had been built, the next inherited schedule could fail authorization while mirrors, crops, canals, and clinics still required instructions.

Senn had spent the night drawing the trap as two circles and crossing both out.

Fen spoke from the central counsel table. "No one contests that the habitation evidence deserves final determination. My clients contest an order that grants fiscal and climatic claims before this body understands their distributional effect."

Hesh sat three places from him at the provisional witness table. They wore the dark work coat they had used in the Lorn Dusk address hall. Their hands rested on a bound copy of the Charter, not on the address ledger itself. That book would come later, if the chamber allowed its keeper more than witness standing.

"Your clients understood the effect well enough to receive eleven days," Hesh said.

Fen inclined his head. "They received schedules authorized by the Conservatory. Growers built contracts, hospitals built heat reserves, and schools built calendars around them."

"Lorn Dusk built graves around the same schedules."

Pell raised one finger. "Neither counsel nor witness will repeat the case already admitted. We are deciding sequence."

Senn waited for the speaking lamp at the technical table to turn green. It stayed dark while delegates entered questions into the queue. The chamber clerk projected them along one edge of the board: Could temporary recognition carry temporary floors? Who would bear emergency authority? Did immediate standing create compensation liability? Could three districts veto a planetary schedule? What happened if recognition and implementation diverged?

Most questions confused a right with the machinery for honoring it. The confusion had protected the blank category for years.

A delegate from Caldrift received the first lamp. "I favor recognition. I also represent growers whose rain turn can be ruined by a half-day shear shift. If we declare three new floors this morning and no legal schedule can close tonight, what governs?"

Fen answered before Pell redirected the question. "That uncertainty supports the central sequence."

"It supports separating two decisions," Senn said.

Her lamp had not lit. Pell looked toward the clerk, then pressed his own control. Green appeared at Senn's table.

"Explain the separation," he said.

She carried two transparent sheets to the floor display. One showed a district register. The other showed the planetary allocation model. When she overlaid them, the recognized bands aligned with protected climate floors, weather shares, notices, appeals, and voting privileges. The administration had treated that stack as one indivisible object because established districts had received every layer together.

"Recognition answers whether a community meets the Charter's habitation test," Senn said. "Allocation answers how the Conservatory meets obligations under physical constraints. The first question depends on continuous civic heat, an address ledger, and local births or burials. The second depends on forecasts, surplus, infrastructure, and transition time. We can answer the first without pretending the second has become easy."

The Caldrit delegate leaned toward her lamp. "What changes immediately?"

"The three settlements receive non-fungible climate floors in every schedule authorized after recognition. Their measured minimum demand can no longer enter as discretionary infrastructure load. Existing physical transfers enter staged review rather than disappearing at the instant of declaration."

Fen stood. "That phrasing conceals the contradiction. If the floor takes effect, any continued winter debit violates it."

"Correct."

"Yet you propose continued transfers during staging."

"I propose no schedule may place them below floor. Burden above every district's floor can move while inherited dependencies are retired."

"You have not proved sufficient surplus exists on every forecast."

"Dael Orro proved distributed concessions outperform a sacrificial sink. The remedy group still has to convert that proof into operating rules. Lack of final rules does not turn inhabited settlements into machinery."

Fen's fingers tightened around the desk edge. "If the model fails, the central cities carry duties no one can perform."

"They already carry duties the Charter imposes. Administrative delay does not suspend them. It changes how openly we manage the failure risk."

Pell asked the clerk to split the board. Under RECOGNITION, he placed habitation finding, immediate floor, district notice, appeal rights, and access to policy audits. Under IMPLEMENTATION, he placed burden formula, tower repairs, bloom retirement, emergency reserve, and schedule dates.

Hesh studied the list. "You omitted participation in writing the second column."

The clerk's stylus paused.

Pell said, "Witness Dara, your present status permits testimony and submission

of language through a delegate sponsor.”

“That means people who received the benefit can edit the remedy at a lamp, while we pass paper through someone willing to carry it.”

“Your objection has been recorded.”

“Recording an inequality does not remove it.”

Several gallery benches answered with the scrape of shoes. Pell waited until the movement stopped. His face showed no irritation, but he placed Hesh's objection beneath the implementation column rather than in the general transcript margin.

Senn returned to her seat. Pera had left a folded note beside the water cup. The note listed the Charter sections that separated habitation from weather-share allocation. At the bottom she had written: THEY ARE PRETENDING THE ORDER OF FORMS CHANGES THE ORDER OF FACTS.

Senn turned the page over before Fen could see it.

The morning narrowed into clause work. Delegates who agreed on harm divided over verbs. “Recognized” sounded final to some and merely administrative to others. “Immediate” prompted questions about the next mirror cycle. “Shall possess a climate floor” invited argument over whether the floor existed before the finding or arose from it. Hesh insisted the text say “has possessed,” because the Charter test had been met for decades. Fen objected that retrospective phrasing decided liability beyond the hearing's mandate.

Pell ordered a practical test. He gave each side the same hypothetical schedule: a newly discovered district met every habitation condition, its present temperature stood two degrees above floor, and the next forecast threatened to lower it by three. Clerks had to authorize or reject the schedule under their preferred sequence.

Fen's team added an interim protection order pending complete remedy certification. Hesh read it twice, then pointed to the expiry line. “Seven days, renewable by the Conservatory. Our floor becomes a favor issued a week at a time.”

“The order prevents the predicted breach,” Fen said.

“It prevents this breach. It leaves the office that ignored us in charge of deciding whether we remain protected.”

The darkward draft recognized the district immediately and prohibited the schedule. A central delegate asked what weather replaced it. Hesh answered that the question belonged to allocation, which satisfied the law and frightened everyone responsible for keeping a mirror plan open.

Senn drew a third version. Recognition took effect upon the habitation finding. A temporary operating schedule could continue only if it held the new district above its measured floor, published every concession, and expired when the negotiated allocation began. Emergency authority could move discretionary services but could

not cross any floor.

“Who certifies the measured minimum?” asked Caldrift.

“Existing Charter staff, using the method already applied to your district,” Senn said. “The local representative receives the calculation and may challenge any input.”

Fen tapped the hypothetical. “Your solution assumes enough discretionary room exists.”

“No. It requires the temporary schedule to expose a shortfall if room does not exist. Then reserve authority, voluntary concessions, or an emergency delegate session must close it. Hidden extraction no longer qualifies as a solution.”

Pell placed Senn's version between the competing drafts. It did not settle the language. It changed the dispute from whether recognition could wait to who carried responsibility when a lawful floor made the old schedule impossible.

A canal delegate proposed “shall be treated henceforth as having possessed.” Even Pell removed his glasses at that.

“Language cannot walk both directions,” he said.

By midday, six drafts lay crossed through on the board. Senn ate a seed cake at the witness table while listening to two reservoir delegates dispute whether an unenforced right could be called immediate. Hesh refused food from the chamber service tray and shared a packet of dried mushrooms with the Eyr observer across the rail.

Ceryn arrived after the recess carrying no staff. Her testimony from the policy audit had ended, but Pell had summoned her to answer implementation questions. She read the split board and asked, “Who holds emergency authority between recognition and the first compliant schedule?”

Fen gestured toward her. “The Conservatory, unless this hearing plans to command mirrors by paragraph.”

Ceryn ignored the flourish. “Current reserve authority permits temporary departures from district preferences, not from climate floors. Once these floors enter the register, my office cannot authorize a forecast that crosses them.”

The Caldrift delegate said, “Does that make immediate recognition impossible?”

“No. It makes preparation urgent.”

Fen looked at her sharply. “You testified yesterday that present authority cannot correct the category.”

“It cannot. The delegates can.”

“And then your office may lack a valid schedule.”

“For a limited interval, yes.” Ceryn folded her hands. “Government sometimes creates an obligation before administration has perfected compliance. That does not recommend casual timing. It does recommend honesty about which difficulty

belongs to law and which belongs to engineering.”

Senn heard the shift because Ceryn did not soften it. She had defended delay as famine prevention. Now she described delay as an administrative problem rather than a reason to deny recognition.

A northern district delegate asked, “What preparation can begin before a vote?”

Ceryn named forecast isolation, reserve verification, tower access, and publication of inherited categories. “The Conservatory can perform technical work under audit authority. It cannot assign the darkward communities a floor until you recognize them.”

Hesh spoke without a lamp. “Nor should it assign our floor without us.”

Pell glanced toward them. “That point returns us to participation.”

“Then let it return.”

The chair called a closed count of delegate positions, not a vote on any language. Clerks distributed thin white slips with four choices: recognition before complete remedy; remedy before recognition; simultaneous action only; undecided. Each delegate pressed a district seal and folded the slip once.

Senn watched the bowl move through forty-one seats. Some decisions showed in posture. The Orison delegate held his slip until the clerk waited. Caldrift sealed quickly. Two northern districts exchanged no glance, disciplined enough to avoid the appearance of coordination. Fen wrote notes without looking up.

Pell and three clerks counted behind a low screen. No totals appeared publicly. The chair read the result alone, conferred with the procedural clerk, and ordered a second count. The galleries remained silent enough for Senn to hear warm water ticking through the old canal pipes under the floor.

At last Pell came back to his table. “A sufficient bloc exists to introduce recognition language. Positions on final text remain unsettled. This count authorizes drafting time only.”

A release of breath moved around the chamber. Hesh did not relax.

Fen asked, “Will the chair identify the sponsors?”

“When they attach their names to language.”

“Then counsel cannot test whether the bloc survives specific obligations.”

“That is why we will write the obligations.”

The board cleared. Pell requested draft clauses from any delegate by the second morning bell. Three lamps lit before he finished the sentence. Caldrift offered the first sponsorship. The western reservoirs joined. A small high-light district whose glassworks depended on stable winter accepted recognition if the floor method used existing Charter calculations rather than a newly negotiated minimum.

Senn marked each condition on paper. Agreement had not formed around generosity. It formed where narrow interests could survive a distinction: standing

now, staged allocation after, no district beneath floor. That made the bloc less beautiful and more durable.

The Orison delegate requested a separate clause preserving hospitals and seed-start functions during bloom retirement. Hesh said the request belonged in implementation, not recognition. For once, Fen agreed.

"Then we have discovered a shared filing system," Pell said.

Even Hesh smiled briefly.

During the afternoon, Senn worked with Pera at a side table to trace every immediate consequence of entry in the habitation register. Climate-floor protection came first. District notice followed. Audit access followed notice. Voting rights required a certification schedule under a different Charter article, which meant full delegate status could not appear by simple hearing order. Compensation claims entered ordinary review and did not arise automatically from recognition.

Hesh read the list over Senn's shoulder. "They will use voting delay to keep us outside the room that decides the remedy."

"Yes."

"You say that as if you have already found their clause."

"Fen's clerk requested the certification article four minutes ago."

Hesh looked toward the counsel table. "Can the hearing grant us a working place without inventing a delegate?"

"Pell can appoint technical participants to a negotiating group. They receive the same documents and speaking access, but no vote in the chamber."

"That sounds like provisional witness standing with a better chair."

"It can be, unless the order grants co-drafting authority and direct objections on the record."

"Can Pell do that?"

"The procedure does not forbid it."

Hesh's thumb moved along the worn edge of the Charter. "Your profession has an alarming fondness for gaps."

"Only the useful ones."

"What would Fen call it?"

"Improper delegation of legislative preparation."

"Then he has probably drafted the objection."

Across the room, Fen's clerk requested the negotiating-group rule.

Hesh gave Senn a flat look. "Your predictive gifts grow oppressive."

They wrote a participation order in eleven lines. Recognized settlements would each name one representative to the implementation group upon adoption of the preliminary finding. Before that finding, Pell could appoint Hesh as a party witness

with direct drafting access because Lorn Dusk's evidence formed the proceeding's subject. Every technical model would be shared in the same form and at the same time with all group members. Objections could enter the clause record without a delegate sponsor.

Pera read the draft and crossed out "consultative."

"Consultative means invited to speak after everyone decides," she said.

Hesh replaced it with "negotiating."

Fen challenged the order before ink dried. He argued that a witness could not negotiate planetary obligations. Caldrift replied that central counsel already negotiated without holding a delegate seat. A reservoir delegate observed that the hearing had relied on Lorn Dusk records while denying their keeper equal access to remedy documents. Ceryn, when Pell asked for operational effect, said the Conservatory preferred one authorized representative rather than receiving contradictory submissions through sponsors.

"Preference does not settle authority," Fen said.

"No," Ceryn replied. "But your objection asked whether equal document access would obstruct administration. It would not."

The day darkened only by civic convention. Outside the chamber's high windows, Varda's fixed light remained copper and low, but interior panels cooled toward evening blue. Clerks carried draft pages between desks. Delegates began leaving for district calls, each departure reducing the chamber's certainty.

Senn found Tovin waiting in the outer corridor with a maintenance dispatch tucked into his coat. He had come to report reserve readiness to Ceryn and refused to enter the hearing while anyone might ask him a constitutional question.

"How many?" he asked.

"Enough to write."

"That sounds unlike enough to win."

"It differs."

"Does Hesh get a lamp?"

"Not yet."

Tovin looked through the open doors toward the witness table. "Then you have enough people to write about them."

Senn folded her position notes. "We are fixing that."

"Good. Fix the tower parts next. Language has terrible thermal conductivity."

He left for the service stairs before she could tell him that Dael would have approved the complaint.

On the third morning, Pell reconvened with nine proposed recognition clauses and five implementation reservations. No text held a majority because no text had been called. He forbade delegates from describing the closed position count as an

outcome. The white slips authorized work, nothing more.

He read the procedural schedule aloud. Final recognition language would close at the second evening bell. The implementation group would meet through the following six days, with technical drafts preserved for public audit. Formal debate would resume after both sets of language could be placed side by side.

Fen raised his lamp. "And the chair's participation order?"

Pell took the eleven-line page from the clerk. "Adopted under my authority to structure evidentiary remedy conferences. Objections are preserved for review."

He looked toward Hesh.

"Keeper Dara, you will receive all working models, direct speaking access, co-drafting authority, and a recorded objection channel. You will not cast a delegate vote under this order."

Hesh stood. "Name the place accurately."

Pell considered the page, crossed out Pera's rejected word where a clerk had restored it, and wrote the replacement in his own hand.

"The final language session begins at the second bell," he said. "Hesh Dara will hold a negotiating seat."

Interlude II — Maintenance Below the Map

****CHOIR MAINTENANCE RECORD / YEAR 63 AC / TURN 2 / MIRROR 117 EAST EDGE**** ****Filed by:**** D. Orro, lattice engineer ****Condition:**** Reflected clinic window under target by 0.08 percent following canal haze correction. ****Action:**** East edge held 4.7 seconds past standard release. ****Variance:**** Within instrument tolerance. No district schedule affected. ****Disposition:**** Close.

****LOCAL COPY / LORN DUSK HEAT DESK / SAME WINDOW**** Window arrived short, then strengthened during final four seconds. Treatment room 2 retained sterilizer heat. Six appointments completed. Conservatory notice: none.

Keeper's margin: Ask tower crew who held the edge.

Crew reply, unsigned: Nobody held anything. The mirror happened to remember us.

****CHOIR MAINTENANCE RECORD / YEAR 64 AC / TURN 1 / TOWER 11, EYR**** ****Filed by:**** M. Aven, ceramic-vane apprentice Return-air temperature rose 0.6 degrees during bearing purge. Automatic schedule called for venting to exterior. Local crew delayed vent by ninety seconds and routed purge heat through apprenticeship hall intake.

Reason: Twenty-three trainees occupying hall during lamp failure.

Central review: Service occupancy does not qualify for civic-heat priority. Future purge delays require tower supervisor approval.

Supervisor note: Approval granted retrospectively. Replace “trainees” with “maintenance personnel” in transmitted copy.

Local archive retained original wording.

****NACRE FOLD CLINIC / YEAR 65 AC / TURN 4 / SHELL-LIME CORRIDOR**** Light cart battery fell below surgical reserve after two promised windows were cancelled. Technician I. Sorel redirected reflective inspection panels from lava-tube seam survey for thirty-eight minutes. Corridor temperature remained below comfort minimum. Pharmacy cabinet reached safe range.

Materials borrowed: four shell-lime panels, eight clamps, two hand lamps.

Materials returned: all, with one clamp bent.

Administrative classification: Equipment protection.

Patient note attached by clinic staff: Medicine does not become equipment merely because a cabinet holds it.

Attachment omitted from central summary.

****CONSERVATORY LOAD RECONCILIATION / YEAR 66 AC / QUARTER 3**** Analyst query: Repeated positive offsets appear at darkward radiator feeds immediately before medical reserve peaks. Aggregate effect remains below 0.2 percent. Are local sensors drifting under cold conditions?

Engineering response, D. Orro: Sensors agree within calibration. Offsets arise from timing corrections needed to prevent thermal shock during irregular demand.

Analyst query: Define irregular demand.

Engineering response: Loads not represented in the inherited schedule.

Policy annotation: Accept explanation. Do not expand occupancy category in maintenance workflow.

****ORISON CANAL CREW 8 / YEAR 67 AC / BLOOM TURN / NIGHT SHIFT HANOVER**** Outgoing water exceeded storage target by 0.3 degrees. Crew could have dumped heat through western fins before morning hive release. Operator Kes Tal held two fins closed for seven minutes after receiving a tower-balance request from an unknown darkward feed.

Day supervisor: The hold advanced canal warmth. Why accept an unauthenticated request?

Kes Tal: Feed carried a Conservatory maintenance key.

Day supervisor: Which engineer?

Kes Tal: Key record expired before review.

Corrective action: None. Apricot terraces opened normally. Canal account absorbed the difference.

Private handover line, preserved on paper: Someone needed seven minutes of our warm water more than we needed an exact morning.

****EYR TOWER 11 / YEAR 68 AC / TURN 2 / CERAMIC VANE INSPECTION**** Three cracked vanes removed. Standard procedure required closing the south service gallery. Crew kept one intake open because the adjacent school heat wall shared the gallery return.

Risk accepted: Ice accumulation on inspection rail.

Mitigation: Two mechanics worked tethered; one apprentice cleared frost every twelve minutes.

Central instruction: Shut intake and relocate any temporary occupants.

Local response: Occupants number 184. Relocation distance exceeds safe heated transit during current window.

Central disposition: Gallery may remain open under equipment-continuity exception.

Eyr copyist's note: The children completed arithmetic while the equipment-continuity exception warmed their hands.

****NACRE FOLD MUNICIPAL WORKSHOP / YEAR 69 AC / TURN 1**** A radiator command requested rapid draw at the same hour as fungal cultures in the clinic required stable light. Workshop crews polished two unfinished wall panels and placed them opposite the clinic shaft. No request entered the Conservatory queue because service precincts lacked a civic preference channel.

Measured gain: 1.9 lumen-hours at cabinet level.

Measured cost: seam survey delayed one shift; three workers reassigned; shell dust entered the west ventilation screen.

Cleaning completed before evening.

Forecast effect: none visible at district scale.

****CONSERVATORY CENTRAL CONTROL / YEAR 70 AC / SHEAR WATCH**** Mirror operator R. Im lowered Orison commercial bloom by 0.04 percent to reduce a narrow wind edge. The resulting spare angle traveled darkward through automatic balancing and strengthened two service windows.

Supervisor: Commercial allocation remained inside tolerance. No report needed.

R. Im: Which services received the spare angle?

Supervisor: Tower auxiliaries.

R. Im: Telemetry lists domestic water rise and a school-cycle start.

Supervisor: Those fields enter as auxiliary load.

R. Im: Then auxiliary load has morning classes.

Supervisor: Close the line, Operator.

Line closed. Personal shift book retained the exchange.

****LORN DUSK CLINIC / YEAR 71 AC / WINTER TURN / TREATMENT ROOM 2****
Promised light delayed by forty-two minutes. Local heat desk requested a mirror-edge correction through the maintenance channel. Request denied: no active fault.

At minute fourteen, tower 15 crew began a coolant recirculation test six hours early. Waste heat entered the shared wall behind treatment rooms 1 through 3.

At minute twenty-nine, the test paused without completing its diagnostic cycle.

At minute forty-two, reflected light arrived.

Tower report: Test timing selected to match crew availability.

Clinic report: Eleven patients remained warm.

Keeper's note: Both statements can be accurate. Only one explains the hour.

****CROSS-SYSTEM VARIANCE REVIEW / YEAR 72 AC / INTERNAL WORKING PAPER**** Sample: 436 sub-tolerance deviations across five turns.

Findings: Darkward crews delayed radiator venting during civic-heat drops. Central mirror operators trimmed discretionary bloom during shear margins. Canal workers retained small quantities of heat after unidentified service requests. Nacre Fold staff used survey reflectors to protect medicine. Eyr mechanics routed purge warmth through occupied halls. No common instruction linked the actions.

Estimated combined effect: insufficient to alter planetary crop yield; sufficient to prevent thirty-one recorded local floor excursions, if habitation floors are applied retrospectively.

Reviewer comment: "Floor excursion" inappropriate for unregistered precincts.

Analyst revision: sufficient to prevent thirty-one measured temperature events below the minimum used in comparable districts.

Disposition: Working paper not advanced. Deviations remain within maintenance tolerance.

****CHOIR SERVICE RING / YEAR 73 AC / MIRROR 83 ACTUATOR REPLACEMENT**** A

replacement actuator arrived with a slower release curve than specification. Ring crew compensated by advancing command start. That advance created a fractional light excess over central glassworks.

Ground control offered two corrections: shade the excess locally or pass the angle into darkward balancing.

Ring crew selected darkward balancing after reviewing tower demand.

Reason entered: Lower system wear.

Crew voice note: Tower demand included domestic heaters, though the screen refused that name. We chose the lower wear. We also chose the houses.

Voice note remained in the service copy and did not enter policy accounting.

****NACRE FOLD / YEAR 74 AC / MEDICINE TRANSIT WINDOW**** Delivery sled required a heated guide line through the lava-tube east bend. Scheduled line activation overlapped radiator draw. A central technician divided the activation into three pulses, each too small to trigger manual policy review.

Sled arrived nine minutes late. Insulin cultures remained viable. Radiator output stayed inside tolerance.

Maintenance audit: Pulse fragmentation increased operator workload and reduced diagnostic clarity.

Technician response: A single authorized pulse would have been clearer. The district had no channel to request one.

Audit recommendation: Consider formal service-request path.

Policy response: Defer pending precinct review.

No precinct review opened.

****CONSERVATORY / YEAR 75 AC / COMPILED CREW NOTE FOR HEARING EVIDENCE**** Twelve years of records show no master plan and no coordinated concealment among the crews. Small acts arose independently wherever the formal schedule omitted a clinic, a school, a medicine transit, a heat wall, or a household morning. Engineers used tolerance. Operators traded fractions. Mechanics renamed people as equipment when accurate language would have blocked the work.

The adjustments did not repair the governing category. They kept specific rooms warm and shifted specific risks into margins other districts could spare. Their scale remained too small, their authority too narrow, and their record too scattered to serve as a lawful allocation system.

Final crew finding: Planetary stability already depended on unacknowledged sharing.

Act IV — The Weather That Belongs to Everyone

Chapter 22 — The Shared Winter

Dael pressed a heated probe against the model tower's return pipe and waited for the frost to release its grip on the sensor collar.

The negotiating room had acquired machinery because conversation alone kept producing impossible weather. A waist-high rig occupied the center: four radiator loops made from narrow copper tube, three mirror lamps mounted on jointed arms, a shade membrane, two water trays, and forty-one ceramic tiles representing district demand. Tovin had built it from training parts and rejected valves. Every leak left a dark circle on the old pressureworks floor.

"Your tower is wetting the Charter," Pera said.

A drop fell from the return pipe onto a stack of clause drafts.

"Then move the Charter," Dael said.

"It has survived worse handling."

She lifted the pages. Hesh kept one hand on the Lorn Dusk tile while Senn adjusted floor values at the control slate. Rul Fen stood opposite them with three central technical advisers. Ceryn occupied the end of the table by Pell's procedural clerk, present as administrator of any rule the delegates might later authorize. She had brought no Conservatory insignia, but every operator still looked toward her when the rig made an unfamiliar sound.

Dael warmed the collar until it turned. The sensor beneath showed a slow response, exactly the fault he wanted. "Run inherited demand."

Senn started the pumps.

Light strengthened over the seven central tiles. Heat entered the water trays, moved through the copper loops, and reached the radiator branches. Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold appeared as gray service pieces beyond the district arc. The rig followed current policy. When central crop demand rose, one valve pushed more cold through the gray branches. A rim of frost formed around Hesh's tile.

Fen pointed to the pressure gauge. "Stable."

"For whom?" Hesh asked.

"For the assembly."

Dael tapped the delayed sensor. "And only because this instrument reports enough spare draw. Tower 15 no longer has it. Three others lie in similar directions."

He closed the faulty branch by hand. Pressure climbed along the central loop. One water tray began to steam. Tovin reached past him and opened the shade

membrane before the safety pin released.

"Nine seconds," Tovin said. "On the real field, you get days. The principle remains discourteous."

Dael reset the rig. His suspended license prohibited him from issuing a live Choir command, yet no rule prevented him from making a tabletop leak in front of constitutional negotiators. He had decided to enjoy the distinction.

Senn cleared the inherited weights. "We have five requirements agreed in principle. No district crosses its climate floor. Burden draws only from discretionary surplus. Inherited categories become visible. Physical repairs enter the schedule rather than a maintenance annex. Orison's excess bloom retires in stages."

"Agreed by whom?" Fen asked.

"Everyone at this table has accepted at least four."

"That phrasing avoids my question."

"It records your position accurately."

Dael had watched them spend two hours on whether a principle could be accepted provisionally. Copper behaved better. It leaked, bent, hardened, and failed without reserving a procedural objection.

He moved the three darkward tiles into the district arc. Each gained a red line at its measured minimum. Then he placed transparent caps over all forty-one tiles. The caps represented protected floors. Weather above them could move. Weather below them could not enter negotiation.

"Start with low demand," he said.

The pumps turned. Senn entered the coming forecast. Mirror lamps sent pale circles across the model. Under floor protection, the old winter debit could not open. Excess heat backed into central water. Dael reduced ornamental bloom in Orison, shifted a glassworks heating cycle, delayed two canal-wash periods, and lowered an uncommitted rain preference from Caldrift. Each change released a fraction. Together they kept pressure below the warning line.

Fen's adviser checked the control slate. "You selected concessions manually."

"Yes."

"The planetary schedule contains thousands."

"The Almanac can rank them once policy defines what may move. Today we define the rule."

"What happens when ranked surplus does not close the balance?"

"Reserve action, voluntary calls, or delegate review. Hidden extraction no longer sits at the bottom as an automatic answer."

Hesh rotated their tile. "Show the floor during tower failure."

Dael disabled the Lorn Dusk branch. Cold demand shifted toward Eyr and Nacre Fold. Their caps stopped the transfer before either minimum broke. The rig then

drew small fractions from every tile with available surplus. Some gave light, others accepted colder water, deferred cloud seeding, or increased wind-risk tolerance within local limits.

On the board, no single concession looked heroic. That mattered. His twelve years of covert adjustments had taught the same lesson at an unlawful scale. Stability came from many margins, not from choosing a place that could not object.

"What do you call the call order?" Pell's clerk asked.

"Surplus cascade," said a central adviser.

Hesh's mouth tightened. "That sounds like water falling on whoever lives downhill."

"Distributed reserve ladder," Pera offered.

Tovin shook his head. "A ladder implies someone gets to the top."

Fen said, "Planetary continuity schedule."

"That could mean anything written inside this building," Senn replied.

Dael watched frost retreat from the protected tiles. The model did not promise equal winters. Eyr's geography still demanded longer cold. Orison still held more greenhouse stone, hospital storage, and flexible commercial light. Nacre Fold could not surrender medicine-transit windows merely because another district had surrendered ornamental bloom. The rule shared only what places could lose without crossing the line that made habitation possible.

"Shared winter protocol," he said.

The room stopped trying names.

Hesh looked at him. "Winter has been shared with us for years."

"Imposed on you," Dael said. "I am naming the rule that prevents one district from carrying the whole correction. If the phrase conceals that history, reject it."

They considered the protected tiles. "Keep it for the draft. The clauses must say what sharing permits."

Pera wrote the title at the top of a clean page.

Fen requested a definition. Senn began with legal structure, but Dael interrupted before the language hardened around abstraction.

"First rule," he said. "Every schedule loads the climate floors before any preference. Not after optimization. Not as a warning operators can override. The minimum enters as a fixed physical demand."

Ceryn asked, "Who certifies a floor change after population or infrastructure shifts?"

"Charter method, local data, independent audit."

"Frequency?"

“Each turn, with emergency review for material change.”

Hesh added, “Local reviewers receive the raw instruments, not a district summary.”

Pera entered it in the margin.

“Second rule,” Dael continued. “Only discretionary burden moves. The system publishes what each district holds above floor by service class. No undifferentiated surplus total. A clinic reserve cannot hide beside commercial blossom and become tradeable by arithmetic.”

Fen objected to publishing exact hospital reserves. Ceryn agreed on security grounds. Senn proposed bands, methods, and sealed figures available to authorized auditors. Hesh demanded those auditors include the affected districts. The clerk opened a bracket around the whole clause.

Dael let them argue while he changed the rig's service classes. Red caps protected hospital heat, staple-crop survival, civic water, shelter warmth, and minimum school light. Amber rings marked preferences that could move under defined conditions. Green rings showed voluntarily offered shares. The colors turned the negotiating table into a shallow, uneven city.

“Third rule,” he said when the bracketed language stopped growing. “Every inherited category appears in the public policy register with originating authority, last human review, and current measured contradiction. No label continues merely because the next schedule copies the last.”

Ceryn read the proposed trigger. “Measured contradiction requires a threshold. One domestic heater in an industrial tract cannot open constitutional review.”

“Continuous civic heat, an address ledger, or local births and burials already supply the habitation test,” Senn said. “Any one should open review. The full test decides status.”

Fen wanted two indicators. Hesh refused. “Lorn Dusk had all three and still disappeared. Do not design the next silence around a community that can preserve only one record.”

The two-indicator proposal remained bracketed, marked disputed.

Tovin crouched beside the radiator loops. “You have policy, but the model still assumes metal we do not possess.”

Dael handed him the probe. “Fourth rule.”

They opened the repair schedule. Tower 15 needed a bearing cradle and two coolant seals. Tower 14 required return-pipe reinforcement where cyclic cold had embrittled a weld. Eyr's tower 11 needed ceramic vane replacement across the south bank. The Nacre branch relied on a control manifold whose slow sensor could conceal pressure rise for six minutes.

“Four towers,” Dael said. “Urgent work enters the correction schedule as capacity restoration, not optional maintenance. Until each repair clears load test,

the allocation uses degraded capacity.”

A central adviser asked what that cost.

“Crew hours, ceramic vanes, two crop-alloy shipments, one mirror window for inspection, and reduced radiator draw during each shutdown.”

“Which districts surrender the inspection light?”

“Determine it through discretionary ranking. Do not preassign the answer darkward.”

Tovin placed a black marker beside reserve shade-kite 6 on the board. Its fabric fault had been repaired after the shear deployment, though the kite remained outside ordinary fleet assumptions. “List reserve 6 as transitional storm protection, not permanent capacity. If you make one emergency flight carry a constitutional promise, someone will eventually fly torn cloth.”

The clerk recorded a use limit and mandatory inspection interval.

By evening, condensation covered the room's lower windows. Dael flexed his burned fingers beside a warm pipe. The rig had run thirty-seven scenarios. Nine failed floors because an operator had loaded preferences before minimums. Six exceeded wind limits when tower degradation entered late. Four required reserve action. Eighteen closed through distributed discretionary cuts.

One failure deserved more than a mark in the reject pile. A simulated ice fracture took tower 14 offline while a high-light shear front prevented reserve 6 from opening to its full span. The automatic ranking exhausted commercial bloom, flexible furnace heat, and rain preferences. It still lacked enough darkward draw to hold the central wind edge.

Fen pointed to Lorn Dusk's workshop margin. “That tile remains above floor.”

“By a narrow amount,” Dael said. “It can surrender part.”

Hesh moved the workshop ring down one increment. The pressure gauge eased but stayed amber.

Eyr offered ceramic-kiln heat in the model. Nacre Fold had no further safe light above medicine transit and shelter demand. Orison's protected seed-start block held a large reserve under its current classification.

Senn opened the block. “Half these trays grow export flowers under a municipal seed license.”

Fen's adviser objected. “The trays share heat loops with staple starts. Operators cannot separate them during the current turn.”

Tovin bent over the water tray and followed its tubing. “Not at the distribution header. They can isolate two greenhouse rows at the local manifolds.”

“Those manifolds do not report to the Conservatory.”

“Then the schedule needs a verified local action, not a fictional indivisible block.”

Dael replaced the single seed tile with three smaller pieces. Staple starts kept their cap. Hospital cultivars retained theirs. Export flowers entered discretionary ranking. The new concession closed half the remaining gap.

Ceryn asked the room to find the rest without touching a floor. Nobody answered quickly. The rig's pump clicked against the amber pressure. In live control, that sound would have come from styluses, alarms, and operators waiting for authority while wind continued moving.

Pera reviewed district offers from the prior emergency. "Three canal cities authorized wash-water delay during the early winter pulse. Their permission expired, but the equipment path still exists."

"Permission cannot be assumed," Hesh said.

"Then issue a call with the exact quantity."

The clerk wrote a simulated public request. Two canal districts accepted delay in the exercise. A third refused because its water stores stood below preferred range. Their combined offer left a small deficit.

Dael reduced Lorn Dusk's workshop ring again and stopped before the red cap. "No more there."

Fen studied Orison's school extensions. "Move one evening block."

"Which block?" Senn asked.

"Any one that closes the balance."

"That answer recreates an aggregate. Name the service."

The Orison adviser selected adult greenhouse training scheduled during the extended bloom evening. Moving it into rain turn released the final fraction. The pressure needle dropped from amber to green.

Hesh looked around the table. "That took twelve people, local plumbing knowledge, consent calls, and service-level records the current system does not keep together."

"Which means the operating rules need time limits for escalation," Dael said. "Automation ranks the clear concessions. Local operators verify separations. Public calls gather voluntary shares. If the gap remains, human authority meets before the forecast closes."

Ceryn added response windows measured against atmospheric lead time. A slow crop adjustment allowed two days. A developing shear front might allow hours. Nothing permitted silence to convert into consent.

The exercise left wet fingerprints on every district tile. It also established why shortfall procedure could not live in an annex. Hard forecasts would test the constitutional rule precisely when secrecy looked most efficient.

Fen reviewed the failures. "Your success rate does not support adoption."

"It supports writing the order correctly."

"You cannot legislate weather into compliance."

"No. We can stop authorizing the runs that purchase compliance from a hidden district."

Senn moved the failed sheets into a separate pile. "The protocol needs a shortfall procedure. A failed run becomes public. The Conservatory issues a voluntary call, applies valid reserves, and reconvenes authorized reviewers. It cannot solve the gap by lowering an unrepresented floor."

"Who bears service interruption while review occurs?" Fen asked.

"Preferences pause in reverse priority," Dael said. "Commercial and ornamental schedules first. Flexible industrial cycles next. Protected services continue. If those cuts remain insufficient, emergency allocation comes back to human authority."

Ceryn examined the wording. "Publish the uncertainty range with the call. Otherwise districts will either surrender too much from fear or withhold because they distrust the number."

Pera added uncertainty, source instruments, and update intervals.

The fifth rule concerned Orison. Its eleven extra bloom days could not vanish without throwing hospital gardens, seed starts, schools, and commercial greenhouses into the same bucket the group had spent all day separating. Senn divided the benefit by service. Protected functions retained enough light to stay above floor. Commercial blossom lost first. Decorative terraces followed. Flexible school extensions moved to rain-turn hours. Hospitals kept targeted exceptions subject to audit.

Dael entered retirement across two turns. The first removed six excess days from the general bloom block while preserving named protected exceptions. The second removed the remaining five. No darkward winter debit would finance the transition. Temporary balance came from distributed surplus, reserve action, and restored tower capacity.

Fen read the schedule twice. "Orison's growers cannot replant a greenhouse economy in two turns."

"They can change crop timing in two turns," said Ceryn. "Contracts and municipal supports require separate work. Climate law cannot guarantee every business model built on concealed allocation."

The room noticed her use of concealed. She did not retract it.

Fen's strongest objection came from uncertainty. If a fungal flare or shear front struck during retirement, emergency need could consume all discretionary room. He wanted authority to suspend the second-stage removal.

Hesh wanted any suspension to require consent from communities carrying added winter risk.

Dael reran the worst forecast with the second stage delayed. Orison kept five days longer. No district crossed floor if all preference cuts took effect. Yet

operators could preserve central comfort by classifying more functions as protected. The danger had moved from hidden geography into service definitions.

"Every exception needs a named service, measured floor effect, duration, and review date," Senn said. "No general urban continuity field."

Ceryn added, "No inheritance beyond one turn without delegate authorization."

Pell's clerk drew a box around the language.

Near midnight, they transferred the operational rules from wet pages to a formal draft. Dael read each clause against the rig before allowing it forward. Load every climate floor first. Rank only published discretionary shares. Expose inherited categories and contradictions. Repair degraded capacity under public milestones. Retire Orison's eleven extra days over two turns. Use reserve 6 only within inspected limits. Publish failed schedules and send true shortfalls back to human decision.

The protocol ran again under the room's hard white lamps. Before Senn started it, Dael tightened the wet return collar and marked its delayed sensor for replacement in the public repair annex.

This time, Senn let the Almanac rank concessions under the new order. The lamps dimmed unevenly. Orison's commercial terraces lost the largest share. Caldrift accepted a narrower rain preference. Two glass districts moved furnace cycles. Lorn Dusk surrendered a small workshop-light margin above its newly loaded floor. Hesh watched that tile closely and did not object. Sharing included the right to contribute after protection, not compulsory innocence.

Pressure steadied below the warning line. Tower repairs reduced the burden in later runs. By the second modeled turn, Orison's extra bloom block had retired and no gray sector remained available as a sink.

Fen signed the technical draft as reviewed, not accepted. Ceryn signed for administrative feasibility with six reservations. Tovin signed the reserve and repair annex. Senn signed the floor method.

Dael had no valid license with which to sign an engineering certification. He wrote his name under WITNESS TO MODEL CONSTRUCTION. The demotion hurt less on paper than it had in the service ring.

Pera slid the main draft toward Hesh. "Negotiating representative."

Hesh read without haste. They checked the floor-loading order, the four towers, the two-turn bloom schedule, and the shortfall publication clause. Their finger stopped at the audit section, where local reviewers received reports but central offices retained credential authority.

"This mechanism can work," they said. "Provisionally, Lorn Dusk can accept it."

Fen exhaled through his nose. The clerk reached for the draft.

Hesh kept their hand on the page. "No. Not yet. It needs enforcement language and equal audit power."

Chapter 23 — Lorn Dusk Speaks

Hesh set the address ledger on the hearing rail and loosened the two straps that had kept it closed from Lorn Dusk to Orison.

The book opened with a wooden sound. Its spine had been repaired four times, first with tower canvas, then with greenhouse cord, then with a strip of coolant hose cut thin enough to fold. Bound pages spread beneath the chamber lamps. Blue thermal ink had browned along the handled edges. Chalk dust remained in the gutter despite Nima's attempt to brush it clean before the journey.

Forty-one delegates looked down from their desks. Behind Hesh, the public galleries held central growers, Conservatory workers, darkward observers, reporters, and families who had watched the hearing through delayed projection until seats opened. The Eyr observer now sat at the negotiating table. Nacre Fold had sent a clinic administrator with three boxes of local records. Neither held a delegate lamp.

Oren Pell leaned toward Hesh. "State your name and authority for the record."

"Hesh Dara. Elected keeper of Lorn Dusk's addresses, heating failures, births, burials, and promised light."

"Do you speak for the settlement?"

"I carry authority to present our habitation claim and negotiate correction terms. I do not carry authority to surrender standing."

Rul Fen shifted a page at counsel's table. Hesh heard it because the chamber had narrowed around the book.

Pell said, "Proceed."

Hesh turned to the first marked leaf. "The Charter asks three things. Continuous civic heat. An address ledger. Births or burials recorded locally. Counsel has spent nine days discussing whether the test can apply to a place called a service precinct. I will show that Lorn Dusk met every condition before several people in this room took their current offices."

They placed a transparent strip over the page so the wall camera could read without touching the ink. The earliest surviving entries came from Year 45 AC, one year after Order 9. Construction bunks still carried numbers instead of street names. Beside bunk 6, a mechanic had recorded the birth of Tera Voss during a radiator shutdown. Beside bunk 19, a heater transfer moved from an empty crew bay to a household with two infants.

"The founding order described temporary crews," Hesh said. "Temporary crews do not usually assign a child's address before assigning her a middle name."

A few people in the gallery laughed, then stopped when the next line appeared.

Tera Voss, age eight months, respiratory fever, buried locally.

Hesh did not turn toward the gallery. "The burial ground began that winter. It

remains in use.”

Fen requested the speaking lamp. “No party disputes that families later occupied the precinct. The legal question concerns recognized civic administration.”

“This book records administration.”

“It records local practice.”

“The Charter does not require a marble office. It requires addresses.”

Fen opened his copy of the statute. “Maintains an address ledger under civic authority.”

Hesh had expected the emphasis. They lifted a narrow packet from the book's back cover. Every third year, Lorn Dusk elected a keeper by marked heater token. The precinct supervisor witnessed early selections because central law barred residents from forming a district council. Later elections used the communal stove register and signatures from every heat-wall block.

“Civic authority can grow where central authority refuses it,” Hesh said. “We assigned water duty, fire response, shelter access, heater priority, school rooms, and burial ground. The Conservatory accepted our load reports whenever it needed radiator work. It rejected the same organization when we asked for weather standing.”

A delegate from the northern mills asked whether the elections had ever received Conservatory certification.

“No.”

“Then how do we verify the records beyond your own custody?”

Hesh turned three pages. “Tower shift books list each keeper as the local contact. Clinic medicine receipts carry the same names. Central maintenance messages address my predecessor as precinct civic coordinator when they need workers moved. Pera Iven authenticated the paper, ink, and transmission seals. You may distrust our title. Your own offices relied on it.”

Pera sat behind the archive table, hands folded over a stack of certifications. She gave no sign beyond lifting the top sheet for the clerk.

Hesh moved to the heat record. Continuous civic heat did not look continuous on paper. It looked like a fight against interruption. Every shared wall had a daily line for intake, loss, repair, and occupied rooms. Tower vibration loosened mortar. Failed light windows froze condensation inside pipes. Families moved between blocks when radiator draw sharpened winter.

They showed a five-year span without a missing day.

“Service equipment did not require this distribution,” Hesh said. “People did. The wall sent heat first to the clinic, then infant rooms, then the school shelter, then households by interior temperature. Workshops accepted the remaining share. When supply fell, the keeper recorded who moved and who stayed.”

Fen asked, "Did the system ever fall below what you now claim as a climate floor?"

"Often."

"Then continuous civic heat may not have been sustained under the Charter definition."

Hesh looked at him. "A recognized district does not lose standing when a storm breaks a heater. It receives emergency protection because people live there. You propose that our injuries prove our absence."

The words reached the chamber without force. Fen lowered his eyes to the statute.

Hesh opened the birth and burial index. Nima had helped prepare it, but she had refused to condense the names into a total for this testimony. A total already existed elsewhere in the public record. Today the names needed to perform a different task. They established continuity across generations.

"Ilven Dara," Hesh read. "Born in bunk row 4. Later assigned 4 Cooling Lane when residents named the roads. Died at tower 15, bearing accident, age thirty-two. Mara Olt, born in the clinic annex, became a school mechanic. Still living. Oth Pell, no relation to the chair, arrived as a six-month contract worker and remained forty years. Buried under the east heat wall because the ground beyond it could not be cut during winter."

Pell's expression did not change at the shared surname.

Name after name crossed the wall with an address, a duration, and an event no equipment register could contain. Hesh did not read all 8,140 current residents. Across Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold, the evidence covered 18,420 people: 8,140 here, 6,030 in Eyr, and 4,250 in Nacre Fold. They read enough to show streets replacing bunks, apprentices replacing founders, children inheriting repaired rooms, and dead people remaining part of local geography.

A delegate from Orison asked to compare one household against central records. The clerk selected Mara Olt without warning. Pera opened Conservatory archives on a second panel. A tower requisition listed Mara at age fourteen as a dependent receiving shared-wall heat. An apprenticeship transfer listed her at seventeen. A maintenance injury report named her as the mechanic responsible for school ventilation. Three systems had tracked one life while the district register carried none of it.

"Could those records belong to different people?" the delegate asked.

Hesh supplied Mara's local address changes. Bunk annex 3 became 8 Vane Street after residents named the road. She later moved to the school block, then into her mother's room after the older woman lost mobility. Every date aligned with central heater demand and work assignments.

Pera overlaid the records. "Instrument and paper continuity support one

individual.”

The delegate chose a second name, Oth Pell. His six-month contract appeared in Year 46. Central personnel files ended at contract expiry. The local book continued through his partnership registration, two children, tower retirement, stove duty, and burial. Heater telemetry followed his household across thirty-nine years but never restored his name to the civic index.

“Central records did not know he stayed,” Fen said.

“Central weather records knew his room consumed heat every day,” Hesh replied. “The office knew enough to charge the load. It chose not to ask who required it.”

Pell allowed a third comparison. This time Hesh chose Ressa. Her birth appeared locally. School-cycle demand, clinic vaccinations, and shelter occupancy appeared centrally under equipment service. The public schedule that missed her promised dawn carried no field where her name could have entered.

Three lives made the administrative split visible: a worker followed while useful, an elder counted only through heat, and a child translated into infrastructure from birth.

The western reservoir delegate asked, “Why did Lorn Dusk retain these records when the central register refused them?”

“So a heater crew could find people in darkness. So medicine could arrive. So families could prove who belonged to a room after evacuation. So the dead did not vanish when a supervisor's contract ended.”

“Did you maintain them for a future standing case?”

“My predecessors expected review after five years. Then after the first renewal. Then after the second. Hope becomes a filing practice if denied long enough.”

Hesh disliked the sentence as soon as it left them. It sounded prepared, though it had not been. They put both hands on the ledger until its rough cover corrected their balance.

Senn watched from the technical table, still enough to avoid turning witness into encouragement. Dael sat beside her under the hearing permission that allowed technical attendance despite his suspended license. His damaged fingers rested near the protocol model, not touching its controls.

Pell admitted the ledger packet as habitation evidence. Fen reserved objections to retrospective effect. Three delegates requested copies of the keeper election records. The clerk marked the requests and moved to remedy questions.

A central canal representative spoke first. “If this body recognizes continuous habitation, what compensation does Lorn Dusk seek?”

Hesh closed the book halfway. “Standing.”

“That concerns status. I asked about remedy for past injury.”

"Status determines who sits in the room when remedy gets divided."

"Compensation could begin before delegate certification. Heating grants, clinic support, tower investment, household payments."

"Money sent to a precinct still calls us a precinct."

The representative frowned. "Surely material repair matters more than terminology."

"Then give us authority over the repair and see whether terminology still looks small."

Hesh had watched central offices use compensation in two ways. Sometimes it returned what could be returned. More often it purchased an ending. A payment form named a completed incident, a recipient, and a release. Weather harm did not end when the form closed. The next winter schedule still needed someone empowered to challenge its categories.

They opened the ledger to the page where the early winter pulse had turned the coolant-cistern theater into a warm shelter. Names filled two columns beside borrowed heat bricks and clinic checks.

"Lorn Dusk will accept repair funds," Hesh said. "We will accept clinic heat, tower parts, burial support, and payments owed to households. We will not accept any package that leaves standing undecided or assigns a central office sole control over distribution. Compensation without standing converts us from residents into claimants. Claimants can be paid and dismissed."

Fen said, "Full standing also creates obligations. Audit costs. Surplus declarations. Emergency concessions. Participation in planetary shortfall."

"Yes."

"You do not seek exemption from shared burden?"

"No. We seek protection of the same floor and authority under the same rules."

A glass-district delegate turned on her lamp. "Your negotiating draft permits Lorn Dusk to surrender workshop light above floor. Some residents may ask why a harmed community should contribute at all."

"They have asked."

"What did you answer?"

"That standing does not mean weather becomes free. It means nobody can take our minimum by naming us equipment. Above that minimum, we live on the same planet as everyone else."

The gallery behind Hesh shifted. Not every darkward observer accepted the answer. An Eyr mechanic folded his arms. The Nacre administrator watched the protocol pages rather than Hesh.

Pell invited questions on staging. This portion carried greater danger than Fen's objections because it divided the settlements themselves. Some Lorn Dusk

heat-wall blocks wanted immediate cancellation of every winter debit, regardless of central consequences. They had buried people while Orison's apricots opened early. Asking them to wait through two turns sounded like another official version of later.

Hesh lifted the authority packet from the ledger. "My mandate permits staged correction under four conditions. Floors take effect immediately. The inherited debit loses automatic authority. Every transitional burden appears publicly. Affected communities participate in enforcement."

Fen said, "Why accept staging at all?"

"Because Dael Orro showed what immediate cancellation would do."

Dael lowered his gaze to the tabletop.

"Nine days to dangerous central heat," Hesh continued. "A sharpened shear field over Orison. Hospital and crop systems built around light they should never have received in this quantity, but people now depend on them. If we demand a switch and another district becomes the place where unmanaged harm lands, we have learned only how to move the sink."

The phrase entered Hesh's mouth from twelve years of maintenance notes and one wet negotiating table. They said it more plainly.

"No new sink."

The clerk wrote the words on the remedy board.

A Lorn Dusk voice called from the upper gallery. "What about the old one?"

Pell's hand moved toward order, but Hesh turned first. Ressa stood beside Nima at the rail, older now than the child who had waited by a chalk mark, young enough that anger still lifted her onto her toes.

"The old sink receives a floor, repairs, standing, and a record that cannot be hidden," Hesh said. "It does not receive permission to choose another."

"Two turns still means more winter."

"Yes."

"Whose promise pays for that?"

"Every district's discretionary share, including ours where we have one. Orison retires the eleven added days. The towers regain capacity. If the plan asks Lorn Dusk to cross floor, we stop it."

"Who stops it?"

That question reached the unfinished part of the protocol. Hesh turned back to the delegates.

"Under the current draft, central auditors certify floor calculations and publish reports. Local reviewers may comment. Comment cannot stop a mirror."

Ceryn requested the lamp. "Operational authority cannot fragment across forty-one local vetoes during a live event."

"Neither can it remain whole inside the office that continued Order 9."

"I did not propose that it should."

"You proposed credentialed local access under central standards."

"Because raw control access carries planetary risk."

Hesh rested a finger on the early winter shelter page. "We are discussing audit power, not mirror command. If a schedule varies a climate floor, local auditors must see the raw inputs, challenge the calculation, and withhold consent before authorization."

Fen stood. "That creates a veto over planetary allocation."

"It creates a prohibition against taking a non-tradeable minimum."

"Emergency forecasts may not permit consent from every affected district."

"Then write an emergency rule narrow enough to prove its need afterward."

Senn switched on her lamp. "A climate floor cannot be varied as ordinary allocation. If catastrophe requires a temporary breach to prevent greater loss, the action needs recorded necessity, equal notice, time limit, and automatic review. The affected district must retain authority to challenge continuation."

Hesh heard the word temporary and thought of Order 9. "No inheritance."

Pera said from the archive table, "The system can block renewal unless local consent is attached."

Ceryn considered that. "For a planned variance, yes. For emergency action, local consent may be impossible before execution. Continuation beyond the immediate safety interval could require it."

"How long?" asked Pell.

Dael answered. "Tie the interval to the physical event. A shear intervention might require hours. A tower fracture might require days. Set an absolute ceiling and demand a named engineering basis for anything shorter."

Tovin, seated in the technical row, added, "Require two independent operators to certify the event. Not two signatures from one reporting line."

The chamber began building language around the question Ressa had asked. Central counsel wanted "consultation where practicable." Hesh struck it out. Ceryn proposed "concurrence for planned action." Senn separated floor measurement from preference allocation so consent could not become a bargaining tool for ordinary surplus. Pell's clerk numbered exceptions and refused a catchall category.

By late afternoon, the address ledger had moved from evidence rail to the drafting table. Hesh resented the risk to its binding and accepted the necessity. Names occupied the left side. Clause language grew on the right. Every time a delegate proposed flexibility, Hesh asked which recorded person could be made colder under it. Every time a darkward observer demanded absolute local control, Dael asked what happened to the wind field outside district borders.

The answer did not become simple. It became bounded.

Planned schedules could not cross any climate floor without documented local consent from every affected district. Consent required raw data, an independent technical review, a stated duration, and no penalty to later allocations. Emergency action could proceed only to prevent an imminent greater floor breach. It required two independent operational certifications, immediate notice, public inputs, and expiration at the physical limit or the fixed legal ceiling, whichever came first. Any continuation required local approval.

Equal audit credentials would issue to settlement reviewers under planetary safety rules written openly and applied to central staff as well. The Conservatory could revoke access for demonstrated misuse, not for disagreement, and Pell's review panel could restore it.

Fen read the draft. "No central city will accept unrestricted local obstruction."

Hesh pointed to the emergency section. "Then they should read the restrictions already here."

Ceryn traced the renewal block with one nail. "The no-inheritance provision needs a mechanical lock."

Pera described an authorization field that expired to blank rather than continuing until superseded. Senn asked for the blank to trigger public failure, not quiet reversion. Dael required the schedule to preserve the last lawful non-breaching state while people negotiated.

Hesh listened until each safeguard had an operator, a record, and a consequence. They had spent years recording broken promises after the light failed to arrive. Enforcement had to act before chalk met plaster.

Pell placed a clean clause sheet beside the ledger. "Keeper Dara, you requested this language. Draft the operative sentence."

Hesh took the clerk's stylus. Its metal barrel felt too light compared with the thick pencil used at the heat wall. They looked once at Ressa in the gallery, then at the names spread beneath the lamp.

On the clause sheet, Hesh wrote: NO PLANNED CLIMATE-FLOOR VARIANCE MAY ENTER A PLANETARY SCHEDULE WITHOUT THE INFORMED LOCAL CONSENT OF EVERY AFFECTED DISTRICT.

Chapter 24 — The Price of Orison's Spring

Senn dragged Lorn Dusk out of the gray with two fingers and the Season Table refused to let it go.

The district band brightened for half a breath, a narrow amber strip between radiator duty and darkward heat loss. Then the table's inherited classification

pulled it back to infrastructure gray. Eyr and Nacre Fold followed the same pattern. Their households appeared as load points, their clinics as reserve demand, their schools as timed consumption, but the display would not hold them in the inhabited ring.

“Again,” Hesh said from the negotiating seat.

Senn reset the rendering layer. Around the circular instrument, forty-one delegate positions remained dark while the budget group worked. Rul Fen stood across from her with his sleeves rolled to his elbows and a stack of hospital schedules arranged by district. Ceryn watched from the First Curator's station without touching its controls. Pera sat beside the policy archive port, one hand on the temporary authorization that allowed the category change to run before the vote.

Dael's operational model occupied the table's inner circle. It carried the shared winter protocol in six linked constraints: every climate floor protected, discretionary burden distributed, inherited categories visible, four tower repairs funded, Orison's eleven extra days retired across two turns, local variances subject to consent. The rules fit neatly until the Almanac received three inhabited districts where policy had promised equipment.

“Your temporary authorization names recognized claimants,” Rul said. “It does not rewrite the district map.”

“It authorizes a remedy budget,” Senn replied. “A remedy budget cannot treat the claimants as machinery.”

“Legal standing remains before the delegates tomorrow.”

“Hesh's enforcement clause already passed drafting review. Today we establish whether the correction can survive its own law.”

Rul tapped Orison's band. “Today we establish whether seven central cities can keep hospitals open while you improve the colors.”

The remark drew no response from Hesh. They had placed the Lorn Dusk address ledger on the table beside their seat, bound cover toward the central counsel. Senn recognized the posture from the first nights in the address hall. Hesh let an inaccurate sentence remain visible long enough for its speaker to feel obliged to examine it.

Pera slid the temporary authorization into the policy port. Blue light traveled around its embossed seal. “Try the habitation test directly. Continuous civic heat, local addresses, births or burials. Do not ask the inherited map what they are.”

Senn opened the raw district layer and assigned each criterion to primary records. Lorn Dusk drew heat from walls shared by 8,140 residents. Its address ledger supplied occupied dwellings. Burial entries extended past the founding of Order 9. Eyr resolved around tower 11 with 6,030 residents, apprenticeship heat schedules, births, and ceramic works. Nacre Fold curved through the lava tube in shell-lime segments that held 4,250 people and the clinic records Nima had

authenticated.

The table tested all three against the Charter. Amber entered the gray bands again.

This time Senn severed the inheritance field before it could answer.

Lorn Dusk held. Eyr brightened beside it. Nacre Fold formed the narrowest inhabited band, pale amber against the black outer edge. Eighteen thousand four hundred twenty residents entered the visible budget without altering a single instrument reading. The planet had not gained heat. Only the account had gained recipients.

Hesh leaned forward. Their fingertip hovered above Lorn Dusk without crossing the light. "Keep the radiator load visible."

"It makes the band difficult to read," said one Orison schedule officer.

"It makes the district accurate."

Senn expanded the band until domestic heat, clinic reserves, school cycles, and radiator service appeared as separate threads. She did the same for Eyr and Nacre Fold. The table grew crowded. Clean civic bands fractured into workshops, greenhouses, pipes, heat walls, towers, and homes. Orison's own amber widened into hundreds of dependencies that had previously condensed into bloom.

"Now apply the retirement," Ceryn said.

Her voice carried the calm of an ordinary scheduling instruction. Seventeen years earlier she had used that calm to sign a renewal beneath an acknowledgement of permanent households. Senn no longer mistook control for innocence, but she still trusted Ceryn to recognize a dangerous model before anyone else in the room.

The first reduction removed five bloom days from Orison's coming turn. A second removed six from the following one. Green light contracted along the city's greenhouse terraces. Hospital reservoirs turned yellow. Three seed-start networks followed. School-hour extensions dimmed but remained above their floor. Decorative canal warming vanished. Commercial flower terraces lost their late shift. Public forecast panels shed eleven days of the spring citizens had learned to regard as ordinary.

Rul opened his hospital schedules. "Reverse district twelve."

"On what basis?" Senn asked.

"Sterilization demand and neonatal heat."

"Those belong in protected need, not inherited bloom."

"They share the same reservoir."

Senn isolated the reservoir. Its water served a municipal hospital, two private clinics, a bathhouse, and a commercial nursery whose night lamps kept ornamental vines in continuous color. The old schedule had hidden all four behind

medical continuity.

"Separate the draw," she said.

The schedule officer shook his head. "The pipe does not separate it."

"Then the account must."

Rul passed across a maintenance diagram. The reservoir left through one insulated main before branching beneath the terrace. Meters existed at the hospital and clinics, none at the bathhouse or nursery. Without branch measurements, the Almanac treated the strongest policy category as the purpose of the entire draw.

Hesh looked at the diagram. "How long to fit meters?"

"Six days if we take crews from canal work," the officer said.

"Then give the hospital its measured minimum and place the unmeasured remainder in review."

Rul's mouth tightened. "You would risk a neonatal ward on a category dispute."

"No," Hesh said. "I would stop a vine merchant from standing behind an infant."

Senn entered a temporary hospital exception at the highest recorded medical draw plus a cold-margin allowance. The clinics received the same treatment. Remaining reservoir use shifted into discretionary review until meters could distinguish it. Orison recovered a fraction of one bloom day, enough to preserve sterilization cycles without restoring the nursery's commercial night.

The next conflict came from seed starts.

Caldrift's modest preference sat outside Orison's account, but five central seed banks supplied staple transplants across the ribbon. Their germination rooms depended on staged soil warmth before public bloom. Rul had brought crop-failure projections for each delay. Some measured staples. Others quietly included early fruit, specialty leaves, and export flowers under the same seed-start heading.

Senn called up the plant registry. "Name what fails if the room cools by two degrees."

A grower representative at the side station began with grain roots and storage tubers. Rul interrupted when she reached glass melons.

"Staples first," he said.

The representative gave him a startled look.

"You asked for the exception," Senn said.

"I intend to keep one." Rul moved the glass melons into commercial bloom. He transferred two aromatic leaf lines after them, then three varieties bred for color rather than yield. "My clients will call this confiscation."

"Your clients can call it weather accounting," Hesh said.

"They vote more reliably when angry."

Dry laughter traveled around the working stations. It did not soften the numbers. Staple seed-start heat required nearly a full day of Orison's surrendered light. Taking it from the darkward correction would push Nacre Fold against its soil-temperature floor during the first turn. Taking it from central rain protection raised shear risk. The model offered no harmless place.

Ceryn opened reserve assumptions. "The Conservatory retains authority over shade-kite 6 for emergency balancing."

"Tovin has already flown it past preferred strain," Senn said.

"He also certified nine controlled deployment hours before fabric replacement."

"Emergency authority cannot fund a routine exception."

Ceryn met her gaze. "Correct. It can protect the first seed cycle while Orison converts two decorative heat banks to staple use."

Rul studied the conversion map. One bank warmed the canal frontage during evening markets. Another fed the municipal color gardens beside the delegate hall. Their stored heat could move through service pipes to three seed rooms, though not without closing both public displays for a turn.

"The city promised those gardens for the Charter festival," an officer said.

"The city promised Lorn Dusk dawns," Hesh answered.

Ceryn entered the conversion. No defense of the festival followed. The garden bands went black. Seed-start demand held yellow for nine hours, then green once the converted banks came online. Reserve 6 remained available for storm control instead of becoming a concealed subsidy.

By midday the table showed Orison's loss district by district. The western terraces gave up late blossom heat. Canal wards accepted colder water and shorter evening markets. School schedules lost optional extensions but kept classroom warmth. Hospitals preserved sterilization and neonatal reserves. Staple seed rooms kept their first cycle. Commercial nurseries, decorative gardens, bathhouses, and festival bloom surrendered all priority claims.

The eleven days no longer looked like one indulgence. They appeared as thousands of habits built around a transfer no citizen had been invited to see. Some habits protected life. Some protected income. Others protected the appearance of a city where weather arrived without bargaining.

An officer from the public forecast bureau asked to test the budget against citizen schedules. She fed the revised bands into a wall display used on tram glass and water towers. Orison's familiar bloom ribbon shortened at once. Five days near the coming turn's end changed from green petals to white cloud marks. The second turn lost six more, including the festival interval.

"People will read that as failure," she said.

"Then label what changed," Senn replied.

"The public format has no field for unlawful inheritance."

Pera looked up from the archive port. "It has a field for cause."

"That field allows twenty-four characters."

"Try `recognized districts`."

Rul objected before the officer could type. "That tells Orison its spring vanished into a legal phrase. It does not say who keeps a clinic window or why the loss comes now."

Hesh opened one of the blank notice forms beside the address ledger. "Lorn Dusk notices name the window, duration, receiving place, and consent record. How many characters do you require for truth here?"

The officer flushed. "Our screens were built for citywide changes, not transfers between households."

"Districts," Senn said. "The transfer runs between districts."

They rebuilt the notice instead of shrinking the account. Each changed day opened to a second layer. Hospital and staple exceptions appeared by measured need. Decorative cancellation carried no emergency wording. Eyr's repair margin showed as pending because its bearing report had not yet arrived. Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold appeared by name on Orison's forecast for the first time, not as destinations for charity but as districts whose protected minimum constrained the schedule.

The bureau officer sent the draft to a tram-glass test pane. A narrow panel rose beside the table. On it, Orison's altered spring looked less beautiful than the old public ribbon. White intervals interrupted the green. Cold-water advisories appeared beneath two canal wards. Market hours shifted. A worker tapping the panel could trace every change to an instrument, a policy rule, and a receiving district.

"Will Lorn Dusk see the same notice?" Rul asked.

"No," Hesh said. "We will see our own weather."

The distinction mattered. Equal standing did not require identical forecasts or a central city's explanation pasted over every local window. Senn asked the officer to open the darkward view. Lorn Dusk's screen showed a longer dawn allocation, radiator repair risk, and the local consent condition for any variance. Eyr's displayed tower service. Nacre Fold's carried clinic soil heat and a narrow caution margin.

Ceryn compared all four panes. "Publish source layers with the schedules. If the numbers change, the notices must change in the same release."

"Public source layers will generate disputes over every forecast," the officer said.

"They should," Ceryn replied. "Forecasts allocate consequences."

Senn heard no apology in the instruction. Ceryn rarely offered one when a procedure could carry more than remorse. Yet the source-layer order stripped

away one of the protections her office had relied on: the delay between an internal category and the weather citizens believed they received.

The test exposed another disguised exception. Orison's north tram ward claimed continuous heat for worker safety through both removed turns. Passenger counts supported only morning and evening service. Midday heat fed shopfront stone, keeping the arcade warm enough for open stalls. The forecast had called all of it transit continuity.

Rul questioned the ward officer until the commercial hours separated from the platform minimum. Senn preserved rail-switch warming, sheltered waiting rooms, and the two peak intervals. The arcade's midday comfort moved into discretionary loss. Vendors would need insulated stalls or shorter hours. The municipal adaptation fund had enough material credit for both, provided procurement began before the next turn.

"Put the credit beside the cancellation," Rul said. "A visible cost without a visible response becomes punishment theater."

Senn added the adaptation line. The revised notice remained unpleasant. It also became usable.

After the forecast test, Rul worked through the remaining bands without ceremony. He won a dialysis reservoir after proving its heat exchanger lacked cold tolerance. He lost a heated tram arcade when Senn found its safety claim counted retail comfort twice. He kept two school greenhouse windows for meal crops and conceded the flowering courtyards attached to them. At each station he demanded the unit, the instrument, and the consequence.

Senn respected him more for the concessions than she had for his strongest objections. Opposition could serve the remedy if it forced every exception into view. The old debit had survived because no one needed to choose its victims aloud.

At the sixth hour, Eyr's band flashed red.

Dael's model had assumed tower 11 could accept a stepped repair shutdown during the second turn. The maintenance record now carried an updated bearing temperature, four degrees above the previous projection. Red spread from tower service into Eyr's domestic heat margin. The inhabited color did not vanish, but its lower edge crossed the climate floor.

"Stop the run," Senn said.

The schedule officer froze all transfers.

Rul rubbed both palms over his face. "How much?"

"Point three of a bloom day in the first turn," Senn said. "More if the bearing worsens."

"Take it from Orison's hospital margin and you lose what we settled."

"We are not taking protected need."

Hesh enlarged Eyr's maintenance thread. "The repair crew needs heat during shutdown. Can Nacre Fold shift radiator service?"

"Not without moving coolant through an untested cross-line," Ceryn said.

Senn searched discretionary bands. Six central cities still carried small weather surpluses, but this session had authority only to price Orison's retirement. Borrowing from them before the amendment would create another obligation without consent.

A thin blue segment remained inside Orison's second turn: cloud-brightening for commercial vine yards. Removing it would not produce direct heat at Eyr, but it would lower Orison's cooling demand enough to release radiator capacity.

Rul saw the path at the same time. "Those yards employ nine hundred people."

"Employment does not make cloud preference a floor," Senn said.

"It makes the consequence human."

"Yes."

The word stopped her own impulse to simplify. Nine hundred workers could not become an acceptable abstraction merely because Orison had benefited from an unlawful transfer. Senn opened the labor heat schedule. Vine work could continue under ordinary light, but yields would fall and one processing shift would close. The city had a crop-variance fund built from twenty-two years of stable bloom receipts. Its balance could cover wages during conversion to hardier vines.

Rul read the fund line. "The treasury will object that weather relief cannot finance labor replacement."

"Then the treasury may explain why its definition of relief protects vines but not workers."

He considered this, then signed the concession. "Record my objection to the conversion timetable."

"Recorded."

Orison's cloud preference disappeared. Eyr rose three tenths above its threshold. Senn added a repair contingency, reducing the city's second-turn decorative bloom by another fraction. The margin held when she ran hot-bearing and crew-delay branches.

Evening dimmed the old pressureworks windows from copper to brown. Varda never set, but Orison's mirror schedules withdrew light from the chamber glass. The Season Table carried its own glow upward into tired faces.

Only one unresolved line remained. Nacre Fold's clinic retained a soil-temperature margin narrow enough that an instrument error could breach it. The easiest repair would restore a portion of Orison's canal heating and use increased radiator duty elsewhere. No one proposed it.

Ceryn asked for the error range. Senn supplied the sensor tolerance, shell-lime

retention estimate, and worst recorded coolant draw. Pera found a duplicate category in the old account: Nacre Fold's clinic greenhouse had been counted once as medical reserve and again as equipment waste heat. Correcting the duplication did not create energy, but it revealed that the clinic required less assigned input than the model carried.

"Is the lower number authenticated?" Hesh asked.

Pera turned the source record toward them. "Three instruments and a paper service log."

Nacre Fold gained a margin of one tenth. Small, but real.

Senn released the frozen transfers one layer at a time. The inhabited bands held their color. Orison's eleven days remained absent across two turns. Hospitals stayed above protected need. Staple seeds warmed on schedule. Decoration and commercial bloom contracted into the city's actual discretionary share. Every red line cleared.

Rul signed the exception ledger last. "I still oppose implementation authority in its current form."

"You can oppose it with accurate costs now," Senn said.

"That may not help you."

"It is not meant to."

Hesh closed the address ledger. Across the table, Lorn Dusk glowed amber beside the load of its towers. No gray cover hid its workshops or homes. Eyr carried a repair contingency. Nacre Fold held its narrow margin. Orison showed shorter bloom, colder canals, protected wards, and dark festival gardens.

Senn pressed the budget seal.

The final account closed. Forty-one district bands settled around the Season Table, each with a visible floor beneath its trades. Orison's shortened bands flickered as delegates opened their objections for the vote.

Chapter 25 — Weather Standing

Oren Pell counted the occupied seats before he called the chamber to order.

He moved his finger around the circular register, stopping at each green acknowledgement. Forty-one delegates had answered. No proxy marks remained. No district had left its vote with a technical minister. Hesh sat at the negotiating position inside the ring, close enough to speak but still outside the delegate circle until the amendment decided whether Lorn Dusk belonged there.

The Season Table carried yesterday's budget beneath a transparent legal layer. Orison's eleven surrendered bloom days appeared as white interruptions. Lorn

Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold held amber color, but a gray hatch crossed each band to show provisional status. The table could calculate their climate floors. The Charter had not yet agreed to see them.

Senn stood at the audit station with the final source ledger open. She had slept for two hours on a records-room bench and still felt the embossed edge of an order seal against her cheek. Across from her, Rul Fen arranged three sheets and nothing else. His clients' hospital and seed-start exceptions had entered the budget. His opposition now concerned authority, not hidden dependency.

Ceryn took the First Curator's station without the blue office mantle. She wore a plain work coat fastened at the throat. The missing color drew more attention than ceremony would have.

Pell tapped the sounding strip. "The planetary delegates will consider the Weather Standing amendment and its attached staged implementation protocol. The register contains forty-one eligible votes. A simple majority carries the amendment. Debate has closed except for statements entered under the final-language rule."

One delegate raised a hand. "Point of order. The negotiating seat has contributed language but has no vote."

"Correct," Pell said.

"Then the affected districts may determine terms without accepting electoral consequence."

Hesh placed both palms on the closed address ledger. "We have accepted the weather consequence for thirty-one years."

Pell's gaze stayed on the delegate. "Do you maintain the point?"

The hand lowered.

Procedure moved forward. A clerk read the amendment's title, then each operative clause. Full weather standing would attach to the Charter's habitation test rather than an inherited administrative category. Every inhabited district would receive a non-fungible climate floor. Only discretionary surplus could enter trade. Emergency classifications would expire unless reviewed by named human authority. Published policy objectives would accompany public forecasts. The staged protocol would retire Orison's eleven inherited bloom days over two turns, repair four radiator towers, and distribute necessary cold burden according to discretionary weather surplus.

Local consent governed any proposed variance below a scheduled floor. Hesh had written that sentence in the margin of a central form. Pera had preserved the words through six drafting attempts that tried to turn consent into consultation.

The clerk finished. Forty-one vote plates remained dark.

Rul stood for his final statement. "The seven central cities recognize the habitation evidence. We do not dispute the addresses, births, burials, schools,

clinics, or continuous civic heat. We dispute combining recognition with implementation authority that may compel discretionary surrender before district councils complete their own adaptation plans.”

He passed his three sheets to the record clerk. “The budget protects hospitals and staple seed starts because this chamber permitted exact exceptions. Future schedules may not receive such care. My clients therefore oppose the attached authority while accepting the standing claim.”

Senn watched Hesh. They did not nod in gratitude for recognition separated from power. Rul had made the cleanest version of the argument that could still preserve inequality: name the districts now, delay their usable protection until every beneficiary felt ready.

Pell asked whether anyone sought to challenge a factual statement.

Senn activated her audit mark. “The district councils have adaptation plans in the source annex. Six requested additional review time. Fourteen completed review. The remaining councils filed no response. Lack of response cannot operate as a claim on another district's floor.”

Rul turned toward her. “And compelled implementation cannot substitute for consent.”

“No district consents to Charter limits after each forecast. The floor limits the schedule before trade begins.”

“Your distinction will comfort a council when its rain preference disappears.”

“It should not comfort them. It should tell them what they may contest without offering someone else's survival minimum as the remedy.”

Pell marked both statements entered.

A delegate from a reservoir district rose next. She supported standing and opposed the two-turn timetable. A darkward maintenance representative supported the repair authority but wanted tower workers exempt from shared cold. Two agricultural delegates asked whether seed failures during transition would restore retired bloom. The clerk cited the contingency rule: emergency reserve could protect measured staple need, but no failure could revive the old winter debit.

Each objection narrowed the amendment without stopping it. Senn had expected the final hour to feel like revelation. Instead it felt like reconciling a difficult ledger while everyone who disliked the result remained in the room.

Pell recognized Senn for the audit statement required by the Charter violation finding. She carried no prepared pages. The source ledger already held every number she intended to use.

“The question before the delegates contains two decisions,” she said. “One concerns who has standing. The other concerns how a correction proceeds without crossing any district's floor. Separating them in time would not make either

decision cleaner.”

She opened the habitation criteria over the table. Three columns appeared for each darkward district: continuous civic heat, local address record, births or burials. Every column carried authenticated sources.

“Lorn Dusk, Eyr, and Nacre Fold met these tests before Order 9. They met them through every renewal. Recognition does not begin their habitation today. It ends an administrative refusal to record it.”

A central delegate activated a question light. “If standing follows automatically from these records, why require a vote?”

“Because the inherited category blocked administrative correction. This chamber must remove that block and authorize the consequences. The people did not become optional while procedure caught up.”

Another delegate asked whether the three districts could claim restitution in weather shares for all prior winters. Senn kept the historical debit visible beside the remedy schedule.

“Weather already imposed cannot be returned. The record supports legal and material claims outside this schedule. It does not create spare lumen-hours in the current turn. This amendment protects present floors and governs future trade.”

“You offer no compensation here.”

“I offer no false compensation here.”

Hesh watched her without approval. They had rejected the early proposals that treated population as a fair burden and equal division as sufficient justice. Senn had learned not to search their face for permission while speaking about work they had already corrected.

She called up Caldriest's storm-loss file from eight years earlier. Names remained sealed, but payment dates, lease transfers, and district aggregates appeared. The old reconciliation had declared full compensation while twelve tenant growers lost their leases before funds arrived.

“I approved this account,” Senn said. “Every measured loss received a payment. The total closed. The timing left twelve households without the farms the payment was supposed to preserve.”

Rul looked from the old file to Orison's weather budget. “What relevance do you assign to a delayed crop settlement?”

“A right that arrives after its use has passed does not protect the holder. If this chamber grants standing without implementation authority, the recognized districts receive an appeal after each schedule has already consumed their floor. The category changes. The cold does not.”

The Caldriest delegate asked to inspect the dates. Senn released them. He found the interval between verified loss and first payment, then compared it with the two-turn remedy.

"Your proposed schedule also delays full correction," he said.

"Yes. Staging protects the other floors. The difference lies in authority during the delay. Under this amendment, Lorn Dusk can challenge a variance before it is imposed. Under deferred implementation, the district can object only after central councils decide what remains available."

A high-light city delegate leaned toward her plate. "You are treating discretionary surplus as if districts have no legitimate reliance on it."

"No. Yesterday's budget preserved hospitals, staple seed starts, school warmth, and safe transit where instruments supported protected need. It removed commercial and decorative claims from the floor. Reliance deserves adaptation support. It does not convert surplus into a right superior to habitation."

The delegate opened Orison's public notice and pointed to the closed tram arcade. "Those vendors may lose income."

"The adaptation credit appears beside the cancellation. Their consequence remains visible and reviewable. So does the consequence of restoring their heat from Eyr's repair margin."

Senn expanded both branches. One shortened market hours and funded insulated stalls. The other pushed Eyr nearer its threshold during tower service. No one looking at the full table could call either cost imaginary.

"Standing first," she said, "does not mean comfort last. It means every claim enters the same account without disguising one district as equipment. The staged protocol keeps the correction inside physical limits. Independent audit keeps the implementing office from deciding alone which facts count."

Pell asked whether her statement contained any recommendation beyond the filed audit finding.

"It recommends passage of both attached parts."

"On technical necessity or constitutional grounds?"

"Both. The Constitution names the floor. Thermodynamics prevents us from restoring it through an unsafe switch. Neither constraint excuses the other."

Senn closed the Caldrift file. Its late payments remained in the archive, still mathematically correct and still unable to restore the leases. She had no intention of helping the chamber produce another recognition that arrived after the weather.

The delegate from Caldrift spoke in support. He named the rain preference their growers had already surrendered during the early winter pulse. He also named the seedlings lost when the timing changed. "We did not enjoy proving burden could move," he said. "We learned that a visible concession can be repaired. An invisible one cannot even be appealed."

Tovin listened from the public gallery, maintenance badge at his collar. His hands rested on the rail. Senn saw the pale abrasion across one knuckle from reserve 6's test frame. He did not look down at her when Caldrift's loss entered the

record.

Pell waited until no final-language lights remained. "Before the vote, the First Curator has requested an institutional statement. It will not alter the text unless a delegate moves to reopen."

Ceryn stood.

Low conversation disappeared from the gallery. Reporters shifted their slates toward her. On the table, the gray hatching across three darkward bands pulsed with the regular timing of a pending classification.

"Seventeen years ago," Ceryn began, "Meral faced a fungal crop failure across four staple families. Projected reserves fell below the minimum required to carry the central ribbon through replacement planting. As acting allocation curator, I signed the fifth renewal of Order 9. The supporting page stated that permanent households remained in the thermal service precincts."

She offered no softer wording. Senn remembered the signature in blue thermal ink and the private room where Ceryn had described choosing famine prevention over recognition.

"My decision preserved bloom allocation during an emergency," Ceryn continued. "It also preserved a category that denied inhabited communities the floor granted by the Charter. The crop emergency ended two years later. Review did not occur. Administrative inheritance converted delay into policy."

A delegate on Rul's side activated his light. "Does the First Curator now claim the original renewal lacked necessity?"

"No. I claim necessity did not authorize permanence."

"Would you make the same decision under the conditions then known?"

Ceryn took one breath. "I would impose a temporary schedule only with named households, a fixed end, and independent review. I would not renew equipment occupancy over residents. Those safeguards did not exist because I chose speed over standing."

The chamber held still. Even Pell left his stylus above the record.

Ceryn touched the policy layer. The old phrase appeared in the central field: MANAGED EXPOSURE. It had followed the case from the first closed technical review through the hearing, polished enough to make a district sound like a risk contour.

"I used the term `managed exposure` for a burden imposed on people who lacked the authority to refuse it. The phrase concealed the governing act. It described cold as if no one had assigned it."

She deleted the phrase from the active implementation note. Archive copies remained visible beneath it.

"I support full weather standing. I support staged implementation because immediate cancellation remains physically unsafe. I support implementation

authority under independent audit because this office has demonstrated that internal review can preserve its own assumptions for decades.”

A stir passed through the Conservatory staff seats. Ceryn did not turn toward them.

“First Curator,” Pell said, “does your statement commit the Conservatory to execute the amendment if carried?”

“Yes.”

“Does it concede the Charter violation established in this hearing?”

“Yes.”

“Does it request immunity for past implementation?”

“No.”

Senn heard Pera release a breath beside the archive port. Hesh's hands remained on the ledger. Their expression offered Ceryn neither absolution nor contempt. They had asked for authority, records, and a floor. Public remorse could not substitute for any of those.

Rul requested one question. Pell allowed it.

“Who appoints the independent auditors during the first turn?” Rul asked.

Ceryn faced him. “One selected by the central districts, one by each newly recognized district, two by the planetary delegates, and one drawn from licensed maintenance staff without current Conservatory management rank.”

“That composition can outvote the cities carrying most of the reduction.”

“It can outvote the office that hid most of the transfer.”

Rul sat. His objection entered the record without reply.

Pell ordered the chamber doors closed for the count. Staff could remain. Reporters could observe but not transmit until certification. In the gallery, hundreds of slate screens dimmed as the local hold engaged. The old pressureworks pumps continued below the floor, sending a faint pulse through every delegate station.

Voting plates rose from the table. Each carried three marks: FOR, AGAINST, ABSTAIN. Delegates authenticated with their district seals. The display would hide individual choices until Pell announced the total, though every vote would become public afterward.

Senn had no plate. Neither did Hesh. Their work had reached the point where other people could accept or refuse its terms.

The first marks entered. Seven lights registered, then twelve. The table did not show alignment, only participation. At nineteen, one plate rejected its district seal and had to be reset. At twenty-three, a delegate asked whether abstention counted toward the denominator. Pell answered that the Charter required a majority of eligible seats, not merely votes cast. Twenty-one votes for would carry

it.

Thirty acknowledgements appeared. Then thirty-four.

Senn found herself checking physical details because the count supplied no useful work. The Lorn Dusk band carried a slight flicker near tower 15. Orison's hospital exception remained yellow but above floor. A corner of Rul's upper sheet had curled under the table heat. Ceryn's bare work-coat cuff showed an ink line where she had amended the implementation roster.

Hesh looked toward the public gallery. Nima sat with three families from the names hearing. Dael occupied a maintenance seat under license suspension, gray visitor badge replacing his engineer's blue. Tovin stood two rows behind him. Pera's archive clerks had filled the far rail.

At thirty-eight votes, the chamber waited for the last three delegates. One represented a city whose commercial bloom loss exceeded Orison's proportional reduction. Another came from a high-wind district that feared reserve deployment would favor central agriculture. The third had argued that recognizing the settlements might reopen every obsolete service category on Meral.

Their plates registered within moments of each other.

Forty-one acknowledgements circled the table.

Pell locked the register. "The clerk will perform the arithmetic twice."

The first count traveled only to his slate. He read it without expression and passed the slate back. The clerk reset her calculation from the raw register, comparing district seals against the attendance roll. No one spoke. A maintenance pump changed cycle beneath the chamber, and the floor's vibration shifted under Senn's shoes.

The slate came back to Pell.

"On the Weather Standing amendment with attached staged protocol," he said, "24 votes are cast for. Fourteen are cast against. The register records 3 abstentions. The required majority has been met."

The gallery made a sound too mixed to call cheering. Relief rose beside anger, sobbing, applause, and the sharp exchange of people already preparing the next dispute. Pell struck the sounding strip twice.

"The amendment carries. Full weather standing attaches immediately upon certification. Operational provisions enter force at the start of the next schedule interval. Independent audit appointments open now."

Hesh did not move.

The legal layer brightened over the Season Table. Gray hatching withdrew from Eyr first, then Nacre Fold. Lorn Dusk remained crossed while its address-ledger authentication processed. A warning appeared: INHERITED PRECINCT IDENTIFIER CONFLICTS WITH DISTRICT STATUS.

Senn opened the conflict. Order 9 still claimed priority in one archive link despite

the amendment's supersession clause. Pera was already reaching for the policy port.

"Do not delete the order," Hesh said.

"We need to detach its authority," Senn replied.

"Detach it. Leave the record."

Pera copied Order 9 into the public inheritance archive, preserving every renewal and signature. Senn changed its operational state from active inherited authority to expired emergency classification. The Almanac recalculated Lorn Dusk from the Charter evidence already authenticated: continuous civic heat, 8,140 residents, address ledger, births, burials, local governance.

The warning cleared.

Lorn Dusk's district band changed from gray to amber while delegates were still gathering their papers. Radiator service remained visible inside it. Clinic reserves held at floor. The promised dawn window for the next turn appeared as protected civic weather rather than equipment support.

Hesh stood only after the color held.

Pell opened the inner ring and directed a clerk to move the district marker into the delegate circle. The physical seat would be fitted later. For the moment, Hesh carried the amber marker across the narrow gap and set it among the forty-one positions.

Senn watched the band, not the gallery. Before the chamber emptied, Lorn Dusk remained inhabited color under its own name.

Chapter 26 — The First Shortfall

The first lawful schedule failed before it reached the sky.

Senn saw the deficit spread across the implementation slate at 04:18, a red seam opening between promised light and available delivery. The Almanac had finished its first full run under the Weather Standing amendment. Every inhabited district appeared by name. Every floor held. Every discretionary trade carried consent and source records. The arithmetic still lacked 2.4 million lumen-hours.

A tower repair notice arrived four seconds later.

Tower 11's replacement bearing had not left Eyr. A ceramic locking collar failed its pressure test, delaying the repair crew at least nineteen hours. Without the tower's projected capacity, the staged retirement of Orison's bloom pushed heat into the central ribbon faster than the darkward system could reject it. The old schedule would have closed the difference through a winter debit. That line no longer existed.

Senn froze the run before any mirror instruction could inherit it.

Around the Season Table, night staff looked up from half-filled cups and maintenance slates. Orison's civic dawn lay two hours away. Lorn Dusk's reflected window followed forty-one minutes after that. If they missed the release boundary, both schedules would shift into contingency weather, a legal state designed for storms and instrument failure, not insufficient planning.

"Source the shortfall," Ceryn said.

She had not gone home after the vote. Her plain work coat hung open now, and the skin below her eyes had taken on the gray cast of people who spent too long under instrument light. First Curator authority remained hers until the implementation council certified a successor or accepted her resignation. Senn had expected Ceryn to use every remaining hour.

"The tower delay accounts for one point six," Senn said. "Forecast error accounts for point five. The rest comes from floor recalculation in two high-wind districts."

"Can reserve 6 cover the forecast portion?"

"Only if the shear edge stays north of Orison. Current confidence gives us sixty-two percent."

"Not enough."

"No."

Pera opened the new public variance ledger. "The protocol requires notice before reserve authority shifts a published share."

Ceryn nodded. "Then publish the deficit now."

A schedule officer stared at her. "Before we have a correction?"

"Especially before we have one."

Senn released the red seam to the public source layer. The first implementation notice went out with no reassuring language: 2.4 million lumen-hours unassigned; tower 11 repair delayed; no district floor authorized for reduction; discretionary offers requested. Tram glass, address halls, district councils, clinics, tower workshops, and greenhouse boards received the same figures.

The room changed after transmission. A concealed shortfall invited technical improvisation. A public one created witnesses. Every future correction would have to survive those witnesses and remain legible after the emergency passed.

Rul Fen arrived nine minutes later, fastening his counsel collar as he crossed the chamber. "Orison's hospital exceptions remain protected?"

"Yes," Senn said.

"Seed starts?"

"Protected through first cycle."

"Then which share do you intend to take?"

"None without authority."

He read the deficit notice twice. "The civic council will offer decorative bloom before it allows a contingency declaration."

"Have them submit the offer through the ledger."

"You could enter it provisionally."

"That would make this office the author of their consent."

Rul's irritation sharpened. "You have two hours."

"Then they should type quickly."

The first offer came from Caldrift.

Its council surrendered eighteen rain-seeding hours from a preference scheduled after the coming staple cycle. The share converted poorly to immediate light because cloud-water timing constrained its use, but it released enough shade-kite capacity to reduce the deficit by one hundred eighty thousand lumen-hours. Tovin's maintenance note arrived attached: ACCEPTABLE IF KITE 6 REMAINS BELOW SEVENTY-THREE PERCENT TENSION.

Senn entered the offer, source instrument, district seal, and conversion loss. The red seam narrowed.

Nacre Vale, a central orchard district unrelated to Nacre Fold, offered late-fruit warming. Its council attached three dissenting votes and a condition that worker heat shelters remain protected. Eyr offered a kiln-light preference even while its own tower crew struggled with the failed collar. A reservoir city surrendered ornamental mist cooling. Orison's civic council submitted the expected decorative bloom reduction, though its notice included four paragraphs blaming the Conservatory for inadequate planning.

Five districts had volunteered discretionary shares within thirty-two minutes. Together their offers closed only 1.1 million lumen-hours after conversion losses.

"No sixth offer?" Ceryn asked.

Pera checked the ledger. "Two inquiries. No seal."

The Season Table displayed what remained: 1.3 million lumen-hours and a repair delay that could lengthen. Every floor stayed green if the schedule did not release. Once the civic boundary passed, missed windows would begin creating local deficits of their own.

Dael called from Eyr's tower workshop. His image appeared on the service panel, compressed by the darkward relay. A gray supervisor badge crossed his coat where his Conservatory license patch had been removed.

"The collar did not fail," he said. "The pressure rig did."

"Authentication?" Senn asked.

"Two gauges disagree by eleven percent. The ceramic shows no fracture trace. I need a third test on tower 10's rig."

A licensed engineer stood behind him, younger than Pera and visibly unhappy to be on camera. His name marker read REK OLAN, SUPERVISING LICENSE.

Ceryn addressed Rek. "Who holds operational authority?"

"I do."

"Who diagnosed the rig discrepancy?"

"Orro."

"Do you accept the diagnosis?"

Rek looked toward Dael. "I accept the need for an independent test."

Dael's suspended license barred him from signing repair release, not from handling tools under direct supervision. The new review rules had not yet taken effect, so every action required Rek's witnessed instruction. Senn could see what the arrangement cost both men. Dael knew the machinery. Rek carried legal responsibility for decisions he lacked the experience to make alone.

"Time to tower 10?" Senn asked.

"Thirty-six minutes if the cross-corridor stays clear," Dael said. "Fifty if radiator duty starts early."

"We have not released it."

"Keep it that way."

Rek lifted the ceramic collar into view. Its shell-white surface showed a dark test line, not the branching stain of structural failure. "I authorize supervised transfer and repeat test."

Pera entered his authority into the public repair log. Dael turned away before the connection closed. Mechanics rolled a padded carrier beneath the collar. Eyr's workshop doors opened onto a corridor rimed with coolant frost.

Ceryn returned to the reserve model. "We can cover six hundred thousand with emergency capacity for three hours."

"Under what trigger?" Rul asked.

"Implementation shortfall threatening protected windows."

"You would spend reserve on an error in your own plan."

"Yes."

"Who audits the declaration?"

Senn opened the independent roster. The district-selected auditors had not all arrived, but the amendment allowed remote concurrence during the first interval. Hesh answered from Lorn Dusk's address hall. An Eyr apprentice auditor joined from tower 11. The planetary delegates supplied two members. The maintenance seat remained vacant because Dael's suspension excluded him and Tovin had direct operational involvement.

Ceryn stated the proposed use without euphemism. Six hundred thousand

lumen-hours equivalent from reserve 6, limited to three hours, protecting district floors while tower 11 underwent repeat testing. The authority would expire automatically. Any extension required a new public declaration.

Hesh asked, "What does Orison keep during those hours?"

"Hospital reservoirs, staple seed rooms, rail safety heat," Ceryn said. "No canal frontage, decorative gardens, or commercial night bloom."

"What does Lorn Dusk keep?"

"Its full scheduled dawn and clinic margin."

"What bears the risk if reserve 6 tears?"

"Tovin's fleet shifts to fixed shade. Central wind variance rises. No darkward floor changes."

The Eyr auditor requested the fabric strain record. Tovin sent it from the kite hangar with his name, instrument set, and inspection time. The record carried the damaged-cell map from the first hangar test, the repair seal from the cold-afternoon deployment, and the current projection: seventy-one percent tension under the revised branch, two points below the tested limit.

Four auditors concurred. Hesh entered the fifth concurrence after requiring the automatic expiry to appear on every public forecast.

Ceryn pressed her office seal to the declaration. Reserve authority moved into the schedule as an amber block, not a concealed balancing line. Her name remained attached to it. The deficit dropped to seven hundred thousand.

Rul read the public layer. "You understand the central councils will use this as evidence that the Conservatory still governs by emergency."

"They may," Ceryn said. "The evidence will also show exactly what I did."

Her answer held no challenge. Transparency did not make the choice harmless. It made the office available for judgment.

The sixth district offer arrived too late to solve the branch and proved unusable anyway. A high-light municipality offered school-hour extensions already protected under its own floor calculation. Senn rejected the offer with the source reason visible. Five districts remained the valid contributors.

At Eyr, Dael and Rek reached tower 10's pressure rig. The relay followed them through a low service room where ceramic heat vanes hung from ceiling racks. Frost melted on Dael's shoulders as he guided the carrier beneath the test cradle.

"Supervisor authorizes collar placement," Rek said for the log.

Dael fitted the piece with his burned fingers clear of the clamp. "Placement complete."

"Pressure sequence to sixty percent."

A mechanic opened the valve. The rig hummed. Three gauges climbed together.

Senn divided her attention between the repair image and the shrinking release

interval. Fifty-eight minutes remained before Orison's civic dawn boundary. Lorn Dusk had ninety-nine. If the collar passed, tower 11 could return enough capacity to close the remaining deficit, but transport and installation would consume most of the margin.

The gauges reached sixty percent. No disagreement appeared.

"Hold," Rek said.

Dael crouched beside the ceramic seam with a light strip. "No trace."

"Eighty percent."

Pressure rose. The left gauge trembled, then settled within half a point of the others. Tower 11's earlier rig had condemned a sound component.

Rek ordered full service pressure. Dael did not urge him faster. The collar had to survive the same force it would carry around a bearing above inhabited Eyr. A hurried certification could preserve one dawn and fail inside a radiator run.

At full pressure, the ceramic emitted a thin ringing note. Dael placed two fingers against the rig housing. His face tightened.

"Stop," he said.

Rek closed the valve. "Reading?"

"Not the collar. Mount vibration."

The mechanics checked the cradle. One locking pin had not seated. Under old informal practice, Dael might have corrected it without speech and continued. Under supervision, each action halted for authority.

"Recommend reseal and repeat from zero," he said.

Rek looked at the schedule clock visible in the relay corner. "Authorized."

Senn felt impatience like heat under her collar. She wanted the sequence shortened. She also knew what shortcuts became after enough people depended on them: customs, assumptions, inherited debits. She left the repair team their full procedure.

Pera found another seven hundred thousand in the model, but not as spare capacity. The Almanac still carried the five district offers at conservative conversion rates drawn from old regional averages. Current air temperature and cloud mass improved three conversions. Using live rates could close nearly two hundred thousand without changing any offer.

"Why did it choose averages?" Senn asked.

"First-run audit rule," Pera said. "Unreviewed live instruments default to historical confidence."

Senn inspected each source. Caldriest's cloud mass had three authenticated sensors. Orison's decorative bloom release carried direct reservoir temperature. Eyr's kiln-light conversion depended on a wind monitor with intermittent packets.

She accepted two live rates and left Eyr conservative. The public ledger showed

both substitutions. Remaining shortfall fell to five hundred twelve thousand.

Tovin called from the kite hangar. Reserve 6 hung in its test frame behind him, black fabric flexing under controlled draw. "I can give you another ninety thousand equivalent if we narrow the deployment edge."

"What changes?"

"Less shade over Orison's north canal. More concentrated tension on panel four."

"Your limit?"

"Seventy-four percent for forty minutes, then back below seventy-two."

"Your earlier note capped it at seventy-three."

"That assumed full edge width. I have a fresh seam scan."

Senn requested the scan. It showed panel four's repair threads, strain spread, and thermal history. The higher load sat inside emergency tolerance but outside preferred use.

Hesh spoke through the audit connection. "Does the added reserve protect a floor or improve a preference?"

"Floor timing," Senn said. "Without it, one district dawn shifts into contingency."

"Which district?"

She ran the allocation branch. "Lorn Dusk."

A brief quiet came from the address hall. Hesh could have accepted the late window under local consent and removed the pressure from Tovin's fabric. Their enforcement clause gave them that authority.

"How late?" they asked.

"Twenty-seven minutes under current estimates."

"Clinic effect?"

"None. Greenhouse soil loses point two degrees. School opening shifts."

Hesh looked away from the relay toward someone outside frame. Voices moved through the address hall. Senn heard Nima ask about the clinic reserve, then a mechanic ask whether the tower test had passed.

"We do not consent yet," Hesh said. "Finish the repair branch. Do not spend reserve above the signed limit while another lawful path remains."

Tovin nodded once. "Holding seventy-three."

The decision kept the deficit visible. Senn understood its force. Lorn Dusk had waited through broken seasons for decades; standing gave it the power to refuse both sacrifice and reckless rescue.

Tower 10's second test reached full pressure. The collar rang cleanly. All gauges held within tolerance for the required four minutes. Rek inspected Dael's trace image, questioned the edge shadow, then signed the component release.

"Transport back in thirty-six," Dael said.

"You have twenty-nine before Lorn Dusk's safe installation boundary," Senn replied.

"We can install during active transfer if tower 11 stays below forty percent duty."

Rek shook his head. "Procedure prohibits bearing work above twenty."

"Old procedure assumed one crew and no external heat brace."

"Do we have a certified brace?"

Dael pointed toward tower 10's wall rack. "Eyr apprenticeship rig. Certified for thirty-five."

Rek pulled its record. The brace had passed inspection six days earlier. Dael described a supervised installation at thirty percent duty, enough to begin heat rejection while mechanics seated the new collar. Rek asked three questions about hand clearance, coolant isolation, and release if the brace slipped.

Senn watched the young engineer decide whether to trust expertise without surrendering authority. The distinction resembled every argument in the chamber, reduced to metal and gloved hands.

Rek authorized the plan.

The collar carrier moved into the cross-corridor. Eyr mechanics cleared frost ahead of it. At tower 11, another crew fitted the external brace around the bearing housing and connected a live strain line to Rek's slate. Dael coordinated from behind the safety rail, naming each bolt sequence while licensed hands approved it.

Twenty-one minutes remained.

Ceryn prepared a second reserve declaration in case installation failed. She did not seal it. Rul called Orison's hospital network and confirmed its protected draw could tolerate a nine-minute shift, offering a small timing buffer without surrendering energy. Senn recorded the flexibility as a measured condition, not a contribution.

At fourteen minutes, the carrier reached tower 11. Dael checked the housing temperature. Rek ordered duty to thirty percent. Radiator hum deepened through the relay, a low force Senn felt only as distortion in the chamber speakers.

Mechanics opened the bearing collar. Heat brace strain rose to sixty-eight percent. The new ceramic piece slid around the shaft in two halves. One fastening tooth resisted.

"Back it out," Dael said.

A mechanic reversed half a turn. Frost vapor crossed the camera.

"Rotate lower half two degrees starward."

Rek repeated the instruction as authority. The crew shifted the ceramic. This

time the tooth seated.

Seven minutes remained when all fasteners reached hand tension. Tower 11 could accept fifty percent duty after the first machine check, enough to erase four hundred sixty thousand lumen-hours of projected shortfall. The remaining fifty-two thousand sat within instrument tolerance, but Senn refused to let it disappear there.

"Find the line," she said.

Pera searched conversion losses. Rul checked protected exceptions. Ceryn kept the unsigned reserve declaration open. Hesh waited on the audit connection.

A district council clerk from Caldriфт sent a correction: its offered rain preference included an unused preparatory cloud pulse. The council had surrendered the hours but not explicitly named the pulse. Senn called the clerk.

"Does the district consent to include it?"

"Yes. The seal amendment is transmitting."

"Consequence?"

"Lower soil moisture margin after staple planting. Still above floor by nine percent."

The amended seal arrived. The pulse converted to sixty-one thousand lumen-hours. Senn accepted only fifty-two thousand, leaving the remainder with Caldriфт.

Tower 11 reached fifty percent duty.

Red withdrew from the schedule. The first implementation run balanced at 05:57, three minutes before Orison's civic boundary. Reserve 6 remained below its signed strain limit. Five districts carried visible voluntary concessions. Ceryn's emergency block showed its exact duration and authorizing name. Dael's supervised role, Rek's decisions, every test result, and the repair delay remained attached to tower 11.

Senn checked each district line rather than trusting the green total. Lorn Dusk held its promised window. Eyr stayed above domestic heat margin during the repair. Nacre Fold preserved clinic soil temperature. Orison kept hospitals and staple seeds while losing decorative bloom. Caldriфт retained nine percent above its floor after the amended offer.

Pera asked what to call the old balancing field in the archived comparison.

Senn looked at the empty place where a winter debit would once have closed the account without a meeting, a notice, or a district seal.

"Leave it blank," she said. "Add the reason."

Pera entered: NO HIDDEN DEBIT PERMITTED UNDER WEATHER STANDING.

The schedule released. Across the table, mirror instructions flowed toward the Choir while tower 11's repair log continued in public view. Every district remained

above floor. No hidden debit closed the difference.

Chapter 27 — The First Shared Winter

Cold rain struck the Conservatory windows at an angle the public forecast had once reserved for maintenance advisories.

Senn stood on the upper canal bridge with water inside her collar and watched Orison discover that a scheduled inconvenience still felt like bad weather. The mirrors had withdrawn five of the city's inherited bloom days. Shade-kite 6 held a narrow edge above the western terraces. Air from darkward crossed the canal hard enough to tear petals from early apricot branches.

Below, workers dragged insulated covers over the seed cooperative's open bins. Tram passengers crowded beneath roofs designed for bright spring, not colder rain. A hive keeper carried two boxes into a greenhouse corridor while bees pressed against the mesh in a dark, irritated mass.

Nothing on the bridge had crossed a survival threshold.

That fact did not warm Senn's hands. It also did not keep the canal crews dry, replace the vendor's damaged flowers, or shorten the line beneath the covered tram stop. Floors prevented catastrophe. Above them remained a wide territory of expense, argument, and ordinary misery that every public notice would now have to name.

Tovin's voice came through her service receiver. "North canal temperature?"

"Seven point eight and falling."

"Report gives eight point one."

"My probe sits in the wind."

"Your probe also spent yesterday in an audit case."

Senn crouched beside the bridge gauge and compared instrument seals. Her handheld carried a fresh calibration mark. The fixed gauge had been checked six days earlier. A three-tenths difference fell inside tolerance, but the storm edge made small errors expensive.

"Use seven point eight for the next branch," she said.

"You enjoy making my weather worse."

"I enjoy keeping the model behind the sky."

Tovin sent a revised kite angle. The storm field appeared on Senn's slate as a curved red boundary north of Orison. One side carried colder rain and gusts. The other carried a shear line that could sharpen if reflected light warmed the canal too quickly. Lorn Dusk's promised dawn required the Choir to hold its darkward path through the same moving air.

"Eyr crew has the tower edge," Tovin said. "Lorn Dusk mechanics are reading local pressure. I need bridge temperatures every four minutes."

"Not the municipal feed?"

"Yours includes wet stone. The storm cares about wet stone."

Senn set the probe against the canal retaining wall. Water ran over her knuckles. Across Orison, forecast panels showed the same public variance: rain colder than the turn average, school bridges closed on the western side, commercial bloom delayed, hospital and staple heat protected. The source layer named Lorn Dusk's dawn window beside the central reduction.

A man sheltering under the bridge arch read the notice and swore. His flower cart held six trays of open yellow cups that had begun to fold inward.

"They say this lasts all morning," he said to Senn.

"Current branch gives six hours."

"My market permit gives me three."

She checked the municipal response line. Vendors could move permits to insulated arcade stalls, though the north arcade had only forty places and more than a hundred carts.

"That does not help all of us," he said after reading it.

"No."

"Did the people getting our light agree to this rain?"

Senn turned the screen so he could see the allocation. "Lorn Dusk receives a protected dawn. It did not trade for your rain. Orison's council surrendered decorative bloom. The colder air follows from keeping the whole schedule inside the shear limit."

"So no one chose the rain."

"People chose the constraints that make it safer than the alternatives."

He looked at his flowers, unimpressed by constitutional accuracy. "Will the city pay for these?"

"The adaptation claim opens at noon. Record the temperature and permit time now."

The man did. Senn watched him press his thumb to a loss form while rain flattened the paper label on one tray. Visible cost did not remove cost. It gave him a place to carry it.

Her receiver clicked twice. Tovin had no patience left for civic conversation.

"Seven point six," she reported. "Stone surface six point nine."

"Storm edge moved four kilometers south. Tell canal control to hold gate three."

Senn relayed the order under his maintenance authority. Gate three stopped halfway open. Water backed along the terrace channels, cooling stone that would

otherwise feed heat into the shear line. Greenhouse managers protested through the district channel. Their root beds would lose circulation for twelve minutes.

Tovin answered each with the same number: minimum soil temperature after the hold, still two degrees above floor.

The rain strengthened. Orison bent around it rather than breaking. Pumps slowed, workers moved, and complaints entered records that no balancing clerk could quietly erase after the sky cleared.

Hesh felt the first reflected light through the heat wall before it reached the address-hall window.

A shallow warmth moved beneath the plaster where old pipes crossed the stone. People stopped speaking. Ressa, taller than when Senn first came to Lorn Dusk but still impatient with adult caution, stood beside the chalk wall holding a blunt white piece between both hands.

The promised dawn had begun at the outer greenhouse roofs. It had not yet entered the hall.

Hesh checked the local schedule. Full window: eighty-three minutes. Arrival tolerance: four minutes. Clinic reserve protected. Tower 15 radiator duty limited until the storm edge passed. The numbers occupied the top of the slate. Below them, Tovin's crew channel displayed wind vectors from Orison while Lorn Dusk mechanics entered pressure readings from the radiator spine.

"South vane dropped," called Marek from the wall station.

"How far?" Hesh asked.

"Six percent in two readings."

"Instrument or air?"

"Air unless three vanes failed together."

The central storm edge had reached the darkward mirror path sooner than forecast. Light still crossed the black sky above Lorn Dusk, but its angle trembled across the greenhouse roofs. A hard correction could preserve intensity and increase wind load. A soft correction could let the window arrive dimmer without breaching clinic heat.

People in the hall watched Hesh as if standing had made them responsible for the sky.

It had made them responsible for consent.

"Send the vane bundle to Tovin," they said. "Copy tower mechanics."

Marek transmitted. Ressa remained beside the wall.

"Can I mark it when it reaches the floor?" she asked.

"When the window completes."

"It already came."

"A kept promise includes duration."

Ressa frowned at the chalk. Old bars covered the plaster from knee height to Hesh's shoulder, each one a window missed, cut short, or taken without notice. Hesh had refused every request to clean the wall for the delegates' visits. New standing did not turn those bars into decoration.

Light entered through the upper window. It struck the opposite heat wall as a pale rectangle, weak at first, then broadening. Children moved their hands through it. An older mechanic closed his eyes and let the reflection reach his face.

The slate sounded a storm warning.

Tovin's image opened beside the schedule. Rain streaked the hangar window behind him. "I need Lorn Dusk to reduce mirror intensity by eight percent for eleven minutes while we move the edge."

Hesh asked, "Does the full duration remain?"

"Yes. We add the minutes at the end."

"Clinic margin?"

"Drops point three degrees, stays one point four above floor."

"Greenhouses?"

"Lowest bed stays point eight above. School opening unaffected if we restore by the twelfth minute."

Marek leaned toward the local pressure trace. "Your branch uses tower 15 at thirty percent."

"Correct."

"Our bearing vibration rose this morning. Hold it at twenty-six."

Tovin's eyes shifted offscreen while his crew recalculated. "At twenty-six I need a twelve percent light reduction."

Hesh looked toward Nima, who stood near the clinic relay. "Medical consequence?"

"None if the extension arrives," she said. "If it does not, infant room reaches floor with no margin."

A central operator entered the channel. "We can guarantee the extension only if Orison releases gate three heat for no more than twelve minutes."

Hesh understood the bargain as physical work rather than moral symbol. Orison held cold rain over its canal. Lorn Dusk accepted dimmer light while mechanics protected a bearing. Neither district fell below what kept people alive. Both carried inconvenience and fear through the same storm edge.

"Local consent for twelve percent reduction, eleven minutes," Hesh said. "Conditioned on a full extension and tower 15 capped at twenty-six."

Pera's variance ledger appeared automatically. Hesh read every term before sealing it. The change became visible on the address-hall forecast, the clinic slate, Orison's tram glass, and the public Season Table.

Reflected light faded across the wall.

Someone near the stove muttered that they had voted for dawn, not another adjustment. A woman from the greenhouse asked whether an extension after school opening counted as the same service. Hesh answered neither with reassurance.

"We will record what arrives," they said.

Ressa gripped the chalk harder. "And if it does not?"

"Then we record that too."

The storm edge crossed Orison's western terrace at 09:22.

Senn saw it in the canal before the field model caught up. Rain shifted direction, running sideways across the water in silver threads. Gate three's held basin darkened under cloud. The fixed temperature gauge fell another half degree.

Tovin ordered kite 6 to narrow its southern panel. High above the city, the black fabric changed from a broad shadow to a thin blade. Mirror light withdrew from one greenhouse tier and strengthened along the darkward path.

"Panel four at seventy-two percent," he said. "Lorn Dusk reduction active. Tower 15 holding twenty-six. I need the canal release in ninety seconds."

"Stone still warm," Senn replied.

"If we wait for it to cool, their extension moves past clinic margin."

"Release now and the shear line crosses the tram roofs."

Eyr's mechanics entered a third option through the shared channel. Tower 11 could accept a short duty pulse while its new bearing remained under observation. Dael's voice followed under Rek's licensed authorization.

"Forty-two percent for seven minutes," Dael said. "It pulls the edge darkward enough to open gate three gradually."

Tovin asked, "Bearing strain?"

"Within service limit. Rek has the trace."

Rek confirmed. The public repair log showed the new collar temperature, brace removal time, and safe pulse range. Tower 11 mechanics had no obligation to offer the capacity; Eyr's kiln-light preference already carried part of the implementation burden.

An Eyr council seal appeared beside the pulse. Discretionary radiator margin surrendered for seven minutes.

Senn accepted it into the branch. "Gate three to one quarter now, half in four

minutes.”

Canal control acknowledged. Water began moving beneath the bridge with a low push against the stone. Greenhouse roots received circulation without dumping the basin's full retained heat into the storm.

Tovin adjusted the kite. Lorn Dusk's mirror path steadied on Senn's field display. The red curve stopped moving south, held for three readings, then eased north by less than a kilometer.

“Do not celebrate,” Tovin said. “We have nine minutes of ugly air left.”

A gust struck the bridge hard enough to pull Senn's coat away from the rail. The flower vendor had moved his surviving trays beneath an insulated stall. Two transit workers fitted temporary screens across the arcade opening. School crews spread grit on wet steps where bloom warmth would once have dried them.

Orison looked inconvenienced because it had become inconvenienced. The changed system had not erased labor. It had moved some of that labor into places accustomed to calling weather reliable.

The hospital network sent a heat warning from one reservoir. Senn opened it and found a branch meter newly installed after the budget session. Neonatal and sterilization draws remained protected. The alarm came from the attached commercial nursery, whose vines had continued pulling warm water after their exception ended.

“Close nursery branch,” she told the district operator.

“They claim pipe shock risk.”

“Reduce over six minutes. Keep medical branches steady.”

Rul joined the line from the civic response room. “I have the owner contesting your classification.”

“He can contest after he stops using the hospital's margin.”

“The branch has shared the reservoir for fourteen years.”

“And now it has a meter.”

Rul examined the live draw. “Reduce over four. Six wastes another forty thousand lumen-hours.”

Senn checked pipe temperature. Four minutes stayed within contraction tolerance. “Accepted.”

The nursery draw fell. Hospital reserve recovered its margin. Rul filed the owner's objection before closing the channel, preserving resistance as carefully as Senn preserved the meter reading.

At minute six, tower 11's bearing warmed faster than Dael projected.

Eyr mechanics cut the pulse without waiting for central instruction. The storm edge quivered. Tovin shifted reserve 6 by half a degree. Lorn Dusk's path dimmed another fraction but stayed within the consented reduction.

"Can you hold?" Senn asked.

Hesh answered through the district channel. "We can hold the agreed eleven minutes. Not twelve."

"We need forty seconds."

"Then find forty seconds inside Orison's share."

Senn looked at the canal field. Gate three had reached half open. One tram-roof heating line still carried decorative snowmelt despite rain. She cut it under the city's surrendered bloom authority. The reduction cooled the western air just enough for Tovin to complete the move.

"Edge stable," he said. "Restore Lorn Dusk on schedule."

The mirror command left the Choir control station. On Senn's slate, the darkward path brightened.

Colder rain continued over Orison. The storm had not become pleasant. It had become bounded.

The address-hall light returned to full strength with twenty-two seconds left inside the agreed reduction.

Hesh watched the rectangle sharpen against the chalk wall. Marek confirmed tower 15 at twenty-six percent. Nima reported the clinic margin holding. Greenhouse bed four sat eight tenths above floor, exactly where the branch had placed it.

"Extension clock begins now," Hesh said.

A local clerk started the added eleven minutes. No one left the hall. People had lived through too many windows that resumed only in central records. They watched the light remain on the plaster while radiator hum traveled beneath their feet.

Tovin kept the shared channel open. His crew read kite strain. Lorn Dusk mechanics supplied tower vibration. Eyr reported the temperature of its new bearing. The three sets of workers spoke in clipped numbers, correcting units when one station used a different scale. No office voice translated them into a story of cooperation.

At the fifth minute, a pressure dip appeared along Lorn Dusk's greenhouse line. Marek traced it to a valve that had not fully reopened after the reduction. Two mechanics left the hall with insulated tools.

Hesh followed the repair on a wall diagram. The valve sat between the school beds and the clinic reserve, accessible through a low corridor behind the heat wall. If it remained half shut, the promised window would warm the hall while soil pipes failed to carry enough heat to seedlings.

"Manual override?" Nima asked.

“Mechanics are there.”

Their voices came through the local channel. Frost had jammed the outer thread. Central maintenance offered a heating pulse. Marek refused because rapid expansion could crack the old housing. An Eyr mechanic suggested tapping the valve stem from the warm side while holding the thread with a ceramic brace.

Lorn Dusk's crew had no fitted brace in that size.

Dael pulled a workshop pattern into the shared channel. “Use two heat-wall clamps opposite each other. Quarter turn only. Keep hands off the stem line.”

Marek inspected the pattern. “Those clamps are rated below valve torque.”

“For full turn. You need enough movement to break frost.”

Tovin asked whether a mirror-angle pulse would warm the corridor instead.

Hesh looked at the extension clock. Four minutes remained. Changing the angle could preserve the pipe while taking visible light from the hall. Under old practice, someone central might have made that adjustment and entered it later as tolerance.

“Local consent for a two-minute angle pulse if clamps fail on first attempt,” Hesh said. “No extension credit for light removed.”

The variance ledger opened. Terms appeared before anyone touched the mirror.

In the corridor, mechanics fitted the two clamps and pulled in opposite directions. Metal knocked against stone. The valve did not move.

“Pulse authorized,” Hesh said.

Mirror angle shifted. Light climbed off the chalk wall and narrowed across the ceiling. Warmth entered the service corridor. Frost released from the thread in a white crumble. The mechanics turned the valve one quarter, then another. Pressure rose in the school line.

“Full flow,” Marek called.

Tovin restored the angle. The hall brightened again. Pera's ledger added two minutes to the extension automatically because the variance had interrupted delivered light.

No one applauded. They kept counting.

Ressa sat on the floor beneath the old chalk bars. The white piece rested across her knees. Hesh joined her while the final minutes passed.

“Was Orison frightened?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“Were we?”

“Yes.”

“Did that make it fair?”

Hesh looked at the old marks. Fair had been used too often for arithmetic that

distributed harm neatly and left authority untouched.

"It made this a shared winter," they said. "Fair depends on what we do when the next line fails."

The extension clock reached zero. The local clerk checked total delivered duration against the primary light sensor, not the central schedule. Eighty-three minutes had arrived. Intensity varied within the consented range. Clinic heat stayed above floor. The school beds recovered. Every interruption carried a visible record.

Reflected dawn began its scheduled withdrawal. The rectangle on the wall softened at the edges.

Ressa stood. She did not wipe away any of the older bars. Hesh had not asked her to. She placed the chalk beside the newest empty space and drew one short line, then wrote the date and duration beneath it in the careful hand of someone who expected another person to verify the claim.

Beside the missed promises, she added the kept dawn.

Chapter 28 — The Conservatory of Broken Seasons

Senn failed the first exercise because she trusted the central timestamp.

The local auditors let her complete the entire reconstruction before pointing to the wall clock. It ran seven minutes ahead of Conservatory standard, not from neglect but by district agreement. Lorn Dusk used the advance on tower-service mornings so school heat checks finished before radiator duty changed.

"You copied the timestamp without asking whose time it kept," Ressa said.

Senn looked from her slate to the apprentice weather clerk at the front bench. Nine months had made Ressa taller and no less direct. A blue training cord crossed her gray coat. Chalk dust marked one cuff.

"I authenticated the instrument," Senn said.

"You authenticated that it keeps time consistently."

"Not that the displayed time governs the promise."

Ressa nodded. "Now fix the variance."

Dry amusement moved through the coolant-cistern theater. Central Conservatory staff occupied the curved lower rows where Lorn Dusk residents had once slept during the early winter pulse. Local auditors stood at the old stage beside portable forecast screens. The disused coolant pipes above them carried no fluid, but their metal still gave the room a faint bitter smell. Heat bricks lined the aisles beneath coats and tool cases.

The first Conservatory training session held outside Orison had begun with

central staff receiving correction from an apprentice. Hesh had arranged the order deliberately.

Senn reopened the exercise. A dawn window had arrived according to central time and run six minutes short according to the local service clock. Under the old account it would have passed as a one-minute overdelivery. Under the district's governing schedule it counted as thirteen minutes missing.

She changed the reference clock, attached the local agreement, and entered the interrupted promise into the practice ledger.

"What triggers next?" asked Marek, who had exchanged greenhouse tools for an audit slate without losing the posture of a mechanic examining a bad valve.

"Source review," Senn said. "Local notice, mirror instruction, receiving sensor, and any variance consent."

"Who can close it?"

"Not the office that issued the schedule. One local auditor and one independent member must agree on disposition."

"And if they disagree?"

"The entry remains open."

Marek accepted the answer. Ressa did not. "What happens to the next window while it stays open?"

Senn checked the new rule set. "The district keeps its floor. Discretionary trade from the disputed source pauses."

"Now you may sit down."

Senn returned to the second row beside Dael. His blue engineer's patch had been restored that morning, new thread brighter than the worn fabric around it. The licensing board had returned his authority under review rules that separated unauthorized protective work from concealment while still recording both. For two years, every schedule he signed would receive an independent technical check. Clinic adjustments now required public variance entries and district consent.

Before the next exercise, the maintenance representative asked Dael to demonstrate the review rule. A practice tower schedule appeared on the stage, built from his old clinic offsets. It offered three extra minutes of mirror edge to a medical reservoir while keeping all displayed tolerances green.

"What would you have done twelve years ago?" asked the representative.

"Entered a maintenance correction and left the district blank," Dael said.

A central trainee looked uncomfortable. "Because the clinic lacked standing."

"Because naming it could have triggered cancellation. I told myself a small hidden adjustment protected more than a failed challenge."

"What do you do now?"

Dael opened the source layer. He named the receiving clinic, requested its

measured reserve draw, and sent the proposed shift to the district ledger. The practice council refused because the reservoir already held enough heat. His offset disappeared.

The representative changed one input. Clinic reserve fell below its margin after a sterilization cycle. Dael submitted the same adjustment again. This time the district consented, but the independent checker found that its mirror edge would raise wind load over a neighboring greenhouse.

"Can you reduce the greenhouse share?" the trainee asked.

"Not without asking its district."

"That takes time."

"Yes."

"What if the clinic cannot wait?"

"Emergency authority can act inside a protected trigger. My engineering license does not carry that authority by itself."

Dael moved the case into emergency review. The audit council approved a shorter edge shift and added a later light window for the greenhouse. Every step stayed visible: clinic need, neighboring consequence, district responses, reserve authority, and final delivery.

Hesh asked what happened if no independent checker answered before the service boundary.

"The clinic floor governs," Dael said. "The emergency action proceeds under a named authority. Review stays open afterward."

"So secrecy has merely become paperwork?" one central mechanic asked.

"No. Paperwork can still hide things. The difference comes from who receives the record and who may refuse the next step."

Pera attached his old anonymous offset beside the practice case. Both had warmed a clinic. Only one let the affected districts contest the cost. The exercise did not excuse twelve years of hidden corrections, but it gave the restored license a procedure sturdier than trust in Dael's intentions.

He leaned toward Senn after the panel dismissed him. "Seven minutes seems generous. I expected them to catch you on the chalk dates."

"I read the chalk dates."

"You read the ones at eye level."

She looked toward the theater wall. Old marks continued behind the stage curtain and down to the floor where children had begun recording them. "You knew?"

"I failed yesterday."

At the stage, Hesh called the next group. Three policy officers from Orison climbed the steps with an Eyr apprentice and a Nacre Fold clinic clerk. Their

exercise involved a category conflict rather than timing. Pera had built it from an actual archive error found during the ninth-month review.

Pera now led the category archive. She sat beneath a portable shelf of Order 9 records, sorting questions into changes, disputes, and historical annotations. Her new title, Keeper of Policy Inheritance, had made her laugh for almost a full minute when Pell announced it. She had accepted only after adding a rule that no keeper could approve an inherited category alone.

The exercise displayed a heat draw labeled SCHOOL AUXILIARY. Central officers treated it as protected classroom warmth. The Eyr apprentice asked for the source meter. The Nacre Fold clerk requested the address. Pera refused both until they identified which office had assigned the label.

“Why does authorship matter if the load is real?” one officer asked.

“Because a real load can carry a false purpose,” Pera said. “We spent thirty-one years proving that.”

They found the assigning office in an emergency crop annex. SCHOOL AUXILIARY referred to flower-show lamps in a courtyard rented by a school, not classroom heat. The load stayed real. Its claim on the floor disappeared.

Pera made them preserve the old label in the archive, add the corrected category, name the assigning office, and notify the school before changing its schedule. Erasure earned no credit. Neither did exposure without repair.

Senn watched central habits meet local resistance in small procedural collisions. Staff asked for standard forms. Lorn Dusk auditors asked what the forms omitted. Engineers wanted common time. Clerks wanted the authority attached to each clock. No one opposed standards in principle. They opposed letting a standard hide the place where weather landed.

At midday, the theater doors opened for the implementation council session. Training benches became public seats. Portable screens shifted into a semicircle around the stage. Hesh moved from instructor's station to the permanent audit council position bearing Lorn Dusk's district seal.

The council had seven standing members: three district auditors, two planetary appointees, one maintenance representative, and one rotating public clerk. Hesh held no ceremonial role. They could open records, suspend a disputed discretionary trade, and require local consent evidence before a variance closed.

Rul Fen sat in the public counsel row with a thicker stack than he had carried to the vote. Nine months of shared winter had generated claims over market losses, seed timing, rain preferences, repair delays, and one central district's allegation that floor calculations favored darkward heat walls. The new institution had not reduced his workload.

Ceryn entered last.

She wore the First Curator's blue mantle for the final time. No staff procession

accompanied her. She carried one testimony slate and the original fifth-renewal signature page inside a clear archival sleeve.

Pell opened the session remotely from Orison. His image occupied a narrow screen rather than the center of the room. "The council will receive the First Curator's resignation, effective upon appointment of the interim office. Implementation testimony remains subject to summons and audit. Curator Ahl, do you affirm both conditions?"

"I do," Ceryn said.

"Does resignation conclude any pending review?"

"No."

"Does it remove your obligation to authenticate decisions made under your seal?"

"No."

Pell recorded the answers. "The office accepts the resignation."

No applause followed. Ceryn removed the blue mantle and folded it across the back of the empty curator's chair. Beneath it she wore the same plain coat from the vote.

Hesh addressed her from the council. "Your testimony concerns the first implementation shortfall and two later reserve declarations. Do you remain available?"

"Yes."

"Then take the witness seat."

Ceryn sat without looking at the mantle.

Senn had imagined this transition more often than she admitted. In some versions, Ceryn left the institution and carried its blame with her. In others, she retained command because no one else understood the Choir's interlocking risks. Neither outcome would have changed enough. Stepping down removed concentrated authority. Remaining for testimony kept expertise and responsibility available to the people reviewing its use.

The council began with the 2.4-million-lumen-hour shortfall. Ceryn authenticated her reserve declaration, expiry, source forecasts, and knowledge at the time. Hesh asked why her office had used emergency authority before all local auditors reached the roster.

"Protected windows would have entered contingency before the full appointments arrived," Ceryn said. "The amendment permitted remote concurrence."

"Permission does not establish best practice."

"No. Best practice would have seated the council before the first run."

"Why did you not?"

"I prioritized schedule release over institutional readiness."

"Again."

Ceryn accepted the word. "Again. This time the authority remained public, limited, and independently concurred. That difference does not remove the planning failure."

Hesh entered the answer without comment.

The next declaration concerned a shear front during the fourth shared-winter interval. Central shade had increased beyond forecast while Eyr surrendered kiln light. Ceryn had authorized reserve 6 for fifty minutes. Tovin's maintenance record showed seventy-four percent tension on one panel, above its preferred limit but within emergency tolerance.

The maintenance representative asked why the office had not reduced Orison's rail-platform warming first.

Ceryn opened the branch. "Wet-switch risk crossed the rail safety floor under that option."

"Whose instrument supplied the risk?"

"Orison transit authority."

"Independent check?"

"None during the interval."

The council marked the decision technically supported but procedurally incomplete. Future transit claims required a second sensor before they could override an offered discretionary share.

Rul objected that duplicating sensors during a storm could delay action. Hesh accepted the objection into review and left the requirement active.

The hearing continued through lunch. No one treated Ceryn as a villain or an oracle. She answered exact questions and asked for records when memory might misstate a number. Once she corrected Hesh on a kite-angle conversion. Twice she conceded that the office's source choice had favored central infrastructure. Her testimony improved the rules that limited her former position.

During a recess, Senn found her beside the old coolant manifold, reading the district's chalk record.

"Did you know they kept all of them?" Ceryn asked.

"Yes."

"I saw photographs. They did not show how low the first marks are."

"Children made some."

Ceryn crouched to read a date near the floor. Thirty-one years separated it from the newest kept-dawn entry. "My daughter used to mark growth on a pantry wall. I had forgotten how near the floor such records begin."

Senn said nothing. Ceryn's famine history explained the choices she feared. It could not stand in for the people those choices chilled.

After a moment, Ceryn rose. "The interim curator asked whether you would direct central audit."

"I declined."

"I expected you would."

"Did you recommend me?"

"Yes."

"That may have contributed."

A small movement touched Ceryn's mouth. "Then my influence has finally become useful through opposition."

Senn looked toward the theater doors. Beyond them, Lorn Dusk's market corridor carried greenhouse lamps, tower vibration, and the voices of trainees comparing variance forms. "Pell offered a roving weather-standing post."

"With what authority?"

"Cross-district origin traces. Temporary suspension of disputed discretionary trades. No power to alter a floor or close a local record alone."

"You will spend most of your life in transit."

"I already spend it following transfers."

Ceryn considered the answer. "Accept it. Central audit will become clean again if no one keeps bringing it untidy places."

Senn had reached the same conclusion during the morning exercise, when a local clock defeated an authenticated timestamp. She entered her acceptance on the appointment slate. The roving post began after the current training cycle.

The appointment terms required each district to choose its own records liaison before any local visit began. Senn could request instruments, open an origin trace, and pause a disputed surplus transfer for one service interval. Beyond that, local or planetary authority had to act. The limits pleased her. An auditor able to impose a remedy alone would become another curator with a different coat. She signed beneath the restrictions before signing beneath the title.

Dael found her before the recess ended. He had seen the appointment enter the public roster.

"How far does roving include?" he asked.

"Every district under the Charter."

"That sounds poorly designed."

"You designed an installation at thirty percent radiator duty."

"Under supervision."

"So will I."

His restored license allowed him to lead Choir field reviews again, though another engineer would sign the check for two years. Their assignments would cross at towers, mirror stations, district halls, and disputed pipes. Neither promised to arrange it.

Dael touched the bright edge of his license patch. "Eyr wants its pressure rigs audited before the next repair cycle."

"I have an opening in nineteen days."

"Terrible news for the rigs."

Pera called them back before Senn could answer.

The final training exercise used no fabricated record. Hesh had selected a variance from Nacre Fold's previous rain turn. A reflected window arrived at full intensity but thirty-four minutes late because a neighboring clinic requested priority light during a sterilization failure. Nacre Fold's council had consented to the delay. The window later arrived in full. No floor had been crossed.

Central staff classified it as schedule met with authorized timing variance.

The Nacre Fold clerk objected. "The promise did not arrive when posted."

"It arrived under an agreed revision," said an Orison auditor.

"Agreed after the original schedule."

"Before the service boundary."

"Residents waiting under the first notice still experienced an interruption."

The dispute moved through the theater. Some local auditors wanted every deviation called a failure. Engineers argued that lawful adjustments kept the system alive. Rul warned that an adverse label could produce compensation claims even when districts consented. Pera asked whether classification existed to describe experience, assign fault, or trigger review.

"Those are different jobs," Senn said.

Hesh looked toward her. "Then give them different fields."

Senn opened the formal weather ledger. Its existing categories allowed delivered, failed, cancelled, emergency substituted, and consented variance. None captured a promise interrupted and later kept. The old system had treated the original notice as superseded, leaving only the successful revision. Local chalk records kept both.

Ressa carried the wall-clock exercise slate to the stage. "If you replace the first schedule, the person who waited becomes wrong."

Pera added a new record layer without closing the consented variance. ORIGINAL PROMISE remained beside REVISED AGREEMENT. Delivery attached to the revision. The initial interruption stayed visible.

"What do we call the condition?" asked the maintenance representative.

Hesh did not answer immediately. The phrase belonged to Lorn Dusk before it

belonged to policy.

"A broken season," they said. "Not because the weather broke. Because the promise did."

Rul raised his counsel light. "Does the term assign liability?"

"No," Pera said. "It triggers review."

"Does consent close it?"

"Consent can resolve the variance. It cannot erase the interruption."

Ceryn spoke from the witness seat. "Add source, affected service, notice time, consent time, floor margin, and final delivery. Require review only when the original promise and delivered condition differ beyond posted tolerance."

The Nacre Fold clerk asked for local description to remain attached. Central staff asked for a standard code so records could be compared across districts. Both entered the form.

Senn tested the category against old cases. It captured Lorn Dusk's missed dawns, Orison's altered bloom, Caldrift's moved rain preference, and the lawful clinic-priority delay without treating them as identical harms. Each record carried its own consequence and authority.

Pera asked the archive whether any active category already used the proposed term. None did. She asked Hesh for permission to retain the local words in the formal ledger.

"Retain where they came from," Hesh said.

The origin field received LORN DUSK ADDRESS RECORD. The definition followed: PROMISE INTERRUPTED; ORIGINAL NOTICE RETAINED; VARIANCE, CONSENT, CONSEQUENCE, AND FINAL DELIVERY SUBJECT TO REVIEW. A district could now challenge the change without denying that later delivery had occurred under agreement.

Senn authenticated the test entry. Hesh added the local council seal. A planetary auditor signed the independent field. Pera released the category into the policy archive with no inherited authority and a mandatory review date.

On the portable screen, the Nacre Fold schedule kept both times. Its clinic priority remained lawful. Its delayed window remained delivered. The interruption no longer vanished between them.

Pera's new entry read: BROKEN SEASON. PROMISE INTERRUPTED. REVIEW REQUIRED. A date followed, attached to authorities who would have to answer when it arrived.

Epilogue — An Uneven Morning

Ressa posted Lorn Dusk's dawn seventeen minutes later than Orison's and waited for someone to object.

The address-hall forecast took the schedule without warning color. Amber light traced the local window across the wall slate: start at 06:43 district time, duration eighty-one minutes, clinic margin two degrees, tower 15 duty twenty-four percent. A smaller line showed Orison's canal bloom beginning at 06:26.

Three years earlier, any difference from the central schedule would have arrived as cancellation, tolerance, or no notice at all. Now the variance field named Nacre Fold clinic as the receiving priority. Its sterilization reservoir had cooled after a pump seal failed. Eleven districts had reviewed the light shift. Lorn Dusk's council had consented before the service boundary.

Ressa checked the seals again.

"You have already checked them twice," Hesh said from the ledger desk.

"The first check found the missing tower reading."

"The second found nothing."

"That does not prove the third lacks ambition."

Hesh returned to a burial entry, leaving her to the schedule. They had stopped supervising every motion of her apprenticeship, which meant they now expected her errors to have names.

Outside the hall, radiator hum traveled through frozen paving. Families moved toward the greenhouse corridor carrying work lamps and heat bricks. No one gathered beneath the windows to wait. A posted delay with an identified cause changed the morning's work: school opened twelve minutes later, bread ovens held their second trays, clinic staff extended the lamp bank over infant beds.

Ressa released the public notice.

LORN DUSK DAWN DELAYED 17 MINUTES BY AGREEMENT. RECEIVING PRIORITY: NACRE FOLD CLINIC STERILIZATION. FULL LOCAL WINDOW RETAINED. REVIEW RECORD 88-14.

A market mechanic stopped to read it. "Why does Orison get its light first?"

"It does not receive our seventeen minutes. Its canal schedule sits on another mirror branch."

"Then why show it?"

"Because the forecast used to imply every district shared Orison's morning."

He studied the two start times. "Looks uneven."

"It is."

The mechanic grunted and went to work.

At 06:26, the comparison line brightened. Orison's bloom began far starward, invisible from Lorn Dusk. Ressa received its source confirmation anyway: canal gates opened, hive boxes held, cold rain risk low. She attached it to the forecast

without changing the local clock.

Nacre Fold reported its first sterilization cycle complete at 06:31. The pump seal held. Clinic reservoir temperature climbed above margin. Under the consent agreement, those results triggered release of Lorn Dusk's mirror path.

A Choir instruction arrived with a six-minute uncertainty range.

Ressa called the route operator. "Your range crosses our posted tolerance."

"High wind over Eyr," the operator said. "We can narrow by taking two minutes from the end."

"No."

"Total heat still clears floor."

"The consent retained full duration."

"Then start may run five minutes late."

"Enter that possibility in the variance."

The operator did. Ressa published the changed estimate before anyone saw the sky alter. Local review remained open.

At 06:46, three minutes behind the agreed time, reflected light touched the upper greenhouse roofs. The receiving sensor confirmed intensity. Ressa started the duration clock from physical arrival rather than central release.

Warmth entered the address hall slowly. It reached the chalk wall as a narrow silver block, leaving the lower bars in shadow. Children on their way to school put their palms inside it. One complained that Orison had already held twenty minutes of morning. Another answered that Orison had colder rain forecast after bloom.

Neither child treated weather as equal. They treated it as something with records.

The route operator extended the closing time by three minutes. Ressa watched the full eighty-one minutes arrive. Nacre Fold's clinic record stayed attached beside it. Lorn Dusk's greenhouse soil held above margin. No tower warning appeared.

A notice from Orison arrived during the final quarter hour. Its canal ward had complained that the comparison forecast made central bloom look favored. The civic clerk requested removal of the side-by-side start times from darkward displays.

Ressa opened the request for Hesh. "They say the times encourage false comparison."

"Do they dispute either time?"

"No."

"Do the schedules share a source constraint?"

"Yes. The clinic priority changed both route margins."

Ressa denied the request and attached the reason. Comparison did not claim equal weather. It showed that different mornings came from one allocation field. Orison could appeal to the audit council if its clerk preferred a cleaner screen.

When the light withdrew, she printed the variance summary on paper. Hesh authenticated the council consent. A remote auditor in Eyr verified the route. Ressa signed the local delivery line with her apprentice mark.

“Closed?” Hesh asked.

“Delivered and reviewable,” she said. “The start missed agreement by three minutes.”

“Then not closed.”

Ressa left the variance open for the monthly route audit.

She took a piece of chalk from the ledger drawer. The old wall still carried missed windows from before her apprenticeship, bars whose notices had never arrived and whose consequences remained clearly visible in family ledgers. Beside them stood later marks with dates, durations, consent numbers, and repairs. No coat of paint separated one era from another.

Ressa drew today's line without covering the earlier promises. Beneath it she wrote the agreed time, the actual time, the clinic priority, and the full duration received.

At the end she added two words: KEPT LIGHT.